



Thiruviruththam

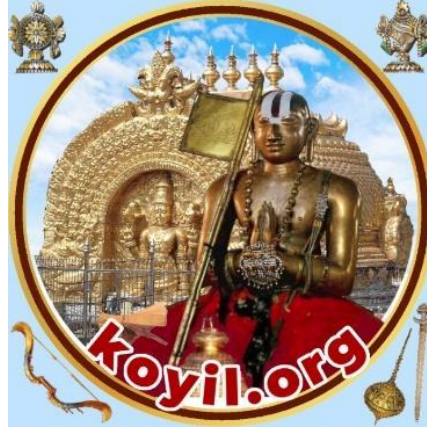
Author: Srl. sArathy thOthathri

Published by Sri VaraVaraMuni Sambandhi Trust

(www.varavaramuni.com)

Book code: **BBBB1**

First Edition: **DDDD1**



Minimum Donation: ₹ 70

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Pronunciation guide

- A is used for “aa” sound – example: emperumAnAr, rAmAnuja
- E is used for “yay” sound – example: EkAdhasi
- I is used for “ee” sound – example: ISvara. "ee" is also used at times, when the word contains both "I" and "I" as in the case of lIlA - it will be written as leelA (to avoid confusion)
- O is used for “Oh” sound – example: Om
- U is used for “oo” sound – example: Urdhva pundram
- zh is used for very strong “l” sound – example: AzhwAr
- L is used for strong “l” sound – example: muL (thorn)
- N is used for strong “n” sound – example: nArAyaNa
- R is used for strong "r" sound - example: puRappAdu (procession); its also used for "tr" sound in thamizh when there is double "R" - example: uRRAr (utRAR - relative)
- d is used strong “d” sound – example: garuda
- dh is used for meek “d” sound – example: gOvindhA
- t is used for strong “t” sound – example: ganta
- th is used for meek “t” sound – example: vratham
- b is used for meek “b” sound – example: budhdhi
- bh is used for strong “b” sound – example: bhakthi
- sa, sha, ksha are typed as it is – examples: samskritham, shashti and kshamA
- S is used for strong “s” sound – example SEsha, kESava
- : is used for ha sound in samskritham words – examples: nama: to be said as namaha



Our AzhwArs and AchAryas have showed us two great treasures - archAvathAra emperumAns and granthams (dhivya prabandham, sthOthrams, vyAkyAnams, rahasya granthams etc). We strive to provide access to both - emperumAn and granthams, and the AzhwArs/AchAryas, through our website portal (<http://koyil.org>). As part of this initiative, we are presenting printed books for the benefit of everyone. We request and encourage everyone to make use of this opportunity and

- get these books for oneself and develop/refresh one's own knowledge
- get these books in bulk and place them in their AchArya's mutt/thirumALigai, so that the AchArya can give a copy of these books to those who become Sishyas. These books can be studied by Sishyas and any doubts can be clarified by the AchArya himself - thus leading to an enriching relationship between AchArya and Sishya.
- share them with others as a compliment during SrlvaishNava festivals, functions at home etc and gift them to friends/relatives during functions and important events at their homes
- think about many other creative ways of sharing/spreading knowledge

Reading the principles explained by our pUrvAchAryas in simple language will make us gain knowledge about our sampradhAyam and will also stimulate the taste for progressing further such as learning the literature in depth through upanyAsams, kAlakshEpams etc under qualified scholars and engaging in various kainkaryams.

With the intent of spreading this divine knowledge far and wide to reach all SrlvaishNavas and those who are aspiring to become a SrlvaishNava, we only expect a minimum donation that covers the cost to print the books. Courier/postage charges will be extra.

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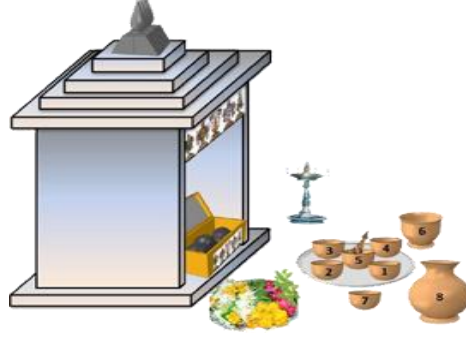
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Basics of SrlvaishNavam

For SrlvaishNavas, the following points are very useful to understand and practice in their lives on a day-to-day basis.



1. Respect SrlvaishNavas irrespective of their varNam, ASramam, gyAnam, etc. Respect towards fellow bhAgavathas is bhagavAn's first expectation from his devotees.
2. Lead a simple life devoid of ego and possessiveness. Once we realize the miniscule nature of the AthmA (self) and the grandeur nature of bhagavAn, we can never think great about ourselves.
3. Regular interaction with one's own AchArya is a very important aspect. It is important and mandated for the Sishya to help his AchArya in physical, financial needs as much as possible.
4. Perform nithya karmAnushtAnams such as snAnam, Urdhva puNdra dhAraNam, sandhyAvandhanam etc., according to one's own varNam and ASramam. Through performance of such ordained activities, one develops internal and external purity which will lead to sustenance and nurturing of true knowledge.
5. Always wear thirumaN and SrlchUrNam (thilak) - this is our primary identity of our servitorship towards bhagavAn. It is most important to wear it boldly at all circumstances and never feel ashamed of it.
6. Wear traditional clothes panchakachcham, madisAr etc., as per one's gender, varNam, ASramam. There is nothing to feel shy about being who we are and what our culture is – especially coming in the great lineage of AchAryas.
7. Always engage in worshiping SrIman nArAyaNa, AzhwArs and AchAryas. On the contrary avoid worshiping dhEvathAntharams (dhEvi dhEvathAs - dhEvathAs such as rudhra parivAr, indhra, varuNa, agni, navagrahams, etc). This is one of the most important principles highlighted by our pUrvAchAryas. One of the main relationships between bhagavAn and jlvAthmA is bharthru-bhAryA (husband-wife) relationship. Since all jlvAthmAs are feminine in nature and bhagavAn is the singular masculine entity, all jlvAthmAs have this common

relationship with bhagavAn. So, it is imperative for one to manifest faithfulness towards bhagavAn at all times and avoid any relationships with dhEvathAntharams.

8. thiruvArAdhanam at home is an important aspect in a SrlvaishNava's daily routine. emperumAn has mercifully descended into our own homes to accept our worship. It is a great insult to ignore him and will be very detrimental for one's own spiritual progress to ignore perumAL at home. Even while we are travelling, it is best to carry the thiruvArAdhana perumAL also with us. If that is not possible, at least adequate arrangements should be made to ensure proper thiruvArAdhanam for him either at our own home by SrlvaishNavas or by placing him in other SrlvaishNavas' homes. It is completely disrespectful to leave him locked in the home without daily thiruvArAdhanam. There is a detailed discussion on thiruvArAdhanam at <http://ponnadi.blogspot.in/2012/07/srivaishnava-thiruvaaraadhanam.html>.
9. Always consume those food materials that are allowed in SAstham based on one's own varNam and ASramam. Such food stuff should first be offered to emperumAn, AzhwArs and AchAryas and then only be consumed. We should never consume such foods that are not offered to emperumAn. There is a detailed discussion on AhAra niyamam at http://ponnadi.blogspot.in/2012/07/srivaishnava-aahaara-niyamam_28.html and <http://ponnadi.blogspot.in/2012/08/srivaishnava-ahara-niyamam-q-a.html>.
10. Seek out the association of SrlvaishNavas. It is important to engage with meaningful spiritual conversations that will uplift us and help us in our spiritual progress.
11. dhivya dhEsams, AzhwAr/AchArya avathAra sthalams and abhimAna sthalams are important parts of our life. One should lead a life of service in dhivya dhEsams and so on. If the circumstances are not right presently to be engaged in such service, try to visit such holy places frequently and also plan for such setup in the future.
12. dhivya prabandham is the most important aspect for SrlvaishNavas. Learning the pAsurams, understanding the meanings of the same (according to pUrvAchAryas' explanations) and putting those principles in to practice are the 3 most important aspects which define a SrlvaishNava. dhivya prabandham develops detachment towards worldly matters and attachment towards bhagavAn and bhAgvathAs.
13. The lives of our pUrvAchAryas are by themselves the greatest source of learning and inspiration for us. They have demonstrated utmost dignity and compassion towards all beings and all the situations/dilemmas that we come across today are addressed clearly in their lives.
14. Study of pUrvAchArya literature is most important. One should allocate some time on a daily basis to plunge into the greatest available treasure, i.e., pUrvAchArya literature in the form

of vEdhAntham, dhivya prabandham, sthOthra granthams, vyAkyAnams, historical depictions, etc. There is plenty of such information available in our websites (<http://koyil.org/index.php/portal/>) for reading.

15. Listening to kAlakshEpams (lectures of commentaries with source text) under scholars is most important to get thorough understanding of the essential principles. Nowadays, there are many lectures available in CDs and websites. For those who cannot attend these lectures personally, they can make use of such resources that are available. Even while listening from home, one should try to be in proper attire and listen to these lectures with attention as it would be done in physical presence.
16. Engage in some meaningful kainkaryam. SAsthram says “servitorship becomes devoid when there is no service” – as a servitor of Srlman nArAyaNan, AzhwArs and AchAryas, one should always engage in some service. It can be physical, monetary, intellectual etc. There are so many ways to engage in service. There is also so much demand for those who are interested in kainkaryam. One should always commit to some service which is recurring and fulfill that too. This way, there is constant engagement with bhagavAn and bhAgavathas.
17. Help fellow bhAgavathas and others in acquiring this most wonderful knowledge about bhagavAn, AzhwArs and AchAryas. Constant engagement in sharing such knowledge is mutually beneficial and enjoyable for both the speaker and listener. Our pUrvAchAryas have set a wonderful precedent by sharing many divine literature for the sole purpose of uplifting everyone through true knowledge. It is the duty of all of us to also study them carefully under proper guidance and then share the same with our family, relatives, friends and all those who desire for such knowledge.
18. Finally, one should constantly long for the eternal blissful life in parama padham which is fully fitting for the true nature of the soul. A real SrlvaishNava would never fear death for that which leads to the eternal service to bhagavAn in the most magnificent SrlvaikuNtam. Our AzhwArs and AchAryas always served bhagavAn and bhAgavathas when present here and desired to continue the same after reaching parama padham also.


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Introduction

iyaRpA





thiruviruththam forms the fifth prabandham (divine composition) in the third thousand “iyaRpA” among the four thousand pAsurams of nAlAyira dhivya prabandham (divine compositions). This was composed by nammAzhwAr who was blessed by emperumAn with divine knowledge and devotion without any fault. This is the first prabandham of the four prabandhams composed by swAmy nammAzhwAr. It is the essence of rig vEdham (first among the four vEdhams, sacred texts, namely rig, yajur, sAma and atharvaNa). This is composed of one hundred pAsurams. periyavAchchAn piLLai has written the commentary for this divine composition. There have been others too who have written commentaries for this prabandham, including nampiLLai who had mercifully written Idu, special meanings mercifully given by azhagiya maNavALa jIyar, commentary written by parakAla jIyar. appiLLai (a disciple of maNavALa mAmunigaL) too has written explanatory notes for this prabandham. It is said that pUrvAchAryars (early preceptors) such as bhattar, had written commentary for this prabandham, but these are not available now.

We will explore the meanings of this prabandham with the commentary of periya vAchchAn piLLai.

In the next article, we will go through the thaniyan for this prabandham.

- thaniyan

- pravESam
- pAsuram 1 – poy ninRa
- pAsuram 2 – sezhu nlr
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- pAsuram 41 – enRum punvAdai
- pAsuram 42 – van kARRaRaiya
- pAsuram 43 – kaNNum sendhAmarai
- pAsuram 44 – niRam uyar
- pAsuram 45 – perum kEzhalAr
- pAsuram 46 – madanenjam enRum
- pAsuram 47 – thiriginRadhu
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- pAsuram 55 – vandugaLO vammin
- pAsuram 56 – viyalidam uNda
- pAsuram 57 – pulakkuNdala
- pAsuram 58 – kazhaRalam onRE
- pAsuram 59 – aLapparum thanmai

- pAsuram 60 – mulaiyO muzhumuRRum
- pAsuram 61 – vAsagam seyvadhu
- pAsuram 62 – iRaiyO irakkinum
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- pAsuram 89 – thlvinaikkaru nanjai

- pAsuram 90 – thalaippeydhu yAn
- pAsuram 91 – surunguRi veNNey
- pAsuram 92 – pENalamillA arakkar
- pAsuram 93 – kAlai veyyORku mun
- pAsuram 94 – maippadi mEniyum
- pAsuram 95 – yAdhAnum Or Akkaiyil
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- pAsuram 97 – ezhuvadhun mINdE
- pAsuram 98 – thunjA munivarum
- pAsuram 99 – Inach cholAyinumAga
- pAsuram 100 – nallAr navil

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1. thaniyan

The thaniyan (special hymn) for this prabandham has been written by kidAmbi AchchAn. It is said that this thaniyan has been composed by slrAmappiLLai (vEdha vyAsa bhattar) as well as by ALavandhAr.

avathArikai (Introduction)

This says that instead of observing the sorrows of samsAram (life in the materialistic realm) through the seven stages of life which are infirm, meditate on one line of thiruviruththam which is a divine composition, as a means of attaining SrlvaikuNtam.

karuviruththak kuzhi nlththapin kAmak kadunguzhi vlzhndhu

oru viruththam pukku uzhaluRuvIr, uyirin poruLgatku

oru viruththam pugudhAmal kurugaiyar kOn uraiththa

thiruviruththaththu Or adi kaRRu irIr thirunAttu agaththE

Word-by-word Meanings:

karu – womb

viruththam – faulty

kuzhi – from the pit

nlththapin – after slipping out of

kAmam – termed as lust

kadum – cruel

kuzhi – pit

vlzhndhu – falling into

(later)

oru viruththam – old age which is unfit for any activity

pukku – attaining

uzhal uRuvIr – Oh those who are roaming!

uyirin – for the jIvAthmA (soul)

poruLgatku – for the entities

oru viruththam – any bad conduct

pugudhAmal – without attaining

kurugaiyar kOn – the lord of thirunagari, swAmy nammAzhwAr

uraiththa – mercifully composed

thiruviruththaththu – of thiruviruththam

Oradi – one line

kaRRu – learning well

thirunAttagaththu – at SrlvaikuNtam

irIr – stay (without any worry)

Simple Translation

Oh the people of this samsAram, who are without the strength to come out of it and who are repeatedly experiencing the seven stages of unending sorrows, namely dwelling in womb, birth, infancy, youthfulness, old age, death and hell! I will instruct you a good way to come out, listen to me. Get rid of the bewilderment of looking at your body as the soul, meditate on the first line of thiruviruththam, a divine prabandham mercifully composed by nammAzhwAr, live without any burden and attempt to separate the soul which is distinct from this body so as to reach SrlvaikuNtam.

vyAkhyAnam (commentary)

The vyAkhyAnam for this thaniyan has been written by piLLailOkam jIyar.

The first line shows the fault of samsAram.

karuviruththak kuzhi nlththapin – this speaks about the first stage among the seven stages of life, viz. being in the womb, being born, being an infant, being young, reaching old age, death and being punished in hell. The term *karu* refers to being in the womb. *iruththak kuzhi* refers to the pit which has been placed. Mother is like a bag which has been kept to hold the foetus. Alternatively, when considered as *viruththak kuzhi*, this could also refer to the repeated births in samsAram (*viruththam* in samskrutham refers to ring, rotating repeatedly). *kuzhi nlththapin* – getting rid of the womb and entering the stage of being an infant who is without any knowledge, experiencing the sorrows of that stage (expecting assistance from mother even for taking bath, eating etc).

kAmak kadum kuzhi vlzhndhu – Just as it says in thiruvAimozhi 7-8-7 “ *thuyaram sey kAmangaLAy* ” (desires which inflict sorrows), periyAzhwAr thirumozhi 5-2-7 “ *vazhukki angOr muzhaiyinil pukkittu azhundhikkidandhu uzhalvEnai* ” (slipping into a cave called as hell (samsAram) and roaming inside it without knowing the way out), periyA thirumozhi 6-3-4 “ *sAndhEndhu menmulaiyAr thadandhOL puNar inba veLLaththu AzhndhEn arunaragaththu azhundhum payan padaiththEn* ” ((in earlier days) I had immersed in the ocean of pleasures by embracing the rounded shoulders of women who had applied vermilion on their bosoms. As a result of this, I attained the result of being in the quagmire of cruel hell, called as samsAram), falling into the cruel pit of lust

oru viruththam pukku – after exhausting the phase of being engaged with worldly pursuits, entering old age which is unique. thirumangai AzhwAr mercifully described the fault in old age in his periyA thirumozhi pAsuram 1-3-1 “ *muRRa mUththuk kOl thuNaiyA* ” ((being infirm) having a stick as support after attaining complete old age).

uzhaluRuvIr – calling out to those who are repeatedly suffering the pain of old age, death and punishment in hell. They keep going continuously between the mother’s womb and the lasso of yama, when he pulls the AthmA for undergoing punishment in hell.

Alternatively, *oru viruththam pukku* would also refer to engaging in improper conduct and getting entrapped in such behaviour.

Instead of getting trapped like this,

uyirin porulgatku – Just as it is mentioned in thiruvAimozhi pAsuram 1-2-10 “*annalaththu oNporuL*” (jlvAthma entities (souls) which have distinguished qualities such as knowledge etc), for the jlvAthmAs who are qualified to enjoy the experience of emperumAn. If the text is *uyirin poruLukku*, it would refer to the benefits of jlvAthmAs instead of benefits of the physical bodies in which they reside.

oru viruththam pugudhAmal – instead of entering even a part of such avoidable obstacles. Not approaching any of such poor conducts. This AzhwAr himself (nammAzhwAr) has said in thiruviruththam pAsuram 9 “*nadAviya kURRam*” (the lord of death who rules over cupid; in other words, one can overcome even death, but it is almost impossible to overcome the attraction of lustful objects). nammAzhwAr has also said in (a) thiruvAimozhi 10-2-5 “*ippiRappu aRukkum*” (emperumAn will rid the jlvAthmA of this samsAram), (b) thiruvAimozhi 6-2-9 “*azhiththAy un thiruvadiyAl*” (destroyed with your divine feet), (c) thiruvAimozhi 1-7-2 “*adiyarai valvinaiththupAm pulan aindhum thunjak kodAn*” (emperumAn will not let his followers to be annihilated being caught in the five senses which stroll through the strong karmas (deeds)), (d) thiruvAimozhi 3-3-9 “*Oyum mUppup piRappu iRappu*” ((emperumAn will get rid of) old age, repeated births and deaths which create tiredness), (e) periya thiruvandhAdhi 23 “*iLaikka naman thamargaL paRRi iLaippeydha nAy thandhu mOdhamal nalguvAn*” (emperumAn will shower his mercy on us such that the followers of yama (the lord of justice) will not trouble us by catching us firmly and by letting dogs on us) and (f) thirumazhisai AzhwAr in nAnmugan thiruvandhAdhi 88 “*uyir koNdu udalozhiya Odum pOdhu OdiayarvenRa thIrppAn*” (when the followers of yama take the follower of emperumAn’s AthmA from the body (to punish it in hell), emperumAn runs on his own and removes the hurdles).

kurugaiyar kOn uraiththa – mercifully spoken by satakOpan, the leader of thirukkurugUr.

thiruviruththaththu Oradi kaRRu irIr – recite one line in thiruviruththam which was composed as the first prabandham (divine hymn, among the four divine hymns) by nammAzhwAr. One line is enough for uplifting yourself. Learn it through the method of “*AchArya uchchAraNa anuchchAraNa*” (AchArya (one’s teacher) would recite a line or phrase once; the disciple will recite the same, twice) and be firmly rooted in it.

Why should this be recited?

thirunAttagaththE – In order to reach SrlvaikuNtam. One can attain SrlvaikuNtam by meditating on one’s shortcomings such as ignorance etc. If one were fully engaged in matters relating to emperumAn, no hurdle will enter. Reciting the hymns of others will be a cause for bondage in samsAram whereas reciting the hymns of nammAzhwAr is the cause for liberation from samsAram.

Thus, by learning the good words of nammAzhwAr from one’s AchArya and reciting them, one can sustain oneself without any fear, getting rid of samsAram and attaining the distinguished *paramapadham* (SrlvaikuNtam).

Next, we will take up the vyAkhyAna pravESam (introduction to the commentary) mercifully written by periyavAchchAn piLLai.

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2. pravESam

vyAkhyAna pravESam

Having mercifully decided in his divine mind to write the vyAkhyAnam (commentary) for thiruviruththam, periyavAchchAn piLLai starts to describe the greatness of nammAzhwAr who has composed this prabandham.

Some people call AzhwAr [whenever the term AzhwAr alone is mentioned, it usually refers to nammAzhwAr], as *mukthar* (one who had been liberated from samsAram (materialistic realm) and had attained SrlvaikuNtam). One follower of aruLALapperumAL emperumAnAr [a disciple of bhagavadh Srl rAmAnujar] would say that AzhwAr is a *mukthaprAyar* (one who is on par with mukthAthmAs and possibly living in SwEthadhwlpam (the land mass in which we live is called as jambudhwlpam; SwEthadhwlpam is another land mass, but in a different galaxy)). Some other people will say that emperumAn ordained someone there (in SrlvaikuNtam) to be born on earth. vangipuraththu nambi (a disciple of bhagavath Srl rAmAnujar) had said that emperumAn himself took the incarnation of nammAzhwAr. All these have been said in view of AzhwAr's greatness.

If AzhwAr had been one among the mukthars who had been sent by emperumAn, he would have waited thinking "We (it was normal during those times to address the self in plural instead of in singular number) have been ordained to come to this earth; once our goal has been reached, we will return to SrlvaikuNtam. Hence why should we make a fuss for this?" However, since AzhwAr kept calling out to emperumAn, just as he had mercifully said (a) in thiruviruththam pAsuram 1 "*inninRa nIrmayAm uRamai*" (We do not want to put up with this nature of being born repeatedly in this samsAram) (b) thiruvAimozhi 6-9-9 "*pala nI kAttipaduppAyO*" (will you display many types of worldly pursuits to me so that I get attached to them, and perish in the bargain?) (c) thiruvAimozhi 2-6-8 "*mARi mARip pala piRappum piRandhu*" (being born repeatedly in various births) (d) thiruvAimozhi 7-1-10 "*mun paravai kadaindu amudham koNda mUrththiyO*" (Are you the one who in an earlier time churned the ocean and gave nectar to the celestial entities and helped them?) it is clear that he was one among the samsAris, having been born here repeatedly and suffered. In a country without a king, a person on whom the elephant places the garland becomes the new king. In the same way, emperumAn searched and located a samsAri on whom he showered his grace.

A question arises here. Could a person, who had been suffering for a long time in samsAram, change like this (gaining knowledge about matters related to emperumAn and becoming deeply devoted to him)? Srl vishNu purANam 5-6-28 says "*brindhAvanam bhagavathA krushNEnAklihta karmaNA | SubhEna manasA dhyAtham gavAm vrudhdim aplpsadha ||*" (brindhAvan, which was like a forest of thorns got a facelift due to the incarnation of krishNa who is capable of carrying out great deeds; cows became healthy due to his divine mind). Srl vishNu purANam 5-6-37 says "*uthpanna navachashbhAtyam*" (Fresh grass sprouted). Thus a forest of thorns became converted into a verdant land mass due to emperumAn. In the same way, AzhwAr too got changed due to emperumAn's grace.

In the next article, we will take up the first pAsuram.

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3. pAsuram 1 – poy ninRa

avathArikai (Introduction)

emperumAn shows to AzhwAr the greatness of his *svarUpam* (basic nature), *rUpam* (divine form), *guNam* (auspicious qualities) as well as his wealth of *nithya vibhUthi* (SrlvaikuNtam) and *leelA vibhUthi* (materialistic realm). AzhwAr realises the knowledge, activities and the way the nithyAthmAs (permanent dwellers of *nithya vibhUthi*) and *mukthAthmAs* (those who have reached *nithya vibhUthi* after being liberated from *leelA vibhUthi*) live there. He also thinks about his situation in *samsAram* which is the exact opposite of those who dwell in *nithya vibhUthi* and appeals to emperumAn to sever his connection with *prakruthi* (*samsAram*) which is a hurdle for his enjoying emperumAn.

AzhwAr has been granted knowledge and devotion by emperumAn without any cause. When such is the situation, why should he, like ordinary people, appeal to emperumAn to sever his hurdles, just as it is said in bhagavath glthA SIOkam 7-29 “*jarA maraNa mOkshAya mamASrithya yadhanthiyE*” (those who wish to rid themselves of old age and death should attain me)? Just as a beloved would remove all the dirt from her person before uniting with her beloved and just as a prince, who is to be coronated, gets rid of his diseases, AzhwAr too wishes severance from *samsAram* as a prelude to enjoying emperumAn. Is this desire arising out of his love towards emperumAn or out of fear for *samsAram*? It is for both reasons, says the commentator, just like *maharAjar* (*sugrIva*) had love towards *perumAL* (*Srl rAma*) and fear towards *vAli*.

Why is the AzhwAr projecting emperumAn’s followers in the forefront in many pAsurams in this prabandham? When a creeper plant starts growing, it needs the support of poles before it can be taken on to a *pandhal* (broad network of sticks). Followers of emperumAn serve a similar purpose. Just as it is said in (a) thiruviruththam 1 “*imaiyOr thalaivA*” (Oh the lord of nithyasUris), (b) thiruvAimozhi 3-7-10 “*adiyAr adiyAr tham adiyAr*” ((we are the servitors of) the followers of the followers of emperumAn’s followers), (3) thiruvAimozhi 2-3-10 “*adiyArgal kuzhAngaLai udan kUduvadhu enRukoLO*” (when will I unite with the groups of emperumAn’s followers?) (d) thiruvAimozhi 10-9-11 “*andhamil pErinbaththu adiyarOdu irundhamai*” (being united with nithyasUris who are present in the great hall of SrlvaikuNtam which has unending happiness), they serve the role of AchAryan (teacher who guides) when attaining emperumAn’s divine feet. They are also required to console when there is *Udal* (love-quarrel) with emperumAn. Since both in the first pAsuram “*inninRa nIrmal*” (the nature of sorrow arising out of repeated births) and in the final pAsuram “*azundhAr piRappAm*” (will not get drowned in the reason for being born in *samsAram*), the meaning is similar, it could be taken that the entire prabandham is centred around AzhwAr requesting emperumAn to rid him [AzhwAr] of his hurdles which prevent him from enjoying emperumAn.

poy ninRa gyAnamum pollA ozhukkum azhukkudambum

inninRa nIrmal iniyAm uRAmai uyir aLippAn

enninRa yOniyumAyp piRandhAy imaiyOr thalaiva

meynninRu kEttaruLay adiyEn seyyum viNNappamE

Word-by-Word Meanings

uyir – all the created entities

aLippAn – to protect

enninRa – many different types

yOniyumAy – births

piRandhAy – Oh one who incarnated!

imaiyOr – for nithyasUris (permanent dwellers of SrlvaikuNtam)

thalaivA – Oh one who is the Lord!

poynninRa – not being truthful

(considering body as the soul)

gyAnamum – knowledge

pollA ozhukkum – bad conduct

azhukku – deficient

udambum – body

(being like this)

inninRa – of this nature

nIрмаi – quality

ini – from now onwards

yAm – we

uRAmai – such that we do not attain

adiyEn – I, who am your servitor

seyyum – make

mey – reality

viNNappam – appeal

ninRu – remaining firm

kEttaruLAy – please listen to, mercifully

Simple Translation

Oh one who incarnated in many births in order to protect all the creatures! Oh the lord of nithyasUris (permanent dwellers of SrlvaikuNtam)! We should be without these births which are the cause for our sorrow and which are with knowledge which is the opposite of truth (we should be without faulty knowledge), with wrongful deeds, physical forms which are full of impurity etc. You should stand firmly and hear my appeal to you from me, your servitor, for the sake of this.

vyAkhyAnam

poy ninRa gyAnamum – this term refers to the knowledge which considers that which is not self as the self, viz. considers body which is not the soul, as the soul. This is called as *anyathA gyAnam* (inaccurate or erroneous knowledge); it is erroneous knowledge because it is about *prakruthi* (primordial matter which is the raw material for all creations) and *prAkrutham* (those which are derived from *prakruthi*); instead of knowledge about true meanings, it is knowledge about untruths. Srl vishNu purANam 6-5-87 says “*thathgyAnam agyAnamanthOnyadhuktham*” (that by which we know emperumAn is knowledge; all the rest are only false knowledge). How can we say that whatever is seen by the eyes in *prakruthi* is false knowledge? It is not the way that *baudhdha* follower says as false or *mAyAvAdhi* (one who is a follower of *adhvaitham*) says as *thuchcham* (non-existing). The opinion is that whatever is seen in *prakruthi* is not like *AthmA* (soul). Just as it is said in Srl vishNu purANam 2-13-100 “*yaththu kAlAntharENApinAnyasamgyAmupaithivai pariNAMAdhisambhUthAn thadhvasthu nrupadhachchakim*” (that for which this world which keeps changing is present and that which does not change at all, though in the grip of time) *AthmA* does not change unlike the other objects. This remains the same all the time. Since the other objects keep changing constantly, AzhwAr refers to them as false knowledge. **ninRa** refers to the fact that these objects have been existing in this *samsAram* from time immemorial. **gyAnamum** – the state where one who sees *prakruthi*, which is insentient, as something great, leading to the state where self becomes equally insentient. The erroneous knowledge which results from such a state, including mistaking body for *AthmA*.

pollA ozhukkum – *bhagavath kainkaryam* (carrying out service to emperumAn) will result from having truthful knowledge. When knowledge is erroneous, activities also become erroneous, and would result in not carrying out service to emperumAn. The basic nature of *AthmA* is to carry out service to emperumAn, just as lakshmaNa had told Srl rAma in Srl rAmAyaNam ayOdhyA kANdam 31-25 “*aham sarvam kariyshyAmi*” (I will carry out all services to you) and 31-22 “*kurushva mAm anucharaNam*” (you should order me to carry out service to you). Instead of being like this, one thinks “I am doing” and indulges in all activities other than carrying out service to emperumAn.

azhukkudambum – the insentient *prakruthi* which is the cause for the above two mentioned characteristics. We can also consider this term to refer to the physical form which is misconstrued as *AthmA* (*ahankAram* or ego) and those which are considered as one’s own, even though they are not (*mamakAram* or possessiveness). Even mahAbhAratham could not state clearly the difference between *prakruthi* and *purusha* (body and *AthmA*) just as one cannot clearly separate hay from jackfruit with which it is stuck. However, AzhwAr, since he has been showered with faultless knowledge and devotion by emperumAn, differentiates between *prakruthi* and *purusha* through these three terms:

poy ninRa gyAnam – by terming *prakruthi* as false, the correctness of *AthmA* has been established.

pollA ozhukku – due to the connection with physical form, one thinks “I am doing”; however, carrying out service to emperumAn is always the basic nature of *AthmA*.

azhukkudambu – if there is no connection between *AthmA* and the physical form (which is the effect of *prakruthi*), *AthmA* is full of true knowledge.

inninRa nlrmai – the nature which has got destabilised like this. ammani ammAL would say that AzhwAr is explaining his position as well that of the people of the world through these words just like a person, who has been hurt badly, would display his blood stained clothes. swAmy ALavandhAr would say – just like the sages of dhaNdakAraNyam who had been hurt by demons would show their scars to Srl rAma, as mentioned in Srl rAmAyaNa AraNya kANdam SIOkam 6-16 “*Ehi paSyA SarIrAni*” (look at our forms), AzhwAr is showing his *AthmA* which has been tortured by *samsAram*. *poy ninRa gyAnam* . . .

. – just like a person who has injuries on his physical form would display them, AzhwAr says “look at this injury; look at this hurt”, displaying the injuries inflicted on his AthmA.

inninRa nlrmai – this is remaining in a situation when one does not listen to AchArya’s instructions and neither does he listen to the instructions of SAsthras (sacred texts) which are authentic.

ini – The time when one thought “I am capable of taking care of myself; why should I depend on emperumAn?” has gone. The situation now is “I do not want anything other than what has been given by you”

yAm – AzhwAr is making the appeal on behalf of all the people since he is able to feel the worthless situation of others and hence is stating this in plural.

uRAmai – incongruent; not affected. Just as it is said in pUrvamImAmsai “SAsthra palam prayOkthari” (only the person who is going to get benefitted should take efforts to attain it), emperumAn asks of AzhwAr “Since I am considering attaining you as my benefit, I have created several paths such as karmayOgam, gyAnayOgam, bhakthiyOgam etc (the paths of carrying out deeds, gaining knowledge and devotion respectively); why don’t you attain me choosing one of those paths?” AzhwAr responds saying “Please state the purpose of your taking various incarnations” periya thiruvandhAdhi pAsuram 56 says “*oruvARu oruvan pugAvARu uRumARum Ayavar thAm*” (in order to ensure that no sentient entity enters some path [which may not lead to liberation from samsAram] emperumAn incarnated as the cowherd boy, krishNa). If emperumAn takes such care of us, why should anyone follow any other path?

uyir – did you come here for the sake of pirAttimArs (consorts), thiruvadi (garudan), ananthan (AdhiSEshan) et al?

aLippAn – did anyone request you to come and incarnate as a human being? Was it not out of your mercy that your incarnations took place? emperumAn himself says in bhagavath glthA 4-5 “*bahUni*” (many incarnations), confirming that he had taken up many incarnations.

enninRa yOniyumAy – just as it is said in Srl rAmAyaNam yudhdha kANDam “*AthmAnam mAnusham manyE*” (I consider myself as a mere man), emperumAn takes incarnations as per his wish.

piRandhAy – emperumAn also takes a birth similar to other human beings, unlike his other incarnations such as narasimha when he appeared suddenly from a pillar or when he came to help the elephant gajEndhran when the elephant called out to him. Srl rAmAyaNam bAla kANDam SIOkam says “*thathaScha dhvAdhaSEmAsE*” (he remained in his mother kauSalyA dhEvi’s womb for twelve months instead of the normal ten months that we all remain for). periyaAzhwAr thirumozhi 3-2-8 also reflects the same meaning “*panniru thingaL*” (twelve months in mother’s womb).

imaiyOr thalaivA – Just as it is said in thiruviruththam pAsuram 21 “*sUttu nan mAlaigaL*” (holding nice garlands ready for adorning emperumAn with ...), isn’t emperumAn one who is having nithyasUris in paramapadham as those who are “Dear to me”? Did he incarnate here since he was not satisfied with nithyasUris alone and wanted to invite those who have shortcomings in their knowledge here? When he became the controller for us too, he became one without any shortcoming.

sarvESwaran told AzhwAr “If nithyasUris make an appeal to me like this, I would consider that to be a statement of fact. But how can I take your words, when you have been in samsAram from time immemorial, to be true? For how long will these words remain truthful? If I go to people thinking that

they are truly calling out to me, they may ask for benefits other than me”. To which AzhwAr responds saying

mey – it is not that way. Our appeal is indeed truthful. Just as sthOthra rathnam SIOkam 57 says “*vigyApanam idham sathyam*” (this is a truthful appeal), our appeal too, to you, is truthful.

ninRu – AzhwAr started his appeal with the first pAsuram in thiruviruththam and ended with thiruvAimozhi 10.7.10 “*mangavottu un mAmAyai*” (rid us of this bondage in samsAram).

kEttaryLAy – to listen to this is apt for emperumAn. It is only till such time that AzhwAr makes the appeal that AzhwAr has any shortcoming. Once he has enunciated it, if emperumAn does not initiate any action on it, the resulting lowliness is his and not AzhwAr’s.

emperumAn is puzzled that someone, who is in samsAram, is making an appeal without expecting any worldly benefit, which is much against the normal behaviour of a samsAri. His words are totally contrary to those of a samsAri. He wonders as to who it is, who is making such an appeal

adiyEn – AzhwAr says that he is emperumAn’s servitor. Had he said, “I”, it would have been at loggerheads with the words spoken thus far. Hence he says “Servitor”

seyyum viNNappam – Had he said “I” in the previous verse, he would have said “Words spoken” here. However, since he said “Servitor” he says “Appeal made”.

vyAkyAthA (commentator for this pAsuram) periyavAchchAn piLLai shows further that this pAsuram explains artha panchakam (five meanings) – svasvarUpam (nature of self, the jIvAthmA), parasvarUpam (nature of paramAthmA, emperumAn), upAya svarUpam (nature of means, the path which leads us to our goal), upEya svarUpam (nature of goal) and virOdhi svarUpam (nature of hurdle). The words *poyninRa gyAnam* and *inninRa nIrmay* explain the nature of hurdles. The words *enninRa yOniyumAyp piRandhAy* reveal the nature of means. The words *imaiyOr thalaivA* explain the nature of goal. The word *adiyEn* explains the nature of self. The words *seyyum viNNappam* reveal that kinkaryam (to emperumAn) is the benefit that one gets on attaining the goal.

We will take up the second pAsuram in the next article.

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4. pAsuram 2 – sezhu nIr

avathArikai (Introduction)

In the previous pAsuram, AzhwAr had called out to emperumAn as “ *imaiyOr thalaiva* ” (lord of nithyasUris), referring to emperumAn’s quality of supreme masculinity. He wanted to attain emperumAn immediately. Since that did not fructify, he assumed the pathos of a lady. Is it possible for a man to assume the mental make-up of a lady? Srl rAmAyaNa ayOdhyA kANdam SIOkam 3-79 says “ *pumsAm dhrushti chiththApahAriNam* ” (Srl rAma would steal the eyes and minds of men). Since that was possible, this also is possible. While it is possible, how is it that AzhwAr donned the role of a noble damsel instead of a normal lady? This is so because AzhwAr felt supremely happy when united with emperumAn, felt very dejected when separated from him and wanted to enjoy and perform service to emperumAn with all his faculties [of mind, body and speech]. While this is acceptable, how is it that he also assumed the conduct of the mother as well as friend of the damsel? Just as excess water during severe flood breaches river and flows into its tributaries and canals before reaching the ocean, since the matter which AzhwAr is experiencing (viz., emperumAn) is without any limit, his supreme affection makes it possible for him to don various roles (of the damsel, her friend and her mother).

How did AzhwAr reach such a situation? emperumAn had shown him the hurdles (inimical entities to be avoided) in samsAram, had prevented any taste for these in AzhwAr and had also shown him his *nithyavibhUthi* (SrlvaikuNtam). After seeing the profound knowledge which those who dwell in *nithyavibhUthi* have as well as the exchanges between them and emperumAn and the distinction which that place has, a craving developed in AzhwAr which will not allow him to rest until he attained that place. Even after he developed a desire towards SrlvaikuNtam and prayed to emperumAn to grant him that, why did emperumAn not grant him his wish? emperumAn delayed granting AzhwAr his wish immediately, thinking in his divine mind “Let us create a distinction between AzhwAr and other samsAris, make him unaware of anything other than us. We will make him not expect anything from us (other than ourselves), and to make him call out to us constantly, even if without any reason. We will then grant him servitude towards us, which is his basic nature. Then we will enable him to attain us. We will do all these when he remains steadfast that we alone matter”. After AzhwAr was granted faultless knowledge about emperumAn in the previous pAsuram, he now craves that he should attain emperumAn immediately.

Why should emperumAn make him wait? When guests come to a house, they are provided food, keeping the inmates of the house hungry. In the same way, one can see that emperumAn keeps those who are totally devoted to him, waiting, while granting the wishes of others who are not that devoted to him. We could see this (a) in the way he fulfilled kaikEyi’s wishes (of denying him the crown and sending him to forest) while making bharatha to wait for fourteen years and (b) in the way he made slthAppirAtti to wait while fulfilling the desire of maharAjar (sugrIvan). What is the reason for fulfilling desires of those who are not that devoted to him, immediately? This is because the wishes of others last only for a short while. Will he not help those who are totally devoted to him? He does that as we could see from the way he helped bharatha to carry only his sandals on his head and not the crown.

While the *nAyaki* (leading lady) and her friend go to the garden to pluck flowers, the *nAyaka* (leading man) also, by chance, reaches that place. The friend, again by chance, leaves the garden, leaving the leading lady and man to be together. They unite with each other and separate too. The leading lady thought that separation is also a form of union only. Due to separation from her beloved, the lady is in

distress. The friend, who returns, finds out all these and resolves that she should help the lady to regain her existence. She wishes her well saying “What situation is she in! This condition should continue like this” (meaning that the leading lady should continue to be affectionate towards her beloved).

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings.

sezhunlr thadaththuk kayal miLirndhAloppach chEyarikka N

azhunlr thuLumba alamaruginRana vAzhivarO

muzhunlr mugilvaNNan kaNNan viNNAttavar mUdhuvarAm

thozhunlr adiyiNaikke anbu sUttiya sUzhkuzhaRkE

Word-by-Word Meanings

muzhu – replete

nlr – having imbibed water

mugil – like a cloud

vaNNan – one who has the complexion

kaNNan – krishNa, who is obedient (to his followers)

mUdhuvarAm – being ahead of all others in terms of time

viNNAttavar – nithyasUris who dwell in paramapadham

thozhum – apt to be attained [and worshipped]

nlr – having it as the basic nature

iNai – being together

adikke – at the divine feet

anbu – garland of love

sUttiya – one who offered

sUzh – being curled

kuzhaRku – she, who has locks

sezhum – beautiful

nlr – having water

thadaththu – in the pond

kayal – fish

miLirndhAloppa – like rolling

sE – reddish

ari – having lines

kaN – the eyes

azhu – crying

nIr – tears

thuLumba – to be agitated

alamaruginRana – to be bewildered

Simple Translation

The divine feet of krishNa who is having the complexion of a cloud replete with water, are constantly worshipped by nithyasUris, who came ahead of all others. A girl with curly hair and whose eyes roam around here and there like fish in a beautiful, water-filled pond, offers her garland of love to such divine feet. Her eyes which have reddish lines, are shedding tears and are bewildered since she is separated from emperumAn. Let her condition, in which her love is blooming, remain forever.

vyAkhyAnam

sezhunIrth thadaththuk kayal miLirndhAl oppa – (her eyes) are like fish which keep moving from left to right and back to left, in a pond which has pure water. The greatness of what is being compared with is so high that the simile needs a correction. In other words, the fish will not equal her eyes in all ways; they could, to an extent be like her eyes. The eyes are having such greatness.

sEyarikkaN azhunIr thuLumba – her eyes, which are similar to the ones mentioned in Srl rAmAyaNam sundhara kANdam 16-5 “*asithEkshaNa*” (slthA with black eyes), are shedding tears copiously. While it is the leading man [here, it is emperumAn] who should shed tears after looking at her beautiful eyes, she is shedding tears. The condition in which the eyes shed tears due to separation from emperumAn is the basic nature of an AthmA (soul). Seeing such a sight is what is acceptable to her friends. Her friend thought “My desire has been fulfilled (of seeing her condition like this); her desire too should be fulfilled”. Even emperumAn does not witness such a situation [where those who separate from him shed tears and wail], as brought out in Srl rAmAyaNam sundhara kANdam 33-4 “*kim artham*” (looking at the tears in the eyes of slthAppirAtti, hanumAn asked her “What is the reason for the tears in your eyes?”) Srl rAma learnt the reason for the tears through hanumAn and did not directly know from her. Looking at the tears, the friend asks the leading lady “What is the reason for your tears? Thinking of whom are you in this condition?”

alamaruginRana – her (the leading lady’s) eyes are bewildered.

vAzhiaYO – She tells the leading lady “Let this disheartening condition of yours sustain” (since the leading lady is pining for emperumAn’s love). Is there anyone who complimented on seeing the disheartening condition of someone else? Srl rAmAyaNam AraNya kANdam 67-15 “*yAmOshadhivAyushman*” jatAyu praised Srl rAma “May you live long” even though Srl rAma was in distress [searching for slthAppirAtti].

muzhu nIr mugil vaNNan kaNNan – Unlike the clouds which are mentioned in mEghasandhESam 1-5 “*dhUmajyOthis salilamaruthAm sannipAdha*” (a mixture of fire and smoke), the complexion of kaNNan (krishNa) was that of a cloud which did not have smoke but had only water. It appeared as if the cloud had imbibed entire water from the ocean, making the floor of the ocean visible. Such a dark cloud.

emperumAn who has such a complexion, totally enticed her. She was enticed not only by his complexion, but by his simplicity too. When a *sarpayAgam* (a ritual to bring all the snakes to one place) is held, just as all the snakes gather at that place, while everyone goes to krishNa, he comes to her, falling for her. She got caught by such a person!

viNNAttavar mUdhuvar – Just as it is said in purusha sUktham “*yathra pUrvE sAdhyAs santhi dhEvA:*” and in yajur vEdham “*yathra rushaya: prathamajAyE purANA:*” the nithyasUris are far ahead of all others, in terms of time; they are ancient. Their sustenance is only through worshipping emperumAn’s divine feet.

thozhu nlr – they remain with worshipping as their basic nature. It is just as it has been said in mahAbharatham mausala parvam 166-40 “*nama ithyEvAdhina:*” (they constantly say “Our salutations to you”)

iNai adikke – the two divine feet where each is an exact match for the other. If a person is very beautiful in one limb of his physical form he may think “Who is as beautiful as I am?” When a person is obedient (servitude) towards one person alone, he may think “Who is as obedient as I?” and when a person is controlling a few persons he may think “Who controls as much as I do?” *parathathvam* (being supreme) is a combination of all these, without any shortcoming. Did this leading lady not fall for such a supreme entity!

adikke anbu sUttiya – wouldn’t the others, who have been won over by a person’s sheer simplicity, fall at the feet of that person! Why use the term *sUttiya* (to adorn)? It is similar to thiruvAimozhi 4-3-2 “*vAsagam sey mAlaiyE*”(garland strung with words).

sUzh kuzhaRke – locks which are curled; alternatively, locks which attract others and make them to follow.

In the next article, we shall take up the 3rd pAsuram.

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5. pAsuram 3 – kuzhaRkOvalar

avathArikai (Introduction)

In the previous pAsuram, unable to bear the pain of separation from emperumAn, the leading lady had assumed the pathos of her friend; she assumed the shyness typical of a girl and mentioned about her sorrows. Since she is sure that she can sustain herself only if she speaks to her friend, she asks her “My heart has gone behind him. Will it return or will it stay there itself?”

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

kuzhaRkOvalar madappAvaiyum maNmagaLum thiruvum
nizhaRpOlvanar kaNdu niRkungol meeLungol thaNNandhuzhAy
azhaRpOladum chakkaraththaNNal viNNOr thozhak kadavum
thazhaRpOl sinaththa appuLLin pOna thani nenjamE

Word-by-Word Meanings

thaN – being cool
am – being beautiful
thuzhAy – divine thuLasi
azhal pO l – like hot
adum – roasting
chakkaram – having sudharSana disc in his hand
aNNal – sarvESvaran, who is the lord
viNNOr – nithyasUris (permanent dwellers of SrlvaikuNtam)
thozha – to be worshipped
kadavum – conducting
thazhal pOl – like fire
sinaththa – having anger
appuLLin – behind that garuthmAn (garuda)
pin – following
pOna – one who followed
thani – without any support
nenjam – mind
kuzhal – having locks

kOvalar – born in cow-herd clan

madam – being obedient

pAvaiyum – nappinnai pirAtti (neeLA dhEvi)

maNmagaLum – Srl bhUmi pirAtti

thiruvum – and periya pirAtti (Srl mahAlakshmi)

nizhal pOlvanar – being like shadow (to followers) (and invigorating)

these three pirAttimArs,

kaNdu – after seeing them

niRkungol – will it stay there itself?

meeLungol – will it return?

Simple Translation

One who dons the cool and beautiful divine thuLasi garland, one who has the *chakrAyudham* (weapon in the form of disc) which roasts enemies like fire, is worshipped by nithyasUris. garuda is conducted by such emperumAn and his anger is like fire. My mind went behind such garuda. After seeing nappinnaip pirAtti who has beautiful locks and who incarnated in the clan of cowherds, bhUmippirAtti and periya pirAtti, will my mind stay there itself or will it return to me?

vyAkhyAnam

kuzhaR kOvalar madappAvai – cowherds with flutes. Just like brAhmaNas will carryout sandhyAvandanam (worshipping the conjunction of day and night) as their norm, this (playing of flutes) is typical of cowherds. Alternatively, this term would refer to nappinnaip pirAtti, who has beautiful locks and was obedient towards them.

maNmagal – Srl bhUmip pirAtti

thiru – periya pirAtti.

periya pirAtti will condone the faults of those who attain her. Srl bhUmippirAtti will say “Why should one look at the faults and then condone them? It is better not to look at the faults”; nappinnaip pirAtti will be the epitome of forbearance and forgiveness. She will make emperumAn not to look at our faults. periya pirAtti is the repository of all of emperumAn’s wealth. bhUmippirAtti is the land where this wealth is nurtured. nappinnaip pirAtti is the one who makes emperumAn to enjoy the wealth.

nizhaR pOlvanar – these three pirAttis are like shadow for emperumAn, never separating from him. Alternatively, they will be shadow for one another; another interpretation – they will be shadow (a source of invigoration) for their followers.

kaNdu niRkungol meeLungol – After looking at emperumAn and his consorts in this condition, will my mind stay there permanently, taking them as its refuge? After looking at their greatness etc, will be mind be tossed about, just like a piece of crumb is tossed about by the waters of an ocean?

thaN am thuzhAy azhaRpOl adum chakkaraththu aNNal – one who has the divine thuLasi which emits coolness and sweet fragrance and who also has the divine disc which emits hot winds like fire. Due to her separation from emperumAn, even the cool thuLasi appears like fire, burning her. As an example for the emission of heat from thuLasi, she cites the divine disc which is fiery. In other words, even while citing an example, she could only think of entities which are closely connected to emperumAn. She cannot think of anything other than matters related to him. The divine disc does not distinguish between followers and enemies. While it will be a decoration for followers, it would be a weapon for enemies, hurting both, one through its beauty and the other, through its state of weaponry. In the case of divine thuLasi, it will be apt for followers. The lady says that even thuLasi is hurting her, like the divine disc.

aNNal – by holding the divine disc such that it does not slip out of his hands, he made me submit to him totally.

thazhaRpOl sinaththa – having an anger which appears like a raging fire

viNNOr thozhak kadavum – emperumAn conducts periya thiruvadi (garuda) such that they [nithyasUris] worship him (emperumAn). They are the ones who worship and he is the one who is worshipped. Their sustenance is through worshipping emperumAn.

appuLLin pOna – she is not worried about her difficulties. She is celebrating the fact that there are those who are concerned about emperumAn. She says that her mind went behind that garudan rather than behind emperumAn himself, since he is loving towards emperumAn. The commentator cites reference to periya thirumozhi pAsuram 11-1-9 “*keNdai oN*” whose meaning is as follows: My eyes which are like carp (a kind of fish) will sleep and my complexion will be healthy only when beetles blow on me, the fragrance of thuLasi from the garland submitted by SrlvaishNavas who are *ananyaprayOjanars*. The term *ananyaprayOjanar* refers to those who carry out activities without expecting any benefit or those who do not know what benefit they will attain. Why should this term be brought in here? This is to emphasise that while there are many who are loving towards her beloved [emperumAn], there are those, like the beetle, who are caring towards her without expecting any benefit.

thani nenjam – independent mind. Even when she tells it “Do not go behind emperumAn” it goes behind him and does not return.

svApadhEsam (distinguished/internal meaning of the pAsuram): By referring to pirAttimArs and nithyasUris, she [AzhwaR in feminine pathos] affirms the superiority of emperumAn and says that affection towards SrlvaikuNtanAthan (the lord of SrlvaikuNtam) was created in her.

In the next article, we will see the 4th pAsuram.

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6. pAsuram 4 – thani nenjam

avathArikai (Introduction)

Just as AzhwAr had addressed emperumAn in the first pAsuram as “ *imaiyOr thalaivA* ” (lord of nithyasUris), he had mentioned about how garudan, thuLasi and others, who reside in nithyavibhUthi, had troubled her (AzhwAr in feminine mood) further, so far. Wind joined them now. All these kindled memories of emperumAn more. Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

thani nenjam munnavar puLLE kavarnhadhu thaNNandhuzhAykk

ini nenjam inguk kavarnvadhu yAm ilam nI naduvE

muni vanjap pEychchi mulai suvaiththAn mudi sUdu thuzhAyp

pani nanja mArudhamE emmadhAvi panippiyalvE

Word-by-Word Meanings

thani – distinguished

nenjam – heart

mun – already

avar – that sarvESvaran’s

puLLE – the bird garuda himself (emperumAn’s vehicle)

kavarnhadhu – had stolen

ini – further

yAm – we

ingu – in this place

thaN – being cool

am – beautiful

thuzhAykk – for the divine thuLasi

kavarnvadhu – for stealing

ilam – do not have

muni – having anger

vanjam – having deceit

pEychchi – the demon pUthanA

mulai – bosom

suvaiththAn – krishNa who drank

mudi – in his crown

sUdum – proffered

thuzhAy – divine thuLasi

pani – having coolness

nanjam – being poisonous

(being hurtful)

mArudhamE – Oh wind!

nI – you

naduvE – amidst these

emmadhu – our

Avi – prANan (life)

panippu – shivering

iyalvE – is it its nature? (is it correct?)

Simple Translation

garuda had already stolen my mind completely such that there is no connection between me and my mind. I do not have another mind with me so that his cool thuLasi garland could steal from me. Oh wind which is coming with coolness resulting from pervading through the thuLasi garland which adorns the beautiful crown of krishNa who had drunk milk from the bosom of demon pUthanA who was full of anger and deceit! When I am already struggling like this, is it proper for you to come in between and make me to shiver further?

vyAkhyAnam

thani nenjam – AzhwAr had only his mind; but there are several entities such as garudan, thuLasi, wind etc who were attempting to steal it. Thus, the implication is that those who create hurdles are more in number.

mun avar puLLE kavarndhadhu – Looking at the majestic way in which emperumAn was seated on garuda, I wanted to hug him with the garland on his shoulder. Before I could do it, didn't garuda steal my mind!

avar puL – Because of his distinguished connection with emperumAn, did garudan steal it?

puLLE – garudan did not give scope to others in SrlvaikuNtam such as thuLasi et al to steal my mind. He did that himself.

kavarndhadhu – my mind was insufficient for that garudan too, filling up only half of his stomach.

mun – garuda preceded thuLasi, in stealing my mind.

thaN andhuzhAykkku – for that cool thuLasi garland.

ini nenjam – she tells thuLasi “Even if you remain here firm like a tree, in order to steal my mind, what is going to happen? There is no purpose in staying here saying that you will not leave this place without taking her mind. Your desire will not be fulfilled”.

ingu – she states her position clearly.

yAm ilam – my mind has already gone behind garudan. I, a sinner, am not endowed with several minds so that all of you could steal one mind each. I do not have another mind for thuLasi garland to steal.

ni naduvE – Seeing that the divine thuLasi, after coming to steal my mind, was standing like a tree, it appears that the wind came very fast. While thuLasi, who too is connected to emperumAn, is waiting, what is your urgency? While garudan, thuLasi et al have direct connection with emperumAn, your connection with emperumAn is through them. In other words, you have connection with thuLasi who has direct contact with his divine form.

muni vanjap pEychchi – the demon pUthanA who came with lot of anger and with deceit.

mulai suvaiththAn – he was taking in her milk with plenty of saliva. *periya thirumozhi 1-3-1* says “*peRRa thAy pOl vandha pEychchi perumulai Udu uyirai vaRRa vAngi uNda vAyAn*” (he drank, without leaving anything behind, including her life, through the bosom of the demon pUthanA, who came in the form of his mother yaSOdhA).

mudi sUdu thuzhAy – this wind is bringing the fragrance of thuLasi from the crown of that krishNa. Just as clouds imbibe the waters of ocean and precipitate that as rain everywhere, this wind is also carrying fragrance of thuLasi and spreading it everywhere. He donned the thuLasi garland as easily as he put an end to pUthana.

How did she (AzhwAr in feminine mood) know that emperumAn had thuLasi on his crown?

pani nanjam mArudhamE – the wind which is cool, is now blowing like poison. Just as pUthanA smeared poison on her bosom, the wind has come carrying thuLasi’s fragrance [when in separation, even thuLasi is not welcome]

emmadhu Avi – my prANan (vital air) which is in distress due to garuda, thuLasi, wind et al.

panippu iyalvE – It is natural for my prANan to be in shivers. She asks the wind “Could you, who would cause distress to his enemies, cause distress to his followers too?”

svApadhESam (distinguished/internal meaning): Since AzhwAr had earlier enjoyed sarvESvaran through the faculty of his mind, all the materials which are connected with emperumAn are now reminding him about emperumAn. Since he is in separation from emperumAn, he is in distress and he is speaking about how the cool breeze is troubling the leading lady who is separated from her beloved.

We will take up the 5th pAsuram in the next article.

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7. pAsuram 5 – panippiyalvAga

avathArikai (Introduction)

All the materials in this world are present to remind us about emperumAn. But these thoughts are also hurtful. As said in chAndhOgya upanishath “ *na cha punarAvarthathe* ” (one does not return again), one can reach that land of no return only after getting rid of all the contractions to knowledge. It is only after reaching that place could one know about him and entities connected to him, fully. Wouldn't those entities, which are connected to him, remind about him, only after that? How is it then that it was possible for AzhwAr to be reminded of these entities, even while he was living in this world? The knowledge which AzhwAr had, was not obtained due to his effort. That was granted to him by emperumAn through his causeless mercy. Since he was granted faultless knowledge and devotion by emperumAn, it was possible for him to attain the states of *parabhakthi* (knowledge about emperumAn), *paragyAnam* (inability to sustain self when separated from emperumAn) and *paramabhakthi* (attaining emperumAn) simultaneously, even while living here. Thus, the entities connected with emperumAn are capable of reminding him about emperumAn even when he is still here and they are capable of hurting him, too. This is the nature of his knowledge.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*panippiyalvAga udaiya thaNvAdai ikkAlam ivvUrp panippiyalvellAm thavirndhu erivIsum
andhaNNandhuzhAy panippuyal sOrum thadangaNNi mAmaith thiRaththuk kolAm panippuyal vaNNan
sengOl orunAnRu thadAviyadhE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

panippu – creating chillness

iyalvAga udaiya – having as its nature

thaN – being cool

vAdai – northerly wind

ikkAlam – at the present time

ivvUril – in this place

panippu – making it cold

iyalvellAm – all its basic nature

thavirndhu – leaving aside

eri vIsum – started to emit fire

am – beautiful

thaNNam – having coolness

thuzhAy – for the sake of divine thuLasi

pani – cold

puyal – tears, like a rainfall

sOrum – shedding

thadam – expansive

kaNNi – this girl with eyes

mAmait thiRaththukkolAm – for the sake of beauty

pani – cool

puyal – like a cloud

vaNNan – sarvESvaran, who has such a complexion

sengOl – order

oru nAnRu – today

thadAviyadhu – became bent

Simple Translation

Making things cool is the nature of northerly wind. But even that wind, in this place and at this time, discarding its nature, is emitting fire everywhere. Why did the sceptre of sarvESvaran, who has the quality of a cool, rain-bearing cloud, bend like this? Was it to destroy the complexion of this lady, who desired his beautiful, cool thuLasi and who sheds tears like rain-bearing clouds?

vyAkhyAnam

panippu iyalvAga udaiya thaN vAdai – the northerly wind which has chillness alone as its basic nature.

ikkAlam ivvUr panippu iyalvu ellAm thavirndhu eri vlsum – Since it is emperumAn who changes the basic nature of the wind, at that place and during that time, the wind is bewildered because of him. Many entities stood there, determined to destroy her, by changing their form and nature. When the form and nature of sarvESvaran could change in her case, should one say anything about the entities which follow him! Protection is emperumAn's basic form and mercy is his basic nature. He changed his basic form from being protective to causing harm and his basic nature from being merciful to being cruel. Thus the wind also sheds its basic nature of being cool and emits fire.

am thaNNandhuzhAy panippuyal sOrum thadam kaNNi – She stood there, shedding tears copiously, after desiring sarvESvaran's cool and beautiful thuLasi. Is desiring his divine thuLasi a crime? Even if it were, should one, who has committed such a crime, suffer to this extent? Her eyes are pouring out tears, just like a rain-bearing cloud would let out water that it is bearing. If the tears in her eyes dry up, all the water in the ocean would not be sufficient to fill the eyes again.

mAmaith thiRaththuk kolAm – Was it not for changing her complexion that emperumAn and his entities changed their basic form and nature so arduously?

panippuyal . . . – there are two interpretations for these terms. *pani* would refer to coolness; *puyal* is cloud and *vaNNan* is one who has that complexion. Thus, this combination would refer to emperumAn who removes the three types of anguish (*thApathrayam* which would refer to anguish brought on by self (by indulging in forbidden activities); anguish brought on by nature (floods, cyclone, drought etc);

anguish brought on by emperumAn based on our karma) that samsAris suffer from. Alternatively, the term *vaNNan* could be taken as referring to nature; then this would mean emperumAn who showers mercy without any reason, just like cloud showers rain without expecting anything in return.

sengOI – we suffer due to his orders. Let it be so. We may suffer, but nothing untoward should occur to his sceptre (his orders). In other words, even if the cool wind starts emitting fire, if it had been done under his orders, let me suffer because of that; however, his order should not be crossed.

oru nAnRu thadAviyadhE – to attain her, his sceptre bent a little, today. The lady's mother laments that it should not bend any further.

svApadhEsam (distinguished meaning): While for all the people, in samsAram (materialistic realm), while outside entities (those which are not connected with emperumAn) are favourable, for AzhwAr who cannot sustain himself without emperumAn, even the entities which are close to emperumAn are creating trouble.

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8. pAsuram 6 – thadA viya ambum

arrow which has an expansive edge – the expansive eyes of the leading lady

that which can be felt only after it pierces us – we can feel only after the glance of the leading lady falls on us

arrow together with the bow – expansive eyes together with the eyebrows

crooked arrow – the glance which hurts us in an indirect [hidden] manner

Content Source - <https://divyaprabandham.koyil.org/index.php/2020/11/thiruviruththam-6/>

9. pAsuram 7 – gyAlam panippa

avathArikai (Introduction)

The leading man had told the leading lady that he will return once the monsoon starts. Since he did not return, though monsoon had set in, the lady starts feeling sorrowful. The lady's friend, to console the lady who suffers after seeing the change of season and in order to make her sustain herself in separation, tells the lady "this is not the season that he had said that he would come by", thus bewildering the lady into believing that it is not the monsoon time. She tells the lady that these are not clouds in the sky but they are dark coloured bulls which, due to the enmity between them, have risen to the sky since there isn't sufficient space on the ground for them to fight with each other. The friend denies arrival of monsoon just as those [bhaudhdhas] who deny existence of world by saying that the world which we see with our eyes does not exist. They will say that neither the world nor emperumAn exists. However, the friend says that though monsoon has not arrived, emperumAn exists, as does the world. Is it appropriate to tell a lie like this [denying that monsoon has arrived]? If she had not said this, the leading lady may not live due to separation from her leading man. If she does not live, emperumAn (the leading man) too would not live and with him, the entire wealth [of both spiritual realm and materialistic realm] would become nonexistent.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*gyAlam panippach cheRuththu nannIrittuk kAl sidhaindhu neela vallERu poRA ninRa vAnam idhu
thirumAL kOLam sumandhu pirindhAr kodumai kuzhaRu thaN pUm kAlam koLO aRiyEn vinaiyAttiyEn
kANGinRavE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

idhu – this

neelam – darkening

val – very strong

ERu – bulls

gyAlam – earth

panippa – to tremble

seRuththu – becoming angry

nal nIr – the exulting water

ittu – copiously increasing

kAl sidhaindhu – clawing with their feet

poRA ninRa – fighting

vAnam – sky

(had it not been there)

vinaiyAttiyEn – I, with lot of sins

kANginRa – seeing

thirumAL – consort of Srl (mahAlakshmi)

kOLam – decoration

sumandhu – to bear

pirindhAr – those who separated

kodumai – the cruelty (of their sorrow)

kuzhaRum – saying incoherently

thaN – cool

pU – beautiful

kAlangoLO – is it the (rainy) season

aRiyEn – I am not sure

Simple Translation

(Looking at the monsoon clouds) Are these the skies which appear like bulls which are raring to fight with each other with anger, such that the world trembles, letting out the water from their bodies and scratching the ground with their hoofs? (Or) Are these the cool, beautiful clouds during rainy season which have taken the bluish divine complexion of sarvESvaran, who is the consort of pirAtti, revealing his cruelty due to separation? I, having lot of sins, am unable to know this (she says that looking at the leading lady's sorrowful state is due to her sins)

vyAkhyAnam

gyAlam panippach cheRuththu – the leading lady tells her friend “You could see the entire world trembling on account of the chilly wind and rain, blasting here”. The friend tells the lady “It is not like that. This isn't the rainy season at all. The world is trembling on seeing two bulls which are fighting with each other fiercely”

seRuththu – standing with anger

nannIr ittu – since it had been raining for a while, all the dirt had been wiped off the ground and plenty of pure water has got collected which could be drunk. Looking at that, the lady asks her friend “What is the reason for such copious amount of water?” The friend responds saying “Since these are distinguished bulls which are fighting with each other, water gets generated out of their anger, due to their sweat”

kAl sidhaindhu – this is interpreted in two ways: *kAl* could mean either wind or feet. The lady tells her friend that the wind has stopped and it is raining heavily. The friend tells the lady that it is not like that; since the bulls are fighting with anger, they scratch the surface of earth with their hooves and feet.

neela vALLERu poRA ninRa vAnam idhu – the friend tells the lady “Don’t we see only the sky in which two bulls, which are dark and strong, are fighting with each other? If these are clouds, by now, wouldn’t they have become white in colour, after raining for such a long time?”

thirumAl kOLam sumandhu neela vALLERu poRA ninRa vAnam idhu – why is the friend saying this? She thinks that if she were to keep saying only false things, the friend may not believe her. Hence she feigns as if she too is doubting whether it is monsoon. It could also be taken to mean that the friend is saying this in order to convince the lady that since it is monsoon time, the leading man will come soon.

thirumAl kOLam sumandhu pirindhAr kodumai kuzhaRu – the clouds, assuming the complexion of emperumAn, are telling the lady “We have come without fail, during this rainy season. But emperumAn has not come yet”. In other words, they are telling her about his faults.

thaN pUm kAlangolO aRiyEn – I do not know whether it is the cool, beautiful time, implying that this is the time to be united happily with the leading man.

vinaiyAttiiyEn kANginRavE – what is the reason for this situation? It cannot be said that he is the type who gives up on those who desire him or those who he desires; it cannot be said that the leading lady is not desiring him; it cannot be said that this is not the time for him to come; and it cannot be said that she will not attain him. What else can be the reason? Only reason is that it is because of my (the friend’s) sins; *math pApamEva nimiththam* . In other words, the friend says “Seeing this sorrowful condition of my leading lady is only due to my sin”.

swApadhEsam (distinguished meaning): Looking at the sorrowful condition of AzhwAr in separation from emperumAn, it becomes pertinent on the part of SrlvaishNavas to sustain him even if they have to tell lies that something doesn’t exist [in this case, saying that the monsoon season has not arrived].

In the next article, we will take up the 8th pAsuram.

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10. pAsuram 8 – kAnginRanagaLum

avathArikai (Introduction)

In the previous pAsuram, the friend comforted the leading lady with different types of reasoning. The leading man then came there and spoke to the lady. The friend, looking at his actions, feels that they were not natural. She doubts whether these are pretences by the man in order to separate again from the lady.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

kANginRanagaLum kEtkinRanagaLum kANil innAL pANKunRa nAdar payilginRana idhellAm aRindhOm mANKunRam Endhi thaN mAmalai vEngadaththumbar nambum sENkunRam senRu poruL padaippAn kaRRa thiNNanavE

Word-by-Word Meanings

innAL – at the present moment

kANginRanagaLum – activities (of yours) which are seen

kEtkinRanagaLum – words spoken (by you) which are heard

kANil – if one were to analyse

pAN – having the songs (of beetles)

kunRam – the hills of thiruvEngadam

nAdar – you, who are having that hill as your dwelling place

payilginRana – carried out in sequence

idhellAm – all these

mAN – beautiful

kunRam – gOvardhana hill

Endhi – holding it aloft

thaN – being cool

mAmalai – the huge mountain

vEngadaththu – of thiruvEngadam

umbar – nithyasUris (permanent dwellers of SrlvaikuNtam)

nambum – apt to be liked

kunRam – hill

senRu – attaining it

poruL – thiruvEngadamudaiyAn, the wealth

padaippAn – to attain

kaRRa – taking efforts

thiNNanavu – deceitful

aRindhOm – we have come to know

Simple Translation

If we analyse the activities carried out and words spoken of, by the lord of the place with mountains, they appear to be feigned. What is the purpose of doing all these? It appears that he wants to reach the cool, huge hills of thiruvEngadam, which belongs to krishNa who had lifted the distinguished gOvardhana hill, and which is apt to be attained by nithyasUris too. It appears that he is doing all these activities since he wants to remain on that hill and earn materials.

vyAkhyAnam

kANginRana – even as he is standing, he would suddenly bend and hold on to the feet; he would feign as if he is prostrating.

kEtkinRana – feigning courteous words such as “I am your servant”, “I will massage your feet”, “My mind is bewildered” etc.

kANil – if one were to analyse. periya thiruvandhAdhi pAsuram 36 says “ *nenjennum utkaNNEl kANum uNarndhu* ” (if it can be visualised through the inner eye of mind)

innAL – today

pAN – it appeared just like flattering

pANKunRa nAdar – the leading man who has thiruvEngadamalai, where beetles constantly keep humming, as his dwelling place. The lord of *kurinji nilam* , the land which encompasses mountains and allied lands. *kurinji* also refers to a meeting place. When this is the case, is it proper to separate? She (the leading lady’s friend) says that his activities do not appear to be those carried out by someone who wants to attain something.

payilginRana – the way he united with her, it appears that he is going to give her up. Just as maharAjar (sugrIvan) had made perumAL (Sri rAma), who had come to protect him, to suffer in lightning and thunder and was enjoying himself without knowing whether it was sun rise or sunset.

mAN kunRam Endhi – holding one mountain [gOvardhana] aloft and standing atop another hill [thiruvEngadam] and protecting all. *mAtchi* (root for *mAN*) – beautiful.

Endhi – lifting easily, without any effort.

thaN mAmalai vEngadaththu – just as it is said in nAchchiAr thirumozhi 8-3 “ *kuLir aruvi vEngadam* ” it is cool, invigorating thiruvEngadam hill.

umbar nambum – just as amalanAdhipirAn pAsuram 3 says “ *mandhipAy vadavEngada mAmalai vAnavargaL sandhi seyya ninRAn* ”, thiruvEngadam is the apt place where nithyasUris come every day and carry out divine worship. nithyasUris have always worshipped him as the supreme *paravAsudhEvan*

; now, since he is manifesting his simplicity here, contrary to his supreme nature, they like thiruvEngadam.

sENkunRam – thiruvEngadam which has tall peaks

poruL – we have seen that they stand in front of you saying “You are the greatest entity”

padaippAn – we have seen that these are readily available; we do not have to take any effort.

kaRRa – these pretences were not seen in you earlier. From which teacher did you learn these?

thiNNanavE – from where did this harshness come in you, superseding the earlier softness?

In the next article, we will take up the 9 th pAsuram.

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11. pAsuram 9 – thiNpUnjudar

avathArikai (Introduction)

The leading lady tells the leading man “You are determined to leave me and go to thirumalai”. He tells her “I did not think that way. Did you not think of going there?” Further he tells her “After reaching the stage of being together with the followers of emperumAn, is it not you (AzhwAr) who is thinking of being together with emperumAn? We have understood that you have not realised your greatness. You may not have understood about us. Would we too be like that?” An incident is cited here. Once emperumAnAr (bhagavadh rAmAnujar) had decided to go to thiruvEngadam and mentioned this to his disciples. piLLai uRangAvallidhAsar immediately went to his house. Seeing this, emperumAnAr sent a SrlvaidhNavar to see what was happening there. He returned and told emperumAnAr “He is reciting the pAsuram ‘kANginRanagaLum’ with tears in his eyes”. Immediately emperumAnAr told him “Shouldn’t you have reminded him about the pAsuram ‘vaN pU maNivalli yArE piribavardhAm’ and consoled him?”

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings.

thiNpUnjudar nudhi nEmiyam selvar viNNAdanaiya

vaNpU maNivalli yArE piribavar thAm ivaiyO

kaNpUngamalam karum sudar Adi veNmuththarumbi

vaNpUnguvalai madamAn vizhikkinRa mAyidhazhE

Word-by-Word Meanings

thiN – being firm

pU – being beautiful

sudar – being splendidous

nudhi – being sharp

nEmi – with the divine disc

am selvar – SrIya: pathi (consort of Srl mahAlakshmi), who has beauty and wealth

viNNAdanaiya – enjoyable, similar to SrlvaikuNtam

vaN – magnanimous

maNi – renowned like a gemstone

valli – Oh leading lady, who is like a creeper plant!

kamalam – lotus

kuvalai – blue coloured Indian water-lily

karum sudar – a bluish effulgence

Adi – having

veN muththu – having tears of white pearls

arumbi – shedding them like buds

mA idhazh – having lip similar to tender mango leaves

madamAn – you, who are like an obedient doe

vizhikkinRa – looking, by opening your eyes

ivai – are these

kaNNO – eyes!

ArE – who

piribavardhAm – will separate (from you who are like this)?

Simple Translation

Oh one who is like a beautiful creeper and who is full of enjoyment similar to the *paramapadham* (SrivaikuNtam) of sarvESvaran who is wealthy and has the divine disc which is firm, beautiful, fiery and sharp which are fitting together! Are your eyes, mere eyes? No! They are like lotus flower, like the beautiful water-lily, emitting a bluish splendour. Whitish pearl like tear drops are welling up in those eyes. Your eyelids are like tender mango leaves. Who will separate from you who are opening eyes slowly, like an obedient doe?

vyAkhyAnam

thiNpU – the nature of divine disc is that it will not step back when it comes to annihilating the enemies of emperumAn's followers. The term *thiN* refers to firmness while *pU* refers to gentleness. In other words, divine disc is firm when it is a weapon and gentle when it is an ornament.

sudar – splendid

nudhi – sharp

nEmi – divine disc, chakraththAzhwAr

am selvar – the beauty and wealth which accrue because of holding such divine disc

viNNadu anaiya – paramapadham (SrivaikuNtam) which is as said in chAndhOkya upanishath 8-15-1 “*na cha punaravarthathE*” (there is no returning from that place); only if someone who goes there returns would I separate from you and go to thiruvEngadam.

vaNmai – quality of being magnanimous. He [AzhwAr] was showered with faultless knowledge and devotion, in his mind, such that he could experience and enjoy. Instead of experiencing and enjoying that alone, he spread it to the whole world as thiruvAimozhi prabandham (divine collection). When he refers to himself in his prabandham, he calls himself as *vaNsatakOpan* (the magnanimous nammAzhwAr).

pU – one which gives enjoyment

maNivalli – being an ornament to itself. The word *valli* has two connotations here: she is clinging on to the neck of her beloved, just like a creeper will spread on to a supporting pole. Alternatively, while she

should be holding on to a supporting pole, she is lying on the ground, being anguished in separation from her leading man.

ArE piribavardhAm – even if I do not have affection to the extent that you have, should I not be considered as one with knowledge?

ivaio kaN – aren't they eyes which are so beautiful that they have to be protected from evil eyes?

pUm kamalam – eyes which are beautiful like a lotus flower.

karum sudar Adi – having an arrogance

veN muththu arumbi – just as a pearl forms in the oyster, sorrow was appearing in the beautiful eyes

vaN pUnguvalai – the magnanimously blossomed purple coloured water lily.

madamAn vizhikkinRa – even when being united, anticipating separation, fluttering the eyes like a doe.

mA idhazhE – the word *mA* could refer to either black or reddish colour. If it refers to being black, it would apply to the black eyes while if it refers to being red, it would apply to the reddish lips.

svApadhESam – even when he is together with SrIvaishNavas, AzhwAr is sorrowful anticipating that they would separate from him and go away and wonders as to what will happen should they separate from him. This pAsuram is the result of their mocking at him because of his doubts.

In the next article, we will consider the 10th pAsuram

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12. pAsuram 10 – mAyOn vadathiruvEngadam

avathArikai (Introduction)

This pAsuram comes under the classification of *madhiyudan paduththal* in thamizh literature. This signifies that the leading man, who had separated the previous day, returns the next day and expresses his desire to the leading lady and her friends when they are guarding the paddy fields (from birds). The opinion is that he expresses his feelings to the friends and, bewildering them, tells them to inform his desire to the leading lady.

Let us look at the pAsuram and its meanings:

mAyOn vadathiruvEngadanAda vallikkodigAL

nOyO uraikkilum kEtkinRileer uraiylr numadhu

vAyO adhu anRi valvinaiyEnum kiLiyum eLgum

AyO adum thoNdaiyO aRaiyO idhu aRivaridhE

Word-by-Word Meanings

mAyOn – belonging to thiruvEngadamudaiyAn (lord of thiruvEngadam), the one with amazing activities

vadathiruvEngadanAda – those who are dwellers of thirumalai which is on the northern side

valli – like a creeper plant

kodigAL – oh women!

nOy – (my) disease

uraikkilum – even if mentioned

kEtkinRileer – you are not listening

O – alas!

numadhu – your

vAyO – mouth?

adhu anRi – or else

val vinaiyEnum – me, who has the sins (to say these words)

kiLiyum – even the parrot

eLgum – to quiver (after hearing)

AyO – is it the sound “AyO”?

thoNdaiyO – is it the lips which are like the reddish fruit

adum – affected (like this)

uraiylr – please tell the reason for this disease

aRivaridhu – unable to ascertain

The term *aRaiyO* refers to a battle cry.

Simple Translation

Oh women who are like the creeper plant and who are dwelling in thiruvEngadam hills which are to the northern side and for which thiruvEngadamudaiyAn, who has amazing activities, is the lord! You are not aware, on your own, of my disease of separation and are not listening to me when I reveal it to you. You should tell me as to what is troubling me. Is it your talk which is troubling me? Or am I, having lot of sins, the reason for this? Or is it the sound “AyO” which you make to drive away the parrots which are sitting on the trees? Or is it your lips which are reddish like the fruit?

vyAkhyAnam

mAyOn – one who has amazing activities. Why is he [AzhwAr] talking about amazing activities here? While emperumAn has *paramapadham* (SrlvaikuNtam) which is beyond one’s words and mind, he left that and took residence atop thiruvEngadam hills, as said in nAnmugam thiruvandhAdhi pAsuram 47 “*gAnamum vAnaramum vEdum udai vEngadam*” (thiruvEngadam which has forests, monkeys and hunter-tribe people). This simplicity, even when he is so supreme, is the reason which makes AzhwAr to address him as one with amazing activities.

vada thiruvEngadam nAda – while there are places beyond thiruvEngadam too, on the northern side, AzhwAr is calling this place as one on the northern side since this place has been sung in praise of, by most of the AzhwArs.

vallik kodigAL – both terms *valli* and *kodi* would refer to women. What is the need for using both terms? This is to affirm that they do not have any of the qualities of masculinity and are full of feminine qualities only. Since creeper plants need to cling on to a supporting pole, he is stressing on the need for holding on to emperumAn for sustaining oneself. The leading man is the only supporting pole and all the other women look up to him as their support.

nOyO – being separated from her, I am neither able to live nor give up my life.

nOy uraikkilum O kEtkinRileer – Looking at my state, shouldn’t you all have come to me and comforted me saying “Oh, your situation has become like this”? Instead of that, I, who am affected with this disease, am coming to you and, I am asking you the reason for this disease. In other words, while you should have got this disease due to separation from me, I have been afflicted with this. This is very strange. You do not have to give any treatment for getting rid of this disease. It is enough if you listen to my outpouring.

uraiylr – he is imploring those who are not listening to his words “Please listen” thus manifesting his desire towards her. After listening to him, the leading lady’s friends tell him “You have realised on your own that you have the disease. What is there for us to say?” To this, the leading man responds saying “I do not know the reason for this disease. You should tell me that”

numadhu vAyO – is your blossomed face the reason for my disease?

adhu anRi valvinaiyEnum kiLiyum eLgum AyO – is it the sound “AyO” that you make to drive away the parrots (which have come to eat the grains in the field which you people are guarding)?

kiLiyum eLgum – the word *eLgum* has two meanings – to leave and to be involved. In the former case, it would refer to the parrots leaving the place on hearing their words “AyO” and in the latter case, it would refer to the parrots being involved with what they were saying and staying put in their place.

valvinaiyEnum – I did not become attracted to you, only on account of your sound (when you speak); I was engaged with you on account of your sweet voice and your beautiful forms. The implied meaning is that sarvESvaran is engaged with AzhwAr like the parrot, listening to his pAsurams while the SrlvaishNavas are engaged with AzhwAr on account of the pAsurams as well the qualities of his soul.

thoNdaiyO – is it because of your reddish lips?

adum – all these make me perish.

aRaiyO idhu aRivaridhE – I do not know as to which of these troubled me and caused this disease. For not knowing the reason, he is saying the words *aRaiyO* as if he were raising a battle cry.

svApadhEsam (distinguished meaning) – SrlvaishNavas were engaged with the qualities of AzhwAr’s AthmA (soul) as well as his *dhEham* (physical form) such as his pAsurams, his splendour etc, without making any distinction among them.

We will take up the 11th pAsuram in the next article.

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13. pAsuram 11 – ariyana yAm

avathArikai (Introduction)

The leading lady was united with the leading man in total happiness, not knowing anything about separation. A person came and told the leading man about earning wealth in a different place. On hearing this, the leading lady thought “While I was thinking that we could be together like this for a long time, he is thinking of separating from me” and was distressed. Seeing this, the leading man was amazed, thinking “Even when I had not told her anything about leaving her, she is so distressed”

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings.

*ariyana yAm inRu kANginRana kaNNan viNNaNaiyAy periyana kAdham porutkO pirivena gyAlam
eydhaRku uriyana oN muththum paim ponnum Endhi OrO kudangai periyana keNdaikkulam ivaiyO
vandhu pErginRavE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

kaNNan – krishNa’s

viN aNaiyAy – Oh one who is most enjoyable like paramapadham (SrlvaikuNtam)

porutku – for wealth

pirivu – separation

ena – even as this was being mentioned

periyana – being huge

kAdham – being afar

(appears like having been separated)

O – how amazing!

gyAlam – distinguished people with supreme knowledge

eydhaRku – to experience

uriyana – being apt

oN – beautiful

muththum – pearls of tears

pai – fresh (new)

ponnum – gold with distinguished colour

Endhi – holding

OrO kudangai – each one being as much as the palm of the hand

periyana – large

keNdai – of fish

kulam – schools of

ivai – these eyes

vandhu – coming

pErginRana – are flipping

yAm – we

inRu – now

kANginRana – what we see

ariyana – are rare

Simple Translation

Oh one who gives happiness similar to krishNa's paramapadham (SrlvaikuNtam)! I had merely said that it is normal for the head of a family to travel afar for earning wealth, but had not left you. On hearing this, your eyes which are capable of keeping the world under their control, which are as large as the palm of one's hand, which are like the carp fish, are shedding tears of pearl and fresh gold with distinguished colour. How amazing is this! What I see here is very much a rarity.

vyAkhyAnam

ariyana – even as we (the leading man says of himself and the lady) were together, why is she in such a tearful condition, wonders the leading man. He says that he had not seen this condition when they were together or when they were separated [in earlier times].

yAm inRu – by adding the numeral one to one thousand, will the value of one thousand increase considerably? By adding the quantum of water which is present under the hoof of a cow, will the quantum of water in an ocean increase? In the same way, when I was together with her, while I had lot of wealth, what else is needed? This was my state.

kANginRana – There are four different reasons for separating from a beloved: to increase one's level of knowledge, to earn more, to take part in a battle and to be with some other girl. None of these is applicable here, says the leading man.

kaNNan viN aNaiyAy – just as chAndhOkya upanishath 8-15-1 says “*na cha punarAvarthathE*” (one does not return from SrlvaikuNtam), only if someone leaves that place and returns does the question of my leaving you arise. That place (SrlvaikuNtam) does not undergo any change. You, who provide happiness which is much similar to that distinguished place of Srl krishNa's, should not undergo any change, like that place.

pirivu ena O periyana kAdham – on hearing the word “Separation” she feels as if we have been separated by a very long distance with many oceans and mountains between us, with no one who could act as a messenger between us. She feels very distressed

porutku – the leading lady seems to say “If the purpose of separating from me is to earn lot of wealth, such wealth is available in plenty here itself”

gyAlam eydhaRku uriyana – This wealth (which is available here) is such that those with distinguished knowledge can enjoy well. Its value will equal the wealth of nithyavibhUthi as well as leelAvibhUthi (the spiritual and material realms). The wealth which you are seeking elsewhere is available here itself, she says.

oN muththum – pearls at their place of origin [very pure]

paim ponnum – fresh gold

Endhi – holding them, as if saying “When these are here, why do you have to go elsewhere for wealth? Accept these”

OrO kudangai – the beauty of her eyes was such that those who see them, which are as large as one’s palm, would imbibe them.

periyana – they were so huge that the enjoyer (the leading man) would be totally satiated

kudangai – through her face, isn’t she offering wealth which could not be held in one’s palm!

keNdai – like fish which have an arrogance

kulam – they (her eyes) would match each other; nothing else will come anywhere near them.

ivaiyO vandhu pErginRavE – the eyes suffered similar to the sufferings of those who saw them. Even an inanimate object could flop over someone

vandhu pErginRavE – they are being spoken of as animate objects.

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): AzhwAr wanted to be together with SrlvaishNavas all the time. He expressed his feelings in this pAsuram as though they would separate from him and go on their own.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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14. pAsuram 12 – pErginRadhu maNimAmai

avathArikai (Introduction)

In several pAsurams so far, AzhwAr had considered SrlvaishNavas as the leading man and composed the pAsurams. In this pAsuram, he is considering emperumAn as the leading man. It is natural for union with emperumAn to end with union with SrlvaishNavas as also for union with SrlvaishNavas to end with union with emperumAn. In the pAsurams before the 6 th pAsuram of *thadAviya ambum* , he had mentioned about his distress on account of separating from emperumAn and from the 6 th pAsuram *thadAviya ambum* till the 11th pAsuram he mentioned about his distress due to his doubt that the SrlvaishNavas will separate from him. In this pAsuram, separation from emperumAn is causing him distress.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

pErginRadhu maNimAmai piRangi aLLal payalai UrginRadhu kangul UzhigaLE idhellAm inavE IrginRa chakkaraththu emperumAn kaNNan thaNNandhuzhAy sArignRa nannenjinAr thandhu pOna thani vaLamE

Word-by-Word Meanings

IrginR a – splitting (me) with (his) beauty

chakkaraththu – having the divine disc

emperumAn – one who is my swAmy (lord)

kaNNan – krishNa's

thaN – being cool

am – beautiful

thuzhAy – in divine thuLasi

sArignRa – being engaged with

nal – distinguished

nenjinAr – mind

thandhu pOna – given

thani – unique

vaLam – wealth

What is it?

maNi – praiseworthy

mAmai – beauty

pErginRadhu – is leaving

piRangi – abundant

aLLal – being close

payalai – sickness due to love

UrginRadhu – is spreading

kangul – night

UzhigaLE – grew like unending time

idhellAm – all these sickness etc

inavE – became hindrance

Simple Translation

krishNa is holding the beautiful divine disc and is splitting me with his beauty. My mind desired such krishNa's cool and beautiful thuLasi garland, and left me, following thuLasi. Due to this, it made my beautiful complexion to change. Sickness due to love is spreading throughout my form. Nights lengthened to unending *yugas* (long periods of time). Entities such as breeze etc became hindrances for me.

vyAkhyAnam

pErginRadhu maNimAmai – the complexion in my distinguished form is changing. Just as it has been mentioned in the 5 th pAsuram of thiruviruththam *mAmaitiRaththukkolAm*, the complexion of the form which he [emperumAn] desired is receding. My complexion is getting destroyed as I keep seeing him. *maNimAmai* refers to beautiful complexion. Is it proper for one to praise one's own complexion? Since he [emperumAn] praises her form saying "Oh the complexion! Oh the beauty!" there is nothing wrong in her praising it herself. Since she exists for his sake rather than for her sake, it is not improper in her praising something which is pleasing to him.

piRangi aLLal payalai – instead of keeping the place, from where the complexion has left, barren, it has been filled up with paleness, a sign of sickness due to love. *piRangi* refers to abundance, like a flood. *aLLal* refers to the fact that while desilting a well in which there is plenty of mud, the foot will sink when one steps on it, if emperumAn himself comes to remove the paleness, he could not remove it. There is such an abundance of paleness.

Urginradhu – spreading fast, just like poison spreads. Just as someone comes surreptitiously when a powerful king leaves the private quarters of his queen or just as rAvaNa came when iLaiyaperumAl [lakshmaNa] left the hermitage to go looking for Srl rAma, the paleness came spreading, when the beautiful complexion left me.

kangul UzhigaLE – night time felt as if it were lasting several ages; while the time spent before uniting with emperumAn appeared like half a day and the time spent uniting with him appeared like a moment, the time separated from him appeared to last forever.

idhu eIlAm inavE – apart from these, whatever affected her, whatever caused her distress are being mentioned. This includes entities such as love-bird and gentle breeze, which, in normal times, would have caused happiness. Whatever entity appeared to be sweet and favourable when slthAppirAtti and

Sri rAma were together in the forest, appeared to be inimical in the same place when they were separated.

IrginRa chakkaram – affecting without any distinction between favourable and unfavourable persons; [The divine disc] affects because of its sentient quality. It will destroy those who are inimical towards it; it will destroy those who are dear to it, through separation, by going afar from them. It will kill those who are unfavourable to it through its power and bewilder those who are favourable through its beauty.

chakkaraththu emperumAn – through his beautiful divine hands and the way he held his beautiful divine discus, emperumAn affirmed “He is my property” and enslaved me.

kaNNan – krishNa. One could get the doubt whether he is with two shoulders. Sri vishNu purANam SIOkam *upasamhara sarvAthman rUpamEthach chathurbhujam* – his beautiful form is with four shoulders.

thaNNandhuzhAy sArginRa – my heart was fully engaged with the beautiful garland of thuLasi which he had donned. Instead of falling at the feet of the primary entity [bhagavAn, emperumAn], my mind was engaged with the ultimate entity [thuLasi, likened to bhAgavathas, SrlvaishNavas].

nannenjinAr – is it apt to refer to one’s heart as “ *nalla nenju* ”(good heart)? Even if they are one’s own children, if they are better than the parents in terms of engaging with emperumAn, they should be praised. He [AzhwAr] is in such a state that he is wandering without even realising that his dress is dishevelled. What he wants to do is to tell emperumAn that emperumAn is everything for him just as he had said in thiruvAimozhi pAsuram “” *pUsum sAndhu en nenjamE*” (my heart is the sandal paste for you), that he is all the enjoyment for him and hence he wants to be always with emperumAn, singing and dancing about him.

thandhu pOna thani vaLamE – the loss of complexion is the wealth which emperumAn left for him.

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning) for the pAsuram: AzhwAr is mercifully mentioning through the words of the leading lady, her inability to suffer separation from her leading man, since her heart has got fully engaged with him, as a result of which how she decayed being unable to bear the separation.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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15. pAsuram 13 – thani vaLar

avathArikai (Introduction)

Daylight, which gives some comfort, has gone and night time, which creates sorrow, has arrived. Entities such as cool wind have joined hands with night time to increase the sorrow. The person, who could save her from these entities, has not arrived yet. Hence the leading lady says that she will perish. During daytime, since the sensory organs can engage with various entities, it was possible to forget the separation from her beloved and survive. In the night time, however, since all entities subside, the sensory organs impel the mind to engage with the entity which has got separated (the leading man) and since it is the time for uniting, it becomes all the more difficult to survive.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings.

thani vaLar sengOl nadAvu thazhal vAyarasaviyap panivaLar sengOl iruL vIRRirundhadhu pAr muzhudhum thunivaLar kAdhal thuzhAyaith thuzhAvu thaN vAdai thadindhu ini vaLai kAppavar Ar enai UzhigaL IrvanavE

Word-by-Word Meanings

thani – unique

vaLar – growing

sengOl – having order

nadAvu – conducting

thazhal – for the heat

vAy – being the origin

arasu – sUriyan, the king

aviya – to disappear (to set)

pani – cold

sengoL – having order

iruL – darkness

pAr muzhudhum – throughout the world

vIRRirundhadhu – had pervaded

thuni – sorrow

vaLar – one which enables to grow

kAdhal – being the matter for love

thuzhAyai – divine thuLasi

thuzhAvu – mingling

thaN – cool

vAdai – northerly breeze

thadindh – splitting

ini – hereafter *vaLai* – bangles

kAppavar – one who protects

Ar – who

enai – me

UzhigaL – (these nights) like eons

IrvanavE – are splitting

Simple Translation

sUriyan (sUrya), who is the lord of heat and who is unique, is ruling the world with his effulgence which is forever growing. Darkness, which has increasing levels of chillness, spread throughout this world in such a way that sun's rule ended. Who can stop the northerly breeze which comes with the fragrance of thuLasi from my lord, which is the reason for exasperating my sorrow to a great extent? Who can protect and stop the bangles from slipping from my hands? These nights, which seem to extend to eons, are splitting me.

vyAkhyAnam

thanivaLar sengOl nadAvu – sUriyan, on his own, without the help of any secondary entity, emits an effulgence during day which is far greater than the combined light emitted by moon and thousands of stars in the night. Unlike darkness which makes sUriyan to set before letting out its dominance, sUriyan is splendidous without making anything else to disappear, through his radiance. Even when the moon and stars are there during daytime, sUriyan puts their brightness to shade through his radiance. Is there an event when something had shone even when his enemies were around? krishNa did that when dhuryOdhana et al were present, as brought out by the term *kurUnprachchAdhayanaSriyA* .

sengOl nadAvu – sUriyan had a sceptre which will not falter, just like manu and mandhAthA, who came in the clan of sUriyan.

thazhal vAy arasu aviya – he is the personification of heat. *arasu* – unique warrior. a *viya* – sUriyan was like a lamp which had got put out. Is there annihilation for sUriyan? The leading lady thought this way since it had not dawned yet. Just as thiruvAimozhi says *oNsudarOn vArAdhoLiththAn* (effulgent sUriyan hid himself without showing up), she too says this way.

pani vaLar sengOl iruL vIRRirundhadhu – night, which has chillness or dew as a manifestation of its rule, had spread throughout the world and made it as its kingdom. His is like another king taking over a land when a king, who rules it, disappears [sun has gone and night takes over]. The word *pani* can mean both dew and shivering. In line with this, it can be said that night was ruling the roost since everyone shivers when a new king takes over. It appeared that the space over which sUriyan was ruling was sufficient for darkness alone to reside.

vIRRirundhadhu – darkness sat on the kingdom as if there were no one to oppose it.

pani vaLar sengOl iruL vIRRirundhadhu – it was similar to one, who was residing in a small area, grew up to pervade everywhere.

thuni vaLar kAdhal thuzhAyaith thuzhAvu thaNvAdai thadindhu inivaLai kAppavar Ar – who is there who is capable of snapping the breeze, which embraces the fragrance from thuLasi, thus multiplying my sorrow, into two?

thaN vAdai – how is it possible to split wind, which is invisible, into two? Her sorrow was in such abundance that even entities which are invisible became visible to her.

inivaLai kAppavar Ar – is it possible for her to unite with her beloved, so that her bangles could be protected from the chill wind by destroying the wind?

enai UzhigaL IrvanavE – the nights which are like this, appear to be stretching to several eons. This implies that the world is not congruent with AzhwAr.

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16. pAsuram 14 – IrvanavElum anjElum

avathArikai (Introduction)

This pAsuram comes under the classification of *nalam pArAttu* . In other words, the leading man praises the qualities of the leading lady. Here, the leading man, bewildered by the beauty of the leading lady's eyes, describes their beauty in several ways.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

IrvanavElum anjElum uyirmEl miLirndhu ivaiO pErvanavO alla dheyva nal vEL kaNai pEroLiye sOrvana neelach chudar vidumEniyammAn visumbUr thErvana dheyvam annIrakaNNO ichchezhum kayalE

Word-by-Word Meanings

Irvana – splitting

vElum – as the weapon spear

am – beautiful

sElum – as the fish

ivai – these

uyir mEl – on the life

miLirndhu – attacking

pErvanavO alla – they will not go away

dheyvam – as the lord

nal – being distinguished

vEL – manmatha's (cupid's)

kaNai – arrow of red lotus

pEr – huge

oLi – lustre

sOrvana – letting out

neelam – dark

sudar – splendid

vidum – emitting

mEni – divine form

ammAn – sarvESvaran, the Lord's

visumbu – SrlvaikuNtam

Ur – nithyasUris who are present in that place

thErvana – are searching

dheyvam – different from *prAkrutham* (primordial)

annIra – distinguished like that

i – this

sezhum – well rounded

kayal – fish

kaNNO – eyes?

Simple Translation

Her eyes are like the sharp spear as well as like beautiful fish. They are pouncing on my life as if they wish to take it under their control. These eyes emit an effulgence similar to the one emitted by the arrows of the beautiful *manmatha* who looks divine. Moreover, these eyes are searching for nithyasUris who are in SrlvaikuNtam which is the abode of sarvESvaran who has a dark bluish form, emitting splendour. Are these, which appear like well grown-up fish, your eyes?

vyAkhyAnam

IrvanevElum anjElum – there are two interpretations to this term – one is taken as *IrvanavElum anjElum* and the other is taken splitting the two words as *Irvana vElum* and *am sElum*. In the first interpretation, the meaning is – *manmatha*’s arrows will break all the creatures in this world. They enter the creatures through the five senses. Her two eyes create the same impact which the arrows of *manmatha* create through the five senses. In the second interpretation, the meaning is – just as the spear will pierce enemies, her beautiful eyes which are like fish, will pierce the lives of people. Thus, two interpretations namely *vaidhakdhyam* and *maukdhyam* were described here. *maukdhyam* refers to *saundharyam* (overall beauty). This beauty was explained through the term *am sEl* (beautiful fish). Just as a spear will destroy an enemy without changing its form, her eyes will pounce on the person standing opposite them, without undergoing any change in themselves. Through the term *IrvanavElum* the commentator described in a distinguished manner, the entity which created an effect and he also described the effect.

uyirmEl miLirndhu – here, he describes the entity which is affected [by the eyes]. Even though her eyes pounced on the leading man like a spear, they did not create any injury on the body, unlike the spear. Thus her eyes, instead of hurting the body, which has being destroyed as its nature, desires to pierce the life, which has been termed in Srl bhagavath glthA 2-24 as *achchEdhyOyam* (incapable of being split); in other words, it attempts to destroy life which is indestructible.

miLirndhu – just as the spear thrown at an enemy pierces him and stays there, her eyes also pierce the life and stay there.

ivaio – these (the eyes) are cruel

pErvanavO alla – once it pierces, the spear will not move. The person who flings the spear [to attack his enemy] will not throw it in such a manner that it could be removed [by the enemy] for treating the injured place. Her eyes too were similar; they stayed put on his life, without moving.

dheyvam nal vEL kaNaip pEr oLiYE sOrvana – her eyes, apart from being like spear or fish, have taken the form of the arrows of *kAman* (manmatha). Why are they taking different forms, like the sage saubhari? [sage saubhari, in order to marry the fifty daughters of King mAndhAtha, took fifty forms so that each daughter thought that he was spending time only with her). These eyes also emit the splendour of the arrows of *kAman* who is capable of acting well and who is beautiful.

neelach chuddar vidum mEni ammAn visumbUrthErvana – the word *thErvana* has two interpretations – to search out for those who are in SrlvaikuNtam. Also, to be sought by those who are in SrlvaikuNtam. Her eyes searched for the SrlvaikuNtam which belongs to sarvESvaran who has a divine form emitting bluish effulgence. The divine form of sarvESvaran is *dhArakam* and *pOshakam* (sustenance and nourishment, respectively) for nithyasUris.

ammAn – even if one loses out to his [sarvESvaran's] divine form, one will still say that they had been won over by him. He is such a lord. katOpanishath 1-2-23 says *thasyaisha AthmA vivruNuthE thanUm svAm* (he manifests his divine form to one who he chooses to be apt to see his form)

visumbUr – this term refers to those who are in SrlvaikuNtam, viz. similar to the term *manjA: krOSanthe* (literally this means that the cot is making noise; however the noise is made by those who are lying on the cot and not by the cot itself). nithyasUris constantly envision emperumAn's divine form and enjoy it.

thErvana – those who reside in SrlvaikuNtam will not leave that place. However, her eyes are such that even these people will come in search of her eyes, leaving the distinguished SrlvaikuNtam. After winning over leelA vibhUthi [materialistic realm], her eyes have set out to win over *nithya vibhUthi* [spiritual realm].

dheyvam annIra – these eyes are unlike what we see in this samsAram; they are *aprAkrutham* (beyond primordial matter). The word *annIra* refers to such distinction in her eyes. They are like that, being *aprAkrutham*.

kaNNO ichchezhum kayalE – makes one wonder initially whether they are eyes, but subsequently ascertain that they are fish only.

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17. pAsuram 15 – kayalO numa kaNgaL

avathArikai (Introduction)

When the leading man had separated from the leading lady earlier, he had hinted that he would come again, after sometime, and meet her. Once that time has arrived, he comes to the field to meet his beloved. On seeing that she is with her friends and not alone, he is perplexed. He tells them “I have come looking for an elephant” in order not to reveal his intention in coming there. The lady’s friends tell him “You had said that you were leaving in order to earn wealth. You are now saying that you have come to find an elephant. You are also hinting that you are suffering due to separation from our friend. However, we do not see any connection among these three”. There are two interpretations for talking about elephant, as given by the commentator, periyavAchchAn piLLai – to imply the first meaning, he said that the leading man is a warrior. In other words, he said that he goes for hunting elephants. Secondly he said that he had come looking for an elephant. To imply the second meaning, the commentator says that he has come looking for an elephant which has lost its female elephant. He implies that just as a male elephant wanders here and there, in exultation, after losing its mate, the leading man too is wandering in order to overcome the anxiety of separating from his leading lady.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*kayalO numa kangalenRu kaLiRu vinavi niRRIr ayalOr aRiyilum Idhenna vArththai kadal kavarntha
puyalOdu ulAngoNdalvaNNan punavEngadaththemmodum payalOvileer kollai kAkkina nALum
palapalavE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

numa – your

kaNgaL – eyes

kayalO – are they fish?

enRu – asking this way

(later)

kaLiRu – elephant

vinavi – querying

niRRIr – you stood

ayalOr – outsiders

aRiyilum – if they know of this

Idhu – this

enna vArththai – what sort of words

kadal – ocean

kavarntha – cleaning it up completely

puyalodu – along with the water

ulAm – roaming

koNdaI – like a cloud

vaNNan – thiruvEngadamudaiyAn who has the complexion, his

punam – having fields

vEngadam – at thiruvEngadam

kollai – fields

palapala nALum – for a long time

kAkkinRa – those who are protecting

emmodum – with us

payalO ileer – you have not become familiar

Simple Translation

The leading man complimented the leading lady about her eyes. Seeing this, the leading lady and her friends queried him “You came looking for an elephant, but you are talking about our eyes. If others hear these words, what will they think of this? We are residing in the hills of thiruvEngadamudaiyAn who has the complexion of cloud which has imbibed all the water from the ocean and is roaming. We are protecting the fields which are in this place, for a long time. We do not know as to who you are”

vyAkhyAnam

kayalO numa kangal – the leading man had come to the field in order to talk to his leading lady about an elephant which had come there. However, he had not expected her to be with her friends there. Becoming perplexed on seeing them, he asks the leading lady “Are your eyes fish?” like a person closing his mouth while eating. The commentator cites an example to show how the leading man will forget about the elephant on seeing the eyes. chAndhOgya upanishath 8-12-9 says *nOpajanam smaran idham SarIram* – mukthAthmAs (those who are liberated from samsAram and are leaving for SrlvaikuNtam) will not think of samsAram. He [the leading man] stood as if he had forgotten about himself and the matter which he wanted to talk about (since he asked whether her eyes are fish, the opinion here is that he forgot about himself; matter related to emperumAn is such that it will not allow anything else to be thought of; matter related to followers of emperumAn will also act in a similar way). chAndhOgya upanishath 7-23-1 says “*yathra nAnyath paSyathi nAnyath SruNOthi nAnyath vijAnAthi sa bhUmA*” (that, which when seen will not require others to be seen, which when heard will not require other things to be heard, which when known will not require other things to be known, is supreme). This is because of the fact that matter related to *brahmam* (supreme entity) is superior to everything else. Is it apt to equate eyes with fish? Why can’t the eyes be compared to the eyes of a deer? This is because the eyes [of the leading lady] keep darting, like fish. Why should they [the eyes] be referred to in plural? Just as emperumAn has thousands of friends, the leading lady too has thousands of friends. They may be with her, but will their eyes too be similar to hers? The commentator quotes from muNdaka upanishath 2-1-9 “*niranjana: paramam sAmyam upaithi*” (they too attain the same state of being

without any fault). Just as he forgot about himself, he forgot about those he saw. He did not seem to know beyond what he saw.

kaLiRu vinavi niRRIr – wondering as to who this person who is talking in a contradictory way, they looked at him quizzically. If they are not able to see him clearly, his existence itself may be in doubt. Hence he asked them whether they had seen an elephant. Would they see him as soon as he uttered these words? Even if they do not see those who get destroyed, since they look after the fields which get destroyed, they saw him. Since they saw him, he was able to recall what he wanted to ask them earlier. He asked them the same question which he had been asking others too [have you seen an elephant?]. Those who are deceitful and those who are lustful, will say something initially; when queried about it, they will look like a statue as if they do not know anything at all. In the same way, the leading man initially spoke about eyes and now, he was speaking about elephant. Wondering about this, they looked at him. Since they looked at him with wonder, he stood without saying anything further, like a statue. She started speaking further.

ayalOr aRiyilum – why refer to “others”? Just as he was infatuated with her, she too was infatuated with him. All the others who were not infatuated with him like she was, are referred to by this term. She affirmed the distinction that she had over the others.

aRiyilum – even after uniting with him, she does not know much about him. In such a situation, will it be apt for the others to know more about him than she does? Just as it has been said in periya thirumozhi 10.10.9 “ *innArenRu aRiyEn* ” (I do not know about his nature) when he had come in person, since she had not asked him anything, it has come to this pass. When no one could know about him, why does she have a doubt as to whether others would have known about him? Should not the fault of doubt be removed?

Idhu enna vArththai – how are you saying unconnected words such as “Are your eyes fish? Have you seen the elephant?” If you talk like this, what will others think of you? How are you saying words which we have not heard of, to someone whom you have not seen before at all? When we are protecting the fields, why are you saying that we are driving away birds with the word “ *AyO* ”? Why are you speaking words with inner meanings, as if they are mixed with gentle breeze and rain drops? She is wondering as to what all secrets are contained in his words. She is asking whether he is adept with words in his speech. She says that it appears that his activity is to engage with others with word-play. Our activities [she refers to herself and her friends] may not be centred around carrying out apt work at apt time. Do you have activities without this fault?

kadal kavarntha puyalOdu ulAm koNdal vaNNan – aren’t we living in our houses, on this hill, with the hope that you would come? thiruvEngadamudaiyAn has the divine complexion of cloud which has drunk all the water from the ocean and has become immobile since it is pregnant with all the water. Srl rAmAyaNam kinshkindhA kANdam 28-22 conveys the same meaning “ *samuthvahanthas salilAdhibAram* ”.

koNdal vaNNan – water mentioned in the simile does not sustain the people on the hill. It is the physical beauty of the entity who is compared with water [thiruvEngadamudaiyAn], which sustains the people here.

vEngadaththup punaththu emmodum payalO ileer – the lady tells the leading man “You are calling yourself the Master, and as said in jithanthE SIOkam, ‘pUrvajar’ – one who had been there from the beginning” If that were the case, shouldn’t you have come here ahead of us? We have attained the

most pious thiruvEngadamalai, which is apt to be attained. Hearing this, the leading man asks “Are you implying that we have not taken hold of you? What is the necessity for us to do that?” The lady responds saying “Should you not give refuge to us who are without a refuge? If we step out of our house, it is a fault. If you do not step out, it is your fault. Since you are the master and the protector, it is a fault on your part if you do not come to protect us without waiting for us to call you. Since we are your servitors and are protected by you, if we attempt to protect ourselves, it is our fault” Just as it has been said in perumAL thirumozhi 2-6 “*thIdhil nanneRi kAtti*” (manifesting the correct paths which are without faults) she implies that they should not do anything to protect themselves but could carry activities which would please emperumAn.

kollai kAkinRa nALum palapalavE – Are we looking at the fields? Are we not looking at you? She says that they had been looking for such a long time that the crop has become mature, ready for harvesting; she is fearful that they may not be allowed to come to the field anymore by their parents. We had been waiting for you, all along. Did you come now, to manifest your sorrow in separation? She implies that though they had been waiting for him, only now it has dawned on him. Just as you came here with the excuse of going for hunting elephant, we had come here with the excuse of looking after the fields. We are now returning home, since we had done enough of looking after the fields. Just as we had been protecting the fields all along, you may now protect the field, after we leave. Since we are leaving now, did you come as a protector for us, on our way back home? Or else, did you think that we are on our own and hence you failed to show up all along, in order not to accept us?

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): AzhwAr had told the SrlvaishNavas “We would like to instruct you about matters related to emperumAn; hence please come soon” However, the SrivaishNavas arrived, after a delay. AzhwAr tells them “What is the purpose in coming now? He [emperumAn] has granted us SrlvaikuNtam. You have come this late!”

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18. pAsuram 16 – papapala UzhigaLAyidum

avathArikai (Introduction)

The leading man separated from his lady after being united with her for a long time. As a result of this, the sorrow due to separation became severe. This pAsuram could be considered as the leading lady telling her friend or as the friend telling the leading lady.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings.

*palapala UzhigaLAyidum anRiyOr nAzhigaiyaip palapala kURitta kURAyidum kaNNan viNNaNaiyAy
palapala nALanbar kUdilum nIngilum yAm melidhum pala pala sUzhaludaiththamma vAzhi ippAyirulE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

kaNNan – krishNa's

viNNaNaiyAy – one who is enjoyable like paramapadham

anbar – the leading man who is affectionate

palapala nAL – many kalpams (kalpam is one day of brahmA, running to millions of years)

kUdilum – whether united

(during that time)

Or nAzhigaiyai – one nAzhigai (24 minutes)

palapala kURitta – broken down many times over

kURAyidum – will become infinitesimal

(time will fly like a fleeting moment)

anRi – otherwise

nIngilum – even (if the leading man) separates (for a moment)

Or nAzhigaiyai – one nAzhigai

palapala kURitta kURu – an infinitesimal moment by breaking down the nAzhigai

palapala UzhigaLAyidum – will become many kalpams

(it will grow like that over a very long period)

yAm – we

palapala – long time

melidhum – are suffering

amma – Oh mother!

pAy – expansive

i iruL – this darkness

palapala – many types

sUzhal – deceitful acts

udaiththu – has

vAzhi – let it live long

(this is termed as *nindhAsthuthi* – abusing, as if being praising)

Simple Translation

Oh one who is enjoyable like krishNa’s paramapadham! Even if one were united with an affectionate beloved person for a long time, that time would appear as fleeting as breaking down a *nAzhigai* (24 minutes) into infinitesimal parts. It would end that fast. However, if the same man leaves even for a brief time, even an infinitesimal portion of a broken down *nAzhigai* would appear to be as long lasting as many kalpams. I have been in such a sorrowful state, for a long time. This night, which brought my situation to this level, is full of deceitful acts. Let this darkness live forever.

vyAkhyAnam

palapala UzhigalAyidum – After being together for a long time, if one were to separate for a short time, even that short span of time appears like eons.

anRi – instead of that

Or nAzhigaiyaip palapala kURitta kURAyidum – the time that they [the leading man and his lady] were together appears like an infinitesimal portion such as breaking down one *nAzhigai* (twenty four minutes) into a million parts and considering one such part. Even during such an infinitesimal length of time, instead of being united, they had spent it in knowing about each other. The time that they were together did not appear to be for enjoying but to create separation later.

kaNNan viNNaNaiyAy – this term could be considered as having been said either by the leading lady or by her friend. If it is considered as having been said by the leading lady, the meaning would be – “Oh my friend who is sweet and very dear, like paramapadham! I am existing only because you are near me like krishNa’s paramapadham. Just as the sorrows of samsAram will not go anywhere near those who are in paramapadham, despite all my sorrows in separation due to the cruelty of this time, if I exist it is only because of you”. If it is considered to have been uttered by the lady’s friend, the meaning would be – “Is it not true that those who are in paramapadham will never return from there? They will never separate from there, will they? Oh one who is dear like paramapadham! Is it possible for one who has attained you, to leave you? Could they exist, after separating from you?”

palapala nAL – If this is considered as having been said by the leading lady, the meaning would be – “Whether I am with him forever or separate from him for a very short span of time, it is not possible for me to be like him [the leading man], without any change. When I was with him, since I did not think of anything else, I felt like floating in the air and became emaciated; when I separated from him, due to the anguish of separation, I became emaciated; how strange is this!” If this is considered as having been spoken of by the friend, the meaning will be – “My friend, this leading lady, is totally weakened whether she is with her man or separated from him, without any distinction”. The term *sUzhal* refers to plotting. In other words, night time is plotting to hasten the time when the leading man and lady are together

and to delay the time further when they are separated. Both the lady and her friend are feeling sad that they do not have the quality of plotting which the night has. The reason for both of them to feel sad is the separation from the man [leading lady is genuinely affected while for the friend it is because of seeing the lady feeling sad].

palapala sUzhal udaiththu – it is helpful when they are together and inimical when they are separated. Commentator cites a couple of examples to illustrate this – nAchchiyAr thirumozhi 12-3 “ *nandhagOpan kadaiththalaikkE naLLirutkaN* ” (reach me at the doorstep of nandhagOpan’s house before it dawns) implying that darkness is helping them to unite; thiruviruththam 72 “ *surungA iruLin karundhiNimbai* ” (breaking the hold of darkness) implying that night gets scared when they are separated.

amma – calling out to her mother

vAzhi – if this is considered as having been spoken of by the leading lady, this implies that she is paying backhanded compliment just like telling her brothers who had taken her possessions “Oh my brothers! May you live up to the age of hundred”; if it is considered as having been told by the lady’s friend, this would imply that the friend genuinely wishes her to get out of her troubles.

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): this pAsuram conveys the unwillingness of AzhwAr to stay in samsAram (materialistic world)

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19. pAsuram 17 – iruL virindhAlanna

avathArikai (Introduction)

After being united with the leading lady for some time, the leading man thought that the people of the town may talk ill of them and hence decided to leave her and go, for some time. If she saw him going, she would not bear it; hence he leaves on his chariot in the night, unknown to her as well as to the people of the town. Srl rAma left ayOdhyA in the night [for spending fourteen years in exile] since he knew that the people would not be able to tolerate his separation if they saw him going. Lest they find out the route by which he had gone, he ensured that there were no marks of his chariot in the pathway. Unlike that, the leading man here did not remove the chariot marks. Looking at those marks, the leading lady consoled herself. At that time, ocean, with its waves, set out to destroy the marks. Immediately, she surrenders to the ocean. Is it proper to surrender to an insentient entity such as the ocean? Just as Srl rAma had done, as mentioned in Srl rAmAyaNam yudhdha kANdam “*prathiSiSyE mahOdhadhE*” (Srl rAma prostrated in front of that huge ocean), AzhwAr too [in the pathos of the leading lady] surrendered to the ocean.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*iruL virindhAlanna mAnIrth thiraikoNdu vAzhayarO iruL pirindhAr anbar thEr vazhi thUral aravaNai mEl
iruL viri neelak karu nAyIRu sudar kAlvadhu pOl iruL viri sOdhip perumAn uRaiyum eRi kadale*

Word-by-Word Meanings

iruL – darkness

viri – spread out

neelam – dark

sudar – radiance

kAlvadhu – setting out

karu – black *nAyIRu pOl* – like the sun

iruL viri – spread out like darkness

sOdhi – one who has radiance

perumAn – sarvESvaran

aravaNai mEl – on thiruvananthAzhwAn (AdhiSEshan)

uRaiyum – dwelling for ever

eRi – throwing out (waves)

kadale – Oh ocean!

anbar – the beloved leading man

iruL – in the darkness

pirindhAr – separated (from me)

thEr vazhi – marks of (his) chariot

virindhalanna – spread out

mA – dark

nIr – having water

thirai koNdu – with waves

thUral – do not destroy

vAzhivarO – may you be happy

Simple Translation

Oh ocean on whom sarvESvaran, who is like a bluish gem emitting darkness, who is dark like sUriyan (sUrya) emitting radiance and who has a dark complexion, is lying on the mattress of AdhiSEshan! My beloved has left me, separating from me. Please do not destroy the marks left behind by his chariot. May you live long!

vyAkhyAnam

iruL virindhAlanna – looking at the ocean which has spread out expansively, like darkness. While water is associated with the colour white, why is AzhwAr comparing it with black coloured darkness? This is because of the abundance of water present in the ocean. However, if one scoops water in one's palm, it would appear white. Both black and red denote anger. Thus, the opinion is that ocean looks dark because of anger in its mind.

mA nIrththirai koNdu – with its waves which are in abundance, ocean is obliterating the marks of chariot. The term *mA nIr* could be taken either as abundant quantity of water or as dark water.

vAzhivarO – She is praising the ocean to live long, similar to praising a person who is coming to cause sorrow. She is surrendering to the ocean.

vAzhivarO – She surrendered to the ocean since it was destroying the chariot marks, being unable to hear her and since it had abundant waves. Seeing her surrender to it, the ocean asked her “What are you doing?” She responded saying “You should go the horrible way. Did you not listen to my sorrows?” The ocean asked her “What are you suffering from?” She then started narrating how her beloved separated from her in the night. Had he left during daytime, I would have seen how he would have suffered due to the separation, thinking “Alas! He is suffering so much because of me” and would have consoled myself. Or else, I would have looked at the beauty in his face and his quality of being the Lord and would have had some consolation. However, he had left in the night since he probably thought “If I leave during daytime, she would see me. Looking at her suffering, my legs would not be able to move from here”. Let him go wherever he wished. However, didn't he leave during the night that we united? Hearing her narration, the ocean asked her “What should I do?” She responds

thEr vazhi thUral – Just as people give up all their possessions in alms and then eke out a living through taking food from others, I have given him up and am looking at the marks left behind by his chariot. Please do not destroy these marks.

aravaNai mEl – He is sleeping on the mattress of thiruvananthAzhwAn, just as it has been mentioned in periyAzhwAr thirumozhi 5-1-7 “ *veLLai veLLaththin mEl* ” so that the oceanic water on which he is lying will not cause any discomfort to his soft divine form.

iruL viri neela . . . – just like sUriyan who is emitting bluish rays similar to darkness encompassing. Would sUriyan emit bluish rays? Since there is no object in the world which can be compared to the effulgence of sarvESvaran, he is mentioning as a simile, an entity which is not seen anywhere.

iruL viri sOdhi . . . – the permanent abode of emperumAn, who has a dark form similar to darkness which has spread everywhere and, who is resplendent

eRi kadale – it is natural for ocean to rejoice and rise up on seeing moon which is like butter. However, here, it is rejoicing on seeing emperumAn who has a dark form. Refer to mudhal thiruvandhAdhi pAsuram 19 “ *mAlum karum kadale* ” (Oh the black ocean, who is rejoicing!)

eRi kadale – since you are always with him, you know only of union. Since you do not know of separation, please know that separation is not something which is new to this world. Don’t those who attain him have qualities similar to his? [here she is referring to ocean] Why are you seeking a fault by destroying these marks left behind by his chariot? Should you not learn from him? periya thirumozhi 11-3-5 “ *thammaiyEokka aruL seyvarE* ” (he mercifully grants equality [in eight qualities] to those who seek him) is cited here as reference.

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): It appears to AzhwAr that everything which causes separation for him from SrlvaishNavas is harmful for him.

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20. pAsuram 18 – kadal koNdu

avathArikai (Introduction)

The leading man had told his beloved “I will return once monsoon arrives”; however, he did not return even after monsoon had arrived. This pAsuram indicates the mental make-up of the *nAyaki* (leading lady) regarding the monsoon season. This pAsuram, like the seventh pAsuram in this prabandham (*gyAnam panippa*) belongs to the classification of *kAlamayakku* (bewilderment due to change in time). While this has been spoken about in the seventh pAsuram itself, what is the need to mention the same here too? That pAsuram was composed when monsoon had just set in. However, this pAsuram speaks about the *nAyaki*’s anguish at the non-arrival of her beloved when the rainy season is about to end. It has been said this way since she is of a soft nature who cannot tolerate separation, he is one with greatness and this is the time at which he had promised he would return. There is no other way for her to sustain herself other than crying about his continued absence. thirumangai AzhwAr had spoken about *SaraNAgathi* (surrendering to emperumAn) in ten different ways in ten different pAsurams. This AzhwAr too is carrying out in the same way. He too is bewildered on account of *kAlamayakku* . In the seventh pAsuram, she [AzhwAr in feminine pathos] comprehended what she had seen – gathering of clouds – as two bulls fighting with each other; here, she is comprehending a similar incident (rainfall) as arising out of the fight between ocean and cloud. She is mistaking the intimacy of ocean and cloud as a fight between them and is bewildered.

Let us look at the pAsuram and its meanings:

kadal koNdu ezhundhadhu vAnam avvAnaththai anRich chenRu kadal koNdu ozhindha adhanAl idhu kaNNan maNNum viNNum kadal koNduezhundha akkAlam koLO puyaRkAlam koLO kadal koNda kaNNIr aruvi seyyA niRkum kArigaiyE

Word-by-Word Meanings

kadal – ocean

koNda – defeating

kaN – from the eyes

nIr – tears

aruvi seyyA niRkum – making it as a flood

kArigaiyE – Oh lady!

vAnam – the sky

koNdu – swallowing

ezhundhadhu – rose

kadal – the ocean

avvAnaththai – that sky

anRi – getting angry

senRu – following it

koNdu – retrieving (the water taken by cloud)

ozhindha adhanAI – due to the water which stayed (in it)

idhu – these drops of rain

(are pouring)

kaNNan – krishNa's

maNNum – bhUIOkam (earth)

viNNum – the upper IOkam (svarga etc)

koNdu – swallowed

ezhundha – developed

akkAlam koLO – is it that time of deluge?

puyaRkAlam koLO – or is it the monsoon time

(I am unable to determine)

Simple Translation

Oh lady who is shedding tears like a flood, which can defeat the water contained by ocean! The sky imbibed the entire water present in ocean and rose up. Ocean, becoming furious at this, followed that sky and went up. Reaching the sky, it retrieved the water from. At the end of all this, a few drops of water fell down as rain. I do not know whether this is the time for seasonal rains or the time when deluge swallowed krishNa's upper world and this world.

vyAkhyAnam

kadal koNdu ezhundhadhu vAnam . . . – the term *vAnam* here refers to cloud [and not to sky]. Cloud drank up the water from ocean so completely that the ocean bed was visible. Due to this, creatures living in the ocean started struggling for life. Seeing this, the ocean became furious thinking "Our citizens are suffering acutely. The cloud has taken away our possession of water so easily". It ran behind the cloud to retrieve its water. The term *anRi* refers to fury. These should be taken as the words of the *nAyaki*'s [leading lady's] friend. The *nAyakan* [leading man] had not returned during monsoon time, as he had promised when he separated from the leading lady. Since it started raining, and a few drops of water fell on her, the leading lady queries her friend "The monsoon has arrived; however, the *nAyakan* has not arrived"

ozindha adhanAI idu – when the two are fighting with each other [for that water] just a few drops are falling on us; it is not raining, assures the friend. When *rAvaNa* and *jatAyu* were fighting in the sky, several articles such as the decorations of *rAvaNa*'s chariot, his flag etc fell down. In the same way, these drops of water are falling during the fight between ocean and sky. The friend feigns surprise and says "How did this flood get generated? Is it that or this?" The reason for this is that she had been giving some excuse or the other since the *nAyaki* would not be able to bear the continued absence of *nAyakan*

despite the rainy season having set in. Guessing as to what she could do if the *nAyaki* finds out that she had been telling lies, she continues cleverly.

kaNNan maNNum viNNum . . . – don't this world and sky which belong to sarvESvaran, appear to have been taken up by the ocean, as happens during a deluge?

puyaRkAlam koIO – Or is it the rainy season? I am unable to ascertain. The friend, who was cleverly saying such words, says "Oh! I have found out how this flood was formed" and continues.

kadal koNda kaN – Is this [flood] not coming from your eyes? Your eyes will defeat the ocean itself in terms of the water held. There are two interpretations to the term *kadal koNda kaN* – the eyes are as expansive as the ocean; also, the eyes hold more water than the ocean.

nIr aruvi seyyA niRkum – have you not realised that the reason for this flood, which looks like a deluge, is the large quantity of water shed by your eyes, like a stream?

kArigaiyE – you are like a helpless woman, unable to tolerate these.

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning) for this pAsuram: This pAsuram appears to have been narrated by those who are unable to bear the anguish of AzhwAr who is anxious to unite with emperumAn or his followers at the correct time. It appears that since deluge has come in, it has created an urge in him to unite with emperumAn and has bewildered his knowledge.

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21. pAsuram 19 – kArigaiyAr niRai

avathArikai (Introduction)

The friend, in order to placate the *nAyaki* [leading lady] had told her several lies, as in the previous pAsuram when she told her that it is not the rainy season. Just because she had told lies, will the real monsoon season become false? Just as it has been mentioned in Srl rAmAyaNam kishkindhA kANdam 28-31 “*raNOthyathAnAm ivavAraNAnAm*” (clouds which have thunder and lightning as their flags), the clouds have surrounded on all sides, like an army of elephants and are pouring rain. Seeing this, the *nAyaki* swooned, thinking that her *nAyakan* (leading man) has not returned yet, to her. Looking at this, the *nAyaki*’s friend too swooned. Looking at this state, the *nAyaki*’s mother says “Let her sorrow take leave of her”

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings.

kArigaiyAr niRai kAppavar Ar enRu kAr koNdu innE mAri kaiyERi aRaiyidum kAlaththum vAzhayarO sArigaip puLLar andhaNNandhuzhAy iRai kUyaruLAr chErikaiyERum pazhiyAy viLaindhadhu en chinmozhiKkE

Word-by-Word Meanings

kArigaiyAr – of the women

niRai – modesty

kAppavar – one who protects

yAr – who?

enRu – saying so

kAr koNdu – becoming dark

innE – like this

mAri – rain

kaiyERi – gathering in groups

aRai idum kAlaththum – during the time when they announce victoriously like a war cry

sArigai – flying in circles

puLLar – Srlya:pathi (consort of Srl mahAlakshmi), who has garuda as his vehicle

am – beautiful

thaN – being cool

thuzhAy – divine thuLasi garland

iRai – even a little bit

kUy aruLAr – is not offering mercifully, after calling out

en – my

chinmozhi – for her who talks in feeble (gibberish) words

chEri – those who reside in the neighbourhood

kai ERum – lifting their hands

pazhiyAy – as an accusation

viLaindhadhu – happened

vAzhivarO – let this sorrow get eliminated

Simple Translation

The clouds, becoming darker, have gathered on all sides and ask uproariously “Which women could protect their modesty in our presence? Or, who is there to protect the modesty of these women?” Even during this time, sarvESvaran, who has garuda who can circle rapidly in the skies, has not called out to her and given her his cool, beautiful thuLasi garland. As a result, those who live in our neighbourhood raise their arms and accuse my daughter who talks very few words. Let her live long, after getting rid of this sorrowful state.

vyAkhyAnam

kArigaiyAr . . . – There are two interpretations for this term – one meaning is that the clouds ask “When we are roaming here, who is there to protect these women who are suffering in separation from their beloved?” The other meaning is that the clouds ask “When we are roaming, which lady can protect herself or another person?”

kAr koNdu – becoming dark or becoming angry

mAri kaiyERi – the rain which is lashing heavily. It could be said that the clouds had rain as their ornament.

aRaiyidum kAlaththum – similar to making a war-cry in battlefield. Just like sugrIva called out to vAli for battle, with Srl rAma as his support. The clouds here, unlike sugrIva who needed support, won on their own strength. There it was the warrior, vAli. Here, it is the women who are helpless. There, as said in Srl rAmAyaNam kishkindhA kANdam 32-17 “ *antharEnAnjalim badhvA lakshmaNasya prasAdhanAth* ” (the only option to save yourself is to perform *anjali* (join palms together) to lakshmaNa), sugrIva, being a sentient entity, did just that. However, here, the clouds, being insentient, would not listen even when told.

vAzhivarO – let her live long, after getting rid of her sorrows.

sArigaip puLLar – it is not possible for the *nAyakan* to say that he could not come before the rainy season. It could not be said that he had never come fast anytime before this. One needs to recap his speed when he came to help the elephant gajEndhran. It could not be said that he does not have any support to come fast, since he has garuda who comes fast in circles. He has the quality of offering himself to his followers when they are in distress, thus manifesting to them his quality [of being a protector]. While he was wondering “Should I leave today?” to save slthA who was with him for fourteen years, he did not think for a moment when setting out to save the elephant, and had the support of garuda, too. He has all the qualities of being a supreme entity by having garuda who could

take him fast to his followers in distress, by having the divine disc in his hands [again to protect his followers], by having periya pirAtti [Sri mahAlakshmi] who he refers to as “mine” and by having the divine thuLasi as his garland.

andhaNNandhuzhAy – the divine thuLasi which is capable of redeeming life. Similar to saying *santhAnakaraNi* – *visalyakaraNi* : the former term refers to his divine feet and the latter, to thuLasi.

iRai kUyaruLAR – If he tries to avoid her love, should he avoid being her lord too? He has forgotten that he is her *nAyakan* . However, should he not have come to protect her since he is the lord for all? He has forgotten that too! He should have come on his own, embraced me and made the divine thuLasi which is on his shoulder to touch my chest. But he did not do that. He could have at the least, called me and offered thuLasi as well as many other entities. He did not do that. Whether he comes to me or calls me out towards him, the benefit is his only.

chEri kaiyERum pazhiyAyviLaindhadhu – looking at my state, all those who are near me are saying “Oh how she is craving”. Everyone started pointing out to me, saying “Instead of waiting for him, she is attempting to seek the benefit on her own!”

chinmozhikkE – it is not the age for her to crave like this! Isn’t her age such that even if she were asked to say something, she is unable to utter anything!

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22. pAsuram 20 – chinmozhi nOyO

avathArikai (Introduction)

This pAsuram belongs to the classification of *veRivilakku* in thamizh literature. Concerned with the illness of the *nAyaki* (leading lady), the mothers engage fortune tellers to tell them the reason for her state. They say that it is because of (a lowly) deity. Believing that, the mothers engage in remedial activities to rid the *nAyaki* of her illness. The lowly deity, seeing all these, possesses a person in the crowd, making him to go into a frenzy. The *nAyaki*'s friend tells the mother to stop all these and drives away the one who is in frenzy. This is called as *veRivilakku*.

Looking at the clouds surrounding, both the *nAyaki* and her friend became bewildered. The *nAyaki*'s mother became very saddened on seeing this state. Determining that this is the correct time, those who worship deities other than emperumAn, came there and started giving remedial measures to improve the situation of *nAyaki*. The mothers too started carrying out such remedial measures. Another friend of the *nAyaki*'s, who knew the real reason for the *nAyaki*'s sorrow, came there at that time. She told the mothers "When a beautiful garland is given to you, with water sprinkled on it to freshen it up, you act as if you want to throw it into fire. Don't destroy her *svarUpam* (true nature) by indulging in these remedial measures". She explained to them the reason for her illness, the antidote for that illness and the method to remove that illness.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*chinmozhi nOyO kazhiperum dheyvam innOyinadhenRu inmozhi kEtkum iLam dheyvam anRu idhu vEla
nil nI en mozhi kENmin en ammanaimIr ulagu Ezhum uNdAn sonmozhi mAlai andhaNNandhuzhAy
koNdu sUttuminE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

chinmozhi – she, who speaks (illegible) small words, her

nOy – illness

kazhi – very much

perum – huge

dheyvam – happened due to such supreme entity

innOy – this illness

inadhu enRu – resulted due to lowly Gods

inmozhi – non-existent (false) words

kEtkum – feeling happy on hearing

iLam dheyvam – a lowly God

idhu – this illness

anRu – did not result

vEla – Oh vEla (subrahmaNya)!

nI – you

niI – stand at a distance

en ammanaimIr – Oh my mothers!

en mozhi – my words

kENmin – do listen to

ulagu Ezhum – the seven worlds

uNdAn – one who ate

mozhi – divine names

sol – recite

am – beautiful

thaN – cool

thuzhAy – strung with divine thuLasi

mAlai – garland

koNdu – bring

sUttumin – adorn

Simple Translation

nAyaki's friend tells her mothers "The reason for the illness of this girl, who talks only a few words, is the supreme entity who is huge. Her disease has not been caused by any lowly God, as said by some people. Oh subramaNya! Go far from this place. Oh my mothers! Do listen to what I am saying. Keep reciting the divine names of the supreme entity who ate up the seven worlds. Offer her a garland strung with beautiful, cool, divine thuLasi".

vyAkhyAnam

chinmozhi – there are two interpretations: one who uses very few words because of her young age or one who uses few words because of deep sorrow. The commentator uses the former meaning. If one were to consider this as a case where the girl is so young that she can not even repeat the words spoken of by others, one would wonder as to how such a person became engaged with emperumAn to such an extent that she suffers in separation. The commentator gives reference here to Srl rAmAyaNam bAlakANDam 18-27 " *bAlAyAth prabhruthi susnigdha:* " (lakshmaNa was very affectionate towards Srl rAma from infancy stage). In the same way, the *nAyaki* too has been affectionate towards emperumAn from a young age. However, the illness which she exhibits is not congruent with her age. Does it not come after observing many deeds? Is it proper to term the love that one shows towards emperumAn as *illness* ? Since it is a state which one takes upon oneself, it is apt only. The *svarUpam* (true nature) of the person is such that it becomes difficult to sustain himself/herself when separated from emperumAn.

nOy O – she is amazed that it is not the illness which befalls a person at such an age. She says that one can even make a payment in order to get such an illness. It is that good. One’s inability to sustain oneself during separation from emperumAn is the *svarUpam* of the AthmA.

kazhi perum dheyvam – the term *kazhi* refers to abundance. Here, it refers to a huge deity or one who has such greatness that he cannot be described by words. Several references are cited: purusha sUktham “*pathim viSvasya*” (lord of all the worlds); *pathim pathInAm* – superior to all the kings of the world; *tham ISvarANAm paramam mahESvaram* – one who is his own lord [he does not worship any other lord] and is the lord of all other deities; *thaiththirlya upanishath yathO vAchA nivarthanthE* – words return unable to describe the supreme entity.

innOy inadhenRu – [it is difficult to say] that this is the illness that she is suffering from or that this is the medicine or method to get rid of that illness

inmozhi – the lowly words which convey the meaning that this illness was caused by a lowly deity who wishes to listen to meaningless words such as “This disease was caused by such and such lowly deity”. Here, *inmozhi* refers to meaningless words.

kEtkum iLam dheyvamanRu idhu – all the lowly deities are happy and they celebrate when the people praise them ascribing non-existent greatness to them. However, the deity who caused her the illness is not one such deity. This is not the deity who grants people their wishes, expecting in return, words of praise from such people.

inmozhi – as far as other deities are concerned, their greatness will not equal the words spoken in their praise. However, in the case of *bhagavath vishayam* (matters relating to emperumAn), his greatness will be such that no words of praise can truly reflect it.

vEla nil ni – on hearing the words spoken by the *nAyaki*’s friend finding fault with the fortune tellers who were praising him, vElan (one who has spear, subrahmaNya) started getting jittery. Through the fortune teller, who he had taken possession of, he started blabbering “We will protect her as our child” etc. But the friend told him “We will not allow you to enter this place. Just as it has been said in *thiruppaLLANdu engal kuzhuvini pugudhalottOm*, we will not permit you to enter our group. Just as *thiruvAimozhi 6-6-1* says *kUrArAzhivi veNsangEndhi*, we are waiting to see sarvESvaran with his divine hands carrying divine disc and white conch. But you are standing here with your spear. Leave this place at once”.

enmozhi kENmin enammanaimlr – the *nAyaki*’s friend tells them “Oh mothers! Listen to my words”. Normally we see people instructing those who are younger or disciples or children. We do not come across younger people instructing elders. piLLai IOkAchAryar says that this is similar to the words spoken by Sukra to *pithrus* (forefathers) who had incurred a curse from brahmA. The remedy for the curse is for them to approach Sukra. Sukra comes there and tells them “*puthrakA ithihOvAcha*”. However, there, Sukra addresses the *pithrus* as *puthrakA* (children) whereas here, the friend addresses them as “Mothers!” which appears to be incongruent. There is a difference between the two incidents. In the case of Sukra, the *pithrus* were ignorant; hence he addressed them as *puthrakA*. Here, the mothers are aware of *bhagavath vishayam*. They appear bewildered on seeing the condition of daughter who is separated from emperumAn. Thus, it is not incongruent here.

ulagamEzhum . . . – She tells them to recite to the daughter the divine names of the entity who had protected the worlds from the dangers of deluge by keeping them in his stomach. The mothers counter

this saying “He will protect if there is danger to the worlds. For this girl alone, will he come and protect?” The friend responds saying “He protected the worlds as an equivalent of ridding her of her disease. You could consider that her illness is similar to the illness of all the worlds”.

mAlai andhaNNandhuzhAy koNdu sUttuminE – ensure that the divine, cool, beautiful thuLasi garland on his divine shoulders touches this girl’s form. The commentator says that *sonmozhi* (reciting the divine names of emperumAn) is internal medicine while *thaNNandhuzhAy koNdu sUttumin* is external medicine for her illness.

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning) – for nammAzhwaAr, connection with other deities and their followers is harmful while connection with emperumAn and his followers is the reason for his sustenance.

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23. pAsuram 21 – sUttu nanmAlaigaL

avathArikai (Introduction)

In the previous pAsuram, it should be said that both mother and friend (of the *nAyaki*) did not know the greatness of emperumAn. While the mother was in bewilderment, the friend told the mothers to adorn her with the divine thuLasi garland which had earlier adorned the divine shoulders of emperumAn. On hearing this, the *nAyaki* woke up. In other words, the mere mention of the word thuLasi was sufficient for the *nAyaki* to come to her senses and wake up. There was no need for adorning her with the garland made of thuLasi. Such was the greatness of emperumAn. How would we know that on waking up, the *nAyaki* engaged with krishNa's incarnation? On waking up, she did not speak about thiruvAimozhi 1-1-1 “*uyarvaRa uyar nalam udaiyavan*” (one who had greatness nonpareil) but spoke about 1-3-1 “*uralinOdu iNaindhirundhu Engiya eLivu eththiRam*” (What simplicity did emperumAn have that he remained tied to a mortar!) The opinion is that followers of emperumAn, when they wake up after being in bewilderment for a long time, would engage with his incarnation as krishNa which only is apt for them [this pAsuram, which follows the earlier one, talks about krishNavathAram].

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

sUttu nanmAlaigaL thUyanavEndhi viNNOrgaL nannIr Atti andhUbam tharA niRkavE angu Or mAyaiyinAl Ittiya veNNey thodu uNNappoNdhumiERRuvan kUn kOttidaiyAdinai kUththu adalAyar tham kombinukke

Word-by-Word Meanings

angu – in that nithya vibhUthi (spiritual realm)

thUyana – being sacred

sUttu – apt to be adorned as an ornament on the divine crown

nal – distinguished

mAlaigaL – garlands

Endhi – holding them

viNNOrgaL – nithyasUris (permanent dwellers of nithyavibhUthi)

nal – sacred

nIr – with water

Atti – giving a divine bath

am – beautiful

dhUbam – fragrant smoke

tharAniRkavE – even as they were offering

Or – unique

mAyaiyinAl – with his solemn vow

Ittiya – gathered

veNNey – butter

thodu – stealing

uNNa – to eat

pOndhu – mercifully reached

imil – very strong

ERu – bulls’

val – powerful

kUn – curved

kOdu – horns’

idai – in-between

adal – strong

Ayar tham – the cowherd boys’

kombinukku – for nappinnai pirAtti

kUththAdinai – you had danced

Simple Translation

nithyasUris, who are the permanent dwellers of the spiritual realm, are holding ornaments and divine thulasi garland, which are apt to be adorned on your divine crown, to submit to you, after divinely bathing you with sacred water. Even as they were waiting to offer you the divine fragrant smoke, you, with your incomparable divine vow, took birth in the clan of herdsmen in order to steal and eat butter which had been gathered by them. You danced in between the curved horns of the strong bulls in order to marry nappinnai pirAtti, who was also born in that clan.

vyAkhyAnam

sUttu – distinguished materials which are apt to be decorated on the head. If emperumAn’s followers wish to offer something to his divine feet, just as mentioned in the words “ *gruhNAthi SirasA svayam* ” he would lower his head and accept the offering on his head. When ponnAchchiyaAr asked her husband piLLai uRangAvillidhAsar (a disciple of Srl rAmAnuja) as to why emperumAn accepts on his head what had been proffered to his divine feet, he responded by quoting Srl bhagavath glthA SIOkam 9-26 “ *pathram palam pushpam thOyam yO mE bhakthyA prayachchathi | thadhaham bhakthyUpahrutham aSnAmiprayathAthmana: | |* ” (if one offers me a leaf, a flower, a fruit or water with devotion, I partake of that article with pure consciousness). When he [emperumAn] is like that, should we even say that he would accept with his head any material which has been proffered to his divine feet?

nanmAlaigal – these are not flowers of *erukkam* or *thumbai* (shrubs such as Indian madder plant or dead white nettle) plants which are offered to him because he is willing to accept any leaf or any flower; these are distinguished flowers which are apt and most appropriate for him. When krishNa was going

along with balarAma to mathurA for participating in the bow-festival, he came across a washerman who refused to give the clothes which krishNa asked for; krishNa dealt him a blow which killed the washerman. Next he went to a garland vendor and got himself the beautiful garlands which he desired and donned them on his divine crown. Then he saw a *kUni* (grotesque woman) who was selling sandalwood paste. He asked for sandalwood paste to apply on his form. Thinking that these lads are cowherd boys who do not know the value of sandalwood, she gave him a watery paste; he smelt it and said “*sugandham Ethath*” (the smell of this paste is not appealing) and wanted a better paste. When she offered a better paste, he said “*rAjArham*” (it is fit to be applied to kings); I need better than this. She then gave him an even better paste; he said “*ruchiram*” – its colour alone is beautiful. On hearing this, the affection which the *kUni* had in her mind, for krishNa, spread to her face too. She was amazed, thinking “We thought that the herdsmen do not know about the differences in sandalwood paste, but these boys seem to know!” She then proceeded to offer him the sandalwood paste which she had kept for kamsan (the king of mathurA). krishNa told her “*AvayOrgAthrasadhruSamdhlyathAm anulepanam*” (You are capable of offering the most distinguished type of sandalwood paste) Don’t you know which type of sandalwood would suit which type of person? You decide which type of sandalwood would suit my brother’s divine form and my form and offer that.

thUyana – garland, sandalwood paste etc which are offered by those who do not expect any benefit for their offering.

Endhi – just as offering these to him in itself is a benefit, waiting with these materials for him is a benefit for the nithyasUris. Just as periyAzhwaAr had mentioned in periyAzhwaAr thirumozhi 2-4-4 “*manjaLum sengazhunlrum vAsigaiyum*” (turmeric, reddish water-lily, string of flowers), they will hold distinguished garlands and give him *thirumanjanam* (a divine bath) so that they could adorn him with these garlands.

viNNOrgal . . . – he is one who accepts materials offered by people in this world. Should we even speak about his accepting such materials from nithyasUris in paramapadham? The *thirumanjanam* which those who are there [paramapadham] carry out is not in expectation of any benefit. It is carried out for the welfare of world.

andhUbam tharA niRkavE angu – he remains as the source of sustenance, nourishment and enjoyment for them there. While they are waiting to perform *dhUpa hArathi* (offer the fragrant smoke), he carried out an amazing act. Sage nAradha et al told him “In *thiruvAyyppAdi* (Sri gOkulam) there is lot of butter available with those who are favourable to you”. Immediately he hid himself from nithyasUris who are referred to in rig vEdham as “*sadha paSyanthi sUraya:*” (the nithyasUris keep looking at him constantly) when they offered him the fragrant smoke and went to *thiruvAyyppAdi*.

mAyai – just as it is mentioned in the phrase “*mAyAvayunam gyAnam*” (mAyA, vayunm, gyAnam etc mean knowledge) he left for gOkulam on his desire.

Ittiya veNNey thodu uNNappOndhu – eating mischievously, the butter earned over a long period of time. He would not relish if someone offered him butter in his hand. He has to steal it and eat. It was through this manner that he showed both his supremacy and simplicity to AzhwAr [for one moment he was in paramapadham, accepting *thirumanjanam* etc from nithyasUris, a mark of his supremacy; the next moment, he was in *thiruvAyyppAdi* eating butter by stealing it, showing his simplicity].

Just as it has been mentioned in Sri rAmAyaNam AraNya kANDam 14-1 “*atha panchavatIm gachchan*” (Sri rAma came across jatAyu, the king of eagles, as he was proceeding towards panchavati), while his primary purpose in reaching *thiruvAyyppAdi* was to steal and eat butter, he attained the gem among

women, nappinnaip pirAtti (neeLA dhEvi) when he was there. It is similar to attaining a carbuncle while going to buy firewood.

imilERRi . . . – he pounced on the strong bulls which had powerful, curved horns, in order to embrace nappinnaip pirAtti next. Since it was appropriate for him, AzhwAr calls it as *kUththu* (dance).

adalAyar tham kombinukke – just as it has been said “ *krishNASrayA: krishNabala: krishNanAthAScha: pANdava:* ” (krishNa was the refuge, strength and lord for the pANdavas), after krishNa was born amidst them in the clan of herdsmen, the herdspeople looked upon him as their strength and did not respect their enemies. Why was nappinnaip pirAtti not offered to him immediately after he came to gOkulam by pouring water on his hands as symbolic of offering her, but bulls were lined up for him to fight with? If he had to embrace nappinnai who was like a *kombu* (she had waist as thin as a stick; the term *kombu* would refer both to thinness of the waist of a lady and to the horns of a bull), he had to fight with the bulls which had *kombu* (horns). The term *tham* refers to his identification with the clan of herdsmen, just as it has been mentioned in Srl rAmAyaNam bAla kANdam 67-22 “ *janakAnAm kule kIrthim AharishyathimE suthA* ” (king janaka tells of his daughter “My daughter slthA will bring celebrity to the clan of janakas”)

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24. pAsuram 22 – kombAr thazhaikai

avathArikai (Introduction)

The *nAyakan* (leading man) asks the *nAyaki* (leading lady) and her friend as to who are the people who had put them in charge of guarding the fields. Just as one goes to a place where those who are dear to that person are assembled, asking for water (in order to start a conversation), the *nAyakan* goes to the fields where these girls are guarding with some foliage in his hand and asks them “Have you seen an elephant here?” in order to strike a conversation with them. They respond asking in return “Are we here to guard these fields or are we here to answer your queries?” When the *nAyakan* went there, why did he break the shoot of a tree? This was to tell them [especially the *nAyaki*] that just as the tree shoot has started withering after being separated from the tree which is its sustaining force, he too is withering in separation from the *nAyaki*. However, the shoot appeared to have become fresh due to its contact with *sarvESvaran* (supreme entity) who is the *nAyakan*. The friend, thinking that her friend, the *nAyaki*, has not become rejuvenated like the shoot after coming in contact with the *nAyakan*, tells him “You have brought this foliage in order to express your anguish in separation. However, the foliage appears to be as fresh as it would have been had it been on the tree”. The *nAyakan* responds “Any entity which is in your presence will not get withered. Won’t the entities show signs of drooping only when they are in their respective place, being separated from you?”

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*kombAr thazhaikai siRu nAN eRivilam vEttai koNdAttu ambAr kaLiRu vinavuvadhu aiyar puLLUrum
kaLvar tham pAragaththenRum AdAdhana thammir kUdAdhana vambAr vinAchchollavO emmai
vaiththadhu ivvAn punaththE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

kombu – stick

Ar – full of

thazhai – foliage

kai – was in the hand

siRu – small

nAN – bow’s

eRivu – scar

ilam – we are not seeing

aiyar – a respectable person such as you

koNdAttu – celebrating

vEttai – hunting

vinavuvadhu – asking

ambu – with arrow

Ar – being complete

kaLiRu – elephant

puL – garuda

Urum – one who conducts

kaLvar tham – sarvESvaran who is deceptive, his

pAragaththu – leelAvibhUthi (our world)

enRum – at any time

AdAdhana – (these activities) did not happen

thammil – amongst them

kUdAdhana – will not gel

i – this

vAn – expansive

punaththE – fields

emmai – us

vaiththadhu – appointed

vambAr – complete with oddities

vinA – query

sollavO – is it to answer?

Simple Translation

It is only foliage which is held by this respectable person in his hands. There is no mark of any scar which would have occurred had he held a bow in his hand. It is only to talk to us that he is saying that he has come hunting [an elephant] This sort of incident has never taken place in this world, belonging to sarvESvaran who conducts garuda. His words are contradicting one another. Is it to respond to his odd queries that we have been appointed here?

vyAkhyAnam

kombAr thazhai kai – at a place where one can gain [sympathy] by standing with a forlorn face, why should that person carry a bow and show his valour?

siRu nAN eRivilam – we are unable to see the scar on your hand which forms due to constantly holding the bow. For a bow, the presence of arrow is characteristic. The arrow will never leave its owner, the bow. But there is no bow in your hand, say the friends. Immediately, the *nAyakan* shows them the foliage and tells them “Here is the bow”

vEttai koNdAttu – they are amused that the shoot is bow and the place that he entered [where they are standing guard over their fields] is his hunting ground, and are amazed at the strange combination. Even

if we assume that the shoot in your hand is the bow, where is the arrow? He says “The arrow was shot at the elephant and is stuck in it”

ambAr kaLiRu vinavuvadhu aiyar – they make fun of his words which are contradictory [since he has foliage in his hand and tells them that he was hunting elephant]. Using a respectable word *aiyar* [a respectable person], they tell him “You are saying words which are not gelling with one another. You seem to be a great chief!”

puLLUrum kaLvar – one who controls everything; the supreme entity

tham pAr agaththu enRum AdAdhana – in this world which is under the control of emperumAn, the supreme entity, we have not come across such words or deeds which are contradictory. We do not know whether such events take place in paramapadham.

thammil kUdAdhana – though it has not happened before either at paramapadham or here, why cannot such contradictions be taken as the normal from now onwards, asks the *nAyakan*. They say “It is not possible to consider it that way. There is no congruence between your words and you. An entity should either be existing or non-existing. It cannot be said to be outside these two, as propagated by the *mAyavAdhis* (those who claim that everything in this world is illusory). Where did you learn to say such words which are not seen either in this world or in paramapadham?”

vambAr vinAchchollavOemmai vaiththadhu – They ask him “Have we been kept here by our parents in order to ask counter questions to your novel queries?” It could also be taken that they are asking him “Have we been kept here by our parents to ask questions on the novel words which you are using?”

ivvAn punaththE – We do not have the time to respond to your queries. We do not have the time even to guard these huge fields.

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): these are words mentioned by nammAzhwAr to SrlvaiNavas who were engaged with the *svarUpam* (true nature), *rUpam* (form) and *gUnam* (qualities) of AzhwAr who himself is fully engaged with the *svarUpam*, *rUpam* and *guNam* of emperumAn.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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25. pAsuram 23 – punamO punaththayalE

avathArikai (Introduction)

In the previous pAsuram, the *nAyaki* (leading lady) and her friends had posed a few questions to the *nAyakan* (leading man). In this pAsuram, the *nAyakan* poses a few questions to them.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*punamO punaththayalE vazhi pOgum aruvinaiyEn manamO magalir num kAval solleer
puNdarlgaththangEzh vanamOranaiya kaNNan kaNNan vAnAdamurum dheyvaththu
inamOranaiylrgaLAy ivaiyO num iyalvugaLE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

am – beautiful

kEzh – having complexion

puNadarlkam – lotus flower's

Or – being distinguished

vanam – with forest

anaiya – being similar

kaNNan – having eyes

kaNNan – krishNa's

vAn – being enjoyable

nAdu – in paramapadham

amarum – dwelling

dheyvaththu – nithyasUris'

inam – with their clan

Or anaylrgaLAy – being similar in a way

magalir – Oh girls!

num kAval – to be kept under your protection

punamO – are they, the fields?

punaththu – fields'

ayal – near

vazhi – in the path

pOgum – one who is going

aruvinaiyEn – one who has cruel sins, my

manamO – is it the mind?

solleer – please tell me

num iyalvu – your nature

ivaio – is it this?

Simple Translation

Oh girls who are in a way similar to nithyasUris who live in the enjoyable paramapadham of krishNa, who has eyes similar to the colour of a forest of lotus flowers! Should the fields be kept under your protection or should it be the mind belonging to me, who has cruel sins and who is going in the path near the fields? Please tell me.

vyAkhyAnam

punamO – why is the *nAyakan* calling himself as a sinner [this comes later in the pAsuram]? He feels that had he been that field itself, he would have had the fortune of being looked at by the girls continuously (since they are standing guard over the fields). Instead of that, he is a human being, a sentient entity. A doubt arises here: it was only in the previous pAsuram that the *nAyaki* had fully seen him holding foliage in his hand. Why then is he wailing that he would have been looked at by the *nAyaki* had he been the field? The reason perhaps is that the *nAyakan* is longing for her side-glance instead of a straight forward look at him.

punaththayalE vazhipOgum – Did I come inside your field? Is there no fence for your field? I had merely passed by the path near your field. It seems that whichever place he has to go to, he has to pass through the path near the fields which they are guarding.

vazhi pOgum – are we not going in our path? Should people go through forests and thorns? It appears that for him, places other than the place where they are present, are forests, full of thorns.

aruvinaiyEn manamO – I have sinned so much that wherever I go, the path has to be through the fields. *piLLai thirunaRaiyUr araiyar*, one of our preceptors, had once said “While all the dhivyadhESams are there, why should one incur a sin of having to go through thirunagari?” The meaning of this is that if people engage with matters relating to bhAgavathas and that is deemed as a sin, then the remedy is to engage with an act of virtue, which is engaging with matters relating to bhagavAn. Instead of that, if they were to engage fully with bhAgavathas, they will immerse in it and find it difficult to extricate themselves and this will be like a sin to them.

num kAval – are you guarding the fields or are you guarding my mind?

magaLir – the reason for addressing them in the plural is that they are all similar in making him [*nAyakan*] feel distressed. Their thoughts gel together.

solleer – even when they are not responding, he is imploring them to respond to his questions. If one were imprisoned, wouldn't those who had imprisoned him serve food to sustain that person?

puNdarlgaththangEzh . . . – just as it is mentioned in chAndhOgya upanishath “ *thasyayathA kapyAsam puNdarlkamEvam akshiNI* ” (emperumAn's eyes are like lotus flowers which blossom under sunlight).

angEzh – eyes are like a forest of beautifully complexioned lotus flowers. *Or* refers to the fact that the eyes are unique, distinguished. Even the forest of lotus will to an extent only equal the eyes and not fully. *Or* can just be said to be present for the completion of the sentence (without any meaning).

kaNNan – this term refers to simplicity. Through terms such as *puNdarIkam*, the beauty of emperumAn's divine form was narrated.

vAnAdu amarum arum dheyvaththu inam Or anaiyIrgaLAy – rig vEdham says “*sadhA paSyanthi sUraya* :” (nithyasUris keep having dharSan [vision] of emperumAn constantly in SrlvaikuNtam). Even if all the nithyasUris get together, they will equal these girls only to an extent. In other words, if all the happiness of the nithyasUris, who enjoy emperumAn constantly in SrlvaikuNtam, gets added, it would not equal the happiness of these girls. The reason for this is that if one were to enjoy samsAram, it cannot offer sufficiently for that one person to become fulfilled while if all the nithyasUris were to enjoy the happiness in paramapadham, the entity which they enjoy is such great that more people will be needed to partake of that happiness.

anaiyIrgaLAy ivaiyO . . . – is this your true nature? You enslave me somehow but do not offer anything for my sustenance. Is this your nature? Even after laying siege on my mind, you are not uttering a word. Is this your nature?

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): Looking at the affection of nammAzhwaAr towards nithyavibhUthi, these are the words spoken by SrlvaishNavas.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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26. pAsuram 24 – iyalvAyina vanjanOy

avathArikai (Introduction)

Looking at the uncontrolled engagement and unflinching love which the *nAyaki* (leading lady) had for the *nAyakan* (leading man), her mother gets worried as to what will happen to the *nAyaki*.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*iyalvAyina vanjanOy koNdu ulAvum OrO kudangai kayalpAyvana perunIrkaNgaL thammodum kunRam
onRAI puyalvAyina niraikAththa puLLUrdhi kaLLUrum thuzhAyk koyalvAy malar mEl manaththodu
ennAngol em kOl vaLaikkE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

iyalvAyina – being of one's nature

vanjam – caused by (emperumAn's) deception

nOy – disease

koNdu – having

ulAvum – moving about

perunIr – in huge water body

pAyvana – those which dart

kayal – being like fish

OrO kudangai – size of one's palm

kaNgaL thammodum – being with such eyes

oru kunRAI – with a (gOvardhana) hill

puyalvAy – in rains

inanirai – clan of herds

kAththa – one who protected

puL – garuda

Urdhi – the rider, that is, Srl:ya:pathi, consort of Srl mahAlakshmi

kaL – honey

Urum – generating abundantly

koyalvAy – round in shape

thuzhAy malar mEl – on the garland strung with thuLasi

manaththodu – with (desirous) mind

em – as our daughter

kOl – one who is beautiful

vaLaikku – for her who is having bangles

ennAngol – what will happen?

Simple Translation

Her eyes are darting here and there due to the disease of love which occurs naturally and which is difficult to be seen by others. Each of her eyes is the size of a palm and is like a fish darting in water. The eyes seem to hold plenty of water. What will happen to my daughter who has such eyes and who desires the thuLasi garland, dripping with honey, and which belongs to krishNa who had protected from rain, the herd and herd-people in an earlier time with gOvardhana hill and who conducts garuda?

vyAkyAnam

iyalvAyina – something that is natural, and not assumed. Just as it has been mentioned in thiruvAimozhi 2-3-3 “*aRiyAkkAlaththuLLEadimaikkaN anbu seyviththu*” (you engaged me in servitude towards you at an age when I did not know anything) and in Srl rAmAyaNam bAlakANDam SIOkam “*bAlyath prabhruthi susnigdha:*” (lakshmaNa was affectionate towards Srl rAma from very young age itself), this too has been there from the beginning and did not come up in between.

vanja nOy – by manifesting his beautiful divine form to her, sarvESvaran deceitfully removed her engagement with worldly pursuits and created the disease called as *bhakthi* (devotion). Just as it has been mentioned in thiruvAimozhi 6-7-2 “*Urum nAdum ulagamum thannippOl*” (making everyone in the town, country and world, like herself) and in thiruvAimozhi 6-5-9 “*marangaLum irangum vagai*” (even the trees grieved for her), he deceitfully made everyone who saw him to be like himself.

nOy koNdu ulAvum – she behaved the way the disease made her to. Srl rAmAyaNam AraNya kANDam SIOkam 16-29 says “*vrutha: prakruthibhir nithyam prayAthi sarayUm nadhIm*” – lakshmaNa tells Srl rAma that bharatha would go every day to the river sarayu, surrounded by the ministers, to take a bath. Unable to tolerate the separation from Srl rAma, bharatha was going to the river to take bath in the cold water. Would he go with others when separated from Srl rAma? The opinion here is that he did not walk on his own, but due to the disease of separation, they carried him to the river. Being deceived by sarvESvaran would mean being united with him initially and then being separated from him. In the next SIOkam 16-30, lakshmaNa tells Srl rAma “*athyantha sukham samvrudhdha sukumArO himArdhitha : | katham thu apara rAthREshu sarayUm avagAhathE |*” (how bharatha, who grew up in comfort and who had a delicate form, became very distressed towards the last part of the night to take a bath in the cold waters of the river sarayu?) The commentator explains here the meaning of this SIOkam: *athyantha sukham* – After dhaSaratha had completed sixty thousand years, you, rAma, were born to him so that he could rid himself of the stigma of being without a progeny. Thus, you were brought up in total comfort by the emperor. bharatha derived the same comfort with which you were brought up. *sukumAra:* – how delicate was his form? Even if you were to look at his form intently, his form would wither; it was that delicate. *sukhOchitha* : – he was apt to live, being united with you and not in separation from you. *kathannu* – lakshmaNa thinks that bharatha too would feel the water to be cold, just as he had felt. Since lakshmaNa was always with Srl rAma, he had not suffered due to separation from him. He thought that the water, which was very cold for him while having a bath in the early hours of the morning, would have been cold for bharatha too. However, since bharatha was suffering in

separation from Srl rAma, the water felt hot for him [separation brings about excessive heat in the body] and lakshmaNa was not aware of this. *apararAthrEshu* – early hours of the morning. Why did bharatha go to the river in the early hours? Just as a newly widowed lady would go for her bath very early in the morning so that other people in the place would not see her, bharatha felt that if he went for his bath in daylight, others would scoff at him saying “He is the son of kaikEyi; did not Srl rAma have to go the forest, only because of him?”; hence he went for his bath while it was still very dark. *sarayUm avagAhathE* – if he were drowned in the river sarayU, people would have to feel for him in the water to bring him out [since it was very dark].

OrO kudangai – this does not imply that the eyes were small, just sufficient to fill out one’s palm. The eyes were large enough to be enjoyed fully by the *nAyakan* .

kayal pAyvana – they were beautiful and motionless.

pAyvana perunlr – her eyes were such that it appeared as if the water of entire ocean had entered them.

kayal pAyvana perunlr – just like fish would dart from one place to another in the ocean, foraging for food.

kangal thammodum – along with the eyes, the mind and other senses too went

kunRamonRAI – he [sarvESvaran as krishNa] wanted to protect the herd and herd-folk. He lifted what was near his hand so that they could take shelter under it. It so happened that what was near his hand was a hill and hence he lifted it.

puyalvAy – in the hurricane. It was not any ordinary rain. Just as it is mentioned in thiruvAimozhi 7-4-10 “*thlmazhai*” (rain which caused disaster), it was torrential rain.

inanirai kAththa – while protecting, one should have the determination to protect, come what may. One should not distinguish between the sentient and insentient entities at that time. Everyone and everything has to be protected. This word only talks about protecting the cows. Were the cowherds not protected? Since the herd-folk are identified only through their cows, the term cow would include the cowherd too. Hence the herd-people were protected too.

puLLUrdhi – one who controls everything.

kaLLUrum thuzhAy – thuLasi from which honey is dripping. The thuLasi garland is reaching down from sarvESvaran’s shoulders to garuda. She [*nAyaki*] wants to embrace him with that garland. It is the garland desired by sarvESvaran too! Is there any precedence for him to offer the garland to someone who desires it? The commentator quotes from Srl rAmAyaNam ayOdhyA kANDam 16-21 “*pathi sammAnithA slthA*” (slthA, who has black eyes and who was given a happy message by her husband). Emperor dhaSaratha’s minister sumanthran had come to fetch Srl rAma as he was called by his father. Before leaving, Srl rAma adorned slthA with the garland which he was wearing. Our preceptors would say that Sri rAma was telling her “until I return keep remembering about our beauty”; Srl parAsara bhattar would say that Srl rAma felt ashamed that he was giving her the garland which he was wearing and caught hold of her legs while getting up, to indicate that he felt sorry. asithEkshaNa – while Srl rAma offered her his thuLasi garland, SithA garlanded him with her eyes.

koyal vAy malar mEl – the mind went after the beautiful, circular garland.

engOlvaLaikkE – I do not know as to what will happen to her [*nAyaki*], who is wearing beautiful bangles.

malar mEl manaththodu – along with her eyes, her mind to went to him, obediently.

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): SrlvaishNavas took comfort with the presence of nammAzhwAr in samsAram; however, on seeing his excessive involvement with matters related to emperumAn, they were worried as to what will happen to him.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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27. pAsuram 25 – engOlvaLai mudhalA

avathArikai (Introduction)

The *nAyaki*'s (leading lady's) mother wonders whether among those who had been engaged with *bhagavath vishayam* (matters relating to emperumAn) and who had taken refuge only under him, anyone else had suffered this much. The commentator refers to mUnRAm thiruvandhAdhi 27 " *ArE thuyaruzhandhAr . . .* " (who has suffered even for one day after attaining emperumAn? Who has experienced sorrow like that?)

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

engOlvaLai mudhalAk kaNNan maNNum viNNum aLikkum sengOl vaLaivu viLaivikkum mAl thiRal sEr amarar thangOnudaiya thangOn umbar ellAyavarkkum thangOn nangOn ugakkum thuzhAy enseyyAdhu ini nAnilaththE

Word-by-Word Meanings

thiRral sEr – being strong

amarar thangOnudaiya – brahmA who is the lord of dhEvas (indhra et al), his

thangOn – being the distinguished lord

umbar – being great

ellAyavarkkum – other nithyasUris (permanent dwellers of SrlvaikuNtam)

nam kOn – being our lord, sarvESvaran

ugakkum – pleased with

thuzhAy – divine thuLasi

kaNNan – kaNNan's

maNNum – bhUmi (earth)

viNNum – upper worlds

aLikkum – protecting

sengOl – for the order

em – our girl

kOl – being beautiful

vaLai mudhalA – for her bangles

vaLaivu – salutations

viLaivikkum – did not offer

ini – hereafter

nAnilaththu – on the earth, which is of four types [of lands]

enseyyAdhu – what will it not do?

Al – how amazing!

Simple Translation

He is the lord of brahmA who is the lord of all the dhEvas who are more powerful than human beings; he is the lord of nithyasUris who dwell in paramapadham (SrlvaikuNtam); he is the lord of people like us. What is the divine garland of thuLasi, which is worn with pleasure by such sarvESvaran, doing? It is not offering salutations to my daughter who is wearing beautiful bangles, and who is under the protection of sarvESvaran's orders, which rule both this world (earth) and upper worlds. What else will this divine thuLasi not do on this earth which is of four types?

vyAkyAnam

engOl vaLai mudhala – it is said that this pAsuram has been sung by the *nAyaki*. Some others will say that it is the *nAyaki*'s friend who had sung while yet others will say that it is the *nAyaki*'s mother who had sung it. Since the pAsuram starts with the words *engOlvaLai* (my bangles) *nayaki* becomes the subject. Elsewhere in the vyAkyAnam the words "If one attains such a helpless woman in samsAram" are seen, indicating that the *nAyaki*'s friend who has sung the pAsuram. The previous pAsuram has been sung by the *nAyaki*'s mother and hence it could be taken that she has sung this pAsuram too. If the pAsuram is taken as the words of the *nAyaki*, the meaning for this term will be "Should the *nAyakan* manifest his independent nature by destroying my soul?" If it is taken as the words of the mother, the meaning will be "To kill my daughter"

kaNNan – The sceptre of emperumAn is conducting both this world and the upper worlds properly, protecting them. However, the divine thuLasi is causing harm to such righteous conduct of the sceptre. What is causing the harm? . . .

nam kOn ugakkum thuzhAy – the divine thuLasi, which is much liked by sarvESvaran, is doing this. If one gets this helpless girl in samsAram . . .

en seyyAdhu – sarvESvaran is there to protect both this world and the upper worlds. But instead of protecting, if he himself issues orders contrary to that, who is there to protect my girl?

thiRal sEr . . . – he is the lord of brahmA who in turn is the lord of dhEvas such as the mighty indhra.

umbar . . . – the distinguished dhEvas who are spoken of as *ayarvaRum amarargaL* – nithyasUris who do not have any bewilderment at all. Through these two terms, that emperumAn is the lord of both vibhUthis (leelA and nithya) is established.

nangOn – he is the lord of not only the two vibhUthis; he is my lord too.

ugakkum thuzhAy – thuLasi is such that it is desired by even such a lord, as mentioned in thiruvAimozhi pAsuram 1-9-7 *thOLiNai mElum nanmArbin mElum* (the garland of divine thuLasi is in contact with his divine shoulders and divine and distinguished chest).

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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28. pAsuram 26 – nAnilam vAykkoNdu

avathArikai (Introduction)

This pAsuram comes under the classification of *puNarndhudan pOkku* or *nagarkkAttal* (the *nAyakan* (leading man) guides the *nAyaki* (leading lady) to his dwelling place by foot. The distance is fairly long and the *nAyaki* could get tired. In order to keep her spirits up, the *nAyakan* encouragingly tells her ‘my house is very near’ so that she gets consoled). As they cross an arid land (desert) he tells her “Once we cross the arid land, we will reach the cool place which is green”

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*nAnilam vAykkoNdu nannIraRa menRu kOdhu koNda vEnilanjelvan suvaiththumizh pAlai kadandha
ponnE kAnilandhOyndhu viNNOr thozhum kaNNan vehkA udhu am pUm thEnalanjOlai appAl adhu
eppAlaikum sEmaththadhE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

ponnE – oh one who looks like lustrous gold!

vEnil – having hot rays

am – beautiful

selvan – sUriyan (sUrya)

nAl nilam – earth, which is classified into four types [of lands]

vAykkoNdu – taking in his mouth well

nal – the essence

nIr – water

aRa – to be removed

menRu – chewing

kOdhu – residual matter

koNda – taking it (again), in the mouth

suvaiththu – sucking on it fully

umizh – spitting it out

pAlai – desert land

kadandha – has been crossed

viNNOr – celestial entities

nilam – on the earth

kAl thOyndhu – standing on their feet firmly

thozhum – worshipping

kaNNan – the noble place where kaNNan has mercifully taken residence

vehkA – thiruvehka (a noble place in present day kAnchIpuram)

udhu – is nearby

appAladhu – what is seen after that

pU – having flowers

thEn – with honey dripping

nam – beautiful

sOlai – orchard

eppAlaikku – in all states

sEmaththadhu – will be good

Simple Translation

Oh one with the complexion of gold! sUriyan, who is beautiful and who has fiery rays, started chewing this earth with the help of his hot rays, in his mouth, drank up all the water on earth and spat out the residue which is called as desert land. We have crossed that desert land. The divine land of thiruvehka, in which kaNNan has taken residence mercifully and which is worshipped by celestial entities with their feet placed firmly on earth, is nearby. After that is the beautiful orchard which is full of beautiful flowers and honey, which will remove all sorrows and give happiness.

vyAkyAnam

nAnilam vAykoNdu – sUriyan takes earth which is classified into four types, through his fiery rays which are like his mouth. The four types are – *kuRinji* (mountainous region), *mullai* (forest region), *marudham* (agricultural region) and *neydhal* (oceans with their shores). *thamizhars* (people living in the land where thamizh is spoken) will add a fifth region, *pAlai* (desert region) and AzhwAr recognises this.

nannIr . . . – sUriyan chews these four types of lands and removes water, which is the sustaining force in these lands, from them, thus rendering them as useless residue. This residue became desert land, devoid of any water. The heat of this desert land was so high that even sUriyan could not keep that residue in his mouth and spat it out.

kadandha – crossing samsAram (materialistic realm). In other words, crossing desert is similar to crossing samsAram.

ponnE – the *nAyakan* tells the *nAyaki* that he cannot feel the desert when she is with him. He addresses her as *ponnE* to remove her fear and to emphasise his presence to support her. She became fearful looking at the desert land since she thought that it will seize her life.

kAl nilam . . . – when residents of earth perform *yagyams* (ritual conducted where food is offered to celestial entities in the form of *havis*), the celestial entities will come to earth to accept the *havis*. However, being scared of earth, they will not come inside earth fully. Instead, they will stand at some distance away and accept the *havis*. However, thiruvehka is such a noble land that even such celestial

entities will come full inside, stand with their feet firmly on the ground. It is the place where nithyasUris will circum-ambulate and salute their most desired entity, sarvESvaran.

kaNNan – sarvESvaran. Where there is affection, shortcomings will not be evident. Shortcomings of earth will not be minded by nithyasUris since their most desired entity has taken residence here, mercifully.

vehkAvudhu – this is thiruvehka. The term *udhu* refers to a place which is neither too far nor too close. It is nearby. Is there an instance when a similar incident had occurred? Srl rAma shows ayOdhyA to slthAppirAtti when they were returning from lankaA saying as in Srl rAmAyaNam yudhdha kANdam 123-55 “ *EshA sAdhruSyathE ayOdhyA rAjadhAnI pithurmama | ayOdhyAn kuru vaidhEhi praNAmaAm punarAgathA |* ” (Oh slthA! Here is seen the capital city ayOdhyA, of my father. Oh the princess of vidhEha territory! Having duly returned, offer your salutation to ayOdhyA).

appUndhEnalanjOlai appAladhu – it is a place which has orchards having beautiful flowers and honey. It is composed of several divine lands.

eppAlaikku sEmaththadhE – it will remove all the sorrows created by the desert land and offer the protection that we need.

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning) – nammAzhwAr knows that samsAram is to be given up and bhagavath vishayam (matters relating to emperumAn) is to be attained. Since the attainment [of SrlvaikuNtam] is getting delayed, he feels distressed. SrlvaishNavas, who look at him, comfort him saying “It shouldn’t matter that samsAram has still not left; since divine lands are nearby, you are standing in SrivaikuNtam only”

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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29. pAsuram 27 – sEmam sengOn

avathArikai (Introduction)

The mercy of emperumAn, who is our lord and who helps us as his nature, without any reason, is the apt protector for AthmAs (all living creatures). When he looks at us with mercy, all the hindrances change themselves so that they become our helpful entities. This is similar to those who had ostracised a prince when he was imprisoned, falling head over heels in welcoming him when he ascends the throne. When slthAppirAtti was in aSOka vanam, having been imprisoned by rAvaNa, she was tortured by demons some of whom had single eye or single ear. When they came to know that Srl rAma was very much present in lankA [to fight with rAvaNa] they became favourable to her.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

sEmam sengOn aruLE seruvArum natpAguvar enRu Emam peRa vaiyam sollum meyyE paNdellAm aRai kUy yAmangaL dhORu eri vIsum nam kaNNan thaNNam thuzhAyth thAmam punaiya avvAdai IdhO vandhu thaN enRadhE

Word-by-Word Meanings

paNdu ellAm – before (this)

aRai kUy – making war cry (like a soldier)

yAmangaL dhORu – during every *jAmam* (a time-period of three hours)

eri – fire

vIsum- – throwing up

avvAdai – that northerly wind

nam – our

kaNNan – mercifully donned by krishNa

thaN – cool

thuzhAy – strung with divine thuLasi

thAmam – garland

punaiya – since he donned

IdhO – here

vandhu – coming

thaN enRadhu – is very cool

sem – beautiful (and ordained)

kOn – Srlya: pathi (consort of Srl mahAlakshmi), who is the lord, his

aruLE – mercy alone

sEmam – protection

seruvArum – even enemies

natpAguvar – will become friends

enRu – saying

Emam peRa – such that protection occurs

vaiyam – people of the world

sollum – words

meyyE – are true

Simple Translation

Oh the mercy of the beautiful emperumAn who is the lord for all! During the time that I was separated from sarvESvaran, my lord, the northerly wind was blowing fire on me every hour, just like a soldier would make a war-cry against his enemies in the battlefield. However, that northerly wind is now blowing the fragrant smell from thuLasi garland, worn by krishNa who is dear to us, and it appears cool. Thus, the words of the people of the world that even enemies would become friendly at some point of time, ring true.

vyAkyAnam

sEmam sengOn aruLE – only the mercy of emperumAn, who is the lord and who is apt for the AthmA, is the apt protector for AthmA. Even though sarvESvaran is the protector, the jIvAthmA acts in ways which make him undeserving of sarvESvaran’s mercy. sarvESvaran creates the worlds, gives body and senses to the jIvAthmAs, creates paths for them such as *bhakthiyOgam* (path of devotion) etc to attain him and takes residence in divine abodes such as thirumalai etc so that they could approach him easily. However, the jIvAthmas discard all these and act as if *dhEham* (physical body) is AthmA. The horrendous knowledge of AthmA is such that he would destroy himself while sarvESvaran’s wisdom will be just like as it is mentioned in mudhal thiruvandhAdhi 69 “ *uLan kaNdAynannenjE* ” (Oh heart! emperumAn exists only to protect us) – willing to take the jIvAthmA into himself.

sengOn – beautiful and capable administrator. Just as it is mentioned in thaiththirIya upanishath nArAyaNavalli *pathim viSvasya* , he is the lord of the entire universe.

aruLE – there is nothing apart from his divine mercy, just as it has been mentioned in thiruvAimozhi 9-9-6 “ *avvaruL allana aruLum alla* ” (anything other than his mercy is not mercy at all). There is no need for any intervening devotion etc.

seruvArum natpAguvarenRu – even enemies will become friends; here, the body itself is referred to as enemy, as per the explanatory notes given in the commentary. In other words, enemies will act in a way which is appropriate for us. This physical form, which is fit to be given up, will, with the mercy of sarvESvaran, assist us in attaining him. At the apt time, it would leave us too.

Emam peRa – to get protection

vaiyam sollum meyyE – whatever has been said by the people of the world from time immemorial, is true only. Just as it is mentioned in Srl rAmAyaNam sundhara kANDam 34-6 “ *kalyANI batha gAthEyam*

laukiki prathibhAthi mA | EthijlvanthamAnandhO naram barshaSathAdhapi || ” (the adage that joy comes to a living being even though it may be at the end of a hundred years is true – slthAppirAtti tells hanumAn that she wanted to put an end to her suffering by perishing; however she wanted to see Srl rAma just once before dying and hence delayed her decision; that turned out to be a happy one since it was at that time that hanumAn appeared there, singing Srl rAma’s praise), it is true that the fiery wind too would be cool one day, justifying the adage “If one who is in distress does not end his life, he would become happy one day”.

paNdellAm – just as one had been born and brought up only in prison, separation has become the norm. In this situation, being distressed by the northerly wind too has become the norm.

aRai kUy – just as sugrIva had let out a war-cry when challenging vAli for a fight, with Srl rAma as his support, the northerly wind was letting out a war cry, all on its own, as a single soldier.

yAmangal dhORu eri vIsum – due to its engagement in causing harm, the wind is coming hard at her, like a tiger which has disguised itself like a cow.

vIsum – the fire of separation is blowing from all sides. The fire of hell is more cruel than the fire of samsAram (materialistic realm). But this fire of separation makes the fire of hell look like cool water.

nam kaNNan thaNNandhuzhAy . . . – just as it has been mentioned in thirunendundhANdagam 13 “*vehkAvil thuyilamarndha . .*” (one who is mercifully reclining in the divine abode thiruvehkA), the northerly wind embraced the divine thuLasi garland which is decorating sarvESvaran there and which is capable of invigorating anyone. It is enough if that wind gently contacts the thuLasi garland; there is no need to embrace it completely.

avvAdai – she [the nAyaki who is saying all these] changes her countenance – in other words, it is the same northerly wind which caused her harm.

IdhO vandhu thaN enRadhE – now it is blowing with a comforting coolness. Thus it proves the words of the people of the world “Those who carry out harmful deeds towards us will do us beneficial acts once we get sarvESvaran’s mercy”

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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30. pAsuram 28 – thaNNandhuzhAy

avathArikai (Introduction)

Due to the greatness of the entity which is lying at thiruvehka (sarvESvaran) and due to knowing about that entity in the mind, the desire for that entity grew a lot. As a result of that desire, there was a need to unite with that entity. Since that union did not fructify, that led to separation from the entity. All those which were helping the *nAyaki* (leading lady) so far turned into her foes and started distressing her. When the King gets angry with a person, wouldn't the other citizens too show their anger on that person? Northerly wind, which was cool until it carried the fragrance of thuLasi, now started blowing fire on her. Just as food which had been cooked could not be eaten due to a lack of opportunity, despite getting thuLasi etc from thiruvehka, the *nAyaki* could not get the opportunity to embrace sarvESvaran who is lying inside thiruvehka, and that led to separation.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

thaNNandhuzhAy vaLai koLvadhu yAm izhappOm naduvE vaNNandhuzhAvi Or vAdai ulAvum valvAy alagAlpuNNandhuzhAmEporunIrth thiruvarangaA aruLAY eNNandhuzhAvum idaththu uLavO paNdum innannavE

Word-by-Word Meanings

thaN – being cool

am – being beautiful

thuzhAy – the divine thuLasi

vaLai – bangles

koLvadhu – stealing (is apt)

yAm – we

izhappOm – losing is also apt

naduvE – in between

Or – unique

vAdai – northerly wind

vaNNam – the body

thuzhAvi – stealing it

ulAvum – will wander

puL – bird

val – curved

vAy alagAl – with its beak

nandhu – conch [here, this term refers to snail which carries the protective shell, conch, on its back]

uzhAmE – without troubling

poru – fighting

nIr – having water

thiruvarangA – oh one who is the lord of SrIrangam!

aruLAy – you should show mercy

eNNam – mind

thuzhAvumidaththu – during the time of being troubled

innanna – the nature of not showing mercy

paNdum – earlier too

uLavO – was it there?

Simple Translation

With the help of their bent beaks, birds are trying to peck and take away the snails which are inside the river kAviri. However, kAviri is pushing away the birds with its waves and protecting the snails. Oh thiruvarangA who is reclining on that kAviri river! The thuLasi garland which is donning your broad shoulders is making my bangles to slip out [since I am thinning]. This is apt only, since we are willing to lose them for your sake. However, a northerly wind, with which we have no connection, is coming in between and making my complexion become pale, due to which my mind is saddened. You are not coming to my rescue in these circumstances. Please tell me whether in the past too, there have been instances like this when you had not shown your mercy

vyAkyAnam

thaNNandhuzhAy . . . – there is no embargo on thuLasi. thuLasi can cause me pain any number of times. There is nothing wrong in it. The *nAyaki* says these since there is a connection of ‘harming’ and ‘being harmed’ between them (thuLasi is harming her and she is being harmed). thuLasi is a very distinguished and superior entity for sarvESvaran. She [*nAyaki*] has a connection with his divine feet always. Thus, even if thuLasi were to harm her indirectly, considering the circumstances, she is willing to accept it since this is the reason for her having a connection with thuLasi. If the King becomes angry with someone, the King’s army too will become angry with that person and look at him as an enemy. Hence, since sarvESvaran is causing her distress, thuLasi, which is his great entity, is also causing her distress.

naduVE – It is alright if thuLasi, which is connected to her, causes her harm. Why does the northerly wind, which has no connection with her, cause her harm? We can say that it is harming her because it is in this world. But we [*nAyaki* and her friends/clan] are not any ordinary citizens. Aren’t we in his *andhappuram* (private quarters)? Reference to wind is equivalent to referring to the other four elements too.

vaNNam thuzhAvi – on its way [the wind is] troubling everyone like this and destroying their complexion.

Or vAdai – there is no second entity to destroy like this. It is like a unique soldier.

ulAvum – the wind is like an elephant which has pushed aside its controller and which roams around since there is none to control it. It [wind] desires to snatch the body too, not only the complexion and splendour. Looking at the pitiable condition of her daughter, the mother lays her at the divine feet of periya perumAL (the presiding deity at Srlrangam) and asks him whether there is any connection between his taking residence in Srlrangam and her distressed condition.

vaLvAy . . . – Two instances are narrated in the commentary: (1) once a few persons brought a lady to parASara bhattar (son of kUraththAzhwAn) and told him “She has committed a crime; you should mete out punishment to her” He mercifully responded saying “She has given up everything related to worldly matters and taken refuge in Srlrangam. How do we punish her?” (2) There was some misunderstanding between embAr (rAmAnujar’s cousin) and one vlrasundharan. A person who was vlrasundharan’s enemy and living in his village, took refuge under embAr out of fear for vlrasundharan. embAr’s disciples told embAr “There is already a misunderstanding with vlrasundharan; at this juncture, is it apt to accept this person?” embAr mercifully told them “If we accept a person who takes refuge under us saying ‘I am surrendering to you’ the *SaraNAgathi dharmam* (the principles of surrendering) would protect everyone”. kAviri is protecting the snails which are lying in her water so that they are not troubled by birds which have curved beaks. Oh thiruvarangA (Lord of Srlrangam) who is reclining on that kAviri which is protecting the snails by fighting with the birds through its waves which are like its hands!

porunIr – bird with curved beak is waiting expectantly for snatching its prey from kAviri. Snail, unaware of the presence of the bird, is not asking kAviri to protect it from the bird. Yet, since the snail has taken residence inside it, kAviri is engaging in warfare with the bird through its waves and at the same time it is pushing the snail deep inside it so that it will not be snatched by the bird. If an insentient entity such as river could help those who are with it, oh thiruvarangA, what should you not do to protect her? Are you not reclining here in order to protect the *Sudhdhasathva* (purely good) entity of AthmA so that it is not harmed by the insentient samsAram (materialistic realm)?

thiruvarangA aruLAY – since she is requesting him to shower his mercy, it is evident that he is not showering it until that moment. Why is he not showering his mercy? emperumAn says “I have given you physical form, all the senses to know about me, the path of devotion to attain me and SAsthras which tell you that these are the means for attaining me” AzhwAr says “You are the omniscient and omnipotent entity who has created all these. But how will I, with ignorance and with no strength, attain you? You have not created *svarUpagyAnam* (true knowledge about self) in me” Why is AzhwAr, who is immersed in *bhagavath vishayam* (matters relating to emperumAn) afraid like this? Since he has attained knowledge with emperumAn’s mercy, he has given up all which needed to be given up and the knowledge has shown him the goal too. He has developed the required desire too, to attain sarvESvaran. Yet he has not attained him. The reason for this is the inimical samsAram and he is afraid of that only. One should be fearful of samsAram and that fear should disappear on seeing sarvESvaran. If one has not lost fear of samsAram even after seeing emperumAn, it reflects that one has not understood the greatness of emperumAn. If one is not afraid of samsAram (to start with) it means that one has not understood the nature of samsAram. Only those who preach lowly narratives such as “samsAram is an illusion; jIvan will attain liberation on realising this” will not be afraid of samsAram. sarvESvaran can tell a jIvAthmA as in bhagavath glthA 18-6 “*mA Sucha:*” (do not grieve) only if the jIvAthmA knows the greatness of sarvESvaran and is afraid of samsAram. Only then could the jIvAthmA say as in bhagavath glthA 18-73 “*sthithOsmi*” (I will stand firmly).

thiruvarangA – what for are you reclining here? Is it to experience the result of your *karma* (deeds from past)? Is it in search of an enjoyable abode? Is it because there is none with any shortcomings? Is it because there is none with taste in liberation? Why are you not showering your mercy?

aruLAy – if emperumAn has mercifully granted “ *mayarvaRa madhinalam* ” as in thiruvAimozhi 1-1-1 (knowledge and devotion without any shortcoming), should not the result be “ *sudaradi tho zhudhezhu* ” (worship his splendid divine feet and rise)? Has it been your practice not to shower grace on those who are in turmoil and bewilderment? Or is it being done only now?

uLavO paNdum innannavE – is it not famously known that “emperumAn has showered his mercy on those who had cried to him in distress”? Has this not been seen in the cases of dhraupadhi, Srl gajEndhrAzhwAn, Srl prahAdhan, Srl vibhIshaNan, kAkAsuran et al?

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31. pAsuram 29 – innanna thUdhu

avathArikai (Introduction)

In the previous pAsuram, she had submitted to periyā perumAL saying *porunIrththiruvarangA aruLAy* . As a response to this, thiruvarangan did not say either “I will shower my mercy” or “I will not shower my mercy”. Hence, she sends a few swans as messenger to him.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*innanna thUdhu emmai ALaRRappattu irandhAL enRu annanna sollAp pedaiyodum pOyvarum
neelamuNda minnanna mEnip perumAn ulagiR peN thUdhuseLLa annanna nIrmai koLO kudichchIrmaiyl
annangaLE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

kudi – arising out of being born in a clan

sIrmai – quality

il – not having

annangaLE – Oh swans!

ivaL – this girl

ALaRRappattu – being without any other person

emmai – us

innanna – of this type

thUdhu – need as messenger

irandhAL – beseeched

enRu – thinking this way

annanna – words like those

sollA – not saying

pedaiyodum – with your female swans

pOy varum – you are going

neelam – bluish cloud

uNda – one who swallowed

minnanna – similar to lightning

mEni – having divine form

perumAn – sarvESvaran’s

ulagil – his world of paramapadham

peN thUdhu – messenger sent by a girl

sellA – will not fructify

(saying so)

annanna – like that

nIrmai koLO – do you have such a nature?

Simple Translation

Oh swans who do not have the distinction of having been born in a distinguished clan! You are roaming with your female swans, thinking in your mind “This girl is beseeching us to go as messengers since she could not get anyone else” and are not carrying her message. Is it your nature not to carry such message to paramapadham which is the residence of sarvESvaran who has a complexion similar to dark bluish clouds and who has a divine form which is similar to effulgent lightning?

vyAkyAnam

innanna thUdhu – sending an errand like this is not carried out when one is living in happy times; it is not sent for one’s pleasure; it is sent as a sustenance for oneself. Just as sithAppirAtti tells hanuman in Srl rAmAyaNam sundhara kANDam 39-22 “*gathEhi harisArdhUla puna: AgamanAyathu praNAnAmapi sandhEhO mama syAn na athra samSaya :*” (Oh warrior of the monkey clan! If after this there is any doubt about your return, then there will be a doubt about my survival too. There is no doubt about this matter), here too a similar narrative is mentioned.

emmai – my status is very much similar to the way I am sending my errand. Just as sithAppirAtti sent an expert in grammar [so that he could recount the status very clearly, without any degree of ambiguity], I too should have sent one [says the *nAyaki*]. But my present state is such that I have to send you [the swans] only.

ALaRRappattu – since there is none else to send errand. Her greatness is such that even sarvESvaran, the lord of both vibhUthis (spiritual and materialistic) has to send her a messenger; however, she, who is like slthAppirAtti, who had about ten crore people who could be sent as messengers even if most of her people go to various corners in mithilA and kOsala countries, is now in a position where she has none to be sent as messenger.

irandhAL – she is doing what he should be doing. While he should be sending a messenger to her, she is sending him one.

ivaL – she is similar to slthAppirAtti who was spoken of as in Srl rAmAyaNam AraNya kANDam 37-18 “*apramEyamhi thaththEja :*” (that rAma, whose wife is janaka’s daughter, is with inestimable resplendence)

annanna solIA – they did not say anything like that. Those who go on errand should say what the person, who had sent them, told them to say, as well as say a few words of their own, in order to add strength to the message given. This is termed in thamizh language as *Olai pAdhi-thUdhu pAdhi* (what is seen in the letter sent through the messenger is 50% and what the messenger adds of his own, is 50%). But these [swans] did not do that, but made a mockery of that proverb in thamizh. Some people will not desire anything. But shouldn’t they help those who desire something and carry on in that state?

pedaiyodum pOy varum – when they carry out such errands, when they go to sarvESvaran, they will meditate on his auspicious qualities and when they return, they will meditate on the experience gained through their service. Those who carry out service to sarvESvaran do so as a pair. We could see this in the cases of sEnai mudhaliyAr- sUthravathi, garudan-sukIrthi, athri-anasUyai et al. Will meditating on his auspicious qualities be the basis for their sustenance? The commentator quotes the verse *pAdhEyam puNdarIkAksha nAma sankIrthanAmrutham* – meditating on the divine names of the one with lotus-like eyes is the nectar which sustains one.

neelamuNda . . . – he is everything to those who are in SrlvaikuNtam. Just as it is said in vEdham *neelathOyathamadhyasthA vidhyullEkEva bhAsvarA* , he keeps pirAtti always on his splendorous chest, like lightning across bluish, dark clouds. The situation during separation will be as mentioned in thirunedundhANDagam 25 *minnilangu thiruvuvuvu* – his divine form will be like lightning and when united with him, the situation will be as mentioned in thirunedundhANDagam 24 *karumugiloppar* – he will resemble dark clouds.

peN thUdhu sellA – would you go as a messenger only if sent by a man? Would you not go on errand for a lady? Did you think that none other than sarvESvaran will send someone as a messenger? There is no point in blaming either you [swans] or him [sarvESvaran]. All the blame is mine only.

kudichchIrmaiyl annangaLE – *kudichchIrmai* is the knowledge about the distress caused by separation. It is not your fault that you do not have this knowledge. Since he was not born in a great clan, he did not have this quality. Due to this, he would have reached a stage where he could not listen to me or to you.

neelamuNda minnanna mEnip perumAn – he keeps his divine form not for his sake but for keeping periya pirAtti in his divine chest. Since you have come in a clan which does not have *kudichchIrmai* it appears that you are not listening to me.

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning) – AzhwAr is in distress due to separation from emperumAn. This pAsuram speaks about his state where even those who are helping him to attain emperumAn are not to his liking.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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32. pAsuram 30 – annam selveerum

avathArikai (Introduction)

When we send messengers, until they return, we may engage in some pastime activities such as gambling, chess etc. In the case of *nAyaki*, however, since the entity to whom she had sent the messengers is a great one, she keeps sending all those whom she sees, as messengers. Srl rAmAyaNam sundhara kANdam SIOkam 30-3 says “ *yAm kapInAm sahasrAni subahUni ayUthAnicha dhikshu sarvAsu mArganthE sA iyam AsAdhithA mayA* ” (that slthAppirAtti, who was searched out by thousands of monkeys in many directions, was found out by me). Thus there is precedence for sending many messengers towards one entity. In the referred instance, hanuman feels that while all the monkeys who had set out to locate slthAppirAtti should have seen her, he alone was able to see her. The happiness which would not have been sufficient had all the monkeys experienced it, was left to him, to enjoy alone. However, he did share his happiness with the rest of the monkeys. While returning from lanka, on entering kishkindhA, he let the monkeys to enter the private garden of sugrIva maharaja, known as madhuvanam, which was guarded by sugrIva’s uncle dhadhimukhan and his army. When dhadhimukhan tried to resist the invasion, hanuman told the monkeys, as in Srl rAmAyaNam sundhara kANdam 62-1 “ *ahamAvArAyishyAmi yushmAkam paripanthina* ” (you enjoy the honey in the garden. I will take care of those who oppose you). On hearing about this incident, sugrIva told lakshmaNa as in Srl rAmAyaNam sundhara kANdam SIOkam 63-17 “ *dhrushtA dhEvi na sandhEhO na cha anyEna hanUmathA* ” (there is no doubt that slthAppirAtti has been seen by none other than hanumAn himself). The happiness which sugrIva felt on hearing about the destruction to his favourite garden made his tail to grow to such an extent that it reached the peak of rushyamukha hill. bhattar, the son of kUraththAzhwAn, would explain this sequence by saying “Had that madhuvanam not been there, Srl rAmA’s and lakshmaNa’s backs would have taken a beating from the monkeys (by their patting) who were celebrating their happiness”.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

annam selveerum vaNdAnam selveerum thozhudhirandhEn munnam selveergaL maRavElminO kaNNan vaigundhanOdu ennenjinAraik kaNdAl ennaich cholli avaridai nlr innam solleerO idhuvO thagavu enRu isaimingaLE

Word-by-Word Meanings

annam selveerum – those who are going [as my messengers] as swans

vaNdAnam selveerum – those who are going as storks

thozhudhu – seeking refuge

irandhEn – I beseeched

munnam – ahead

selveergaL – those who are going

maRavElminO – keep (in your mind) without forgetting

kaNNan – being simple

vaigundhanOdu – with sarvESvaran who is residing in paramapadham (SrlvaikuNtam)

(going around with him)

en nenjinArai – my mind

kaNdAl – if you see

ennai – me (who has reached this state)

solli – inform about

avaridai – with that mind

innnam – further

selleerO – will you not go?

idhuvO thagavu – is this (your) nature?

enRu isaimingaL – please say

Simple Translation

I took refuge under and beseeched the swans and storks who are going (as my messengers). Those (among you) who are going ahead, should keep in your minds, without forgetting. When you are flying, if you see my mind who is roaming around with vaikuNtanAthana who incarnated as krishNa, please inform my anguished state and tell further “Will you not return to that *nAyaki* after all these days? Is this your nature?”

vyAkyAnam

annam selveerum vaNdAnam selveerum – those who are going as swans and as storks.

thozhudhu irandhEn – it is my pitiable position, due to which I am beseeching you to go as messengers, when the learned wise man such as hanumaN and the omniscient krishNa went as messengers without feeling lowly about it. Instead of sending such people, I have to send you. While saying “I request you to go as my messenger” itself would appear to be excessive, she tells these birds, “I seek refuge and beseech you to go”. mahAbhAratham udhyOga parvam SIOkam 86-17 is quoted by vyAkyAthA periyavAchchAn piLLai in his vyAkyAnam – *anyath pUrNathapAm kumbhAth anyath pAdhAvanEjanAth anyath kuchala sampraSnAnnachEchadhiJanArdhana* : – that krishNa is complete in all aspects; he does not expect anything other than *pUrNa kumbham* (a filled pot of water) with which to wash his divine feet; that alone is sufficient. While discussing this with kidAmbi AchchAn (one of the disciples of bhagavath rAmAnujar), nambi thiruvazhudhinAdu dhAsar and other AchAryas asked him “Should we keep things like *pUrNa kumbham* ?” kidAmbi AchchAn said “We do not have to think that we are keeping this for krishNa; if we keep it in order to wash one’s feet when entering the house from outside, he would think that it has been kept specially for him. When we wash our feet from that pot and a few droplets of water fall on his divine feet, he would consider that we have washed his divine feet with dedication”. The reason for her beseeching birds to go on her errand is because she thinks “It is my fault that I am sending such distinguished entities such as you on my errand”. When sugrIva was enjoying his life in his palace, forgetting about Srl rAma and lakshmaNa [and his word that he will send his monkeys to search for slthApirAtti once the monsoon is over], lakshmaNa came to his palace with fury and called out to him. sugrIva trembled on hearing this, realising his mistake. hanuman offering him counsel, told him that bowing down to lakshmaNa alone will calm him down. This could be seen in Srl rAmAyaNam

kishkindhA kANDam SIOkam 32-17 “ *krutha aparAdhasya hi thE na anyath paSyAmi aham kshamam | antharENa anjalim baddhvAlakshmaNasya prasAdhanAth |* ” (I do not foresee any other appropriate means for you, as a blunder has been committed by you, except seeking lakshmaNa’s pardon by duly adjoining your palms). Just as hanuman had told sugriva that there is nothing to equal *anjali* (adjoining palms), the *nAyaki* too requests these birds by beseeching them, apart from performing *anjali* as an expiation for asking them to on her errand. The vyAkyAthA quotes from Srl rAmAyaNam yudhdha kANDam 17-11 as an example for beseeching apart from performing *anjali* – *sa uvAcha cha* – (vibhIshaNa) also told (Srl rAma). While it was sufficient for Srl rAma that vibhIshaNa came to him to surrender, that he started speaking a few words too, came as a surprise for Srl rAma.

munnam selveergal maRavElminO – those who are going in the front, keep what I said, in your mind, without forgetting. After reaching that place [paramapadham], as said in thaitthirly upanishath “ *aham annam* ” (I am your food), do not forget my message. Looking at the eagerness with which he would come [to meet them since they have been sent by her], would they remember even if they are told not to forget? This is the reason she had worshipped them and beseeched them. Is it that only those who went in the front rows would forget? The commentator says that even sarvESvaran and her heart forgot her. The one who said *piriyEn piriyil dhariyEn* – I will not separate, and were I to separate, I cannot sustain myself, separated from her. *periya thirumozhi* pAsuram 9-3-3 says *pEdhai ninnai* – the term *pEdhai* refers to the innocent stage in a girl’s life cycle at which she treats both union and separation as the same. The term *ninnai* conveys the meaning that he is indeed a sentient entity to separate from her. Even when he said *piriyEn* she felt as if he had separated. The heart which went looking for him, also forgot about her. Thus, when such is the situation, she is doubting whether the birds who are going in the front rows would remember. She thinks that sarvESvaran, who went like this [in separation from her] would be wandering around with his dress in dishevelled condition as there would be none to take pity on him. Several SIOkams from Srl rAmAyaNam are cited here by the commentator in this context [whether there are people to take pity on sarvESvaran]. Srl rAma took rest for a night in Srl guhapperumAL’s place, Srl rAmAyaNam SIOkam ayOdhyA kANDam 87-22 “ *niSAmathishtath parithO asya kEvalam* ” (lakshmaNa walked alone [going around Srl rAma] in that night). Looking at lakshmaNa walking alone during the night, guha tells him, as in Srl rAmAyaNam ayOdhyA kANDam 51-2 “ *iyam thAth sukha SayyA thvadh artham upakalpithA* ” (I have made a comfortable bed for you, my friend), I had made a comfortable bed with green leaves, befitting you, and asked Srl rAma to sleep comfortably on it, hence you too take rest; lakshmaNa responds to this through Srl rAmAyaNam ayOdhyA kANDam 51-9 “ *katham dhASarathau bhUmau sayAnE saha slthayA* ” (when the son of emperor dhaSarathan is sleeping on the ground). lakshmaNa says that he cannot sleep after seeing Srl rAma, who was born to emperor dhaSarathan after sixty thousand years to rid him of the stigma of being without progeny, sleeping on the ground, along with his wife slthAppirAtti. He says *saha slthaya* – implying that Srl rAma, having been the disciple of sage vaSishta, could have hardened his body and mind so that he could sleep on a hard surface too; however, here, slthAppirAtti, who had not stepped out of her house and who is the dear daughter of King janaka, is sleeping on the floor. After seeing this, how could I sleep? Hence he says in the same SIOkam *sakyA nidhrA mayA labhdhum* – how is it possible for me to sleep? guhapperumAL says as in Srl rAmAyaNam ayOdhyA kANDam 87-23 and 87-24 “ *mahath dhanu: sajyam upOhya laksmaNau..... sa yathra lakshmaNa athanthrabhir gyAthibhir Aththa kArmukhair...* ” when lakshmaNa went around the bed on which Srl rAma and slthAppirAtti were sleeping, guarding them with a huge bow, I too went around, like that lakshmaNa, along with my kinsmen who were free from lassitude, carrying bows. Through all these references, the *nAyaki* implies that she too cares for sarvESvaran, just as guhan had shown in Srl rAmAyaNam.

kaNNan . . . – my heart went to paramapadham meditating on the amazing, auspicious qualities of krishNa.

ennenjinAr – she recounts how her heart was praised by emperumAn. In other words, he enticed her heart to follow him so that she could become more anguished in separation from him.

kaNdAI – she hints that it is very difficult to see her heart which followed krishNa. Just as thaiththirlyA upanishath says *sadhA paSyanthi* – he would be constantly seen by nithyasUris, it is possible to see sarvESvaran; however it is well nigh impossible to see her heart. Even if you see it per chance, it will not ask about me “How is she?” manifesting love in its tongue and teeth.

ennaich cholli – approach that heart which is like this and tell it “She is like this; would you know about it?” Isn’t she, who was spoken of in Srl rAmAyaNam AraNya kANdam 37-18 “*apramEyam hi thaththEja :*” (she, who is with inestimable resplendence), now speaking like this?

avar idai – to that heart, which has been lying like this from then

nIr – don’t you know now that I am expectantly waiting with tears in my eyes, so that you would say “I will bring that heart immediately”

innam selleerO – I had sent messengers to you who had gone as my messenger [she is now addressing her heart which she had originally sent as her messenger behind sarvESvaran]. Did you delay returning to me thinking that time is not an entity there, just as it has been mentioned in mahAbhAratham SAnthi parvam mOksha dharmam 25-9 “*na kAlasthathravai prabhu :*” (time is not the lord there)? There are sequences for time there, just as it has been mentioned in thiruvAimozhi 10.3.1 “*oru pagal Ayiram UzhiyAIO*” (a noon is similar to thousand kalpams).

idhuvO thagavu – agreed that you may not have much of involvement with me. But should you not have a mind to show pity on a person even if (s)he were an enemy, just as it has been said in Srl rAmAyaNam sundhara kANdam 38-41 “*AnruSamsyam parOdhamamsthvaththa Eva mayASrutha :*” (I have heard from you alone that kindness is the best righteousness)?

isaimingaLE – tell that heart, she informs the birds. She tells them to speak boldly and with pride in such a way that it destroys his [her heart] *svarUpam* (true nature). She is not sure whether to address the heart as a masculine gender or as a feminine gender.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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33. pAsuram 31 – isaimingaL thUdhu

avathArikai (Introduction)

In thiruviruththam 29 th pAsuram, the *nAyaki* had sent messengers to paramapadham as mentioned in the verse *neelamuNda minnanna mEnipperumAn ulagu* (the abode where emperumAn with dark complexion resides). She realised that paramapadham can be entered only by those who are engaged with *parabhakthi*, *paragyAnam* and *paramabhakthi* and not by others. Then she sent messengers to emperumAn who had incarnated as krishNa (in the previous pAsuram) as mentioned in the term *kaNNan vaigundhan*. She realised that here too, it is possible only for those who had lived at the same time as the incarnated emperumAn and not for those who followed later. Hence she now sends messenger to thiruvEngadamudaiyAn who resides on the hills of thiruvEngadam and who is easily approachable for those who had come after the time of incarnations.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*isaimingaL thUdhu enRu isaiththAl isaiyilam en thalai mEl asaimingaL enRAI asaiyum kolAm am pon
maNigal thisaimin miLirum thiruvEngadaththu van thAL simayam misai min miLiriya pOvAn
vazhikkoNda mEgangaLE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

am – beautiful

pon – gold

ma – excellent

maNigal – gems

thisai – in the directions

min – like lightning

miLirum – shining

thiruvEngadam – known as thiruvEngadam

van – being strong

thAL – having foothills

simayam misai – with the mountain as motive

min – lightning

miLiriya – making it glow

pOvAn – to go

vazhikkoNda – attempting

mEgangaLE – Oh clouds!

thUdhu – message of errand

isaimingaL enRu – please state

isaiththAI – if I say

isaiyilam – you went without stating

en thalai mEl – atop my head

asaimingaL – roam

enRAI – if requested

asaiyum kolAm – could you not?

Simple Translation

thiruvEngadam is emitting a glow which is shining like gold and various gems in all the directions. Oh clouds who are attempting to go towards the strong peaks of such thiruvEngadam emitting lightning everywhere! When I requested you to take my errand [to emperumAn], you are not doing that. When I requested you to roam on my head, you are not doing that too.

vyAkyAnam

isaimingaL – Oh clouds who are going towards thirumalai! If I tell you “Please convey my message”, you are not responding by saying that you would accept it. Since you are deeply engrossed in your travel to thirumalai, you are not speaking anything. If I ask you to keep your feet on my head, would you do that? Aren’t the divine feet of those who are going to thirumalai very exalted? Will such divine feet of those who are going to thirumalai be easily accessible? In Srl rAmAyaNam sundhara kANdam 68-3, slthAppirAtti told hanuman “*viSrAntha*” – stay here for a day – but hanuman refused that and left immediately. The clouds too are going like that without keeping their feet on my head.

am pon – in thirumalai which has strong slopes and which emits glow in all directions with the help of gold and expensive gems in such a way that darkness runs away with fever.

simayam – peaks

min miLiriya – similar to holding light for kings who are radiant like lightning

pOvAn vazhikkoNda – the clouds are fully focussed on their path towards thiruvEngadam. Will they carry my message if I ask them to carry it? Will they keep their feet on my head if I request them to? Just as thirumangai AzhwAr says in periya thirumozhi 7-4-1 “*thaNchERai emperumAn thAL thozhuvAr kANmin en thalai mElArE*” (the feet of those who worship the divine feet of emperumAn who is residing at thiruchchERai will be on my head), this AzhwAr too considers the divine feet of those who proceed towards thiruvEngadam to be of high esteem.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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34. pAsuram 32 – mEgangaLO uraiyIr

avathArikai (Introduction)

In the previous pAsuram the *nAyaki* had told the clouds “Oh clouds! You are not carrying my message to him when I ask you to; you are not keeping your feet on my head when I ask you to”. Since they did not listen to her, she tells them “Even if you are not doing these, please come down here and say a few words”. Imagining that on hearing her words, the clouds said “We cannot do that; our gathering is very large; if we do not proceed now, we will get into difficulties” she tells them “You do not have to come down here; tell me a few comforting words from wherever you are”

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*mEgangaLO uraiyIr thirumAl thirumEni okkum yOgangaL ungaLukku evvARu peRRIr uyiraLippAn
mAgangaL ellAm thirindhu nannIrgaL sumandhu nundham AgangaL nOva varuththum thavamAmaruL
peRRadhE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

O mEgangaL – Oh clouds!

thirumAl – the consort of Sri mahAlakshmi

thirumEni – with his divine form

ungaLukku – for you

okkum – to attain equality

(reason for that)

yOgangaL – the means

evvARu – with which means

peRRIr – did you attain?

uraiyIr – inform

aruL peRRadhu – getting (sarvESvaran’s) mercy

uyir – all living creatures

aLippAn – to protect

mAgangaL ellAm – throughout the sky

thirindhu – roaming

nal neergaL – good water

sumandhu – bearing them

num tham – your

AgangaL – forms

nOva – to be painful

varuththum – troubling

thavamAm – would be due to penance

Simple Translation

Oh clouds! Through which means did you get the complexion equalling the divine form of sarvESvaran who is the consort of Srl mahAlakshmi? You are roaming here and there, putting your forms to difficulties, carrying the pure water which is essential and which sustains the life of all the creatures. As a result of this penance, which is tormenting your forms, you have received the grace of sarvESvaran to equal the complexion of his divine form.

vyAkyAnam

mEgangaLO – she is calling out to the clouds so that they will realise her anguish in separation, in totality. After hearing her sadness-filled voice, anyone will stop to hear her narrative. However, these clouds did not stop; being amazed, she raises her voice so that they too will hear her. She called out in such a way that even those afar could hear her. Since it appeared to her that the clouds stopped on hearing her voice in distress, she tells them *uraiyIr* – tell me. They had not carried out what she had told them earlier – they did not go on her errand, they did not keep their divine feet on her head, they did not come near her and speak comforting words. Yet, why did she make an appeal to them submissively? This is because she did not feel any slackness or deficiency in her desire. She feels that she would be able to sustain herself if they speak just a word or two to her.

thirumAL ... – How did you get such a complexion which is eminent and distinct from everything else? When sarvESvaran and Srl mahAlakshmi get separated, they will lose their colour and become pale. When they are united, they will get a bluish dark complexion out of happiness. Instead of that paleness how did you get this bluish complexion? [she is alluding to the fact that they are separated yet the clouds display dark bluish form] Just as it is said in muNdaka upanishath 3-2-3 “*niranjana: paramam sAmyamupaithi*” (after attaining him, they (jIvAthmAs) get his qualities in the same measure), how did you get his complexion? How did you get the complexion of nithyasUris who are considered to have attained his levels of greatness? This is not possible even for those who meditate on him constantly, with devotion. To get to this level, one should have carried out different means. How and where did you get the authority and qualification to attain those means?

evvARu peRRIr – if you tell us as to how you attained it, we too would attain it by following the same way instead of through devotion and affection.

uyiraLippAn mAgangaL eIlAm thirindhU – the clouds keep roaming throughout, without making any distinction between the great and the lowly, protecting everyone. Why address them in the plural (*mEgangaL* or clouds)? This is to indicate that the clouds keep travelling to different places [to fill themselves with water].

nal nIr sumandhu – on those streets where emperumAn mercifully goes in procession during festivities in temples, people would erect *thaNNIr pandhal* (places where water is served to quench thirst), crying out “*Elakkuzhambu*” (fragrant water). In the same way, the clouds too bear pure water after taking salty water from oceans.

nundham Agangal ... – is it because of the penance that you are doing by subjecting your forms to such difficulties that you got such a divine complexion?

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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35. pAsuram 33 – aruLAr

avathArikai (Introduction)

Clouds gathered on all sides. Looking at this, the *nAyaki* was bewildered and dazed. The *nAyaki*'s mother looks at her and thinks that he [sarvESvaran] is the one who controls everything just as it has been said in thaiththirlya upanishath “ *bhIshAsmAth vAtha:pavathE bhIshOdhEthi sUrya :*” (out of fear for sarvESvaran wind blows, sun rises). Isn't it his order which enables every entity to work in clockwork precision here, without having any freedom to carry out what each entity desires? When such is the case, she wonders whether protecting her daughter is a difficult task for him and calls out to him.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*aruLAr thiruchchakaraththAl agal visumbum nilanum iruLAr vinai kedachchengOl nadAvudhir IngOr
peNpAl poruLO ennum igazhvO ivaRRin puRaththAL enReNNO theruLOm aravaNaiylr ivaL mAmai
sidhaikkinRadhE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

aruL – mercy

Ar – to the brim

thiruchchakaraththAl – with the divine *chakkaram* (chakram – disc)

agal – expansive

visumbum – sky

nilanum – and the earth

iruLAr – full of darkness (made of ignorance)

vinai – sins

keda – to be annihilated

sengOl – order

nadAvudhir – you are employing

aravu – AdhiSEshan

aNaiylr – Oh the lord who has him as your mattress!

ivaL mAmai – her complexion

sidhaikkinRadhu – is being destroyed

Ingu – in this leelAvibhUthi (materialistic realm)

Or – one

peNpAl – matter relating to a girl

(protection)

poruLO – is it the end goal?

enum – saying so

igazhvO – – is it contemptuousness?

ivaRRin – all these entities to be protected

puRaththAL – outside these

enRu – saying so

eNNO – is it your divine opinion?

theruLOm – we do not know

Simple Translation

Oh the one who has AdhiSEshan as your mattress! You are ruling both the expansive sky and this earth such that sins which are caused by ignorance run away, through your divine disc. In such a condition, the beautiful complexion of this *nAyaki* is continuously fading. What is the reason for this? Is it because you feel contemptuously that a girl is also an entity in these realms or is it because you think that she is outside the area of your kingdom? We do not know this.

vyAkyAnam

aruLAr thiruchchakaraththAI – *chakkaraththAzhwAn* (divine disc) is filled to the brim with mercy. Even if sarvESvaran himself stops showering mercy, *chakkaraththAzhwAn* will be full of mercy. periya pirAtti is mercy personified. Even if such pirAtti does not show mercy, *chakkraththAzhwAn* 's mercy will not change. The opinion here is that if someone thinks of him, he will immediately rush to help that person; he has such independence. vyAkyAthA (commentator for the prabandham) periyavAchchAn piLLai calls this as *madu arugil URRUpPOIE* (he is like a spring near a pond, continuously supplying water to the pond so that it never dries up). He cites the narration of chakravarthi ambarIsha (in the clan of ikshvAku). ambarIsha would observe total fasting on EkAdhaSi days [eleventh day after full or new moon] and on the next day, dhvAdhaSi, he would observe *pAraNam* (breaking the fast before a particular time). Once sage dhurvAsa wanted to test ambarIsha. Hence, on the day of dhvAdhaSi, he came to ambarIsha's palace and told him that he would come to have pAraNam with the chakravarthi and went for having a bath. Despite passage of time, he did not come [deliberately]. ambarIsha was getting anxious since there was very little time left for breaking the fast and if he did not have anything, he would not get the benefit of observing fast on the day of EkAdhaSi. dhurvAsa would get very angry and curse him if he did not wait for the sage before taking any food item. Hence, as a compromise, he took a sip of holy water alone and waited for the sage to join him. Once dhurvAsa returned, he realised what had happened. With raging fury [at having been slighted by ambarIsha in not waiting for him], he wanted to curse the chakravarthi. ambarIsha realised what the sage was going to do. He thought of *chakkraththAzhwAn* to save him. That same moment, *chakkaraththAzhwAn* appeared there and started chasing sage dhurvAsa. The sage started running, seeing the divine disc. He sought refuge from all the deities such as brahma, rudhra, indhra et al. None was willing to help him. He went to sarvESvaran himself who told him that he is under the control of his devotees and told him to take refuge under ambarIsha himself. He did that and was saved from the divine disc on ambarIsha's request. If the divine disc looks at someone as his enemy, there is no refuge for that person other than sarvESvaran himself.

aruLAr – mercy is a demonstration of the protection offered to someone who has taken refuge. Instead of saying that it is the act of preventing someone from carrying inimical acts, why is it explained this way? This is because both are acts of benefit.

thiruchchakraththAI – Srlman nArAyaNan is referred to as sarvESvaran because he holds the divine disc on his right hand. The importance of chakkaraththAzhwAn to emperumAn is as much as that of periya pirAtti to emperumAn. This is the reason that he is referred to as *thiruchchakkaram* (divine disc) instead of *chakkaram* (disc) by prefixing the word *thiru* which indicates *aiSvaryam* (wealth, of service).

agal visumbu – sarvESvaran removes the sins which are caused by ignorance with the help of the divine disc who removes all the sins; thus sarvESvaran rules with the radiance of the divine disc as his sceptre.

agal visumbu – purusha sUktham says *thripAdhasyAmrutham dhivi* – paramapadham is three times the size of leelA vibhUthi (materialistic realm). How can ignorance be felt in paramapadham? It is the fear of those who experience and enjoy the presence of sarvESvaran there as to what will happen if there is a hurdle to that continuous *dharSan* (seeing him). sarvESvaran protects those who are in paramapadham by displaying his divine hand and the divine disc held in that divine hand. In leelA vibhUthi he protects his followers by cutting their enemies into two with his divine disc. The former is called as prAgabhAvam – lack of prior existence (enemies do not exist) and the latter is called as pradhvamsAbhAvam – (enemies) ceasing to exist after initial existence.

ingOr penpAI ... – are you thinking that you can help her without any urgency since she is helpless and has no refuge? Or do you think that she is outside the two realms (leelA and nithya vibhUthis)? Do you think that you do not have the capacity to protect her? Do you think that you do not know anything about her? Are you trying to abandon her because you do not have the strength? If you think that she is outside the two realms, you become ignorant and if you think that you cannot protect her, you become weak [both of which are against sarvESvaran’s qualities of being omniscient and omnipotent].

mahAbhAratham udhyOga parvam 70-43 says “*sAHam kESa graham prApthA thvayI jlvithya prabhO*” (dhraupadhi appeals to lord krishNa as she is dragged by her hair to the court by dhushASan that despite krishNa being alive, she, who had taken refuge under him, is being dragged by her hair). The opinion expressed by the *nAyaki*’s mother here is that despite his being the lord, there is no connection between that quality and the *nAyaki*’s suffering though she has taken refuge under him.

theruLOm – we do not know why this has come to such a pass.

aravaNaiylr – you do not deny your divine form to those who desire you. When the *nAyaki* is lying on the floor, do you need to recline on the bed of AdhiSEshan? If you are lying alone on the bed, could you enjoy anything?

ivaL mAmai – her complexion is very difficult to get. Are you thinking that since you are the creator of everything, you could create her again, should she perish? Your quality of *suhrudham sarvabhUthAnAm* – friendly towards all – seems to be failing in her case. If a child falls into a well, the blame will fall on the mother. The world will say that she had pushed the child into the well. In the same way, the world will blame you for destroying her. When looking at her position and his status, there is no shortcoming for her attaining him. However, considering the delay in his coming to her rescue, the mother feels sad, fearing as to what will happen.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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36. pAsuram 34 – sidhaikkinRadhu Azhi

avathArikai (Introduction)

The *nAyaki* is unable to tolerate until the *nAyakan* arrives. Hence she engages with *kUdal* to find out whether he would come or not [*kUdal* is drawing a large circle on sand, either at the river or at the ocean, and drawing many smaller circles inside the large circle. If the count of the small circles is even, it would indicate that the *nAyakan* would return and if it is odd, it would indicate that he would not]. Since this also did not yield the desired result, she gets angry with *kUdal*, as much as the anger that she would have felt had the *nAyakan*, who had separated from her, returned.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*sidhaikkinRadhu AzhiyenRu Azhiyaich chIRi than slrادیAl udhaikkinRa nAyagam thannodum mAIE
unadhu thaN thAr thadhaikkinRa thaNNam thuzhAyaNivAn adhuvE manamAyp padhaikkinRa mAdhin
thiRaththu aRiyEn seyaRpAl adhuvE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

mAIE – Oh swAmy (lord)!

Azhi – ocean

Azhiyai – *kUdal* (drawing of circles on sand)

sidhaikkinRadhu – destroying

enRu – saying so

sIRi – becoming angry

than – her

slr – beautiful

ادیAl – with foot

Azhiyai – ocean

udahikkinRa – kicking

nAyagam thannodu – with pride

thaN – cool

thAr – with flower

thadhaikkinRa – being complete

am – beautiful

unadhu – your

thuzhAy – garland of divine *thuLasi*

aNivAn – to don

adhuvE – in that

manamAy – keeping her mind

padhaikkinRa – having urge

mAdhin thiRaththu – in the matter of the girl

seyaRpAladhu- – what you intend doing

aRiyEn – I do not know

Simple Translation

Oh my lord! She (my daughter) is kicking the ocean with her beautiful feet since the waves of the ocean are destroying the circles that she has drawn. She has a great urge to don the cool, beautiful garland of thuLasi which you are wearing. What do you intend doing in her matter? I do not know.

vyAkyAnam

sidhaikkinRa – three different interpretations are given here: the opinion of those who were prior to parASara bhattar, the opinion of parASara bhattar and the opinion of nampiLLai. In the first two interpretations, the term *Azhi* (in both the verses *sidhaikkinRadhu Azhi* and *Azhiyaich chIRi*) refers to *kUdal*. In the first opinion, the interpretation is – she started carrying out *kUdal*. Since it did not reflect her desire, out of anger, she kicked it. bhattar’s interpretation is – *kUdal* did not hint her desire that he would come and unite with her. Instead, it hinted that he will not come. Becoming angry, she destroyed it. In nampiLLai’s interpretation, the first *Azhi* refers to *kUdal* and the second *Azhi* refers to ocean. Thus, when she drew the circles on the shore, the waves of the ocean destroyed them. Becoming angry with the ocean, she kicked the waves. Is there any precedence for a person becoming angry with ocean? The *vyAkyAtha* (commentator) *periyavAchchAn piLLai* cites the case of Srl rAma in Srl rAmAyaNam yudhdha kANdam 21-22 “*chApamAnaya*” (bring the bow) when he threatened to dry up the ocean with his bow and arrows when the *samudhrarAjan* (King of oceans) did not respond to his surrendering to him to give way for his army to cross it and reach lanka. The second reference is also from yudhdha kANdam 21-13 “*rAmO rakthAnthA lOchana*” (Srl rAma had eyes which were blood red in colour due to his anger) again, in the same context.

slradi – *nAyaki* kicks with her eminent divine feet. While the *nAyakan* was desiring this, instead of happening to him, this was happening to someone else. He did not have his desire of uniting with her fulfilled; he did not get his desire of being touched by her [even if it is with her divine feet] fulfilled! She is kicking the ocean with her feet which are rare indeed to attain! Had he known this, he wouldn’t have hidden himself inside a pillar [as in *narasimhAvathAram*] but would have hidden himself within these sand grains so that he would have been touched by her feet. Perhaps, he pervaded every droplet of water in the ocean in anticipation of this only. As mentioned in the verse “*thvath pAdha pankaja parigraha dhanya janmA bhUyAsam*” it is a great honour to be touched by her lotus like feet. parASara bhattar, in his Srl rangarAja sthavam 1-9 says “*lakshmiPathi lakshaika lakshaNam*” (the identity of her divine feet smeared with vermilion paste can be seen on the chest of *emperumAn*), indicating that he relishes being touched by her divine feet.

than slradiyAl udhaikkinRa nAyagam – she is kicking without considering the soft nature [of *emperumAn*]. *nAyagam* refers to greatness, eminence, pride etc. Her greatness is such that she is not considering his greatness which is sought after by everyone.

mAlE – oh one who is bewildered after making her get bewildered!

unadhu thaN thAr ... – she desires to don the garland of divine thuLasi which appears to be fresher when in contact with your divine form than when it is in its plant. Her condition is similar to the one mentioned in thiruvAimozhi 2-4-9 “ *pattapOdhu ezhupOdhu aRiyAL virai mattalar thaN thuzhAy ennum* ” (she who does not know as to when the sun rises or sets, keeps repeating the word ‘thuLasi’ which is filled with fragrance and honey). The moment she hears the word thuLasi, she starts craving it. Her condition is similar to lakshmaNa when he says as in Srl rAmAyaNam ayOdhyA kANdam 96-23 “ *pAdhasyavathE dhOsham nAham paSyAmi* ” (I do not see any fault in killing this bharatha) and in Srl rAmAyaNam yudhdha kANdam 17-29 “ *vadhyathAm* ” (vibhIshaNa, who has come seeking refuge under Srl rAma) should be killed). Though bharatha and vibhIshaNa had come to Srl rAma with good intentions, due to excessive devotion towards Srl rAma, lakshmaNa became furious. In the same way, the *nAyaki* kicks at the ocean thinking that it is coming to harm her.

aRiyEn seyaRpAl adhuve – I do not know as to what you intend doing with her. Attaining him in course of time and her craving are not the means, since he is the end goal.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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37. pAsuram 35 – pAlvAyp piRaippiLLai

avathArikai (Introduction)

The *nAyaki*'s mother gets worried on seeing the onset of evening, which is far worse than all the other sorrowful situations that the *nAyaki* has been in so far and wonders "How will this end for her?" All those things which the *nAyaki* enjoyed when she was together with the *nAyakan*, turned hostile for her now. All along the mother was distressed by the sorrows of her daughter. Now she feels sorry also for the lady who is in the western direction [this is a simile for dusk time which brings with it, its own trails of sadness]. This is similar to the situation of the *pirAtti* who felt sorry for various naturally occurring events in *thiruvAimozhi* 2-1 padhigam " *vAyum thiraiyugaLum* ". Everything that one looks at, becomes inimical.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*pAlvAyp piRaippiLLai okkalaikkoNdu pagal izhandha mEl pAl dhisaippeN pulambuRum mAlai
ulagaLandha mAl pAl thuzhAykkku manam udaiyArkku nalgiRRai ellAm sOlvan pugundhu idhu Or
panivAdai thuzhAginRadhE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

pAlvAy – having milk in its mouth

piRai – crescent of moon

piLLai – child

okkalai – on the hip

koNdu – carrying

pagal – day time, the master

izhandha – one who lost

mEl pAl – being on the western side

dhisai – as the direction

peN – who could be considered as a lady

pulambuRum – crying

mAlai – evening time

ulagu – worlds

aLandha – one who occupied

mAl pAl – with sarvESvaran

thuzhAykkku – fond of *thuLasi*

manamudaiyArkku – those who have their minds [on such *thuLasi*]

nalgiRRaiyellAm – all those (including existence) which were given

sOlvaN – to steal

pugundhu – entering

idhu – this

Or – unique

pani – cold

vAdai – northerly wind

thuzhAginRadhu – gently hugging

Simple Translation

The western direction is like a lady who has lost daytime, her husband, and was crying. She had on her waist, the moon who is like a child which had milk in its mouth. At this time, the cold northerly wind gently hugged people who were waiting to get the divine garland of thuLasi from sarvESvaran, who had seized all the worlds, with the intention of stealing from those people, whatever had been given by sarvESvaran.

vyAkyAnam

pAlvAyp pirAppiLLai – The lady called as western direction, stood with the crescent moon on her waist, crying for having lost her husband, the daytime or sUriyan. She appears like one who has lost her husband recently, crying out for him, carrying her infant who cannot even suckle properly.

pAlvAy – the child will wither if she removes her bosom from its mouth.

pagal izhandha – this signifies the importance of the husband who has been lost (daytime or sUriyan). It is similar to losing someone such as manu or mAndhAthA (these are great kings of the ikshvAku dynasty). When someone gets something of importance, it is said as “ *pagaRkaNdEn* ” just like it is said in iraNdAm thiruvandhAdhi pAsuram 81 “ *pagaRkaNdEn nAraNanaik kaNdEn* ” (I saw Srlman nArAyaNa who is like sun who never sets). Thus losing that *pagal* is very sorrowful.

mEl pAl dhisaippeN – this gives the importance of the *nAyaki*. When directions are explained, greatness is given to the western direction. The roar from the ocean on the western side is taken as the crying out of the lady in the western direction.

ulagaLandha . . . – her mind is fully focussed on the divine thuLasi garland which sarvESvaran dons.

mAlai nalgiRRaiyellAm – all those which were given by the evening time ; vyAkyAthA calls this as giving existence and *santhAnasApam* – in olden times, when kings waged war and won an enemy country, the king of that country would request the conqueror to leave at the least one son to continue the clan. Similarly, the evening time left her complexion behind for her.

mAlai – sOlvaN . . . – the northerly wind tries to steal the existence, complexion etc left behind by evening. Similar to torturing those who torture others, the wind tries to steal existence.

panivAdai – northerly wind which is poisoned. Since it belongs to the clan of *prANan* (vital air in the body; existence), it knows where the vital air is and it tries to steal it. When queried as to what it was

doing, it would say “Are we destroying the world? We are only trying to take our relative with us” and tried to destroy her.

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): Looking at the condition of AzhwAr for whom even favourable entities appear to be inimical because of separation from emperumAn, the SrlvaishNavas are fearing as to what will happen to his existence.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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38. pAsuram 36 – thuzhA nedum

avathArikai (Introduction)

It is the basic nature of both the daughter of King janaka (slthAppirAtti) and nammAzhwAr to consider that all the benefits which they get are due to emperumAn's mercy and all the sorrows which they experience are due to their misfortune. When his existence cannot take place without emperumAn's presence, AzhwAr doubts emperumAn's ability to protect him, considering his lowly situation. Just as it is said in Srl rAmAyaNam yudhdha kANDam 26-24 " *EshaivASam sathE lankAm svEnAnIkEna mardhithum* " (the army which went under the leadership of naLa hastened (to destroy lankA) in which each monkey cried out "Only I will destroy" and went further) wind and night time competed with each other to destroy her (*nAyaki* , AzhwAr in feminine mood).

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

thuzhA nedum sUzh iruL enRu than thaN thAr adhu peyarA ezhA nedu Uzhi ezhundha ikkAlaththum Ingu ivaLO vazhA nedum thunbaththaL enRu irangAr ammanO ilangaik kuzhA nedu mAdam idiththa pirAnAr kodumaigalE

Word-by-Word Meanings

than – belonging to self

thaN – cool

thAr adhu – desire towards the divine thuLasi

peyarA – as the reason

thuzhA – touching gently

nedum – completely

sUzh – pervading

iruL enRu – called as darkness

ezhA – without enervation

nedu – unending

Uzhi – kalpam (a day of brahmA)

ezhundha – started

ikkAlaththum – during this time too

Ingu – here

ivaL – this *nAyaki vazhA* – without missing

nedum thunbaththaL enReNNi – thinking that she is suffering from great sorrow

irangAr – he is not showing mercy

ilangai – in lankA

kuzhAm – gathered in abundance

nedu mAdam – huge mansions

idiththa – one who destroyed

pirAnAr – the benefactor

kodumaigal – cruel acts

(were like this)

ammanO – how terrible

Simple Translation

Night time came, like an unending *kalpa kAlam* (the day of brahmA running into several millions of years) with such darkness and pervading everywhere, that one has to know objects only by feeling them and not by seeing them. She is unable to tolerate the distress of separation, thinking of emperumAn's divine *thulasi* garland while he remains unaware of her sorrows and is not showing mercy on her. How cruel is the quality of the benefactor who destroyed all the huge mansions in lankA!

vyAkyAnam

thuzhA nedum sUzh iruL enRu – the term *thuzhA* could mean both destruction and touching [objects] to feel; holding tightly on to an object which has been just found so that it does not slip out of one's hands.

sUzh iruL – darkness has pervaded everywhere, surrounding all places in such a way that no one can find a safe place to rest. While night time comprises 30 *nAzhigai* (one *nAzhigai* is 24 minutes; thus night time is 12 hours), AzhwAr calls it as *nedum* (very long; unending) because for those in separation, it is called as *dhlrkka yAmA thriyAmA* (long period, composed of three *yAmams*, with each *yAmam* being about 3 hours duration).

iruL enRu – the night time behaved like *rAvaNa* who came in the form of a pious sage and once he knew that *slthAppirAtti* was alone, changed his form to that of a demon; night time too set in like a normal event but started extending for a very long time.

than thaN thAr adhu peyarA – making use of the opportunity when the *nAyaki* desired the cool, divine *thulasi* garland on his divine shoulder.

ezhA nedu Uzhi – the time of *kalpam* which is unending. Even that *kalpam* will have an end but this [night time] is unending. Just like people from the *malayALa dhESam* will not leave a place until they complete the job for which they came, this night also seems to stay until it destroyed her.

ezhundha – appeared. Normally the term *Uzhi* would refer to *kalpam* only. Using *nigaNdu* (lexicon), the *vyAkyAthA* says *samvardha: praLaya: kalpa:* to show that these terms have the same meaning. Thus, the night time extended like a *praLayam* (deluge). *Sri rangarAja sthavam 2-41* says “*dhayamAnamanA:*” – Oh *ranganAthA*! During the time of *praLaya* your divine mind took pity, looking at the condition of the sentient and insentient entities (which were lying without name and form). If *sarvESvaran* shows

mercy, there will be an end to *praLayam* too. However, since he is not showing his mercy, this night time, referred to as *praLayam* is extending further.

ikkAlaththum – just as it is mentioned in Srl rAmAyaNam sundhara kANdam 28-18 “

slthAthavEnyudhgratham gruhlthvA” (slthAppirAtti says I am going to end myself by hanging from the braid of my locks as a rope), she too is in a similar distressed condition.

IngivaLO – is her condition similar to that of the samsAris (those who are in the materialistic realm) and their position in samsAram? They had lost their forms and senses during *praLayam*. Here her existence is in question. There, it is related to primordial matter; here it is related to the AthmA. There it is *praLayam* due to water; here it is *praLayam* due to darkness. There, the water, which is visible, is destroying the form [of sentient entities], which is visible; here it is the invisible darkness which is trying to destroy the invisible AthmA. There, they did not realise the danger that they were in, only emperumAn was aware of their condition; here, she fully knows the danger that she is in and she has the desire too for his protection.

vazhA nedum thunbaththaL enRu irangAr – he is not taking pity on her condition where she is in deep sorrow which will not go away. Just as it is mentioned in Srl rAmAyaNam sundhara kANdam 15-39 “*dhukkEna bubudhEslthAm*” ((hanumAn) recognised slthAppirAtti who was in deep sorrow); hanumAn could recognise slthAppirAtti from her sorrowful mood. sarvESvaran did not recognise the *nAyaki*’s sorrow. *karma* (deeds from previously encountered sins and virtues) would keep whittling down as it is experienced. But her sorrow is such that it will keep increasing as it is experienced. Since this sorrow is coming on the basis of *bhagavath ruchi* (engagement with sarvESvaran), it is not possible to alter it and it is not possible to make it to be without distinction. For one [sarvESvaran] who is the opposite of all faults, is it not expected of him to remove the faults of those who are engaged with him and shower mercy on them? If affection [from her] is not needed, should her *AthmasvarUpam* (true nature of AthmA) too not be required? If he is steadfast in his stand that he will protect only during times of danger, is her anguished state of being separated from him, false? Is she devoted to someone else for you not to show mercy on her? If it is a fault for us to move away from you, it is also a fault for you not to come towards us [to protect us]. If you come to us, our total dependence on you will be sustained and if you do not come to us, your state of being our lord will be harmed. Is it not the duty of the servants to create eminence for the lord? Creating eminence for one who is complete in all aspects [such as sarvESvaran] is not to protect oneself under any situation. This has been demonstrated in Srl rAmAyaNam ayOdhyA kANdam 31-22 when lakshmaNa tells Srl rAma “*vaidharmyam nEha vidhyathE*” (Make me your servant; there is nothing unrighteous in this. Besides I will be accomplishing my objective of being your servant). Due to the backing of Srl rAma’s powerful shoulders, just as one inserts one’s hand into the mouth of a poisonous snake, slthAppirAtti, while being in aSOka vanam, told rAvaNa as in Srl rAmAyaNam sundhara kANdam 22-16 “*thvam nlcha: SaSavath smrutha:*” (you, a lowly person, are said to be like a hare). For such a pirAtti, the situation now is that she doubts his ability to protect her. The reason for this is because of her doubt on her own nature, similar to the condition in which slthAppirAtti said as in Srl rAmAyaNam sundhara kANdam 38-48 “*mamaiva dhushkrutham kinchith...*” (it is because of the faults in me that the two brothers, Srl rAma and lakshmaNa are neglecting me). If this is the case, why did she say that sarvESvaran is not showering mercy on her? The vyAkyAtha explains this by saying that she has knowledge about his quality of showering mercy but not on her nature. In other words, she has not understood his anguish. His condition has been described in Srl rAmAyaNam sundhara kANdam 36-42 “*naivadhamsAn namaSAkAn*” (he does not even drive away the insects and flies crawling on his body). This is because of the reason mentioned in the same SIOkam 36-

42 “ *thvathgathEnAntharAthmana* ” (his mind is fully engrossed in you), as told by hanuman to slthAppirAtti. His mind is agitated like the agitation one sees in an ocean and not the agitation that takes place in the puddle of water under the hoof of a cow [in other words, his distress is real and deep]. While her condition was just as it was described in Srl rAmAyaNam sundhara kANdam 66-25 “ *Urdhvam mAsAnam najlvishyE* ” (I will not live for more than one month) his condition was described in sundhara kANdam 66-10 “ *na jlvEyam kshaNamapi* ” (I cannot live for a moment more). Both spoke about killing themselves because of the desire that each knew of the other. The vyAkyAthA quotes a few references to prove that one cannot survive without the other, as in nAnmugan thiruvandhAdhi 7 “ *inRAga nALaiyEyaAga inichchiRidhu ninRALum ninnaruL en pAladhE nanRAga nAnunnai anRi ilEn kaNdAy nAraNanE nI ennai anRi ilai* ” (either today or tomorrow or even after a longer time than that, your grace will certain fall on me since for me, your servant, there is no existence other than through you and for you there is no one to be protected other than me). There is no nArAyaNan without nAram (sentient entities). nArAyaNan refers both to the nature [being the lord etc] and the qualities [being with motherly forbearance, simplicity etc]. One cannot speak of a complete person if there were no incomplete (or faulty) persons; there can be no lord without servants.

irangAr – if he does not come, the quantum of sandalwood paste applied and its quantum which dries up and withers due to waiting for his arrival, appear to be doubling.

ammanO – she says this word with the fear that she would have had if she had sighted a tiger or a snake. He is the entity who looks at everyone as “ *suhrudham sarvabhUthAnAm* ” (I am friendly towards all creatures), and she is scared of such an entity. thaiththirlyA upanishath Anandhavalli says “ *Anandham brahmaNO vidhvan na bibhEthi kuthaSchana* ” (one who knows the extent of the happiness of *brahman* (supreme being) does not fear anything). One who has known brahman’s Anandham need not fear the sins that he has committed knowingly. Her situation is such that despite knowing about *brahman*, she has to be scared. The final syllable *O* refers to the cruelty of her sorrow.

ilangai . . . pirAnAr kodumaigale – while interpreting this, embAr [cousin of rAmAnujar as well as the one who succeeded him in the AchArya guruparamparai] would say “What happened to the one who destroyed the huge mansions of lankA for the sake of one lady, by bridging the ocean and shooting arrows which carried the names of Srl rAma and lakshmaNa, and the one who destroyed the gardens such that all the coconut trees lost all their leaves and looked like tonsured heads?” thirumalai nambi [maternal uncle of rAmAnujar as well as one of his AchAryas] would interpret this as “He destroyed lankA out of jealousy since it appeared more beautiful than ayOdhyA and it was not due to a lady”.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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39. pAsuram 37 – kodungAl silaiyar

avathArikai (Introduction)

The *nAyaki* who was distressed after being separated from her *nAyakan*, could not wait till he returned and left on her own [in search of him]. She went through a cruel forest which had animals and people, capable of harming, sounds which caused fear in one, and paths which were dangerous. Her mother found out that her daughter was not in her bed and gets bewildered thinking “Alas! She has gone through a dangerous path. What is she doing?” In the case of the daughter in thirukkOLUr (thiruvAimozhi 6-7) decad, the mother knew as to where her daughter had gone. But in the case of this mother, she did not know as to where her daughter had gone and feels distressed.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*kodungAl silaiyar niRaikOL uzHAVar kolaiyil veyya kadungAl iLaigyar thudipadum kavvaiththu
aruvinaiyEn nedungAlamum kaNNan nINmalarppAdham paravippeRRa thodungAl osiyumidai iLamAn
senRa sUzh kadame*

Word-by-Word Meanings

aruvinaiyEn – I, having cruel sins

nedungAlamum – for a long time

kaNNan – krishNa’s

nIL – being long

malar – like a flower

pAdham – divine feet

paravi- – after praying

peRRa – got as a daughter

thodungAl – merely on touching

osiyum – quivering

idai – having a waist

iLamAn – this girl who is like a youthful deer

senRa – the place that she went to

sUzh – surrounded (by heat)

kadam – the path

kodum – curved

kAl – having leg

silaiyar – having bow

nirai – cows

kOL – those who steal

uzhavar – farmers

kolaiyil – in harming

veyya – being cruel

kadungAI – having legs which will move fast

iLaigyar – youthful hunters

thudi – small drum (tambourine)

padum – created from

kavvaiththu – had a sound

Simple Translation

I, who am having cruel sins, prayed to the long, lotus-like divine feet of krishNa and got this daughter. She has a waist which will quiver by merely being touched and she jumps around like a youthful deer. This girl has, however, left me. The place that she went to is a cruel forest – which has people having curved bows, who steal cows as their profession, young people who kill others and who have legs which will carry them fast and from whose drums (tambourines) a sound is created.

vyAkyAnam

kodum kAl silaiyar – just as it has been mentioned in Srl rAmAyaNam bAla kANdam 6-21 “ *yOdhanAm agni kalpAnAm pESAIAnAm mAhEshuNAm* ” which describes those who are guarding the city of ayOdhyA (firebrand like skilful warriors), these people always carry their curved bows. The term *kodum kAl silaiyar* has two interpretations – it could refer to those who have bows with curved legs or it could refer to those who carry bows and who have cruel legs. In the former case, it would mean that they are constantly ready with drawn bow in order to harm others. For the bow, cruelty refers to its nature of sending another entity (arrow) to cause harm and does not go by itself to harm someone.

silaiyar – they keep carrying their bows, whether it is during the time of taking food or when they are in privacy with their wives. The *nAyaki* is one who has known sarvESvaran who, just as it is mentioned in periya thiruvandhAdhi 86 “ *kai kazhala nEmiyAn* ” always has the divine disc on his hand. This is his authenticity. Since she has moved with him, she is not afraid of anything. That divine disc is one which sustains everyone while this (the bow carried by these people in the cruel forest) is a harmful entity. Just as it is said in Srl rAmAyaNam adyOdhyA kANdam 60-20 “ *nAhArayathisanthrAsam bAhU rAmasya samSrithA* ” (slthAppirAtti does not fear the wild animals in the forest since she is protected by the broad shoulders of Srl rAma), those who are under the protection of his divine disc and divine shoulders need not fear anything. However, that is not the case here.

nirai kOL uzhavar – for these people, stealing cows is a profession. However she is someone who has known sarvESvaran for whom, as it is said in Srl vishNu purANam “ *gO brAhmaNa hithAyacha* ” – protecting cows and brAhmaNas is normal.

kolaiyil veyya – these people exhibit anger when killing others. They kill just to see how their victims tremble when being killed. Alternatively they will torture their victims, ask them to work for them till they die. *periya thirumozhi* 11-8-6 says “ *idaiyan eRindha maram* ” (the tree cut down by the shepherds for their sheep would be fresh at one place and dry at another). These people will harm their victims similarly, by making them half dead and half alive, with pain. In the case of *sarvESvaran*, though he also aims his arrows at his victims, it is only to carry out a beneficial act for them, just as it is said in *Sri rAmAyaNam* *kishkindhA kANdam* 24-24 “ *sanjAtha bhAshpa paravIra hanthA rAmO muhUrtham vimanA babhUva* ” ((on hearing *sugriva*’s words) *Sri rAma* had moist eyes and was for a moment perturbed), after he killed *vAli*.

kadungAl iLaigyar – if they were to harm someone, they will run a hundred miles and return a hundred miles, running. Such is the strength and speed of their legs. One would be fearful of them on just seeing them; there is no need for them to act. Through *AyurvEdha* medicines, they will keep themselves youthful, always.

thudipadum kavvaiththu – having the sound of drums (similar to tambourine). If she (*nAyaki*) goes to such a place, only her physical form will get destroyed. But if she stays in her place, her *AthmA* will get destroyed through the words of her mother.

aruvinaiyEn – it is not that he is not keen on coming to her; it is also not that she doesn’t have the desire to be united with him. They are not uniting with each other only because of my cruel sins [says the *nAyaki*’s mother]. This is similar to the *Sri rAmAyaNa SIOkam* “ *math pApamEva athra nimiththam AsIth* ” – it is only due to my sin.

nedungAlam . . . – I had worshipped *krishNa* who would not tolerate any delay in surrendering to him [*vyAkyAthA* says that the word *sakruth* in *Sri rAma charaka SIOkam* (ultimate hymn) *sakrudhEva prapannAya* is to be considered as immediately; *krishNa* doesn’t want even this delay]. Just as *dhEvaki* had carried out lot of penance to give birth to *krishNa*, I had done lot of penance to beget her. However, not realising about herself or about my penance to beget her, she has gone. *Sri rAmAyaNam AraNya kANdam* 66-3 speaks of the penance carried out by *dhaSaratha* to beget *Sri rAma* “ *mahathA thapasA rAma mahathA cha api karmaNa* ” (Oh *rAma*, you were born because of the great penance and great acts carried out by *dhaSaratha*).

nINmalarppAdham – his divine feet are such that they will go towards the place where his followers are present. They are so easily approachable. Those divine feet considered attaining his followers as their [the divine feet’s] benefit.

malar – soft; beautiful.

paravippeRRa – obtained after offering prayers of various types. It is similar to attaining a treasure after lot of efforts.

thodungAL osiyum idai – her waist was such that it would snap if touched. The *nAyakan* enjoyed that waist merely by looking at it and not by touching it after realising its greatness. *thiruvAimozhi* 6-7-8 “ *osindha nuNNidai mEl kaiyai vaiththu nondhu nondhu* ” (keeping the hand on the already quivering slender waist (out of tiredness) and hurting it more and more). Her waist was such that one would doubt its existence. By looking at the form above and below the waist, one could surmise that waist should be there in between. If one were to keep the hand as a support for that waist, the hand would like a mountain in comparison with the wait; it was that slender.

iLamAn senRa – she could not tolerate any of the difficulties which lay in that path

sUzh kadam – the forest which had pervaded in a cruel way.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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40. pAsuram 38 – kadamAyinagaL

avathArikai (Introduction)

When yOgis (those who are meditating) are in meditation for a very long time, they will turn their attention towards worldly matters for a short time, in order to engage more deeply in meditation once they resume it. In the same way, he too [nammAzhwAr] turned his attention towards worldly objects in order to enhance his experience with matters relating to emperumAn. However, since he has been showered with knowledge and devotion without any illusion, even the worldly objects which he saw reminded him of emperumAn and tortured him further. It is as difficult to turn the AzhwArs away from the path of vEdhas, and towards worldly matters just as it is difficult to turn us away from worldly matters, and towards the path of vEdhas. Just as it is difficult to turn us away from materialistic pursuit and towards matters relating to bhagavAn, it is equally difficult to turn AzhwArs away from matters relating to bhagavAn and towards materialistic pursuits. embAr, the disciple of rAmAnujar, mercifully mentioned these two.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

kadamAyinagaL kazhiththuth than kAl vanmaiyAl palanAL thadamAyina pukku nlr nilai ninRa thavam idhu kol kudamAdiya maNNum viNNum kulunga ulagaLandha nadamAdiya perumAn uruvoththana neelangaLE

Word-by-Word Meanings

neelangaL – blue Indian water lilies

immaNNum – this earth

viNNum – upper worlds

kulunga – to move in amazement

kudamAdi – dancing with pots (in krishNAvathAram)

ulagu – worlds

aLandha – measured (in thrivikrmAvathAram)

nadamAdiya – one who roamed

perumAn – sarvESvaran's

uru – with divine form

oththana – are equivalent

idhu – the reason for this

kadamAyinagaL – three debts owed to celestial entities, forefathers and sages

kazhiththu – fulfilling them

than – one's

kAlvanmaiyAl – strength of legs

palanAL – for a long time

thadamAyina – known as ponds

pukku – entering

nIr – in water

nilai ninRa – residing for a long time

thavangol – could be the penance

Simple Translation

In krishNAvatharam he danced with pots such that this earth and the upper worlds shook with amazement; in thrivikramAvathAram, he measured all the worlds. The blue lilies are having a complexion much similar to the sarvESvaran who roamed like this. The reason for this could be that they paid back their three types of debts, entered water bodies with the strength of their legs, stayed there for a very long time and carried out penance.

vyAkyAnam

kadamAyinagal kazhiththu – just as it is mentioned in manusmrithi 6-35 “*ruNAnithrINyabAkruthya*” – after fulfilling the three debts owed. yajUshi kANDam says “*brahmacharyENa rushibhya : yagyEna dhEvEbhya prajayApithrubhya*” – through *brhamacharyam* (observing the tenets of being a bachelor), one pays back the debt owed to rishis (sages); through yAgams (rituals involving *agni*, fire) one pays back the celestial entities and through siring children, one pays back the forefathers. Similarly, the blue lilies pay back their debts through the distress caused to their bodies in hot season, at the hottest time. Here, the body, hot season and hot time are the debts owed.

than kAl vanmai – through their efforts (strength of their legs), through their penance, considering only their existence, even during cold times, whether it is water formed under the hoof of a cow or in large water bodies like ocean etc, they stay up to their neck and carry out penance. Did you get a similarity with the complexion of sarvESvaran due to the strength of that penance?

kudamAdi – dancing with pots in the courtyard such that everyone could steal his beauty [with their eyes], snipping the pride of cowherd folk.

immaNNum – instead of benefitting some people or people in a street, he danced such that all the world could enjoy,

kulunga – if rudhra (Sivan) dances, the world trembles in fear since he is the celestial entity for annihilation. But if sarvESvaran dances, the word forgets itself and rejoices.

ulagaLandhu nadamAdiya – when sarvESvaran incarnated as thrivikrama and measured the worlds, indhra accepted his lands which he had lost to mahAbali; mahAbali felt happy that he had magnanimously donated the lands [which were not his in the first place]; sarvESvaran felt that he had carried out the act of retrieval as a benefit for himself.

uruvoththana neelangaLE – was it through paying back the debts, entering water bodies through the strength of your legs and carrying out penance over long periods that you attained equality with emperumAn in all aspects of his divine form?

The vyAkyAthA says that the knowledge that AzhwAr had was such that even if he wanted to look at worldly objects due to separation from emperumAn, even those objects remind him of emperumAn only.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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41. pAsuram 39 – neelath thadavaraimEl

avathArikai (Introduction)

In the previous pAsuram, the blue coloured objects appeared like the divine form of sarvESvaran and tortured her. The divine form established itself in a superior part, the divine eyes. AzhwAr describes as to how the divine eyes tortured him such that he could not move away from them. As an example of how each part reminded of another and finally the whole, the vyAkyAthA cites Srl rAmAyaNam sundhara kANDam 36-4 “ *gruhlthvA prEkshamAnA* ” (taking hold [of that ring] and looking at it, slthAppirAtti thought of the finger over which the ring had been placed, and felt as if she had reached her husband).

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

neelaththadavaraimElpuNdarlga nedum thadangaL pOlap polindhu emakku ellAvidaththavum pongu munnIr gyAlappirAn visumbukkum pirAn maRRum nallOr pirAn kOlangariya pirAn empirAn kaNNin kOlangaLE

Word-by-Word Meanings

pongu – agitating

munniR – composed of water from three sources, viz from river, from spring and from rain

gyAlam – for earth

pirAn – being the benefactor

visumbukkum – for the people in the upper worlds too

maRRum – further

nallOr – for mukthAthmAs and nithyasUris, who enjoy sarvESvaran’s *guNas* (auspicious qualities)

kariya – having a dark bluish complexion

kOlam – having a divine form

empirAn – being the benefactor for me, his

thadam – huge *kaNNin* – eyes’

kOlangaL – beauty

neelam – like a bluish gem

varai mEl – on top of the mountain

puNdarlgam – of lotus

nedum – expansive

thadangaL pOla – like ponds

polindhu – full of beauty

emakku – for us

ellAvidaththavum – at all places

(were gleaming)

Simple Translation

He is the benefactor of earth which has three types of agitating water – water from river, water from spring and water from rain; he is the benefactor of brahmA et al who are in the upper worlds; he is the benefactor of nithyasUris and mukthAthmAs; he has a dark bluish complexion; he is the benefactor for people like me. Such empeurmAn's beautiful eyes are like a huge pond filled with lotus flowers atop a huge mountain of bluish gem, shining in all the places.

vyAkyAnam

neelaththadavarai mEl – just as it is said in thirumAlai 2 “*pachchai mAmalai pOL mEni*” (the divine form is like a mountain made of emerald), his divine form is described here as a hill made of bluish gem.

puNdariga . . . – his eyes were like huge ponds of lotus flowers which had occupied his entire divine form; his divine form appeared to be full of eyes. The eyes of the beholder would focus on only on those eyes and will not see any other limb. This is something similar to Srl rangarAjasthavam 1-98 “*krupayA parayA karishyamANE sakalAngam*” (the divine eyes of periya perumAL wanted to shower mercy; hence they attempted to change all the limbs of periya perumAL into divine eyes). Those eyes were similar to the ones mentioned in chAndhOgya upanishath 16-7 “*thasyayathA kapyAsam puNdariksham EvamakshiNI*” (they eyes were similar to lotus flower which has just then blossomed on seeing sUriyan (sUrya)).

emakku ellAvidaththavum – those eyes followed everywhere in such a way that there is no place on earth which had not been visited upon. If one were to close the eyes so that one need not see those eyes which torment the beholder, those eyes will enter the beholder's eyes; they will pervade everywhere. They have come to win me over, in this way. This could be compared with thiruvAimozhi 7-7-1 “*sUzhavum thAmarainANmalar pOl vandhu thOnRum kaNdlr*” (they will appear from all sides, like just then blossomed lotus flower) as well as thiruvAimozhi 8-9-1 “*karumANikka malaimEl maNiththadandhAmaraiKKAdugaL pOl*” (like huge forest of lotus flowers atop a hill of dark carbuncle).

pongu munnIr gyAlappirAn – he is one who keeps rendering help to those who are on this earth which is surrounded by agitating oceans which are made up of three types of water – from rivers, from springs and from rain. As an example of rendering help, the vyAkyAthA cites the instance when he kept the worlds inside his stomach during the time of deluge and protected all.

visumbukkum pirAn – he is also the controller of dhEvathAs (celestial entities) such as brahmA who had given birth to these worlds.

maRRum nallOr pirAn – he is the controller of nithyasUris too.

kOLam kariya pirAn – the divine form of emperumAn is totally subservient to those divine eyes. It is with the divine form that emperumAn subjugates the nithyasUris and makes them bewildered always.

empirAn – just as he is their lord, he is my lord too.

kaNNin kOlangaLE – the distinguished eyes of one who is my benefactor. Just as lotus ponds have occupied the entire mountain of bluish gems, these eyes shine in all the places that I see.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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42. pAsuram 40 – kOlappagal kaLiru

avathArikai (Introduction)

She (the *nAyaki*), who had spoken about the supreme being who controls everyone and everything, has reached a stage where she speaks about one noon time.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

kOlappagal kaLiRonRu kaRpuyyak kuzhAm viriththa neelakkangul kaLiRellAm niRaindhana nErizhaiyIr gyAlappon mAdhin maNALan thuzhAy nangaL sUzh kuzhaRkE Elappunanindhu ennaimAr emmai nOkkuvadhu enRu koLO

Word-by-Word Meanings

kOlam – being beautiful

pagal – sUriyan (sUrya – sun)

onRu kaLiRu – an elephant

kal – in the mountain of sunset

puyya – as it entered

kuzhAm – as a herd

virindha – expansive

neelam – blue coloured

kangul – called as night

kaLiRu ellAm – all the elephants

niRaindhana – abounded

nEr – being apt

izhaiyIr – those who have ornaments

gyAlam – for bhUdhEvi

ponmAdhu – and for SrIdhEvi

maNALan – Sriya:pathi, consort's

thuzhAy – divine thuLasi

nangaL – our

sUzh – dense

kuzhaRkE – locks

Ela – ahead

punaindhu – stringing

ennaiAr – our mothers

emmai – us *nOkkuvadhu* – protect

enRu kol – when will it be

Simple Translation

A unique elephant, called as the most beautiful sUriyan, entered the western setting mountains. Immediately, a herd of elephants, called as night, with dark bluish colour, filled up the entire place. Oh my friends who are donning apt ornaments! On which day will our mothers apply the divine thuLasi garland of azhagiya maNavALan, who is the consort of SrlldhEvi and bhUdhEvi, on our dense locks and decorate us?

vyAkyAnam

kOlappagal kaLiru onRu kaRpuyya – A unique elephant called as noon, which gives happiness to those who see it, entered the setting mountains on the western side. The term noon refers to sUriyan. Why is the noon giving happiness? During noon time, each of the five senses is focussed on its work, enabling the person to sustain himself/herself since the person could bear the anguish of separation [when the senses are not united in torturing the person].

kuzhAm virindha . . . – just as a paramour enters the private quarters of the queen as soon as the king departs, night time, in large gathering, entered as soon as sUriyan left. Since the five senses now get together and torture the person, reminding her of separation from her *nAyakan*, AzhwAr refers to the night time as elephants. But why refer to them [elephants] in plural? Since a night extends to many kalpams, when in separation, he refers to them in plural.

nErizhaiyIr – Oh those who have donned distinguished ornaments! When the *nAyaki* is in distress (having been separated from her *nAyakan*) will her friends who have come to console her, bedeck themselves with ornaments? She is like a helpless woman who has been stomped by the elephant called as night. Her friends are coming to encourage her to sustain herself [till her *nAyakan* returns]; hence they dress themselves up nicely with ornaments etc.

gyAlappon mAdhin maNALan – if he were alone, I can feel distressed thinking that there is none to recommend to him about me. However, I am in a sorrowful state despite the eminent bhUdhEvi and SrlldhEvi being together with him. When someone is wealthy, they will be without fear since they have enough wealth to take care of their expenses. In the same way, the *nAyakan* feels that even if the *nAyaki* is not around, he has bhUdhEvi and SrlldhEvi with him.

mAdhin maNALan – he is in a bewildered condition since he has bhUdhEvi who gives him all that he enjoys. The *nAyaki* feels that the he will have bewilderment towards her too, just as he has towards bhUdhEvi.

thuzhAy . . . – the *nAyaki* does not desire the garland which he had donned as a bachelor. She covets the divine thuLasi garland which has got fully wrinkled in the union between sarvESvaran and bhUdhEvi. She is just like a prince who would dip flowers in a fragrant material to enhance its sweet smell. chAndhOgya upanishath says of him that he is *sarvagandha: sarvarasa:* (he is the repository of all that is fragrant and all that is tasty). She is referred to in thiruvAimozhi 10-10-2 as “*vAsam sey pUnguzhaAL*”

(it is pirtAtti who gives fragrance to flowers and thuLasi). Thus the *nAyaki* desires the garland which has been wrinkled in the union of the *dhivyadhampathi* (divine couple).

nangal sUzhkuzhaRkEA Elappunaindhu – there is no other remedy for her. She wants to don that garland before her existence is destroyed.

ennaimAr – she is looking up to her mothers who are keen on separating her from her *nAyakan* to get her the remedy which she needs to sustain herself. It is similar to asking for water from a person who is shutting the channel which brings in water.

emmai nOkkuvadhu enRu koLO – he [AzhwAr in feminine mood] is asking as to when he will get the protection which he needs.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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43. pAsuram 41 – enRum punvAdai

avathArikai (Introduction)

In the previous pAsuram, at the end, the *nAyaki* said “ *emmai nOkkuvadhu enRu koLO ?*” She was wondering as to who will be her protector. A northerly breeze affects such a *nAyaki* ; wind, which is the sustaining entity for life, is harming her.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

enRum punvAdai idhu kaNdaRidhum ivvARu vemmai onRum uruvum suvadum theriyilam Ongu asurar ponRum vagai puLLaiyUrvAn aruL aruLAdha innAL manRil niRai pazhi thURRi ninRemmai vankARRu adumE

Word-by-Word Meanings

enRum – always

idhu – this

punvAdai – gentle breeze

kaNdaRidhum – we have experienced

ivvARu – like this

vemmai – having cruelty

uruvum – form

suvadum – nature

onRum – any entity

theriyilam – we are not aware of

Ongu – grown well

asurar – demons

ponRum vagai – to be annihilated

puLLai – garuda

UrvAn – emperumAn who conducts

aruL aruLAdha – not showing mercy

innAL – this day

manRil – in the open

niRai – being complete

pazhi – slander

thURRi – to pervade

ninRu – without feeling tired

van – cruel

kARRu – breeze

emmai – us

adum – is harming

Simple Translation

We have experienced this northerly breeze. However, we have not known any entity like this which brings with it cruel heat, form and nature. This day, sarvESvaran, who conducts garuda who annihilates the well grown demons, is not showering his mercy. This cruel breeze is spreading slanderous words in the open and is harming me, without moving out of this place.

vyAkyAnam

enRum punvAdai idhu kaNdaRidhum – it is similar to having been born in prison and brought up only there. *punvAdai* is gentle breeze.

idhu kaNdaRidhum – we have not seen anything like this. In other words, we have not seen anything other than the northerly breeze which is harming. Why speak about the breeze which has been harming? Various other entities are also carrying on with what the breeze had been doing – harming her by amplifying the anguish of separation. They are all of the same species in so far as harming her is concerned.

ivvAru . . . – We have not known any other entity which is as cruel as this.

Ongu asurar . . . – the demons are not like those who are withering in separation from sarvESvaran, are not like those who carry out all the services to him; they are the epitome of *rajas* and *thamas* (qualities of passion and ignorance, respectively). sarvESvaran conducts garuda such that these demons are annihilated; he is not showing his mercy today so that this breeze could be harmed just like he makes the demons to perish under the hoofs of garuda.

aruL aruLAdha innAL – on this day when he did not shower his mercy, like a mother refuses to nurse her infant.

manRil niRai . . . – it is not only that the breeze did not let her unite with her *nAyakan*, it also brought a slander on her. It made the people say “It seems that she was suffering in separation from her *nAyakan* and the moment the breeze touched her, she is quivering; her qualities of shyness, fear etc are like this...”

niRai pazhi – the world did not talk slanderously about her alone. It even spoke disparagingly about the *nAyakan* saying “She is withering in breeze; even then, he is not coming to her rescue”.

ninRemmai van kARRu adumE – it does not leave after distressing her on one occasion or in one type. It continues to do that.

emmai – I did not go anywhere near it so that it could make an attempt to grab me. This strong breeze came to end my life.

van kARRu – it is a breeze which did not have affability.

adumE – it is not even considering my femininity. It is not even thinking that it is torturing a lady.

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): this pAsursm narrates as to how despite staying in samsAram for a very long time, as engagement with emperumAn starts increasing, compatibility with samsAram starts disappearing.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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44. pAsuram 42 – van kARRaRaiya

avathArikai (Introduction)

She said that it is difficult for her to survive the onslaught of this breeze and that she would perish. As soon as she said this, he showered his mercy on her.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*van kARRaRaiya orungE maRindhu kidandhu alarndha menkAR kamalaththadam pOl melindhana
maNNum viNNum enkARku aLavinmai kANmin enbAnoththu vAn nimirndha thanpAR paNindha en pAl
empirAna thadangaNgalE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

maNNum – the earth

viNNum – the upper worlds

enkARku – for my divine feet

aLavinmai – are not apt

kANmin – please see

enbAn oththu – as if saying so

vAn – in the sky

nimirndha – growing

thanpAl – towards him

paNindha – worshipped

en pAl – (caused) towards me

empirAna – sarvESvaran's

thadam – expansive

kaNgal – divine eyes

van – bring cruel

kARRu – wind

aRaiya – to blow

orungE – towards one side

maRindhu kidandhu – having fallen

alarndha – blossoming

men – soft

kAl – having a creeper

kamalam – lotus flowers’

thadam pOl – like ponds

polindhana – were full of beauty

Simple Translation

I worshipped the divine feet of sarvESvaran’s, of which he said “See, neither the earth nor the upper words would equal my divine feet”. How were his divine eyes towards such me? They bent towards me, just like the lotus flowers with long creepers in a pond would, when a strong breeze blows, bend towards one side.

vyAkyAnam

van kARRu . . . – *menkAl kamalam* refers to a lotus whose stem is so slender that it cannot withstand even a gently blowing breeze. *van kARRu* refers to a breeze which blows hard without taking into consideration the gentleness of this lotus.

orungE – on one side alone. In other words, the divine mercy of emperumAn was oriented towards her alone. If he changes his glance to some other direction, the lotus flowers (divine eyes) will lose their beauty.

maRindhu kidandhu alarndha – if a samsAri (dweller of materialistic realm) comes towards him, sarvESvaran looks at him with mercy. If he wishes to look at even pirAtti, after that, he cannot. thiruvAimozhi 2-6-2 says “*e ngum pakkam nOkkaRiyAn*” (he did not look in any other direction)

menkAl kamalam – Srl rAmAyaNam yudhdha kANDam 19-34 says “*prakruthayA dharma Seelasya rAghavasya*” (Srl rAma is one who, by his nature, treads the path of righteousness). In this SIOkam, the word *dharma* refers to Sri rAma being of gentle nature. Srl rAma asks the monkeys “What is the way to cross this ocean which is like a hurdle between us and lankA?” Srl vibhIshaNAzhwAn, since he had recently carried out SaraNAgathi (act of surrendering) to Srl rAma and had got the benefit of that act, since he knew that SaraNAgathi is the means for all advantages and since he knew that it grants highest benefits, told Srl rAma to surrender to the ocean. The greatness of SaraNAgathi is that even an insentient entity will grant what has been asked for, when a person performs SaraNAgathi to it. Among the various means to captivate the hearts of great people, there is nothing higher than SaraNAgathi. If it can be effective with sarvESvaran who does not have a clan or limitations, should one doubt whether it will be effective with those who are having restrictions? Srl rAmAyaNam yudhdha kANDam 19-31 “*SaraNam ... karthum arhathi*” (the ocean will be inclined to do what Srl rAma had surrendered for). Srl vibhIshaNAzhwAn had seen the effectiveness of SaraNAgathi with the disciples of sage vasishta [srl rAma and lakshmaNa]. Hence he firmly believed that it will be effective with an insentient entity such as ocean too. The vyAkyAtha cites a thamizh proverb to buttress this belief – *erudhu keduththArkkum EzhE kadukkAy* – for the one who lost his bull, take seven gall-nuts to retrieve it. The story goes like this – a person had lost his bull; he went to another person and asked him whether he will be able to find it. The other person told him, mischievously, to eat seven gall-nuts and that he would find it. So the owner of the bull ate the gall-nuts and waited at the tank bund. The bull per chance came there. Thinking that he got the bull back because he ate the gall-nuts the person went home happily. On the way back home, a lady, who had not had a child till then, asked of him to give her a remedy for it. This man told her to ask

his friend who had suggested to him to eat the gall-nuts. That person told her too to eat seven gall-nuts. She did that and she conceived. In other words, a deed carried out with deep belief fructifies into desired action.

menkAl kamalam – there is no need for breeze to blow to move these lotus flowers. Their stems will sway on their own; they are that soft. In other words, for sarvESvaran to shower his mercy with his divine eyes, it is not necessary that one should be an *Arthaprapannan* (one who craves to surrender to get mOksham immediately). sarvESvaran will do that on his own. Is it not required to surrender through one's mind? vyAkyAthA responds to this doubt by quoting Srl rAmAyaNam yudhdha kANdam 18-3 “ *mithrabhAvEna samprAptham na thyajEyam* ” (I do not desert anyone who comes with a friendly appearance, even if he has a defect). Instead of analysing whether vibhIshaNAzhwAn has true friendliness or not towards him, Srl rAma says as in Srl rAmAyaNam yudhdha kANdam 18-31 “ *bala vlryam vinASanam* ” (It is enough that he came with a friendly demeanour. If I do not accept him, my strength and valour will get devastated). If sarvESvaran demands something from one who comes to surrender to him, which he does not have, then it would result in his not being easily worshippable. sarvESvaran has the nature of accepting whatever the person who comes to surrender to him, has. Srl rAma says in Srl rAmAyaNam yudhdha kANdam 18-28 “ *ArthO vA yadhivA dhрупtha parESam SaraNam gatha* ” (whether he is oppressed or arrogant, if one comes seeking protection from others ...). If a person comes saying as in Srl rAmAyaNam yudhdha kANdam 17-16 “ *rAghavam SaraNam gatha* ” (I take refuge under Srl rAma), it is enough for sarvESvaran. When he heard such words from Srl vibhIshaNAzhwAn, Srl rAma immediately fully realised the tenderness in vibhIshaNA's heart. sugrIva thought “These are mere words; his thoughts are otherwise. Even though Srl rAma considers him as *Artha prapannan* he is indeed *dhрупthan* only. He has something in his mind and speaks differently; he should be killed”. An *Arthan* is one who thinks that he should live only if he attains sarvESvaran; otherwise, he would die. *dhрупthan* is one who has arrogance in him and says that he has come to take refuge, not with his full heart but with an arrogance. Whether one is an *Arthan* or a *dhрупthan* the benefit is the same. This is because the benefit does not accrue out of the nature of the one who surrenders but based on the greatness of the act of surrendering and the greatness of the one to whom one surrenders. How does *dhрупthi* act like a means similar to *Arthi* ? While the one who has *Arthi* has *Akinchanyam* (not having anything on his own) as a natural behaviour, in the case of one who has *dhрупthi* sarvESvaran thinks “Since he does not have *Akinchanyam* , let us go on our own and show him mercy”. Thus whether one is an *Arthan* or a *dhрупthan* , if he comes to take refuge, as said in Srl rAmAyaNam 18-28 “ *parESam SaraNam gatha* ” (one who comes to take refuge from others), he will be protected, even if he is from the enemy side. periya thirumozhi 1-9-3 says “ *konREn . . . anRE vandhadaindhEn* ” (Oh the lord of thiruvEngadam! I killed many people and immediately, before even cleaning the blood stain, I reached you to take refuge). Srl rAma says in Srl rAmAyaNam yudhdha kANdam 18-28 “ *prANAn parithyajya rakshithavya* ” – he should be protected even if one were to give his life, irrespective of whether one who comes to surrender is *Arthan* or *dhрупthan* . The above mentioned SIOkam ends with the words “ *kruthAthmanA* ” – one who has a disciplined mind, one who stands in the path of righteousness. Thus, Srl rAma gave refuge to Srl vibhIshaNAzhwAn not only to protect him but also to safeguard his nature of being one who does not cross the path of righteousness. If one surrenders to an AchAryan (guru; teacher) in order to practice the path of righteousness, he has to do like this only.

menkAl kamalaththadam poL polindhana empirAna thadangaNgal

Whose eyes are they?

maNNum viNNum . . . – they are of one who stands firmly saying “See that this world and the worlds above are too little to be measured by my foot”. He filled the entire ethereal layers with his divine form. If he had said that “I will keep my divine feet on your heads when I measure these”, just as rAvaNa said in Srl rAmAyaNam yudhdha kANdam 36-11 “*na namEyam*” ([rAvaNa told mAlyavAn, who came to offer him good counsel that] he would not bend before anyone even if he were to be cut into two), the people of the world would have refused. Hence he said “Look at this amazing act” [and measured the worlds, keeping his divine feet on everyone’s head even before they realised it]. But why say that here? This is to illustrate the fact that sarvESvaran, on his own, without any of the worldly people asking him to or taking any efforts on their own, took incarnation as thrivikrama and kept his divine feet on his own, on their heads. In other words, he took the efforts for them to get the benefit. This brings out his quality of *menkAlkamalam*, viz. without the sentient entity taking any effort, sarvESvaran remains the means on his own.

vAn nimirndha than kAl paNindha enpAl – *AnukUlya sankalpam* is the steadfastness with which one remains as favourable to sarvESvaran. For this, sarvESvaran takes the effort himself. Initially [during thrikrama avathAram] he bowed to king mahAbali, then made mahAbali to bow to him and kept his divine feet on mahAbali’s head saying “You were favourable to me” and showed his mercy.

than pAl paNindha – this is similar to *van kARRu aRaiya*

en pAl – this is similar to saying *orungE maRindhu kidandhu alarndha*

empirAna thadakkangaLE – he took the efforts for mahAbali to get the benefit. That sarvESvaran feels happy that the benefit is his, is clear from the blossoming of his divine eyes.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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45. pAsuram 43 – kaNNum sendhAmarai

avathArikai (Introduction)

There is no avathArikai written by the vyAkyAthA for this pAsuram.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*kaNNum sendhAmarai kaiyum avai adiyO avaiyE vaNNam kariyadhOr mAl varai pOnRu madhi vigaRpAl
viNNum kadandhu umbar appal mikku marReppAl yavarkkum eNNum idaththadhuvO empirAnadhu
ezhil niRamE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

kaNNum – divine eyes too

sendhAmarai – are like reddish coloured lotus flower

kaiyum – divine hands too

avai – are like that lotus

adi – divine feet too

vaNNam – divine form

kariyadhu – being black

Or – unique

mAl – huge

varai pOnRu – like a mountain

empirAnadhu – sarvESvaran, our benefactor, his

ezhil – beautiful

niRam – complexion

madhi vigaRpAl – due to differences in intellect

viNNum – dwellers of *svargam* (heaven)

kadandhu – going past

umbar – brahmA et al, who live beyond these people

appAl – going further

mikku – going wondrously

maRRu – further

eppAl – pervading everywhere (through their knowledge)

yavarkkum – for nithyasUris too

eNNum – for thinking

idaththadhuvO – is it a matter?

Simple Translation

His divine eyes are like a reddish coloured lotus flower; his divine hands and divine feet are also like the lotus flower. His divine form is like a dark, huge mountain which is without any parallel. The beauty of such sarvESvaran, who is a benefactor for us all, is past the entities who are dwelling in *svargam*, past brahmA et al, who live beyond them, and is also past the knowledge of nithyasUris who pervade everywhere through their knowledge. Is his beauty a matter for them to think about!

vyAkyAnam

In the previous pAsuram, he enjoyed the divine eyes of sarvESvaran by speaking of them as *empirAna thadangangalE*. The beauty of those eyes took him to the other limbs.

kaNNum sendhAmarai – He had enjoyed his eyes separately. However, he wants to enjoy the eyes along with the other limbs and hence is speaking about them. Earlier he was fully absorbed in the eyes alone. Now, he is enjoying sarvESvaran’s motherly forbearance and beauty.

kaiyum avai – being attracted by sarvESvaran’s divine eyes, AzhwAr wants to touch his divine form. Knowing this, sarvESvaran embraces him with his divine hands. Sri vishNu purANam 5-18-2 says “*samspruSyA Akrushyacha prlthyA sugAdam parishasvajE*” (krishNa lifted akrUrar [kamsan’s minister] who fell at his feet and embraced him tightly) – such divine hands.

adiyO avaiyE – The act of embracing him leads to a feeling of intoxication. Due to this, on swooning, the place where he falls is the divine feet. jithanthE SIOkam 1 says “*puNdarIkAksha nama:*” (salutations to sarvESvaran who has lotus like eyes). In other words, don’t those who lose out to his eyes, fall at his feet!

vaNNam . . . – the divine form is the means for those who swoon and fall at his divine feet to get back to life. piLLaippiLLai AzhwAn (one of the disciples of kUratthAzhwAn) would say “Just like an infant which is suckling looks at the mother’s face keenly, those who fall at his divine feet look at his divine form”

viNNum kadandhu umbar appal mikku marReppAl yavarkkum madhi vigaRpAl eNNum idaththadhuvO empirAnadhezhil niRam

madhi vigaRpAl – due to differences in the level of intellect. Even though there is difference in the intelligence levels of samsAris and dhEvAs (celestial entities), it is not possible to know. What is not possible to know? ...

viNNum . . . – starting with brahmA who is the cause of samsAris and who has his place of birth at sarvESvaran and who got his knowledge through sarvESvaran, and extending to nithyasUris, is it possible to know the beauty of sarvESvaran, who is my benefactor?

empirAn – AzhwAr celebrates how sarvESvaran manifested his beauty to him, as described in

- mahAbhAratham mOksha dharmam (187-4) *nagrAhya kEnachith kvachith* – he cannot be estimated by anyone, in any way

- kEnOpanishath 1-2 *yasyAmatham thasya matham* – one who thinks that he does not know (about emperumAn), knows; one who thinks that he knows, does not know.
- Srl rAmAyaNam AraNya kANdam 1-12 *rUpasamhananam lakshmlm saukumAryam suvESathAm dhadhru vismithAkArA rAmasya vanavAsina:* – the sages dwelling in [dhandakAraNya] forest saw the physical build, its augustness and softness, and the fine arrangement of limbs, remaining in wondrous form. Sri rAma's softness of divine form is such that even if slthappirAtti or lakshmaNa looks at his form, it will wither away. Such a *dharSan* (sight) which even the dwellers of his kingdom ayOdhyA could not get, was manifested to these sages who dwell in forests.

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46. pAsuram 44 – niRam uyar

avathArikai (Introduction)

Some people asked AzhwAr “You say that sarvESvaran is not an entity who could be attained as per our wish. Is it not possible to know about him?” He responds saying “It is not that way. With his mercy, we could know about him”.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*niRam uyar kOlamum pErum uruvum ivai ivai enRu aRamuyal gyAnachchamayigaL pEsilum
angangellAm uRavuyar gyAnachchudar viLakkAy ninRadhanRi onRum peRa muyanRAR illaiyAl empirAna
perumaiyaiE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

niRam – due to the beauty (of the divine form)

uyar – wondrous

kOlamum – decorations

pErum – divine names

uruvum – auspicious divine forms

ivai ivai enRu – saying that these are of such and such type

aRam – righteously

muyal – attempting

gyAnam – having devotion

samayigaL – those who are firmly engaged in the philosophy of paths of vEdhams (sacred texts)

pEsilum – even if they instruct

angangellAm – in all those entities of beauty etc

uRa – to attain

uyar – distinguished

gyAnam – related to knowledge

sudar – splendid

viLakkAy – having intelligence

(as people of wisdom)

ninRadhanRi – apart from being that way

empirAna – emperumAn’s

perumaiyai – greatness

onRum – in any way

peRa – to attain

muyanRARillai – they did not attempt

Simple Translation

People who are firmly established in the path of righteousness may instruct about the decorations, divine names, auspicious divine forms etc which had attained greatness due to emperumAn's beauty. However, it cannot be said that they have splendid knowledge about emperumAn's beauty etc. They have not attempted to describe fully his incomparable greatness in any way.

vyAkyAnam

niRam . . . – beauty is what one gets as existence after holding on to sarvESvaran. vyAkyAthA narrates about what hanuman said after looking at Srl rAma's beauty and becoming subservient to him. Srl rAma and lakshmaNa, searching for slthAppirAtti, had approached the place where sugrIva and others were hiding. sugrIva was worried that they could be inimical people and sent hanuman to find out about them. hanuman came to their place, saw them, and forgetting his primary task, started singing paens on them, as mentioned in Srl rAmAyaNam kishkindhA kANdam 3-14 “ *simhas skandhau mahOthsAhau samadhau ivagOvrishau AyathAScha suvruthASha bhAhava: parighOpamA:* ” (lion-shouldered, full of fortitude, vigorous like bulls, lengthy and circular shoulders, looking similar to clubs). sarvESvaran is that beautiful. hanuman realised that on merely seeing them, the purpose for which he came had become successful [to befriend sugrIva and help him in getting back his wife and kingdom]. *AyathA: AjAnubhAhu* – Srl rAma's divine arms came down to his knees and extended further beyond. hanuman found that both Srl rAma and lakshmaNa, who is referred to as in Srl rAmAyaNam yudhdha kANdam 28-24 “ *rAmasya dhakshiNObhAhu* ” (right hand of Srl rAma) had not decorated themselves with any ornament. He continues, as in Srl rAmAyaNam kishkindhA kANdam 3-15 “ *sarvabhUshaNa bhUshArha: kim artham na vibhUshithA:* ” (while your physique is fit for being decorated with all ornaments, why have you not decorated with any ornament?) Why have you not worn the ornaments which have lost their beauty (since they are not decorating you)? Some kings would take a vow that they would not drink milk or eat betel leaves until they won over a particular king. Have you too taken a vow that you will not wear ornaments until you annihilate the enemies of sages in forests? Or are you not wearing ornaments thinking that you could attract monkeys roaming in the forest such as me with your external beauty?

pErUm – he has divine names, befitting this beauty, such as mentioned in thiruvAimozhi 7-3-10 “ *magaranedum kuzhaikkAdhar* ” (one who has ears similar to long fish). The vyAkyAthA narrates a few incidents from the lives of our pUrvAchAryars (preceptors). thirumalai nambi, the son of periyA thirumalai nambi (who was bhagavath rAmAnuja's AchArya) was in his final days. He called kaNIyanUr siRiyAththAn, the disciple of parASara bhattar, and asked him “Could you tell me the divine name which parASara bhattar used to constantly meditate on, as his refuge?” siRiyAththAn hesitated since he wasn't sure about the specific divine name which he should recount. thirumalai nambi egged him on, saying “dhASarathy! This is not the time to keep quiet.” Immediately, siRiyAththAn responded saying “He used to recount many divine names, including nArAyaNa. However, the one divine name in which he was much engaged with is *azhagiya maNavALapperumAL* ” Hearing this, thirumalai nambi said “Instead of saying namperumAL, he has said *azhagiya maNavALapperumAL* , just like a *dharmapathni* (wife who walks in the path of righteousness) refers to her husband. In any case, other than this divine name which bhattar used to meditate on, there is no refuge for adiyEn” and reciting “

azhayagiyamaNavALapperumALE SaraNam” (I take refuge under azhagiya maNavALapperumAL) he breathed his last and ascended to paramapadham. Another preceptor, Achchimagan, disciple of parASara bhattar, was lying unconsciously, in his final days. bhattar went to his house and recited in his ears “ *azhayagiyamaNavALapperumALE SaraNam* ”. On hearing this, previous memories came flooding to Achchimagan; he recited the same and ascended to paramapadham.

uruvum – it is not only the divine name, even the auspicious divine form has similar effect, says the vyAkyAthA. ALavandhAr’s son, sottai nambi, was in his last days. His disciples came to see him and asked of him “What are you constantly thinking about?” sottai nambi said “I will go to Sri vaikuNtam and have dharSan of (audience with) Sri vaikuNtanAthAn. If his divine face is not as cool as namperumAL’s, I will pierce through Sri vaikuNtam and come back running to namperumAL”. Once, parASara bhattar was near namperumAL who had mercifully come for taking *thirumanjanam* (divine bath). namperumAL asked him “What do you wish to have?” bhattar said “You should remove your divine *vasthram* (dress) and show your divine thigh”. There was belief that if one were to have *EkAnthasEvai* (having dharSan of namperumAL in private), he would ascend to paramapadham. On hearing this, namperumAL asked him “Are you worried whether you would get such a benefit?” bhattar responded saying “ *nAyanthE* (my swAmy (lord))! We are not worried about that. We are worried that we might lose your cool divine face and the beauty of the scar of *kasthUri thilakam* (divine mark applied on namperumAL) [i.e. We may not see these in paramapadham]”

uruvum – divine form.

ivai ivai enRu – saying in amazement, “This is such a decoration! This is such a divine name! This is such a beauty!”

aRamuyal – those who are constantly engaged with the path of righteousness

gyAnachchamayigal – those who constantly meditate on *dhaharavidhyA*, *chAndilyavidhyA*, *sathvidhyA* etc (these are different modes mentioned in upanishaths for meditating on sarvESvaran); due to that devotion and affection, they will focus on any one alone, such as beauty or divine name or divine auspicious form etc, not going to the others.

pEsilum – experiencing only one mode this way, and even if they narrate about it

angangellAm – among those decoration, divine name, divine form etc

uRa – what they had attained

uyar gyAnachchudar viLakkAy ninRadhanRi – they will get distinguished knowledge about that one mode alone. Apart from that . . .

perumaiyai onRum peRa muyanRARillaiyAI – they had not attempted to attain the knowledge about emperumAn’s greatness. They could not say anything in full about his greatness other than what he had manifested to them out of his mercy.

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47. pAsuram 45 – perum kEzhalAr

avathArikai (Introduction)

There is no avathArikai for this pAsuram.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*perungEzhalAr tham perum kaN malarppuNdarlgam nammEl orungE piRazha vaiththAr ivvakAlam
oruvar nam pOl varungEzhbavar uLarE thollai vAzhianjUzh piRappum marungE varappeRumE sollu
vAzhi mada nenjamE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

perum kEzhalAr – varAhapperumAL (divine wild boar) who has a huge form

tham – his

malar – blossomed

puNdarlgam – like a lotus flower

perum – expansive

kaN – divine eyes

nam mEl – upon us

orungE – completely

piRazha – to join

vaiththAr – kept

ivva kAlam – during this time

oruvar – anyone

nam pOl – like us

varum – that which happened

kEzhbavar – having the benefit

uLarE – is there?

thollai – for a very long time

Azhi – cannot be crossed like the ocean – *Am* – beautiful (being cruel)

sUzh – surrounding

piRappum – birth

marungE – nearby (with those connected to me)

varappeRumE – will it occur?

madam – being obedient

nenjamE – oh heart!

sollu – tell

vAzh – may you live long

Simple Translation

varAha perumAn (Sriman nArAyaNa who incarnated as the divine wild boar) with his huge divine form, kept his divine eyes which were like blossomed lotus flowers, completely upon me. Is there anyone else, during this time, who had got the benefit just like we had obtained? When such is the situation, could the cycle of births, which is like a huge ocean surrounding us and which cannot be crossed, come near us? Oh my mind! You please tell. May you live long.

vyAkyAnam

perum kEzhalAr – In the previous pAsuram, AzhwAr had said that we cannot attain sarvESvaran through our efforts and that he attained sarvESvaran through his mercy. Some people asked AzhwAr, who was joyous because of this “You seem happy that sarvESvaran manifested himself to us who are standing in the middle of samsAram. Would the benefit of crossing this samsAram last eternally for us?” He responds through this pAsuram saying that for those who got total mercy through him, there is no shortcoming. varAha avathAram (incarnation as divine wild boar), who protected bhUmippirAtti, the protected entity, was very huge. Just as it is mentioned in nAchchiyAr thirumozhi 11-8 “*mAsudambil nlr vArA*” he let all the dirt gather on his divine form [to appear as natural as a boar]. Just as Srl rAma said in Srl rAmAyaNam yudhdha KANdam 120-11 “*AthmAnam mAnusham manyE*” (I am rAma, the son of dhaSaratha and I am a human being), the radiance of this *varAha* was such that even the radiance of Srl vaikuntanAthan was no match for this. Just as it has been said in thiruvAimozhi 3-3-6 “*en mEL pAsam vaiththa param sudar sOdhiyai ISan vAnavarkkenban enRAI adhu thEsamO*” he manifested himself to many, including monkeys, who had not known him. When such is the case, is it apt to say that he manifested himself to those who knew him?

tham perum kaN malar – his huge form of wild boar was full of eyes. Alternatively, his form was like a huge ocean and that ocean was full of lotus flowers (his divine eyes). Srl vishNu purANam 1-4-26 says “*mahA varAha: sputapadhmalOchana :*” – he has a huge form of wild boar and has divine eyes just like blossomed lotus flowers.

tham perum kaN malar – he lifted bhUmippirAtti who was surrounded by deluge thus carrying out an apt activity for her. He looked at bhUmippirAtti with his cool eyes.

nam mEl – on us, her children.

orungE – the glance which he kept on us was not shifted to bhUmippirAtti too.

piRazha vaiththAr – he glanced towards us fully.

ivva kAlam – it was a time when trees which had shed their leaves fully, became a great foliage with fresh sprouts and flowers.

oruvar nam pOl varum kEzhbavar uLarE – Is there anyone else who has got benefitted like we had got? Since sarvESvaran is not dependent on anyone, there is no benefit for him; since mukthas and

nithyasUris are near him, there is no benefit for them too; since *bhaktas* (those who attempt to attain him through devotion) are fully focussed on *bhagavath vishayam* (matters related to bhagavAn) they also do not have this benefit; Srl rAmAyaNam sundhara kANdam 66-10 says “ *najlvEyam kshaNamapi vinAthAm asithEkshiNAM* ” (I cannot sustain myself without slthA, even for a moment). Since she had this greatness, she too did not get this benefit. The opinion here is that that there is no one else, who had got such a benefit which he had attained, standing in a lowly situation [being a samsAri].

thollai . . . – when such is the situation, will the cycle of births, which is very ancient, which has grown without any shortcoming, which is full of faults and which surrounds us wherever we go, come anyhow near those who are related to me? ALavandhAr had said in SthOthra rathnam 5 “ *madhanvayAnAm* ” (those who are related to me); AzhwAr says that no ill will befall him or those who are related to him.

sollu vAzhi mada nenjamE – Oh heart, you have been roaming around everywhere, giving your opinion on everything. Tell me on this. This AzhwAr is going to say in the 66 th pAsuram of this prabandham “ *vaigundham annAL kuzhalvAy virai poL viNdugaL vArum malaruLavO* ”. Oh heart! You are obedient to me. May you live long.

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48. pAsuram 46 – madanenjam enRum

avathArikai (Introduction)

In the previous pAsuram, AzhwAr praised his heart saying “ *vAzhi mada nenjamE* ”. His heart asked him “Why should you praise me like this? What did I do?” He replied saying “You have been here all along to explain the relationship between sarvESvaran and me. Now, you have become the target of his mercy. You have become friendly with him. Was it not because of you that I too got this fortune?” Having celebrated like this, the previous experience (between AzhwAr and sarvESvaran) became like a dream, with the experience limited to internal faculty (mind). AzhwAr desired external union and since that did not fructify, AzhwAr became upset. Looking at his distressed condition, his divine mind asked him “What should I do here?” AzhwAr told his mind “Go to the divine feet of narashimhan who tore the heart of hiraNyakasipu and inform him of my condition”. The mind too went, but did not return, which made AzhwAr to become more afflicted. While he desired to be united with *perum kEzhaI*Ar (sarvESvaran in varAhAvathAram), why is he sending his mind to narasimhAvathAram? Since both the incarnations were benevolent towards followers, he sent the messenger to the latter. In the previous pAsuram when he called his heart as *mada nenjamE* (Oh obedient heart!) it too, not refusing, became favourable towards him and agreed to carry out his task. Now he is disgusted with the same heart. Why did he praise it earlier and why is he disgusted with it now? The mind created deep desire in him for sarvESvaran and nurtured that desire to such an extent that AzhwAr could not sustain himself without uniting with him. Instead of fulfilling that task by being together with him, the heart deserted him. Hence he is disgusted with it. The mind [in all these vyAkyAnams, mind and heart are interchangeably used], apart from being the reason for creating a relationship with sarvESvaran, should also be the reason for attaining *mOksham* (uniting with sarvESvaran in paramapadham). While sarvESvaran is the reason for *mOksham*, why is AzhwAr saying that mind is the cause for *mOksham*? Just as it has been mentioned in Srl rAmAyaNam kishkindhA kANDam 1-127 “ *raraksha dharmENa balEna cha* ” ((lakshmaNa vigilantly protected (Srl rAma) (with an undespaired mind and) even by his virtue and strength), AzhwAr’s mind should have stayed with him until he attained sarvESvaran and told him “Whatever troubles you have had, I too had experienced with you”. While the words of those who say that only sarvESvaran is the means [for attaining him] are uttered after discriminating between what is apt and what is inapt, there are certain requirements from the chEthana (sentient entity) too who wishes to attain *mOksham*. First he should exist. Even if he exists, he should engage with the means; he should know the *purushArtham* (end-goal or benefit) which is apt for him and a heart which helps to develop *ruchi* (interest / taste) in that benefit. Moreover, he should shun the other means, carrying out activities which alone will be apt for sarvESvaran. When sarvESvaran himself is the means and readily available, the reason for the chEthana to continue in samsAram is because the requirements mentioned above have not developed in him. Thus, when the heart should have stayed with him until he attained his end-goal, since it did not do, he is upset with his heart.

Let us go through the pAsiuram and its meanings

madanenjam enRum thamadhenRum Or karumam karudhi vida nenjai uRRAr vidavO amaiyum appon peyarOn thadanenjam kINda pirAnAr thamadhikkIzh vidappOyth thida nenjamAy emmai nIththu inRu thARum thiriginRadhE

Word-by-Word Meanings

appon peyarOn – that hiraNyakaSipu’s

thadam – broad

nenjam – chest

kINda – tore

pirAnAr thamadhu – benefactor, sarvESvaran's

adikkIzh – under the divine feet as objective

vida – on sending (the mind)

pOy – going (there)

thidam – firmly

nenjamAy – having deep belief

emmai – us

nIththu – leaving

inRu thArum – till date

thiriginRadhu – is roaming

(Hence)

nenjam – mind

madam enRum – saying that it is obedient (to us)

thamadhu enRum – saying that it is our limb

Or karumam – an activity

karudhi – thinking (of doing)

nenjai – mind

vida – to send (on an errand)\

uRRAr – those who had planned

vida – to drop (that activity)

amaiyum – will be apt

Simple Translation

I sent my mind with the intention of taking refuge under the divine feet of narasimhan, who had torn the broad chest of hiraNyakaSipu. My mind which went like this, instead of returning to me, stayed firmly there itself, considering those divine feet as an apt place for itself. Those who think that our mind is obedient to us and is ours, and who are planning to send it on an errand, would do well to drop that firmness.

vyAkyAnam

mada nenjam enRum thamadhenRum – there is a wrong impression among many that their minds are obedient to them. The mind has been provided by sarvESvaran as an aid along with the physical form to enable the chEthana (sentient entity) to reach his end-goal. Hence they may consider the mind as theirs. Moreover, apart from the physical form and the five senses, sarvESvaran had provided the heart to propel the chEthana towards the end-goal and to create an interest in it. This being the case, there is no fault in thinking that the heart is one’s own. If one were obedient to another and the other person becomes distressed, the obedient entity should stand by that person and tell him “I am also suffering the same difficulties which you suffered”. Also, one who is a *SEshan* (carrying out servitude) should reveal his master’s fame and good qualities. However, AzhwAr says that the heart does not have these qualities.

Or karumam . . . – some people may be bold enough to send their hearts on errands. If their hearts leave them without carrying out that errand, it is better not to feel sorrowful about it. It is better not to have an attachment to that errand.

If this is the case, let the heart remain like that. Why search for it? . . .

appon peyarOn . . . – being under his control and being his slave, isn’t this the target for that mind to be engaged in?

appon peyarOn thadanenjam kINda pirAnAr thamadhu adikklzh vida – did I leave it in a place where I cannot be successful? Did I not leave it where the one who does benefits for us, is present? AzhwAr feels that the benefit which sarvESvaran did for his follower [prahlAdhan] is as good as having done for him.

appon peyarOn – prahlAdhan, who was sired by hiraNyakaSipu, recited the divine names of sarvESvaran. Getting angry with him because of this, hiraNyan meted out punishments to his son, which he would mete out to his enemies. Thinking of those cruelties AzhwAr is referring to him as *pon peyarOn* .

Here, the vyAkyAthA explains a few lines from periyA thirumozhi pAsuram 2-3-8 *paLLiyil Odhi vandha siRuvan*

paLLiyil Odhivandha – whatever the children recite, which they had learnt from their school, is always joyous.

than siRuvan – it would be joyous even if other children recite it. But if it is by one’s own child, it is more delightful.

vAyil Or Ayira nAmam oLLiyavAgippOdha – the words recited by prahlAdhan were such that even if they had been recited by an enemy, one would have fallen at the enemy’s feet!

onRum Or poRuppilanAgi – hiraNyakaSipu had carried out *asahyApachAram* (irreverence, being unable to bear) in the case of prahlAdhan. While he was related to prahlAdhan, being his father, not respecting that, he did to prahlAdhan what enemies would do.

piLLaiyaichchIRi – he gave up prahlAdhan saying “He is not my son” just because prahlAdhan recited the divine names of sarvESvaran.

AzhwAr is mentioning a connection that he has with him.

thada nenjam – the huge chest [of hiraNyakaSipu] which had grown to become a prey for sarvESvaran’s divine nails and divine teeth.

kinDa – even when narasimhap perumAn had not torn it, the physical form of hiraNyakaSipu started melting on merely looking at that divine form and fury. Without any difficulty, narasimhap perumAn tore that chest.

pirAnAr – would narasimhap perumAn, who came running when prahlAdhan’s father himself turned inimical, be able to tolerate should AzhwAr send a messenger due to his distressed condition in separation? While he had helped for prahlAdhan’s clarity of mind, he would indeed help for AzhwAr’s distressed condition. Not only because prahlAdhan had deep devotion, as mentioned in Srl vishNu purANam 1-19-88 ” *maththassarvam ahamsarvam* ” (Everything is mine (being a form of bhagavAn), I am everything (having bhagavAn as antharyAmi)), he has devotion with clarity.

thamadhadikkIzh vida – leaving his heart under such narasimha perumAn’s divine feet.

pOy thida nenjamAy – his heart, while going to sarvESvaran as AzhwAr’s messenger had thought “AzhwAr is in tears. Will he sustain himself until I return?” But once it reached there, it seemed to have taken his [sarvESvaran’s] nature. When slthAppirAtti separated from Srl rAma for the second time (due to the disparaging words of a washerman), did he not sustain himself for long? Probably, the heart too took to this nature.

emmai nlththu – leaving me aside, completely.

inRu . . . – let us at the least hear that the heart felt bad saying “Now that I have left him, to whom will he cry about his distress in separation? How bad that we have left him like this?” The heart was roaming around, like this.

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49. pAsuram 47 – thiriginRadhu

avathArikai (Introduction)

The *nAyaki*'s mother, looking at the distress of her daughter in separation (from the *nAyakan*) after being united with him, wonders as to what will happen to her, considering the greatness of various things which torment her as well as considering her softness.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*thiriginRadhu vadamArudham thingaLvendhImugandhu soriginRadhu adhuvumadhu kaNNan viNNUr
thozhavE sariginRadhu sangam thaNNandhuyAkku vaNNam payalai viriginRadhu muzhu meyyum
ennAngol en melliyaRkE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

vadamArudham – northerly wind

thiriginRadhu – is blowing

thingaL – moon

vem – cruel

thI – fire

mugandhu – scooping a lot

soriginRadhu – is showering

adhuvum – similarly, other harmful entities such as the evil cuckoo

adhu – started harming like that moon.

kaNNan – krishNa's

viN – in paramapadham

Ur – SrlvaikuNtam, his dwelling place

thozha – to attain (thinking of worshipping)

sangam – bangle

sariginRadhu – is slipping

thaN – cool

am – beautiful

thuzhAykku – in the divine *thuLasi* (due to desire)

vaNNam – natural colour

payalai – becoming pale

muzhu meyyum – throughout the physical form

viriginRadhu – pervaded

en melliyaRku – for my soft-natured daughter

en Angol – will anything harmful happen (later)?

Simple Translation

The northerly wind is blowing everywhere. Moon is showering cruel fire. Other entities such as the evil cuckoo etc are also raining fire, just like the moon. Since my daughter is thinking of continuously enjoying SrlvaikuNtam, the dwelling place of krishNa, her bangle is slipping out of her hands since her desire is not getting fulfilled. Due to her desire for his cool, beautiful divine thuLasi garland, her natural complexion is fading and she is becoming pale. Where will all these end for my daughter?

vyAkyAnam

thiriginRadhu vada mArudham – Just like an elephant in rut would size up a man and roam around, the northerly wind was roaming here and there. Waiting for the moment when the *nAyakan*’s glance would move away from her face, it wanted to harm her and was roaming around. Another interpretation – normally, northerly breeze would be cool. But it changed its nature and blew hot.

thingal . . . – moon saw the change in the nature of northerly breeze and thought “Why am I not doing anything?” Immediately, he too showered fire, on his part.

vem thl – fire and breeze joined together. The northerly breeze was like boiling water [bringing in another aspect of heat] instead of like fire.

mugandhu soriginRadhu – both of them burnt the *nAyaki* without any shortcoming in the heat.

adhuvum adhu – just like northerly wind and moon, there are other entities too which harm those who are in separation – the sound of ocean, the Indian love bird (*anRil*), breeze, sound from the bell around the bull’s neck etc. Since the harm created by these entities could not be described in words, she (*nAyaki*’s mother) is saying “ *adhuvum* ”. Alternatively, if we consider the meaning for *thiriginRadhu* as roaming, *adhuvum adhu* would mean that the breeze too showered fire just like the moon.

kaNNan . . . – Is it necessary to say that there are some others too who are responsible for her position [such as moon, wind etc]? If someone becomes distressed and the bangles slip out, sarvESvaran would incarnate himself and be easily approachable. She (the *nAyaki*) wishes to see him in his permanent residence of Srl vaikuNtam. Due to despondence, she started slimming and her bangles slipped out of her hands.

kaNNan viNNUr – Is it not sufficient to say *SrlvaikuNtam* ? Why call it as krishNa’s *SrivaikuNtam* ? In Srl rAmAyaNam sundhara kANdam 33-17 it says “ *rAghavasya nivESanE* ” Srl rAma’s palace, to refer to the palace. This is similar to that [to give emphasis].

thaNNandhuzhAy . . . – Srl rAmAyaNam ayOdhyA kANdam 16-21 *pathisammAnithA* – sithA who was respected by her husband – thinking of that event when slthAppirAtti received the garland from Srl rAma and donned it on her shoulders, the *nAyika*’s physical form becomes pale.

vaNNam . . . – her natural complexion became pale and spread throughout her form.

ennAngol – the *nAyikA*’s mother wonders “if even the northerly breeze could turn her complexion into a pale colour, if these things too happen (entire body becoming pale, bangles slipping out etc) what will happen to her?”

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): AzhwAr sings through the pAsuram of those who were nearby, and who felt, on seeing his natural softness and distressed condition as well as the entity that he desired is confidential “Would we lose him forever?” seeing his condition in separation.

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50. pAsuram 48 – melliya! Akkai

avathArikai (Introduction)

AzhwaR felt as if he was deprived of strength, wondering as to why he was being kept in samsAram. sarvESvaran thought in his divine mind “He feels that he is on fire while in samsAram because he feels that he is staying there for himself. If I tell him ‘You are here for my sake’ he will be able to sustain. Moreover, that is also the nature that he wishes to attain”. He told AzhwaR “AzhwaR! Do not feel anguished. There is no connection for you with this samsAram; you are not living here for your sake; it is only for my sake. We want to bring out a few pAsurams (hymns) through you, which will appeal to me as well as to those who are with me. We wanted to bring out our qualities such as simplicity etc through those pAsurams. Is it not for this that we kept you here?” On hearing this, AzhwaR thought “Then there is no hurdle. If it is going to be aligned to my true nature and it is the one which I am going to attain, there is no issue at all”. He is amazed that sarvESvaran is accomplishing this task through him and speaks about sarvESvaran’s quality of considering him as an object worthy of attention.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

melliya! Akkakaikkirumi kuruvil miLirdhandhAngE selliya selgaiththu ulagai enkaNum ennAlum thannaich cholliya sUzhal thirumAlavan kavi yAdhu kaRREn palliyin sollum sollAk koLvadhu uNdO paNdu paNdE

Word-by-Word Meanings

melliya! – being soft

Akkai – having a form

kuruvil – in a wound (i.e. in samsAram)

miLirdhandhu – being born

AngE – in that place

selliya – what is to happen

selgaiththu – having that activity

kirumi – a worm

ulagai – matters relating to the world

en kaNum – what will it know?

ennAlum – through me, who has no intelligence

thannai – about him who is unlimited

solliya – explaining

sUzhal – amazing entity

thirumAlavan – matter concerning Sriya:pathi (consort of SriMahAlakshmi)

kavi – sthOthrams (verses of praise)

Adhu – all of them

kaRREn – I learnt (from him)

paNdu paNdu – from time immemorial

palliyin – lizard's

sollum – whatever it says

sollAk koLvadhu – recognising as true (whether it is favourable or unfavourable)

uNdu – has been in vogue

Simple Translation

A worm, which has a soft form, is born in this samsAram which is like a wound. What will the worm, which keeps getting tossed about inside that wound, know about the world? sarvESvaran, who has unlimited greatness, who is an amazing entity and who is the consort of Srl mahAlakshmi, made me, who has no capability in anything, to speak about his qualities. I learnt from him all those words of praise [about him]. Is it not in vogue from time immemorial to consider the sounds of a lizard as subtly hinting about the future?

vyAkyAnam

melliyaL Akkaik kirumi – There is nothing among his svarUpam (true nature), *rUpam* (divine form), *guNam* (auspicious qualities), *aiSvaryaM* (wealth) etc which is known to me. He decided to carry out the task of explaining about him through me who knows nothing about him.

melliyaL Akkaik kirumi – worm with a very soft nature of physical form. It is so soft that if the air which gets expelled when the eyelids close, blows on it, it will perish. It is so lowly that it cannot even be considered as a creature.

kuruvil miLirndhandhu – being born in a wound called *kranthippuN*. Why did the AzhwAr say *miLirndhu* and not *piRandhu* (another word for being born)? The worm has only birth and death, with nothing called as 'life' in between the two. Hence he called it as *miLirndhu*. It could be called as *piRandhu* only if it takes a body and reaches an end goal, as described in *panchAgni vidhya* (a set of five activities which describes the journey of a soul through five different stages in its repeated cycle of births and deaths).

AngE – in that wound

selliya selgaitththu – involved in some activity. Apart from being born and living, other activities such as being looked at with detestation by the others and death also take place in that wound itself. It thinks that it is becoming beautiful, over a period of time. It knows nothing other than the wound, just like some people will ask "Which is the tree where paddy grows?"

ualagai en kANum – what will that worm know of the world when its existence is as described above? AzhwAr says that this is his status too.

ennAlum – through me, who is the boundary for ignorance, incapability etc

thannai – did he want to convey one of his activities through me who is in the state of that worm? When *Sruthi* and *smruthi* (sacred texts and their explanatory works respectively) returned empty-

handed, after trying to measure just one quality of his, bliss, as mentioned in thaiththirly upanishath, he wanted to convey through me about him.

solliya – sarvEsvaran had intended to explain through AzhwAr. Before he could even guess if it is possible through him, he told AzhwAr about himself. What is the reason for this?

sUzhal – because he is the one with amazing activities.

thirumAL – since he is the consort of Srl mahAlakshmi, he told AzhwAr alone about about his activities and not to all.

thirumAlavan kavi – it is to compose poems on the togetherness of sarvESvaran and periyA pirAtti. This mentions the distinction with Srl rAmAyaNam. While Srl rAmAyaNam started by saying *slthAyAS charitham mahath* – great narrative about slthAppirAtti, when it was sung, he alone heard it, without her presence. It is not like that here; both of them were together.

Adhu kaRREn – it could be *yAdhu kaRREn* or *Adhu kaRREn* ; if it is *yAdhu kaRREn* , it would imply that whatever he [AzhwAr] had learnt, it was his [sarvESvaran's] hymns. If it is *Adhu karREn* , it would imply that he had learnt every hymn about *thirumAl* .

kaRREn – just as it has been mentioned in thiruvAimozhi 7-9-2 “ *en mun sollum* ” (recite in front of me), sarvESvaran started reciting the *santhai*, I continued after him (*santhai* is a method of learning in which the teacher recites a verse once and the disciple repeats twice, after the teacher). How was this completed? He responds saying . . .

palliyin sollum . . . – when a person with very little knowledge starts saying something, one with deep knowledge would correct it and complete it. Lizard would make some sounds such as *nathu nathu* which would be meaningless. However, learned people would make use of that sound for their favourable / unfavourable events. Similarly, I had said some gibberish which came to me at various points of time and he corrected them as if to refer to his auspicious qualities and accepted them.

paNdu paNde – from time immemorial, we have seen respect for lizard's sounds like this. sarvESvaran made that to be seen in AzhwAr's matter, by all.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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51. pAsuram 49 – paNdum palapala

avathArikai (Introduction)

Earlier, AzhwAr was wondering whether sarvESvaran had not blessed him in a distinguished way. In the previous pAsuram, he realised that he has been showered with distinguished mercy by sarvESvaran. He now wonders “Though he has showered his mercy, why is he still keeping me in samsAram which is a hurdle for enjoying him continuously?” Due to this distress of separation from sarvESvaran, he assumes the mood of pirAtti (consort of sarvESvaran). After being united with sarvESvaran and having separated from him, the *nAyaki*, unable to tolerate this distress, tells how she is suffering in the night time. Or, these words could be taken to have been spoken by her friend.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

paNdum palapala vIngiruL kANdum ippAyiruL pOl kaNdum aRivadhum kEtpadhum yAmilam kALavaNNa vaNdundhuzhAyp perumAn madhusUdhanan dhAmOdharan uNdum umizhndhum kadAya maNNEranna oNNudhaLE

Word-by-Word Meanings

kALam – dark

vaNNam – having colour

vaNdu – beetles

uN – drinking (honey)

thuzhAy – having divine *thuLasi*

perumAn – being a benefactor

madhusUdhanan – having annihilated the demon, *madhu dhAmOdharan* – sarvESvaran who has the (scar of) the rope tied around his stomach (by yaSOdhA pirAtti)

uNdum – swallowed (during deluge)

umizhndhum – spat out (during creation)

kadAya – carried out (protected)

maN – bhUmi (earth)’s

nEr – for the beauty

anna – matching

oN – beautiful

nudhaLE – Oh one who has forehead!

paNdum – earlier too

pala pala – different types

vIngu – growing

iruL – darkness

kANdum – we have seen

i – this

pAy – spreading

iruL pOI – like darkness

yAm – we

kaNdum – seen

aRindhum ilam – have not known

kEtpadhum ilam – have not heard of

Simple Translation

sarvESvaran has the divine thuLasi garland from which dark coloured beetles are drinking honey; he killed the demon madhu and has the [scar of the] rope with which yaSOdhAppirAtti had tied him [when he stole butter during his incarnation as krishNa] on his divine stomach. Oh one who has a beautiful forehead which is as beautiful as the earth which that sarvESvaran swallowed during deluge, spat out during creation and protected! We have seen different types of nights in the past. However, have we seen or heard of or known a night which has spread out as much as this?

vyAkyAnam

paNdum palapala vIngiruL kANdum – In earlier times too, she has spent several nights in distress due to separation from him. AzhwAr says that just as sage mArkaNdEya has seen several deluges, he too has suffered in distress over several nights in the past.

vIngiruL kANdum – we have seen several nights which had extended over a long time.

ippAyiruL . . . – However, we have not seen a night which extended for such a long time as this night. We do not see a place where we can rest in this night as it has pervaded everywhere, just like deluge. We have not heard that even the daughter of janaka maharAjar (slthAppirAtti), who had also suffered in separation like us, would have suffered during a night like this. AzhwAr says that he had in the past, as a samsAri, seen and suffered for many nights. Even after attaining knowledge granted by sarvESvaran with causeless mercy, he had suffered for many nights. However, after being showered with distinguished mercy by sarvESvaran, he has not suffered like this ever.

kALa vaNNan – The entity which caused harm for us through this dark coloured night is one which has a dark complexion. Just as it is said in periya thiruvandhAdhi 26 “ *iruLanna mAmeni* ” (huge form which is dark), did he not manifest his dark form to make me like this? This darkness, which is similar to the dark night when he, with a form which is as dark as this, had come in happier times and embraced me, is the reason for my sorrow.

vaNduN thuzhAy – he explains the beauty of the divine form which came through decorations.

madhusUdhanan – he is the one who removes hurdles which come about due to enjoying such beauty, just like he removed the demon *madhu* .

dhAmOdharan – he is obedient towards those who are happy on seeing him, such that they could even tie him down to a mortar.

uNdum . . . – engaging in activities such as swallowing, spitting etc

maNNEranna – when it is considered that she is an entity to be protected by him, she is like bhUmi (earth). If this pAsuram is considered to have been recited by the *nAyaki* , the meaning will be – just like bhUmippirAtti was protected by you from being annihilated during deluge, if I have to exist after being caught by this dark night, it will be with your assistance only; if it is to be considered as having been recited by the *nAyaki*’s friend, the meaning will be – you should understand that he is not one who will see his wealth being destroyed; he is one who will look at with consideration. Just as he had protected bhUmippirAtti from deluge, he will not leave until he protects you too from the sadness of this night.

oNNudhalE – I had cited an example (bhUmi) only to illustrate that you are his wealth. However, will that bhUmi match you? Don’t you alone have the beauty of form which will attract him?

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52. pAsuram 50 – oNNudhal mAmai

avathArikai (Introduction)

In the previous pAsuram, he had mentioned about how he had not seen a long night and suffered distress like this. Just as it is said in bhagavath glthA 10-9 “*bodhayantha: parasparam*” (enlightening one another), the *nAyakan* comes to console her. The distance which Srl rAma had covered only by walking for fourteen years, was covered by him in one afternoon time when he realised the agitation that bharathAzhwAn had. In the same way, the *nAyakan* is coming with a great urge. He tells the charioteer certain words then.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*oNNudhal mAmai oLi payavAmai viraindhu nam thEr naNNudhal vENDum valava kadAginRu thEn
navinRa viNmudhal nAyagan nINmudi veN muththa vAsigaiththAy maNmudhal sErvuRRu aruvi seyyA
niRkum mAmaLaikkE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

valava – Oh charioteer, who is strong!

oN – beautiful

nudhal – *nAyaki* who has a forehead, her

mAmai – complexion’s

oLi – radiance

payavAmai – before it gets discoloured

thEn – like honey

navinRa – referred to as

viN mudhal – for vibhUthis such as paramapadham

nAyakan – one who is the lord, his

nIL – long

mudi – on top of the crown

veN – white

muththam – pearls’

vAsigaiththAy – arrangement

maN mudhal – earth which is primary (for him)

sErvuRRu – to reach

aruvi – having rivers

seyyA niRkum – flowing in abundance

mA – huge

malaikku – for the thirumalai hill

viraindhu – quickly

nam thEr – our chariot

kadAginRu – conducting

naNNudhal vENDum – we should reach

Simple Translation

The *nAyakan* tells his charioteer “Oh charioteer who is strong! Before the complexion of *nAyaki*, who has a beautiful forehead, changes colour, drive the chariot fast [to her place]. We should go fast towards thirumalai hills which have the character of the whitish pearls which are present on the long crown of the lord of paramapadham and which have rivers which start from the peak and flow abundantly towards earth”

vyAkyAnam

oNNudhal mAmai oLi payavAmai – the beautiful complexion of *nAyaki* who has a beautifully radiant forehead. Radiance is the brightness in the complexion. Before that radiance becomes dull ...

oNNudhal mAmai – the *nAyakan* and the *nAyaki* are like *Sri rAma* and *slthAppirAtti* who had separated from each other for ten months. During the period of separation, the *nAyakan* was thinking about *nAyaki*'s beauty and sustained himself. As an example of such behaviour, the *vyAkyAthA* cites the words of *Sri rAma* in *Sri rAmAyaNam chandhrakAnthAnanAm subrUma* – ability to attract like the moon. The *nAyakan* thought that he cannot be patient should he lose that beauty and that he could not retrieve the radiance of that beauty should it become dim.

viraindhu nandhEr naNNudhal vENDum – our chariot should reach her fast. Help me in reaching her fast so that she doesn't blame me in case she loses her complexion.

valava – the activity of the charioteer is similar to that of the charioteer in *mahAbhAratha* war.

kadAkinRu naNNudhal vENDum – our chariot should reach her with your ability to conduct the chariot.

thEn navinRa . . . – the *nAyakan* tells the charioteer that the place where they are going to would be beneficial for the charioteer too; that place, thirumalai, will be like that. The verse could be read as either *thEn navinRa mAmaLaikkE* or *thEn navinRa viNmudhal nAyakan*. In the former case, the word *thEn* would refer to beetles and *navinRa* would refer to the humming sound made by them. In other words, the beetles are singing in thirumalai after drinking honey from the flowers there. In the latter case, just as it has been mentioned in *Sri vishNu sUktham vishNOOr padhE paramE madhva uthsa* : (honey is flowing from the divine feet of *sarvESvaran*), it is the *viNmudhal nAyakan* who has been referred to as shedding honey.

viNmudhal nAyakan – he is the lord of paramapadham which is referred to as *viN*. Alternatively, he is the lord of all *vibhUthis* including *viN* (paramapadham).

nINmudi . . . – you would see that the place (thirumalai) is such that it would remove all the difficulties suffered during the time of separation. *SriIvaikuNtanAthana* has a long crown; the crown has white

pearls; thirumalai has the quality of those pearls. SrlvaikuNtam could be considered as a simile for the greatness of thirumalai. Compared to this place (thirumalai) which could be seen by the eyes, SrlvaikuNtam is a step lower. Since the greatness of thirumalai could be experienced through the eyes, its true nature will be clear to the eyes. Even though authentic texts confirm that such greatness is there in SrlvaikuNtam too, one could only hold a strong belief that the feature exists; only this [thirumalai] could be experienced through the eyes.

maNmudhal sErvuRRu – approaching down to the earth

aruvi seyyA niRkum malaikke – all our difficulties will be removed once we reach there. nAchchiAr thirumozhi 8-3 says *kuLir aruvi vEngadam* – thiruvEngadam (thirumalai) which is with cool streams.

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): looking at the anguish of AzhwAr in separation, the followers of sarvESvaran come quickly to console him. Just as pirAtti (Srl mahAlakshmi) forgot all about mithilA after attaining SrlnivAsan who is standing amidst cool streams, AzhwAr also forgot about [AzhwAr]thirunagari and the followers are rushing to see him in this state.

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53. pAsuram 51 – malai koNdu

avathArikai (Introduction)

Before the *nAyakan* could reach her, the *nAyaki* heard the noise from ocean and reveals how it distressed her. Srl rAma wanted to cover the distance, which he had travelled over fourteen years by foot, within an afternoon. Knowing that bharthAzhwAn would not be able to tolerate even that, he sent hanuman as his messenger to tell bharathan that he was on his way. Until someone is sent as a messenger to her, all the things which she sees appear to cause her harm. Srl rAma tells hanuman as in SrlrAmAyaNam yudhdha kANdam SIOkam 125-17 “*sangathyA bharatha : SrlmAn rAgyEnArthi svayam bhavEth l praSAsthum vasudhAm sarvAmakhilAm raghunandhana : ll*” (bharathAan who is full of the wealth of servitude and devotion, could continue to rule over ayOdhyA should he wish to do so, since he has been ruling it for many years). There are two interpretations for this SIOkam – some learned people, looking at it superficially, would say that since bharathan has been ruling for a long time, he would have developed a desire and a hold on the kingdom. Thus, if bharathan wishes to continue to rule over the kingdom, Srl rAma would not wish to go to ayOdhyA and would rather stay at sage bharathwAja’s ASram (hermitage) itself. Since he thought this way, he sent hanuman ahead of him on an errand. Our pUrvAchAryas (preceptors) considered that this opinion did not gel with Srl rAma’s greatness. The correct meaning of this SIOkam, in our pUrvAchAryas’ opinion, is this [given as the reasoning of Srl rAma]: as per dhaSarathan’s order and due to the boon which kaikEyi had obtained, we had given the kingdom to bharathan. bharathan followed us to the forest and said “Oh rAma! If you delay returning to ayOdhyA even by a day, I will not be able to sustain my life”. We are now returning after fourteen years. When he is in a state of bliss upon seeing us, we will tell him “You get ready for the coronation”. In the supreme happiness of seeing us, due to bewilderment, he would accept it instead of saying “I will not”. dhaSarathan wanted to see us being coronated. But he could not live to see that. To reverse that, we will be ecstatic to see our child bharathan being coronated. Hence you go ahead, he told hanuman and sent him.

What is the reason for some learned people interpreting in one way and our pUrvAchAryas interpreting in the other? This is explained through Srl rAmAyaNam ayOdhyA kANdam SIOkam 19-31 “*shanair jagAma sApEksha :*” (Srl rAma, before leaving for the forest, circumambulated all the materials which had been kept for his coronation, saw them respectfully ...) In this SIOkam, those learned people saw the word *sApEksha* : as *sAvEksha* : which means glancing from the corner of the eye. The meaning for this would then be that Srl rAma had a desire in being the King and made it known in his eyes. On hearing this, parASara bhattar said “It is not to be considered that way. It should be considered as Srl rAma looking at them with despondence since he would not be present to see bharatha’s coronation”,

Before such sarvESvaran could reach the place where the *nAyaki* was present, the ocean troubled her.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

malai koNdu maththA aravAl suzhaRRiya mAyappirAn alai kaNdu koNda amudham koLLAdhu kadal baradhar vilai koNdu thandha sangam ivai vEriththuzhAyththuNaiyAth thulai koNdu thAyam kiLarndhu koLvAn oththu azhaikkinRadhE

Word-by-Word Meanings

kadal – ocean

malai – manthara hill

maththA – as the churning shaft

koNdu – making it

aravAI – through vAsuki, the snake

suzhaRRiya – one who churned

mAyam – one with amazing activity

pirAn – sarvESvaran, the benefactor

alai kaNdu – making the waves to rise up

koNda – taken (from the ocean)

amudham – nectar

koLLadhu – without accepting

baradhar – pearl traders

vilai koNdu – taking money

thandha – offered

ivai sangam – these bangles

vEri – fragrant

thuzhAy – divine thuLasi

thuNaiyA – as support

thulai koNdu – searching a way for destroying

thAyam – share of relatives

koLvAn oththu – as if taking

kiLarndhu – agitatingly

azhaikkinRadhu – makes a noise

Simple Translation

sarvESvaran had done great benefits such as keeping the manthara mountain as the churning shaft, the snake vAsuki as the churning rope and churned the ocean to obtain nectar. The ocean did not accept that nectar which was taken from it in such a way that its waves rose up. Traders in pearl had taken payment from me (*nAyaki*) and given me bangles. The ocean, with the support of divine thuLasi garland, with the thought of destroying me, is making huge noise in order to take these bangles from me, just like relatives would partake of their share in a property.

vyAkyAnam

malai koNdu maththA – sarvESvaran made the immovable mountain to move.

aravAI – he took the snake vAsuki, who has a gentle form, as the churning rope.

suzhaRRiya – the cleverness with which he used these. These entities (mountain and snake) kept churning on their own until nectar came out. This is similar to a potter rotating his wheel once, after which it keeps rotating on its own with that momentum. Since it is sarvESvaran himself who rotated the mountain once, it kept rotating until the work was completed. Thus all the active and inactive states of all entities are under his control.

mAyappirAn – he has amazing activities. periya thirumozhi 5-7-4 “ *mAyirungunRam* ” – keeping the manthara mountain which was broad and tall, as the churning staff, keeping the snake vAsuki as the churning rope, he churned the ocean such that it made a noise like the trumpeting of an elephant and its waves rose to hide the sky. He churned in such a way that the garlands and the dress which he wore kept swinging from one side to the other.

pirAn – he benefited me by manifesting the beauty of his divine form to me. He is AzhwaR’s nectar.

alai kaNdu . . . – he churned the ocean in such a way that the sand at the bottom rose to the top and the sand at the top sank to the bottom, by planting the mountain manthara at the centre of the ocean’s heart like a mammoth pestle. He took away the nectar from the ocean. The ocean did not have the courage to go to him to retrieve its nectar from him. Just as it has been mentioned in nAchchiyAr thirumozhi 10-9 “ *kadale kadale unnaik kadaindu kalakkuRuththu..* ” the ocean did not go to him to trouble him; instead it is creating distress for me. In this world, it has become natural for strong people to show their strength towards the weak ones.

baradhar – the ocean is attempting to take the bangles which I had bought from the pearl traders after payment of money. Did we go near the ocean on our own?

vErith thuzhAy thuNaiyA – it is torturing me by keeping the fragrant divine thuLasi, which it received from sarvESvaran, as a support. Just as sugrIva took Srl rAmA’s support and challenged vAli, the ocean took divine thuLasi’s support to torture me. Srl rAmAyaNam kishkindhA kANdam SLOkam “ *thath garjath harivara: sugrIvO hEmapingala: thEna nAthEna mahathA nirjagAma haRiSvara: anumAnyA thathA dhArAm sugrIvEna samAgatha:* ” (sugrIva, who was with a reddish yellow hue, similar to gold, stood near the entrance to vAli’s cave and roared. When his wife thAra tried to prevent him from going, vAli comforted her and came out). *mahathA* – sugrIva displayed his valour; *nirjagAma* – he came out of his cave; *anumAnyA* – vAli told thAra who tried to dissuade him from going out to fight with sugrIva “Will you not unite with a person like me only if I win over him?” As an example of this, the vyAkyAthA cites Srl rAmAyaNam 30-39 “ *tham dhrushtvA Sathru hanthAram maharshINAm sukhAvaham | babhUva hrushtA vaidhEhibharthAram parishasvajE | |* ” (becoming happy after seeing Srl rAmA annihilating the enemies of the rishis, sIthAppirAtti embraced him well).

thulai koNdu – to destroy her, ocean took the support of divine thuLasi.

thAyam . . . – even after a land had got changed hands four or five times, the relatives of the original owner of the property would stake their claim on that land. In the same way, the ocean, on seeing the bangles on nAyaki’s hands, claimed that these bangles came from it (from conches which are in the ocean), and is trying to take them away.

azhaikkinRadhE – it is calling like a waylaying robber. When the omnipotent entity immersed a huge pestle inside it, churned it with the power of his shoulders and took away nectar from it, this ocean did not have the capability to challenge him and retrieve that nectar. Since I am a helpless lady, it is trying

to harm me. The vyAkyAtha cites an example of how the sounds made by the ocean troubled the *nAyaki*, from a SLOkam in Srl rAmAyaNam kishkindhA kANDam “ *nisvanam chakravAkAnAm niSamya sahachArinAm puNdarIka visAIkshI kathamEshA bhavishyathi* ” (on merely hearing the noise made by chakravAka birds when they fly, slthAppirAtti will be joyous; what sort of difficulty is she in, who has eyes like lotus flower?) Just as the noise made by the birds brought memories of slthAppirAtti to Srl rAma and troubled him, the sound made by the ocean troubled the *nAyaki*.

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54. pAsuram 52 – azhaikkum karum

avathArikai (Introduction)

This is in the classification of *kAla mayakkuth* thuRai (similar to pAsurams 7 and 18) which occurs due to bewilderment regarding time. *nAyakan* who had promised to return by monsoon time, is delaying his return. With the monsoon having arrived, *nAyaki* is in distress since he has not returned yet. Her friend tells her “This is not rainy season. What you are seeing now is not rain, but the tears of bhUmippirAtti (bhUdhEvi)”, thus bewildering the *nAyaki* into thinking that it is not rainy season.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

azhaikkum karum kadal veN thiraikke koNdu pOy alarvAy mazhaikkaN madandhai aravaNai ERa maN mAdhar viN vAy azhaiththup pulambi mulai malai mEl ninRum ARugaLAy mazhaik kaNNa nlr thirumAl kodiyan enRu vArginRadhE

Word-by-Word Meanings

alarvAy – having been born in a lotus flower

mazhaikkaN – having a cool glance, just like rain [in terms of coolness]

madandhai – periyā pirAtti [Sri mahAlakshmi]

azhaikkum – calling out loudly

karu – bluish coloured

kadal – in the ocean

veN – whitish

thiraikke – through the waves

koNdu pOy – inviting (the *nAyakan*)

aravaNai – on the mattress of thiruvananthAzhwAn (AdhiSEshan)

ERa – on climbing

maNmAdhar – bhUmippirAtti

thirumAl – Sriya: pathi (consort of Sri mahAlakshmi)

kodiyan – cruel entity

enRu – saying so

viN vAy – through the mouth of sky

azhaiththu – loudly calling

pulambi – wailing

malai – mountains

mulai mEl ninRum – standing atop the bosoms

mazhaik kaNNIr – tears like rainfall

ARugaLAy – like rivers

vArginRadhu – created copiously

Simple Translation

The bluish ocean invited periya pirAtti who was born in a lotus flower and who has a glance, as cool as the rain. Taking hold of the whitish waves of that ocean, periya pirAtti, along with her lord, sarvESvaran, started mercifully to ascend the mattress of AdhiSEshan. At that time, bhUmippirAtti, standing atop the mountains which are like her bosoms, calling out loudly from the sky, started wailing saying “The consort of Srl mahAlakshmi is a cruel entity” and started letting down her tears of rainfall copiously, like rivers.

vyAkyAnam

azhaikkum karum kadal – in line with the saying “*apAm api Suklam*” – the colour of water is white. However, when it is in abundance, it would appear to be dark. With the bottom portion of the ocean appearing dark and the top portion appearing white (because of the white coloured waves), it appeared like a place made with bluish gems having whitish steps. When Srl rAma was on the mAlyavAn mountain along with lakshmaNa, he told lakshmaNa looking at the clouds, as in Srl rAmAyaNam kishkindhA kANDam 28-4 “*Sakyam ambaram Aruhya mEgha sOpAna pankthibhi : | kutaja arjuna mAlAbhir alankarthum dhivAkara : |*” (it appears that it is possible to decorate the supreme entity, who is at the centre of sUryamaNdala, through the steps of clouds, with wild jasmine and other flowers). He said that there is a deficiency in this. While garlanding the supreme entity, it is necessary to go with one’s wife, just as it is mentioned in Sri rAmAyaNam ayOdhyA kANDam 6-1 “*saha pathnyA viSAIAkshyA nArAyaNamupAgatham*” (Srl rAma meditated on Srlman nArAyaNa along with slthAppirAtti, who has wide eyes). While slthA was with us then, she is not here now to help us. This is the deficiency.

veN thiraikkE koNdu pOy – with the help of those waves which were like hands, taking sarvESvaran along

alarvAy – *alar* – lotus; periya pirAtti has divine lips similar to lotus flower. She was born in the lotus flower.

mazhaikkaN madandhai – after looking at the place of sleeping (AdhiSEshan mattress) and periya pirAtti, he has to follow her. When she looks, it is with cool eyes, just like rain falling on a dry place makes it cool. If he considers her divine mind, he has to follow her.

aravaNai Era – getting atop AdhiSEshan, along with periya pirAtti.

maN mAdhar – bhUmippirAtti (Srl bhUdhEvi)

viN vAy azhaitththu – calling through sky, which is like the mouth; alternatively, calling, standing in the sky. When the waves came up to the sky in agitation, it appeared that the earth was calling out.

pulambi – wailing, as if reciting several pAsurams

mulai mEl ninRum – standing on top of mountains, which were like bosoms. Since earth is bhUmippirAtti's wealth, the mountains can be considered to be her bosoms, just as it has been said in siRiya thirumadal “*kArAr varaikkongai*” (completely dark mountains which were like bosoms).

ARugaLay – when it rained, the water coming down from the mountains appeared like rivers which were full.

mazhaik kaNNa nlr – tears which were like rain water. In normal times, it would appear like rain water; now it appeared like her tears.

thirumAL kodiyaAn enRu – we thought that if we see sarvESvaran and periya pirAtti united, it would be a great fortune; however, it is now distressing us. When he manifests his simplicity, it appears like cruelty to us.

enRu vArginRadhE – as she wails mentioning his cruelty, her tears appear like abundant flow of water.

While it is the normal rainy season, the *nAyaki*'s friend tells her “While sarvESvaran and periya pirAtti united, Srl bhUmippirAtti, unable to bear that, is shedding copious amount of tears which appear like rainfall”, making her bewildered into thinking that it is not the rainy season but tears shed by bhUmippirAtti.

When sarvESvaran is united with periya pirAtti, both bhUdhEvi and neeLAdhEvi would think that he has united with their soul and when he is united with bhUdhEvi and neeLAdhEvi, periya pirAtti would think that he has united with her bosoms and shoulders. Thinking like this is their true nature. Since he is without any limit, everyone has to enjoy him together. When such is their true nature, how is it said that bhUdhEvi is wailing on seeing sarvESvaran being united with periya pirAtti? Our pUrvAchAryas prior to ALavandhAr would explain this saying “bhUdhEvi is in tears because when sarvESvaran and periya pirAtti are together, we are unable to help them by bringing them flowers, sandalwood paste etc” ALavandhAr explained it by quoting thiruvAimozhi 9-2-10 “*vadiviNai illa malarmagaL*” - I have made such periya pirAtti who is unparalleled in her beauty and soft nature to shiver in the cool water and being carried away by the ocean even as I remained as a mattress for her – and wept because of that. parASara bhattar on hearing this would say “There is no need for all these explanations. The *nAyaki* on hearing such inapt explanation from her friend would have thought ‘How is this possible?’ By the time she analyses this and decides on it, the *nAyakan* would have returned. AzhwAr would have mercifully said this, for this position”

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): Since AzhwAr cannot sustain himself without attaining sarvESvaran, he has to be consoled by pointing to events which take place nearby, which may not be true.

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55. pAsuram 53 – vArAyina mulaiyAL

avathArikai (Introduction)

Though the friend had said that it is not the rainy season, in the previous pAsuram, it was raining steadily like a true rainy season. Since the *nAyakan* who had promised to return before the rains had not returned, the *nAyaki* fell down unconsciously. Her relatives who had seen this were bewildered, not knowing the reason for her behaviour. They thought that this must be the act of a lowly deity and started engaging in activities to remedy the situation. An old, knowledgeable woman, who was passing that way and who knew her real condition, told them “The remedies which you are trying to carry out will not revive her. Carry out the remedy which I am going to tell you”

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*vArAyina mulaiyALivaL vAnOr thalaimaganAm slrAyina dheyva nal nOy idhu
dheyvaththaNNandhuzhAyth thArAyinumthazhaiyAyinum thaNkombadhAyinum klzh vErAyinum ninRa
maNNAyinum koNdu vIsuminE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

ivaL – this *nAyaki* *vAr Ayina* – apt bodice with which to tie

mulayAL – having bosom

idhu – this disease

vAnOr – for nithyasUris

thalaimaganAm – being the lord

slr Ayina – having auspicious qualities

dheyvam – caused due to the deity

nal – distinguished

nOy – resulted as disease

(Hence)

dheyvam – being related to that deity, Srlman nArAyaNan

thaN – being cool

am – being beautiful

thuzhAy – divine thuLasi's

thAr Ayinum – whether it is a bunch of flowers

thazhaiyAyinum – whether it is the petals

thaN – cool

kombadhAyinum – whether it is the stem

klzh – seen below it

vEr Ayinum – whether it is the root

ninRa – from which that divine thuLasi plant sprouted

maNNAyium – whether it is the soil

koNdu – bringing that

vIsumin – blow it such that the wind from that [object] falls on her

Simple Translation

The *nAyaki*'s bosoms are apt to be tied with a bodice. The disease that she has is a distinguished one, caused by Srlman nArAyaNan, the lord of nithyasUris and the one who has auspicious qualities. Obtain the cool, beautiful flower of thuLasi plant or its petals or its stem or its root or the soil from which the plant sprouted and blow it on her such that the wind from that falls on her.

vyAkyAnam

vArAyina mulayAL ivaL – she is not in a position to accept the harsh remedies which you are carrying out towards a lowly deity. Isn't her position such that without wasting time, you have to carry out a remedy immediately?

vArAyina mulayAL ivaL – bosom tied by a bodice; bosom sustained by a bodice. Her bosom could be sustained either by a bodice or by the *nAyakan*; it cannot be sustained by her. The vyAkyAthA explains a few verses from thirumangai AzhWar's periya thirumadal “ *ennivai thAn vALA enakke poRaiyAgi* ” (what is the use of these bosoms? They have become an unwanted load for me) starting with the verse

kal navilum kAttagaththu – in the forest which is full of stones

Or vallik kadi malarin – in a fragrant flower on a creeper

nal naRu vAsam – with great fragrance

maRRArAnum eydhAmE – without anyone enjoying that fragrance

mannum vaRu nilaththu vALAnguguththadhu pOl – withering on the ground from which it blossomed, without being of use to anyone; similar to that

ennudaiya peNmaiium ennalenum enmulaiyum – my femininity, my qualities and my bosoms are [wasted] like those creeper, flowers and fragrance respectively.

mannu malar mangai maindhan – sarvESvaran who has been attained by periya pirAtti, who resides on a flower

kaNapuraththup ponmalai pOl ninRavan than – sarvESvaran should come to thirukkaNNapuram, instead of being in SrlvaikuNtam, along with periya pirAtti

ponnagalam thOyAvEl – if I am not embraced by his valorous chest and if my distress is not removed

ennivaidhAn vALA – should there not be a purpose for their [bosoms'] creation?

enakkepoRaiyAgi – when two people are required to sustain them, what is the purpose in my sustaining them alone? They become unbearable for me. Had they been on my back, I would not have to see them losing their beauty.

mUvAmaik kAppadhOr marundhu aRivIr illaiyE – there is none who can give a remedy to prevent them from aging and losing their beauty.

parASara bhattar, on hearing this, said “He is asking whether there is no *AndharALikar* in this land” (*AndharALikar* is one who is an intermediary, helping the *nAyakan* and the *nAyaki* in sorting out their love-quarrel. nanjlyar would say that piLLai thirunaRaiyUr araiyar and others who were listening to this explanation by bhattar would praise bhattar’s sharpness for four to five *nAzhigais* (about two hours), without speaking about any other subject. piLLai thirunaRaiyUr araiyar thought that when he is much older than bhattar and has more knowledge too, others may wonder whether it is apt to praise parASara bhattar like this. Hence he said “Oh child, earlier too AchAryars (teachers) have praised their Sishyars (disciples). In the thirunedundhANdagam pAsuram 14 *vaLarththadhanAl payan peRREn* for which you gave certain explanations, the *nAyaki* had nurtured a parrot, taught it the divine names of emperumAn; when the parrot recited those divine names, did she not fall at its feet?” bhattar told him “Oh swAmy! You could praise me by keeping me in whatever position that you desire; but please do not deny us the opportunity of having you in our midst and enjoying your presence”.

The vyAkyAthA narrates another incident to show how sarVESvaran becomes elated when someone who is totally devoted to him is praised. Once emperumAnAr (rAmAnujar) was sitting near a *punnai tree* close to chandhira pushkaraNi inside Srlrangam temple. thirvarangan [Srl ranganaAthan] had mercifully reached that place as a part of temple festivity. A few people who came there fell at the divine feet of emperumAnAr and worshipped him. An officer of the kingdom, udaiyAr subrahmaNya bhattar, saw this incident. Given below is the conversation between this officer and emperumAnAr:

He asked emperumAnAr “I want to ask you a question. Can I?”

“What is it?”

“In the presence of Srl ranganaAthan, a few persons fell at your feet. They were ignorant. But I did not hear you telling them not to do that. Why is it?”

“Others may ask this question. But your asking this question is not apt”

“What is the difference between others and me?”

“Are you not one who is carrying out service to the King? When someone comes to the court of the King to ask for some help, you would have seen him taking the sandals of the King and keeping them on his head. Would the sandals tell that man ‘Do not keep us on your head’? Is that man truly celebrating the sandals? No. Even if he praises the sandals, are they capable of helping that man? However, doesn’t the King, who is seeing this, feel happy and help the man?” [In the same way, Srl ranganaAthan feels happy and helps the people who had fallen at emperumAnAr’s feet].

vArAyina mulayAL ival – her bosoms are such that the bodice, through its connection with them, realises its true nature. Even the *nAyakan* realises his nature through embracing them. The *nAyaki* too cannot sustain herself without him, just as it has been mentioned in thiruvAimozhi 6-10-10 “*agalagillEn iRaiyum*” (I cannot leave even for a moment) and in Sri rAmAyaNam ayOdhyA kANdam 53-31 “*na cha slthA thvayA hinA*” ((lakshmaNa tells Srl rAmA) sithAppirAtti will not survive without you).

It is due to the connection between the cause of her disease [sarvESvaran] and her disease that AzhwAr says *vAnOr thalaimaganAm slrAyina*.

slr Ayina – widespread disease. It is such a rare disease that no one could say that (s)he will be able to cure her from the disease.

dheyva nOy – it is a disease which has not been caused by any entity in this world.

nal nOy – a disease which one has to accept by even making lot of efforts. Alternatively, a disease caused by the supreme entity who is the lord of nithyasUris, due to his greatness and auspicious qualities.

dheyvaththaNNandhuzhAy . . . – make sure that you find a remedy such that it is aligned with your nature as well as the nature of the disease which is afflicting her. Just as it is said “ *dhEvathAnthara katAksha kauleenA :’* (grace from other *dhEvathAs* (deities) will create major fault for the clan), do not approach other deities.

dheyvam . . . – try to save her by bringing a material which, through its contact with the supreme entity, has his true nature, such as the leaves of *thuLasi*, or its stem or its root or the soil from which the *thuLasi* plant sprouted. With other medicines (obtained through the grace of other deities), only harm will result while medicines which are connected with *sarvESvaran*, even if they are far removed from *sarvESvaran*, will be the apt remedy. Just as it has been mentioned in *thiruvAimozhi* 3-7-9 “ *endhaipirAn thanakku adiyAr adiyAr tham adiyAr adiyAr....* ” it is enough if someone has direct contact with *sarvESvaran* or contact through several of his followers in a lineage. That alone will do.

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): This *pASuram* brings out AzhwAr’s belief that contact with other deities will be the cause of destruction of one’s existence and contact with any material which has even a remote connection with *sarvESvaran* will be the cause for one’s existence

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56. pAsuram 54 – vIsum siRagAl

avathArikai (Introduction)

In the previous pAsuram, a lady who was going that side said “fan her with any material [related to emperumAn] even if it is the soil [from which his divine thuLasi had sprouted]” However, there was no need to do anything like that. It appeared that from her words and activities, one would know that she is conscious. When a person is afflicted with deep hunger, he would be able to tolerate it if he were asleep. However, it is not possible to bear that hunger if he were awake. In the same way, since she was unconscious in the previous pAsuram, it appeared to be normal. She had forgotten him for sometime. Since she is awake now, she can sustain herself only if someone comes from there [from the *nAyakan*] or someone goes from her side as a messenger to him and to await his arrival. It did not appear that anyone would come from there. From her side, there was none who could walk to his place. She is sending beetles which are near her, to go as her messenger to him.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

vIsum siRagAl paRaththIr viNNadu nungatkeLidhu pEsumbadiyanna pEsiyum pOvadhu ney thodu uNdu Esumbadiyanna seyyum emmIsar viNNOr piRanAr mAsinmalaradikkIzh emmaichchErvikkum vaNdugaLE

Word-by-Word Meanings

viNNOr – for nithyasUris

piRanAr – being their lord

ney – ghee

thodu – stealing

uNdu – eating it

Esumbadi – such that (enemies) ridicule

anna – activities like that

seyyum – one who carries out

em Isar – being our swAmy, his

mAsu il – without any fault

malar – like a soft flower

adikkIzh – under [his] divine feet

emmai – us

sErvikkum – having the ability to take us [there]

vaNdugaLE – Oh beetles!

vIsum – spread out

siRagAl – with wings

paRaththIr – you are flying

nungatku – for you

viNNAdu – paramapadham which is in paramAkASam

eLidhu – will be easy (and natural)

pEsumbadi – whatever is to be spoken (there)

anna – those words

pEsiyum pOvadhu – should speak (in our presence)

Simple Translation

Oh beetles! You have the capability to take us under the faultless, flower-like soft divine feet of sarvESvaran who was spoken of derisively after he stole and ate butter from the houses of those who were in thiruvAyppAdi (Sri gOkulam) and who is the lord of nithyasUris. You are flying with widespread wings. It will be easy for you to reach paramapadham where he dwells. Please tell us the words which you are going to tell there.

vyAkyAnam

vIsum siRagAI – The term *vIsugai* refers to swaying, speed and being widespread.

siRagAI paRaththIr – she says that she has to walk since she does not have wings. That is why she swooned, thinking of him, as in thiruvAimozhi 7-2-4 “*itta kAl itta kaiyaLAy*” (legs and hands are immovable)

viNNAdu nungatku eLidhu – The moment they take to the skies she thinks that they can fly all the way to paramapadham. She is firm that paramapadham is above only, just as it has been mentioned in nAchchiyAr thirumozhi 10-2 “*mElulagangaLin mIdhu pOy*” (going beyond the worlds above).

nungatku eLidhu – paramapadham is easy for you to reach. It is difficult only for us! She feels that all those who could fly would be able to reach paramapadham.

pEsumbadi anna pEsiyum pOvadhu – please tell us what you are going to tell him and others who are there.

ney thodu . . . – despite being the lord of the inexhaustible nithyasUris, he incarnated on this earth. He felt that he could not sustain himself without materials such as milk, curd, butter etc which have had the touch of herd-girls who were very affectionate towards him. He had to steal them since they were not easily accessible to him and ate them; he was derided by people like SiSupAlan et al who were inimical to him, because of such acts.

emmlsar – he has the eminence of being the controller of nithyasUris; at the same time, he has the simplicity to consider that he could not sustain himself without materials connected with his followers; with these qualities, he made me to exist exclusively for him.

mAsin malaradi – his divine, soft feet which are without any fault. It is not that he goes to someone only after that person sends him a messenger since he had not gone to that person, saying “Oh, I forgot

completely”. Even if someone were to send him a message, he would put the words in the messenger’s mouth.

The vyAkyAthA explains the SIOkam 40-3 in Srl rAmAyaNam sundhara kANdam “ *yathA tham purusha vyAgram gAthrai: SOka abhikarSithai : | samspriSEyam sakAmA aham thathA kuru dhayAm mayi | |*” (due to grief, my form has become very enervated. I wish to embrace that tiger among men, Srl rAma. Show mercy on me and fulfil my desire) [this SIOkam tells how slthAppirAtti informs hanuman about her condition and her desire, so that he could take that message to Srl rAma]

yathA tham purusha vyAgram – I don’t have to think that time has passed and that I have to tell him something to make him do it. He is like a male tiger who is capable of carrying out whatever he thinks of, the moment he thinks about it.

gAthrai : – You could see that my physical form is becoming emaciated. It is not that I wish to get rid of this form, attain a new form and then go to him. I want to embrace him with this emaciated form itself.

sa kAmAham – I will not remain like him uttering words such as “If you come to the forest, I will not go; if you are lost, I will not search for you”

thathA kuru dhayAm mayi – even when there is no reduction in his power, I have not seen it coming up to me. With your mercy, you should make it happen for me

emmaich chErivikkum vaNdugaLE – Aren’t you the beetles who feel that you would realise your *svaUpam* (true nature) only if you unite me with him?

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): AzhwAr is conveying his distress in separation to sarvESvaran’s divine heart through the mode of sending messengers.

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57. pAsuram 55 – vandugaLO vammin

avathArikai (Introduction)

The *nAyakan* comes and unites with the *nAyaki* after she sends him her errand. Subsequently the time to separate from her came. In order to make her sustain herself even in separation, he praises her so that she thinks “Oh, such a person will not delay in returning”. This comes under the classification of *nalam pArAttudhal* (similar to pAsuram 14). Sri rAma too praised slthAppirAtti as mentioned in Sri rAmAyaNam ayOdhyA kANdam 26-20 “*kulE mahathi sambhUthE*” (Oh one who was born in a great clan!)

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

vaNdugaLO vammin nlrppU nilappU maraththiloNpU uNdu kaLiththu uzhalvIrkkku onRu uraikkiyam EnamonRAy maNdugaLAdi vaigundham annAL kuzhalvAy virai pOl viNdugaL vArum malar uLavO num viyalidaththE

Word-by-Word Meanings

vaNdugaLO – Oh beetles!

nlrppU – among the flowers in water

nilappU – among the flowers on land

maraththil – on trees

oN – beautiful

pU – flowers

uNdu – drinking (honey)

kaLiththu – becoming happy

uzhalvIrkkku – you, who are roaming

onRu – a word

uraikkiyam – I will say

vammin – please come

oru – unique

EnamAy – as a *varAham* (wild boar)

maN – earth’s

thugaL – dust

Adi – one who took it throughout his divine form

vaigundhamannAL – on this *nAyaki* who is like paramapadham (being very much enjoyable), her

kuzhal vAy – on her locks

virai pOl – being very fragrant

viNdu – spread well

kaL – honey

vArum – flowing copiously

malar – flower

num – your

viyal – amazing

idaththu – places

uLadhO – is it there?

Simple Translation

(This has been told by the *nAyakan* to the beetles)

Oh beetles! I am going to tell you all, who are drinking honey from flowers which are present on water, on land and on trees and are roaming happily. Please come and listen to me. Among the places where you keep roaming, have you seen the sweet fragrance on flowers, which you are seeing on the locks of this *nAyaki* who is as enjoyable as the paramapadham of sarvESvaran who incarnated as a unique wild boar and took on all the dust which is present on this earth?

vyAkyAnam

vandugaLO vammin – Oh beetles! Please come here.

niIrppU . . . – some people would say that three types of flowers are referred to here while some others would say that there are four types of flowers. In the term *nilappU* (flowers on land), people would say that two types of flowers are included – those on plants and those on creepers. Added to the flowers on water and flowers on trees, there are four types of flowers, according to these people. There is an old saying *nalla malarppozhil nAlum nuzhaivIrgAL* (may you enter all the four types of good orchards). I will say something to you, who are going around to wherever flowers are seen, being happy by drinking honey from them and having that as your main work. Please come.

Enam . . . – he incarnated as the unique, great boar, trampling the earth. When that earth attained him, due to his pride, he took its dust all over his divine form.

vaigundham annAL – this *nAyaki* is very much concordant with his permanent abode of vaigundham, unlike this vibhUthi (samsAram) where he comes occasionally to protect. She will not let any other enjoyment to come to her heart. She is saying just as ALavandhAr had mercifully said in his sthOthra rathnam SIOkam 5 “*sarvam yadhEva niyamEna*” (by whomsoever everything is controlled...)

kuzhal vAy virai pOl – just like the sweet fragrance on her locks.

vindugaL . . . – Have you seen among the flowers on the wonderful earth where you roam around fully, any fragrance like this, such that you will not bother about passage of time?

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): SrlvaishNavas enjoy the auspicious qualities of sarvESvaran in his para, vyUha, vibhava etc forms (sarvESvaran in paramapadham, in thiruppARKadal, in incarnations etc). They are asked “Among all the qualities which you enjoy there, have you seen any quality similar to the one that AzhwAr has?” In other words, the greatness of *bhAgavatha* (follower of sarvESvaran) is higher than that of *bhagavAn* (sarvESvaran). vyAkyAthA quotes from thaiththirlya upanishath nArAyaNavalli “ *ambasyapArE bhuvanasya madhyE nAkasya prushtE* ” wherein *ambasya* is taken as being equivalent to vyUham, *bhuvanasya* is taken as being equivalent to vibhavam and archchai, and *nAkasya* is taken as being equivalent to param. These are the three different types of flowers mentioned in the first line.

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58. pAsuram 56 – viyalidam uNda

avathArikai (Introduction)

The *nAyakan* , after being united with the *nAyaki* for some time, separated from her. The *nAyaki* 's friend realised that there was a delay in his returning and that the *nAyaki* was in distress because of that. The friend thought “Her sadness due to the separation is so harsh; there is no sign of his returning; she will decide that there is no reason for her to be alive anymore. Thus, will we lose her?” The *nAyaki* realised her friend’s predicament. At that time, by chance, the *nAyaki* felt that there was a connection with a material which had a connection with him. She tells her friend “Without your knowledge, a connection happened just now, with him. Hence, you do not have to feat about my position”. She narrates the connection that she got, to her friend.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

viyalidam uNda pirAnAr viduththa thiruvaryl uyalidam peRRu uyndham anjalam thOzhi Or thaN thenRal vandhu ayalidaiyArum aRindhilar am pUndhuzhAyin in thEn puyaludai nlrmaiyaI thadaviRRu en pulan kalanE

Word-by-Word Meanings

am – beautiful

thOzhi – Oh friend!

viyal – amazing

idam – earth

uNda – one who ate

pirAnAr – sarvESvaran, the benefactor

viduththa – gave

thiru – praiseworthy

aruLAI – due to mercy

uyal – for being uplifted

idam peRRu – getting an opportunity

uyndham – we got our lives back

anjal – do not fear

Or – being unique

thaN – cool

thenRal – southern wind

vandhu – coming and blowing gently

pU – having flowers

thuzhAyin – available in divine thuLasi

in – enjoyable

thEn – honey

puyaludai – cloud's

nIрмаiyinAl – due to its nature

en – my

pulan – senses

kalan – ornaments

thadaviRRu – touched

ayalidai yArum – none in the vicinity

aRindhilar – knew (it)

Simple Translation

(The *nAyaki* tells her friend)

Oh beautiful friend! Due to a distinguished merciful act of sarvESvaran who is the benefactor of this amazing earth, I got an opportunity to uplift myself and live. Do not fear. The cool, southerly breeze, carrying honey from the flowers of divine thuLasi, and with the nature of clouds, came here and blew gently on my senses and my ornaments. None here knew it.

vyAkyAnam

The friend told *nAyaki* “If we have to get his mercy just as *bhUmi* (earth) had got, we should have something with us [which he likes]. But we do not know as to what it is” ...

viyal idam uNda – whatever the earth had during deluge, we have with us now, says the *nAyaki*. It is enough if he thinks that we are in danger. This is the only requirement which he expects from us. During the time of deluge, he had kept earth inside his stomach and protected it. Did earth have any other recompense with her to receive his help? Whatever distressed condition that the earth was in then, is seen in the *nAyaki* too now.

pirAnAr – he has only the quality of bestowing benefit [to others]. All that is required of the recipient to receive his mercy is to be an apt entity for that. He does not offer a help, expecting anything in return.

The *vyAkyAthA* narrates an incident from the life of *emperumAnAr* (bhagavath rAmAnujar). Some *SrlvaishNavas* came to offer their obeisance to *emperumAnAr* at the place where he had mercifully come. After falling at his divine feet, they asked him “What should we think of as our refuge if we have to come out of this ocean of *samsAram* and reach its shore?” *vangipuraththu nambi*, one of *rAmAnujar*'s disciples, told them to think of the words of *kshathrabandhu*, just as it has been mentioned in *vishNu dharmam SIOkam* 98-35 “*mUdOyam alpamathi alpaviSEshtithOyam kalishtAm manOsya vinayair namayi prasangi | iththam krupAm kuru mayi praNathE kIEsa thvAm sthOthum ambuja*

bhavOpihidhEvanESa || ” (Oh the lord of everyone and everything! I have a lowly knowledge, indulging in only lowly activities; this mind of mine is looking for wrongful activities alone. My mind is refusing to obey me. Hence, you have to help me who is coming to you for help. Even *nAnmukhan* (brahma) does not have the knowledge to worship you completely). *emperumAnAr*, after listening to this, said “It is a difficult condition to attain. The word *praNathE* (for me who is worshipping you) indicates that only the one who thinks that he is *nirmama* (nothing belongs to me) should fall at the divine feet of the omniscient *sarvESvaran*. If we think that we attain a benefit only by carrying out some activity, engaging in that activity will create a sorrow in us and will prevent us from getting that benefit. If we think that we have a qualification with us, that qualification will only stop him from bestowing a benefit on us without any reason. That qualification will not be the means to receive his mercy. Even though we should necessarily have the thought ‘you should be our means’ even that thought should come only from him. Even if one gets to the stage of *paramabhakthi* (attaining *sarvESvaran*), that *paramabhakthi* will only end in his getting the taste to enjoy *sarvESvaran*, but it will not, on its own, have the capability to grant him what he desires”. The *SrlvaishNavas* then asked *emperumAnAr* “What else should we think of as our refuge?” He responded, saying “Only the words of *kALiyan* are apt to be considered as our refuge” [*kALiyan* is a snake who had troubled the herd and herdsfolk at *Srl gOkulam* by remaining in the river *yamunA*]. His prayer to *krishNa*, who had come to drive him away from *yamunA* is seen in *Srl vishNu purANam* *SLOkam* 5-7-10 “ *sOham thE dhEva dhEvESa nArchanAthau sthuthau na cha | sAmArthyavAn krupAmAthra manOvruththi prasIdhamE ||* ” (Oh the lord of *dhEvathAs*! I am incapable of praising or worshipping you. For such a person like me, you should yourself shower your mercy; your divine mind should feel happy and show mercy on me). This *SLOkam* is explained in detail here, by the *vyAkyAthA*:

sOham – I, who had coiled myself around your divine form and indulged in activities which are not to your liking and had not freed myself from such activities; such a lowly person

dhEva dhEvESa : your quality is such that not indulging in activities which are not to your liking alone is sufficient to qualify for your mercy. You consider our saying the words “You should shower your mercy” as “renouncing the undesired”. Just as it has been mentioned in *periyA thirumozhi* 5-6-4 “ *nanju sOrvadhOrvenjina aravam veruvivandhu nin Saran enach charaNA ...* ” (the snake *sumukhan* which spits poison and which is fiery and angry, out of fear for *garuda*, took refuge under you saying “I am surrendering to you”) Though its anger was against it, since it surrendered by merely saying the words “ *SaraNam* ” it was granted that. *veruvi vandhu* – it came running to him out of fear [of *garuda*]. The fear towards its enemy alone was with the snake

nArchanAthau sthuthaunacha sAmArthyavAn – [*kALiyan* tells *krishNa*] I am capable of doing everything for myself but incapable if I have to do even a little bit for you [that is my nature]. You are such that you do not expect anything for yourself, from me; I am without any strength to do anything. *krishNa* tells *kALiyan* “If you are capable of doing anything for yourself and incapable of doing anything for me, what is it that you want me to do?”

krupA mAthra manOvruththi – You should show your mercy on me, says *kALiyan* . *krishNa* tells him “For that you need remorse” *kALiyan* responds saying “But I do not have even that remorse. Whatever you want to do for me with my feeling of remorse, you should do with your mercy itself” *vyAkyAthA* cites the reference from *SrlrangaAjasthavam* 2-97 “ *balibhujiSiSupAlE* ” (*kAkAsuran* and *SiSupAla*) [*kAkAsuran* was *indhra*’s son who took the form of a crow in order to trouble *slthAppirAtti* when she was with *Srl rAma* in the forest and *SiSupAla* was *krishNa*’s cousin, who poured scorn on *krishNa* all the time]. Just as it is mentioned in *Srl rAmAyaNam* *sundhara kANdam* 38-34 “ *sa tham nipathitham* ” (that

crow fell on earth and sought refuge) the crow experienced sorrow and sought refuge by falling on the earth. SiSupAlan kept reciting your names [though his intention was to abuse krishNa, that he recited the names was sufficient] to get recognised by krishNa. *kALiyan* continues “Your mercy was refused for them because of the initial lowly thoughts that they had. However, since no such fault can be ascribed to me, your mercy can get manifested beautifully”.

viduththa thiruvarylAI – through the mercy showered by him; without expecting anything from us, treating our benefit as his own, and showering his mercy.

viduththa – allowed to come; given

uyalidam peRRu uyndham – the friend thought “She has no scope to live; I will not be able to see her alive”. The *nAyaki* tells the friend “An opportunity arose for my being uplifted. Instead of waiting for it to happen, we got it immediately and got our lives back”. Since the friend had known the *nAyakan* too, she had thought that she had lost both of them. Now, everyone has got uplifted.

am thOzhi – you are the person who considers my benefit as yours. We are similar to the friendship between Srl rAma and sugrIva as mentioned in Srl rAmAyaNam kishkindhA kANdam 5-17 “*Ekam dhu:kham sukham cha nau*” (our mirth and misery are one). Is it not enough to say *thOzhi* (friend)? Why address her as *am thOzhi* (beautiful friend)? Some people would look for same benefits in both theirs and their friends’. However, this friend is such that she does not look for any benefit for herself. She considers whatever benefit that the *nAyaki* gets as her own. This is why she is addressed as *am thOzhi*. Srl rAmAyaNam yudhdha kANdam 18-16 says “*suhrudhO vA bhavadhvidhA:*” – Srl rAma tells sugrIva “Not all friends are like you”. Srl rAma further tells sugrIva “As soon as you saw me, you considered your elder brother [vAlI] as your enemy, you had more confidence in me than in your brother and you tried to get answers to your confidential problems too. Such was your friendship with me” The *nAyaki* tells her friend “You considered my benefit as yours and my loss as yours; you were fearful of my loss; now, you do not have to fear”

Or thaN thenRal vandhu – earlier, the southern breeze was causing me harm; now a cool southern breeze came, tells the *nAyaki*. Breeze will be cool only when united; the *nAyaki* subtly hints that union did take place. The friend too accepts that and is worried as to what will happen if others around know about it. The *nAyaki* says . . .

ayalidai yArum aRindhilar – None in our vicinity knew about it.

The friend asks her as to what happened further? . . .

am pUndhuzhAyin inthEn – the fine drops of honey collected from the flowers of cool, divine thuLasi

puyaludai nlrmaiyaInAI – the southerly breeze assumed the quality of the cool clouds. This talks about the help rendered by the breeze when one had not expected it.

thadaviRRu en pulan kalanE – it gently touched all my sensory organs and all my ornaments. It touched my sensory organs as if to satisfy their thirst and the ornaments so that they do not slip out of my limbs. Thus the *nAyaki* tells her friend as to how the *nAyakan* united with her.

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): AzhwAr describes that he survived due to the knowledge of sarvESvaran’s auspicious qualities. thaiththirIya upanishath Anandhavalli says *Anandham brahmaNO vidhvAn nabibhEthi kuthaSchana* – one who knows about the joyfulness of brahman (sarvESvaran) does not fear anything.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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59. pAsuram 57 – pulakkuNdala

avathArikai (Introduction)

After being united with the *nAyaki*, when the *nAyakan* separated from her, his distress became more acute. Though he had to separate from her for a reason, just as it is mentioned in Srl rAmAyaNam sundhara kANDam 66-10 “*na jlvEyam kshaNamapi*” (I cannot live even for a moment without her), his distress in separation was very difficult for him. Looking at his distress in separation and a lack of liveliness in him, the *nAyakan*’s friend told him “The way you are distressed about one issue, without engaging with other matters, does not fit well with your leadership qualities” and tried to bring him back to normal situation. The *nAyakan* tells him “You are speaking like this since you do not know how those who have been the target of her glance have suffered. If you too experience her glance, you would not speak like this” denying his accusation.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

pulakkuNdalap puNdarlgaththapOrkkeNdai valli onRAI vilakkuNdu ulAginRu vEl vizhikkinRana kaNNan kaiyAl malakkuNdu amudham surandha maRikadal pOnRavaRRAl kalakkuNda nAnRu kaNdAr emmai yArum kazhaRalarE

Word-by-Word Meanings

pulam – visible

kuNdalam – having ear-rings

puNdarlgaththa – on the face which is like a lotus flower

pOr – engaged in a war

keNdai – eyes which are like fish

valli onRAI – with the nose which looks like a creeper

vilakkuNdu – being separated

ulAginRu – are roaming

vEl – cruel, like the weapon spear

vizhikkinRana – are looking

avaRRAl – through such activities

kaNNan – krishNa’s

kaiyAl – with divine hands

malakkuNdu – being agitated

amudham – nectar

surandha – secreted

maRi – throwing up waves

kadal pOnRu – like an ocean

kalakkuNda – agitated

nAnRu – during that time

kaNdAr – those who saw

yArum – whosoever

ennai – me

kazhaRalar – will not admonish

Simple Translation

The eyes of the *nAyaki* which appear to be battling each other, present on her lotus-like face having beautiful ear rings, are separated by the nose, which is like a creeper. The two eyes are moving around, looking in a cruel way, like a spear. Just like the ocean which was agitated by the divine hands of krishNa and secreted the nectar, I too am bewildered. Whosoever had seen me at that time, would not find fault with me.

vyAkyAnam

pulakkuNdala . . . – The *nAyakan*’s friend had spoken about the condition of *nAyakan* without knowing the facts. The *nAyakan* tells him about the eyes of the *nAyaki* so that he will realise as to what would happen if he were to undergo a similar experience. He would then say “Oh my bad! What all did he suffer? How did he manage?” The ear rings of the *nAyaki* are capable of stealing all the sensory organs. They are present on her face which looks like a lotus flower. The term *kuNdalam* would also refer to a circular shape. If the text is *polakkuNdalam* , it would refer to golden ear-rings.

puNdarigaththa pOrkkeNdai – the eyes look like carp fish which appear to be fighting. The face is capable of making a person to become immobile, more than any other limb. The eyes are the most prominent part, on such a face.

valli onRAI vilakkuNdu – Just like keeping a cross-bar between two rutting elephants which are fighting, her nose is present [between the two fighting eyes]

ulAginRu – since the nose is there between them, the two eyes, which are like fish, are unable to engage in direct combat with each other. Due to the limitation set by sarvESvaran, they are unable to cross the ears too. Hence they are roaming between these two boundaries.

vEI vizhikkinRana – their glance is like a sharp spear, capable of piercing through the other side.

kaNNan . . . – the milky ocean was churned by the divine hands of krishNa such that the sand at the bottom was brought to its surface; the ocean gave him its life saving *amrutham* (nectar). The *nAyakan*’s majesty was similar to that ocean’s. The term *maRikadal pOnRu* is to be considered as *maRikadal pOnRavaRRAI* , thus bringing a distinction to the eyes (the eyes are like an agitating ocean). Once she looks at him, he too looks at her. Being engaged with his glance, she manifests her engagement with him, both inside her heart and outside, in her eyes. The *nAyakan* now reminisces that.

avaRRAI – those eyes create a scar in him, even now, through their glance.

kalakkuNda nAnRu kaNdAr – those who saw me that day when I was bewildered [by her glance]

emmai yArum kazhaRalarE – apart from you, a friend who knows my nature well, even those who have not known me, will not speak a word ill of me.

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): SrlvaishNavas were fully engaged with AzhwAr's *SrlvaishNavaSrl* (wealth of AzhwAr's service). They could not be retrieved even by showing them matters relating to sarvESvaran. This pAsuram depicts such a position of SrlvaishNavas, who remained just like madhurakavi AzhwAr who said as in kaNNinuN siRuththAmbu 2 " *dhEvumaRRaRiyEn* " (I do not know of any deity other than nammAzhwAr). They will take a liking to matters relating to sarvESvaran only because AzhwAr liked them, just like the saying *bhavatha: paramOmatha:*.

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60. pAsuram 58 – kazhaRalam onRE

avathArikai (Introduction)

AzhwAr now narrates an incident carried out by sarvESvaran by which the different types of fatigue experienced earlier get negated. He kept his divine feet on the heads of everyone, without discriminating between those who are favourable to him (his followers) and those who are not favourable to him (his enemies). Through this, he said that there is none who he considers as an enemy. AzhwAr mercifully mentions that after doing all these activities, sarvESvaran remained as if he had not done anything.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

kazhaRalam onRE nilam muzhudhAyiRRu oru kazhal pOy nizhaRara eLLa visumbum niRaindhadhu nINda aNdaththu uzhaRalar gyAnach chudar viLakkAy uyarndhOrai illa azhaRalar thAmaraiKaNNan ennO ingu aLakkinRadhE

Word-by-Word Meanings

onRu – being single

kazhal thalamE – divine foot itself

nilam muzhudhu – entire earth

AyiRRu – pervaded

oru kazhal – the other divine foot

pOy – growing

nizhal thara – as it gave shade

eLLa visumbum – entire sky

niRaindhadhu – pervaded completely

nINda – expansive

aNdaththu – in the oval shaped universe

uzhaRu – roaming fully

alar – blossomed

gyAnam – knowledge

sudar – having radiance

viLakkAy – being self illuminating like a lamp

uyarndhOrai illa – not having anyone superior

azhaRu – in mud

thAmarai – like a lotus

kaNNan – sarvESvaran who has divine eyes

ingu – at this place

aLakkinRadhu – measuring

ennO – what is it?

Simple Translation

One divine foot measured such that the entire world came under it. The other divine foot grew, went up the sky such that it pervaded all the words above and gave shadow to the ones below. What is krishNa, who keeps roaming all over the universe, who has a radiant, self-illuminating knowledge and who has eyes which are like lotus flowers which have blossomed in slush, measuring in my case?

vyAkyAnam

kazhaRalamonRE nilamuzhudAyIRRu – as soon as a drop of water [from mahAbali] fell on [sarvESvaran’s] divine hand, one divine foot spread out such that the entire earth came under it.
kazhaRalam – kazhal thalam (foot)

onRE – without waiting for his thoughts on what is to be done, the foot, on its own, spread out fully [and measured the earth].

oru kazhal . . . – the other divine foot

nizhaRara eIlA visumbum niRaindhadhu – even as it entered its domain, with the confidence that he is there, it gave shade so that everyone can get under it; spread out everywhere.

nizhaRara – nizhal thara; to provide shade. Just as a flood would flow towards low lying regions, it [the divine foot] went to all open spaces and pervaded. *vAsudhEva tharuchchAyA* – shade of the tree *vAsudhEvan* (sarvESvaran). It became the shade of one tree which had pervaded everywhere.
nAthiSithA . . . – it will not be too cold; it will not be too warm; it will not allow the huge fire, *naragam*, hell, to come near. *sAkimartham nasEvyathE* – even if another shade which is an exact match for this is seen, is it proper to take shelter under the other shade? Could one say that this shade is not good?
periyAzhwaAr thirumozhi 5-3-4 “ thirumAlirunjOlaiendhAy un pAdha nizhalallAl marROr iruppidam nAn engum kANginRilEn ” (Oh the lord of thirumAlirum sOlai! Other than the shade of your divine foot, I do not see any shade elsewhere) – since you are the protector of your followers and eliminator of the enemies of your followers, I have not seen a shade where I could take refuge other than the shade of your divine feet.

The vyAkyAthA explains in detail, two SIOkams from Srl rAmAyaNam kishkindhA kANDam 15-19 and 15-20 to explain how sarvESvaran’s divine feet provide comforting shade and are the only refuge for all. *thArA* tells *vAli* that she has heard from angadhan (their son) who had gone to play in the forest, that *sugrIva* has got some apt companions; on being questioned, angadhan had told her that it is *perumAL* who has come to *sugrIva*, along with his brother and that *perumAL* has given refuge to *sugrIva*. *vAli* asks her “Will he not give us refuge?” to which she recites SIOkam 15-19 “ *nivAsa vruksha: sAdhUnAm ApannAnAm parA gathi: | ArthAnAm samSraya : chaiva yaSasa: cha Eka bhAjanam | |*”

nivAsa vrukshassAdhUnAm : *thArA* tells *vAli* “He [Srl rAma] is like a shade for those who desire to take refuge under him. He offers to others flowers, fruits, shade etc while taking sunlight on himself. For those who stand under his shade and wish to utilise him for gaining materials, he has the quality of

offering even himself. vAli asks her “I have not caused any harm to him. Is there any objection in standing under his shade?” thArA replies . . .

ApannAnAm – it is not sufficient to think that we will take refuge under him. We should be under the grip of difficulties. vAli responds “But we are in difficult condition only. The brother born with me is himself my enemy” thArA responds, saying . . .

ArthAnAm – “It is not enough if we are in difficulties. We should also think that we need a refuge” vAli tells her “If Srl rAma is the refuge for sugrIva, we will find out another who will be our refuge” thArA tells him . . .

yaSasachchaikabhAjanam : “He is the only refuge. There is none like him”

The vyAkyAthA cites the reference of bhagavath glthA 7-16 “ *Artha: jigyaAsu arthArthI gyAnI . .* ” – one who is craving, one who is looking for knowledge, one who desires wealth and one who knows me – there are four types of people in the world. In the Srl rAmAyaNa SIOkam cited above, the term *sAdhUnAm* would refer to *gyAni* (as given above), the term *ApannAnAm* would refer to *kaivalyArthi* (one who wishes to enjoy his own AthmA) and the term *ArthAnAm* would refer to both types of *arthArthi* (one who is looking for lost wealth and one who is looking for wealth for the first time). The vyAkyAthA raises a query: Would the words of a lady (thArA) have such deep meaning? He answers this himself quoting Srl rAmAyaNam bAlakANDam 4-6 SIOkam “ *vEdhO’pabruhmanArthAya* ” (capable of explaining the meanings of vEdhas (sacred texts)) Since Srl rAmAyaNam is capable of explaining the meanings of vEdhas, every word in it has deep meanings. bhagavath glthA 7-17 “ *Eka bhakthir viSishyathE* ” (since he is deeply devoted to me, he attains eminence). Such a devotee is very much attached to me and I am attached to him, says krishNa. One should detest samsAram (life in the materialistic world) and break all ties with prakruthi (repeated cycle of birth and death). This holds true for *AthmaprApthikAman* (one who desires to attain sarvESvaran) and then to the one who is looking for lost wealth. This is true of the one who wishes to have wealth, for the first time, too.

nINda . . . – due to the reason of desiring to pervade the entire expansive universe, one who has a splendid, well grown knowledge. He considered keeping his divine foot on the heads of all people as his benefit. The happiness which he obtained due to that act made his entire form to blossom.

uyarndhOrai illa – Since all the entities including brahmA were held under the divine feet, there was none to say “I” [he doesn’t have anyone superior to him].

azhaRalar thAmaraikkaNNan – one who has his divine eyes similar to blossomed lotus flowers standing in slush. Just as chAndOgya upanishath 1-6-7 says “ *thasya yathA kapyAsam puNdarIkam Evam akshiNI* ” (having reddish eyes similar to inverted lotus flower)

ennO ingu aLakkinRadhE – We could not see the joy of having measured. There should be a time interval for saying that he measured. Even that time interval was not seen. Since he stood in the same place, can we say that he measured? Only if a step has been moved after keeping one step could it be said that something has been measured. Thus, none saw him measuring. Alternatively, it could be said that even as he kept his divine foot on the heads of everyone, without any reason, he stood as if he had done nothing. AzhwAr feels exhilarated in his divine mind, thinking as to what he cannot do.

ennO ingu aLakkinRadhE – Will anyone measure if the entity to be measured is extremely small and the entity, which is measuring it, is too large? Thus, the opinion here is that since the people to be protected are very small, he stood as if he has nothing to do.

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61. pAsuram 59 – aLapparum thanmai

avathArikai (Introduction)

In the previous pAsuram, AzhwAr was joyous, praising the incarnation of thrivikrama, by saying “sarvESvaran, who is difficult to attain in SrlvaikuNtam, incarnated here and made himself easily approachable”. While his separation from sarvESvaran when he was in SrlvaikuNtam did not trouble him much, AzhwAr felt very sad due to his separation from sarvESvaran despite his coming here and taking residence. He attained the state of a pirAtti (AzhwAr in feminine form). Though there was a connection with sarvESvaran, since he did not come to see the *nAyaki* (AzhwAr in feminine form) during night time, which is the apt time for being together, she was unable to bear the distress of being separated from him now, after being united with him earlier. Her cry of “This night is harmful to me” is recited by her mother, in this pAsuram.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

aLapparum thanmaiyavvUzhi angangul andhaNNandhuzhAykuLapperum kAdhalil nLiyavAyuLa Ongu munnIr vaLapperu nAdan madhusUdhanan ennum valvinaiyEn thaLapperu nINmuRuval seyyavAya thadamulaiyE

Word-by-Word Meanings

val – being cruel

vinaiyEn – as my daughter, who has sins

thaLam – like jasmine buds

peru – having greatness

nIL – without limit (being enjoyable)

muRuval – having soft smile

seyya – reddish

vAy – having lips

thadam – expansive

mulai – she, who is having bosoms

aLappa – to measure

arum – difficult

thanmai – having nature

avvUzhi – more than that kalpam (a day of brahmA)

am – beautiful

thaNNam – being cool

thuzhAyku – for divine thuLasi

uLa – formed in (my) heart

peru – huge

kAdhalil – more than desire

nlliyavAy – being bigger

uLa – is present

(*ennum* – she will say so)

Ongu – being well grown

munnlr – made of three types of water

vaLam – having richness

peru – being expansive

nAdan – one who has land

madhusUdhanan – destroyer of demon madhu

ennum – she will say so

Simple Translation

(The mother is speaking with reference to the state of her daughter)

Being the daughter of me has cruel sins, she has greatness of a soft smile similar to jasmine buds, reddish lips and expansive bosoms. She says “The night times, which are crueller than *kalpams* which are very difficult to measure, are longer and bigger than my desire which is present in my mind for the cool, divine thulasi. madhusUdhanan has the expansive earth which is surrounded by ocean, which is formed from the three types of water and which is huge”.

vyAkyAnam

aLapparum thanmaiyavvUzhiyam kangul – night times, which are as long as *praLayam* (deluge) are difficult to measure even for sarvESvaran who measured with his divine feet the immeasurable entities too. If it is possible for him to measure them, wouldn’t he have appeared during the night? These nights have as their nature, the quality of being immeasurable.

Uzhiyam kangul – *Uzhik kAlam* (deluge) is the proof that this night is indeed of long duration.

vyAkyAthA raises a query: Is it not possible to recite a pAsuram on that which cannot be measured? He answers that himself, saying . . .

andhaNNandhuzhAy . . . – Just as it has been mentioned in thiruvAimozhi 10-10-10 “*adhaniR periya en avA*” (you, with your desire, surrounded me who has a huge desire to attain you). AzhwaAr’s desire pervaded even sarvESvaran. vEdham returned empty handed, after trying to measure the joy of sarvESvaran, as mentioned in thaiththirIya upanishath “*yathO vAchO nivarthanthe*”. The same is true of this [measuring the length of night] also. bruhadhAraNya upanishath could only say in the negative when trying to describe sarvESvaran, saying “*nEthi nEthi*” (he is not like this), but could not define clearly that he is like this. **andhaNNandhuzhAy** – the garland on his divine shoulders. Those divine

garlands have the power to control over everything in my mind. These nights are larger than the affection that I have for those garlands.

Ongu munnIr vaLapperunAdan madhusUdhanan ennum – am I distressed because I am outside his boundaries of reign? Am I distressed because he is powerless? He is the lord of the opulent land which is surrounded by ocean which contains three types of water (water from rivers, water from springs and water from rains).

madhusUdhanan – he is the destroyer of demon *madhu* who was like a weed for the entities which were to be protected [sarvESvaran's followers]. Am I suffering because I am not connected to sarvESvaran? Am I suffering because he is incapable of destroying my enemies?

valvinaiyEn – if her beauty [these are the words of *nAyaki*'s mother] were to be considered, there is no need for being distressed like this. The reason for her suffering, when actually it should be he who should be suffering for not being together with her when she is so beautiful, is only because of my sin. This is similar to bharathAzhwAn feeling distressed about what happened in ayOdhyA which resulted in Srl rAma leaving for the forest, said that this is “ *math pApam Eva* ” (only because of my sin).

What is the reason for the mother saying that it is her sin which is the reason for the *nAyaki*'s suffering?

thaLapperu . . . – Is there any deficiency in the *nAyaki*'s physical form? *thaLappu* has got shortened to *thaLa*. *thaLappu* denotes something similar to the buds of jasmine, something which is difficult to obtain. Just as it has been mentioned in Srl rAmAyaNam AraNya kANdam 64-77 “ *purEva mE chAru dhathim* ” (slthAppirAtti who had a beautiful row of teeth), it is the smile which is desired by the *nAyakan* and which melts his heart wherever he goes.

nIL muRuval – it is not the boisterous laughter of narasimhap perumAL; it is the gentle smile of a lady. However, an entity must be available like this. The word *nIL* refers to the enjoyability of that smile.

seyya . . . – having reddish lips which will be suitable for that gentle smile. Alternatively, since the next word spoken about is *thada mulai*, referring to the hugeness of her bosoms, the word *seyyavAy* could be added to *thadamulai* to make it as *seyyavAy thadamulai* as a single word, in which case it would refer to the straightness of the bosom.

thadamulaiyE – due to the separation from sarvESvaran, the bosom appeared like the ear of corn which has drooped. It appeared that the time frame set by the *nAyakan* was insufficient.

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning) – this refers to the words of SrlvaishNavas who speak of the distress of separation caused by the incongruence of the connection and knowledge of true nature of AzhwAr with the time suitable for enjoyment.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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62. pAsuram 60 – mulaiyO muzhumuRRum

avathArikai (Introduction)

In the previous pAsuram, she [the *nAyaki*] had said “*thaLapperu nINmuRuval seyyavAya thadamulai vaLapperu nAdan madhusUdhan ennum*”. Her mother says “What is surprising about her saying such words in her youthful state? Isn’t this how she has been thinking even in her childhood days?”

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

mulaiyO muzhumuRRum pOndhila moy pUnguzhal kuRiya kalaiyO araiyillai nAvO kuzhaRum kadal maNNellAm vilaiyO ena miLirum kaN ivaL paramE perumAn malaiyO thiruvEngadam enRu kaRkinRa vAsagamE

Word-by-Word Meanings

mulaiyO – if one considers her bosom

muzhumuRRum – even a little bit

pOndhila – have not sprouted

moy – being dense

pU – being beautiful

kuzhal – locks

kuRiya – are short

kalaiyO – if one considers her dress

araiyillai – has not been properly tied on the waist

nAvO – if one considers her tongue

kuzhaRum – will not be clear

kadal – surrounded by the ocean

maN ellAm – this entire earth

vilaiyO ena – will it be the price (for the eyes)

kaN – the eye

miLirum – huge

perumAn – sarvESvaran’s

malaiyO – if one considers thirumalai

thiruvEngadam – it happens to be thiruvEngadam

enRu – saying so

kaRkinRa – learning

vAsagam – spoken word

ivaL paramE – is it apt for her in her state?

Simple Translation

The bosoms of this girl have not sprouted. Her locks which are dense and beautiful are short. The dress which she wears does not sit well on her waist. Her tongue has not grown out of her child-like gibberish way of speaking. However her eyes are sparkling such that one could say that even the earth, surrounded by ocean, is not equivalent in terms of compensation for them. Her words saying that sarvESvaran's divine hill is thiruvEngadam is indeed surprising.

vyAkyAnam

mulaiyO . . . – these words are best said after reaching a certain stage [in the development of a girl's life].

mulaiyO muzhu muRRum pOndhila – it is not that her bosoms have not grown properly; even the place from where they sprout has not been identified [she is such a young girl].

moy pUnguzhal kuRiya – the locks which are dense and beautiful.

kuRiya – they are so short that if the *nAyakan* wants to arrange the locks into a bun and she, not liking that arrangement, wishes to let the locks down, he will not [be able to] fall at her feet [to beg her to keep them as a bun].

kalaiyO araiyillai – she does not even know as to where to tie her dress.

nAvO kuzhaRum – if the mothers teach her a few words, she would pronounce them indistinctly, like gibberish. They would then teach her a few simple words such as “*iyar* {father}, *Achchi* (mother)” Her indistinct words sound better than their clear pronunciation.

kadal . . . – when parASara bhattar was explaining this pAsuram, his disciple, nanjlyar told him “he (AzhwAr) says that all the other limbs have not developed well. But he has spoken about the greatness of eyes alone. This appears contradictory” to which bhattar responded saying “It is not that way. Even here, he has stated only the condition of under-development”. “How is that?” “At a small age, the eyes will see objects fully; at a youthful stage [adolescent age], the eyes will see through glance only. Hence, here too AzhwAr is speaking of very young age only” The splendour in her eyes is such that even if the entire earth, surrounded by ocean, is given as a compensation, it will not be a match.

miLirum – even if the waves keep pushing against the shore, they cannot cross it. This is similar to that. When united with *nAyakan*, a girl will look at him with tenderness and love. Unlike that, this girl would look at her mother and her beloved, equally.

ivaL paramE – Is it apt for her age? It is because of her friends, just as it has been mentioned in periyAzhwAr thirumozhi 3-7-2 “*sAyvilAdha kuRundhalai*” (even though they are young without any shyness or reverence, my girl is joining with a few girls and appears like one possessed).

perumAL malaiyO thiruvEngadamenRu – is it apt for her age to disregard para and vyUha forms of sarvESvaran and focus on archA form, and that too saying that thiruvEngadam is the divine hill for his residence? vEdhas set out to measure one quality, the joy of sarvESvaran, and returned empty handed. But the eminence of archAvathAram is not like that.

kaRkinRa vAsagam – the words spoken by her; alternatively, the words taught by her mothers so that they could hear them from her mouth. thiruvAimozhi 6-5-7 says “ *ivaL vAyanagaL thirundha* ” (to appear clearly from her mouth). The verse could be arranged as *ivaL paramE perumAL malaiyO thiruvEngadamenRu kaRkinRa vAsagamE* in which the meanings would be as given till now; alternatively, the words could be arranged as *perumAL malai thiruvEngadamenRu kaRkinRa vAsagamE O ivaL paramE* in which case, the sound *O ivaL paramE* would indicate astonishment.

svApadhEsam (distinguished meaning): Just as it has been mentioned in Srl rAmAyaNam bAla kANdam 18-28 “ *bAlyAth prabhruthi susnigdha* :” (amiable since childhood) and thiruvAimozhi 2-3-3 “ *aRiyAkkAlaththuLLE* ” (at that age when I did not know about servitude), this pAsuram speaks about how AzhwAr’s engagement with matters relating to emperumAn has always been his sustaining force.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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63. pAsuram 61 – vAsagam seyvadhu

avathArikai (Introduction)

In the previous pAsuram, the *nAyaki*'s mother, after hearing her saying “*perumAn malaiyO thiruvEngadam enRu kaRkinRa vAsagamE*” elucidated it. On hearing this explanation, AzhwAr returned to his original form [from his feminine form]. Once he realises his true nature, since he is always engaged with krishNAvathAram, he is once again amazed [at the simplicity of that avathAram] .

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

vAsagam seyvadhu nam paramE thollai vAnavar tham nAyagan nAyagar ellAm thozhumavan gyAlam muRRum vEyagamAyinum sOrAvagai iraNdE adiyAl thAyavan AykkulamAy vandhu thOnRiRRu nam iRaiyE

Word-by-Word Meanings

thollai vAnavar tham – for nithyasUris who have been present from time immemorial

nAyagan – as the lord

nAyagar ellAm – all entities such as brahmA et al

thozhumavan – being worshipped

gyAlam muRRum – entire world

vEy agam Ayinum – sufficient space for planting bamboo pole

sOrA vagai – not leaving [even that]

iraNdE adiyAl – with only two steps

thAyavan – one who measured

nam iRai – Sriya:pathim (consort of Srl mahAlakshmi), being our lord

AykkulamAy – in the clan of herdsfolk

vandhu thOnRiRRu – that he came and incarnated

vAsagam seyvadhu – to narrate it

nam paramE – is it possible for us?

Simple Translation

Is it possible for us to speak about the incarnation, in the clan of herdsfolk, of one who is the lord of nithyasUris who have been present from time immemorial, who is worshipped by brahmA who is the lord of celestial entities, who measured this world with just two steps without leaving space even for a bamboo pole to be planted and who is our lord?

vyAkyAnam

vAsagam seyvadhu nam paramE – apart from being unconscious, as mentioned in thiruvAimozhi 1-3-1 “*eththiRam*” (how amazing!), is it possible for us to praise sarvESvaran? Why can’t we praise him through pAsurams? . . .

thollai vAnavar – just as it has been mentioned in achchidhram 42 “*prathamajAyEpurANA* :” (they have been here from the beginning) he is the controller of nithyasUris.

AykkulamAy vandhu thOnRiRRu vAsagam seyvadhu nam paramE – without any distinction between vEdhams (sacred texts) and those who follow the vEdhams, none can speak about him. vEdhams, which desired to speak about his quality of happiness, returned empty handed, as mentioned in thaiththirlyya upanishath 6 “*yathO vAchO nivarthanthE*” (mind and words came back without being able to speak). purusha sUktham says “*thasya dhlrA : parijAnanthi yOnim*” (only those who are well versed would know about his incarnations)

– *thasya yOnim* : sarvESvaran is without any karma (result of sin or virtue from past deeds). Yet, due to his quality of simplicity, he takes birth; the most prominent among wise will not know about it despite engaging deeply with it; they will keep coming back repeatedly, trying to immerse in it. sarvESvaran himself says, as in Srl bhagavath glthA 4-9 “*janmakarmacha mE dhivya*” (my birth and karma are divine) and in Srl bhagavath glthA 7-24 “*parambhAvam*” (superior state). For AzhwAr, to remain unconscious, being amazed at his simplicity, is a naturally occurring phenomenon.

thollai vAnavar tham nAyagan – he is superior to nithyasUris

nAyagar eIlAm thozhumavan – even celestial entities such as brahmA et al, who take pride in saying “We control the fourteen worlds” will remove that pride from their minds and worship him. They, who are termed as being without a birth, will worship sarvESvaran who takes birth in this world. They, who are not visible to human beings, will come after the killing of demon rAvaNa and worship him.

gyAlam . . . – he took over the entire area of earth, without leaving space for even planting a bamboo shoot, with his two steps. Just as dhuryOdhanan had said “I will not give pAndavas, the space even for planting a bamboo shoot”, sarvESvaran, for the sake of his follower indhra, said that he will not give mahAbali even the space for planting a bamboo shoot.

iraNdE adiyAl thAyavan – he took three steps of land as alms from mahAbali and measured the entire space with two steps, keeping the third step on mahAbali’s head to imprison him.

AykkulamAy vandhu thOnRiRRu – he had taken hold of the entire earth under his divine foot and came down to earth as the child of one of the entities caught under his divine foot. Is it possible to praise this simplicity through a pAsuram?

AykkulamAy – just as bruhadhAraNyaka upanishath 5-5 says “*bAlyEnathishtAsEth*” (leaving aside the qualities of silence and not being silent, one becomes a brahmA gyANi (knowing about sarvESvaran)), if a samsAri gains even a little bit of wisdom, he will not manifest his expertise. When such is the case, what is surprising when sarvESvaran, who is omniscient, hides all his supreme nature etc and does not reveal about himself? Srl rAmAyaNam ayOdhyA kANda, 1-7 says “*jagyE vishNu: sanAthana* :” (vishNu, the eternal entity, was indeed born) – when those who attained him and those who have been there from time immemorial do not take birth here, is it possible to praise him when he is born here?

vandhu thOnRiRRu – didn’t Srl vishNu purANam 5-3-2 say “*AvirbhUtham*” (he appeared)? [bhagavan’s incarnations are unlike AthmAs assuming bodies, by their karma]

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64. pAsuram 62 – iRaiyO irakkinum

avathArikai (Introduction)

In the previous pAsuram, AzhwAr was reminiscing about krishNavathAram. He felt saddened that he had not been born in this world, during that time. Due to the pain of this separation, he returned to his earlier feminine mood (as *nAyaki*). Her mother says that the sounds of the ocean aggravated her distress of separation.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

iRaiyO irakkinum IngOr peNpAl enavum irangAdhu aRaiyO ena ninRu adhirum karungadal IngivaL than niRaiyO ini un thiruvaruLAI anRik kApparidhAI muRaiyO aravaNaimEl paLLi koNda mugil vaNNanE

Word-by-Word Meanings

karum kadal – ocean which has a dark complexion

irakkinum – even if beseeched

Or – without any support

peNpAl enavum – even if the person happens to be a lady

Ingu – in her matters

iRai – even a little bit

irangAdhu – is not taking pity

aRaiyO ena – like those who make a huge noise

ninRu – remaining firmly

adhirum – it is making a noise

O – Oh, how cruel!

aravaNai mEl – on top of the mattress, AdhiSEshan

paLLikoNda – one who has reclined

mugil vaNNanE – Oh lord, who has the complexion of cloud!

Ingu – at this place

ivaL than – her

niRaiyO – modesty

ini – henceforth

un thiruvaruLAI anRi – other than by your mercy (with any other entity)

kAppu aridhu – difficult to protect

muRaiyO – (is this) apt?

Simple Translation

The dark ocean, despite being beseeched by her, is not taking any pity on her, even though she is without any support. The ocean is like those who are making a war-cry, being very firm. How cruel is this! Oh lord, who is having the complexion of cloud and who is reclining on the mattress, AdhiSEshan! Her situation is such that she cannot be protected by anything other than your mercy, henceforth. Is her condition proper?

vyAkyAnam

irakkinum IngOr peNpAl enavum iRaiyO irangAdhu – this ocean is not taking even a little bit of pity on her despite her falling at its feet, saying “taking refuge is indeed a great act which manifests her state”, despite hinting “she is without any help and has no other refuge”. This is similar to revealing our weakness to those who harm us, thus giving them an opportunity to harm us even more. vyAkyAthA cites Srl rAmAyaNam yudhdha kANDam SIOkam 21-8 “ *adhya mEmaraNam vAtha tharaNamsAgarasya vA* ” (Sri rAma says that today either he should cross the ocean or die). Even after Srl rAma performed SaraNAgathi (surrendered) to the king of ocean, he did not come. However, the moment he strung the arrow on his bow, he came helter-skelter. Thus, the ocean will not take pity for SaraNAgathi, but will, for the arrow. It will not consider SaraNAgathi but will take pity when faced with death.

aRaiyO ena ninRu adhirum kadal – the ocean behaved like sugrIva who sounded the war-cry on vAli saying “Will you come out of your hiding to fight with me?”

karum kadal – the ocean appears as if its anger inside is visible on its surface. Just as the saying goes “ *sivappum karuppum sinam* ” (red and black colours are manifestation of anger)

Ingu . . . – the modesty of this girl who is in such a distressed state.

un thiruvaryl anRik kApparidhAl – she has lost her senses due to her deep love for you; without your mercy, which is the manifestation of your true nature, she will not revive. She has crossed the stage when she could have corrected herself, due to fear of being ridiculed by the people of the town.

muRaiyO – Srl rAmAyaNam sundhara kANDam 39-30 says “ *thath thasya sadhruSam bhavEth* ” ((SrlthAppirAtti tells hanuman) if Srl rAma comes here and takes me with him after destroying lankA, it will be appropriate for his valour). Instead of waiting like that for him, here, the *nAyaki* is calling out to him to protect her; this is her situation now.

aravaNai . . . – her beauty and the arrangement of the mattress are such that even if she had dressed herself in saffron robe (indicating renunciation) she should have been accepted.

aravaNai mEl – while she is lying on the hard floor, you are looking out for a soft mattress.

mugil vaNNanE – when a person was reading out this line, embAr (disciple and successor of ramAnujar) [sarcastically] told him “even after she has called out so much, if he is not going to turn in her direction, he should be a great sage. Hence, instead of saying *mugil vaNNan* , call him as *mugil vaNNar* (the end syllable *ar* in *vaNNar* is an honorific term, indicating respect while the end syllable *an* in *vaNNan* indicates someone who is of same status or lower status). Even if one gets hit with stick, the person who is hitting should be addressed respectfully” embAr is one who takes delight in the togetherness of perumAL and pirAtti; here, he takes the side of pirAtti when they are separated [and shows his anger on perumAL who is delaying in uniting with pirAtti].

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): This pAsuram illustrates how the distress in separation makes one to destroy one's *svarUpam* (true nature) to attain the end benefit, instead of waiting for the appropriate time, in line with one's *svarUpam* .

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65. pAsuram 63 – vaNNam sivandhuLa

avathArikai (Introduction)

She had asked him whether it was correct (*muRaiyO?*) in the previous pAsuram. The *nAyakan* came immediately and looked at her with comforting eyes.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*vaNNam sivandhuLa vAnAdamarum kuLir vizhiya thaNmen kamalaththadam pOl polindhana thAm
ivaiyO kaNNan thirumAL thirumugam thannOdu kAdhal seydhERku eNNam pugundhu adiyEnOdu
ikkAlam irukkinRavE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

vaNNam – due to colour

sivandhuLa – becoming red

vAn nAdu – nithyasUris who are in paramAkASam (SrlvaikuNtam)

amarum – to sustain

kuLir – refreshing

vizhiya – having glance

thaN – being cool

mel – being soft

kamalam – lotus flowers which have blossomed

thadam pOla – like a pond

polindhana – being splendid

ivaidham – these divine eyes

thirumAL – being SrIya:pathi (consort of Srl mahAlakshmi)

kaNNan – purushOththaman (best among all chEthanAs), who is obedient to his followers

thirumugam thannOdu – with the divine face

(in that matter)

kAdhal seydhERku – one who is desirous, my

eNNam – with that intention

pugundhu – entered [on their own]

adiyEnodu – with me, the servitor

ikkAlam – during the present time

irukkinRavE – are present

Simple Translation

The eyes [of sarvESvaran] are reddish in colour, are the sustaining force for nithyasUris who are in SrlvaikuNtam due to their refreshingly cool glance and are splendorous like cool, soft lotus flowers which have blossomed in a pond. These eyes entered my heart on their own, when I was with the intention of desiring the divine face of Sriya:pathi, the obedient kaNNan, and are present without leaving me.

vyAkyAnam

vaNNam sivandhuLa – the divine eyes of sarvESvaran are reddish as a natural corollary of not having seen AzhwAr. With this term *vaNNam sivandhuLa*, it is opined that these were like this even earlier. The distress of separation is similar to what Srl rAma had said in Srl rAmAyaNam sundhara kANdam 66-10 “*najlvEyam kshaNamapi*” (I cannot live even for a moment (without slthAppirAtti)). The implication is that the reddishness in the eyes which happened due to not seeing AzhwAr, has now gone.

vAnAdu amarum kuLir vizhiya – those in *thripAdhvibhUthi* (SrlvaikuNtam which is three times bigger than *leelAvibhUthi*, the materialistic realm) sustain themselves through these divine eyes. The divine eyes are cool, so that they [nithyasUris] could sustain themselves. Sustenance for them is through eating, dressing and living, because of the divine eyes. They are *dhArakam*, *pOshakam* and *bhOgyam* (water as sustaining material, food as nourishment and betel leaves as enjoyment) for nithyasUris.

thaN . . . – the divine eyes appear like a pond whose surface is full of just blossomed lotus flowers which are cool and soft.

thAmivaiyO – just as it has been mentioned in chAndhOgya upanishath 1-6-7 “*thasya yathA kapyAsam puNdarIkam Evam akshiNI*”, we have heard through those who recite vEdhams that sarvESvaran’s divine eyes are like just blossomed lotus flowers. Would they be like these?

kaNNan thirumAL – should be rearranged as *thirumAL kaNNan* – Sriya:pathi, the consort of Srl mahAlakshmi, who is like an obedient attendant of his followers.

thirumugam thannOdum kAdhal seydhERku – for me who had desired that such *nAyakan* should come with his beautiful, divine face and glance at me with his cool divine eyes.

eNNam pugundhu – entering, as I had intended. Alternatively, considering my desire as his own.

adiyEnodu – AzhwAr says as in jithanthE SIOkam 1 “*jitham*” (success to you). The true nature of the word *aham* (I) appears to be *adiyEn* (your servitor). The term *adiyEn* has two meanings: AzhwAr says that he has lost out to the beauty of the divine eyes and has become a servant. *adiyEn* also refers to the natural servitude (of jlvAthmA). What is the *pramANam* (authentic source) for saying that servitude is the natural quality of jlvAthma? thaiththirlyA upanishath nArAyaNavalli 5-1 says “*OmithyAthmAnam yunjitha*” (one should meditate on AthmA, by reciting the praNava manthram, *Om*) as well as in the vEdhic saying *OnkArO bhagavAn vishNu* – vishNu is identified by the manthram *Om*.

ikkALam – I do not know if the reason for the benefit that I had attained [of his divine eyes entering me] had happened earlier.

irukkinRavE – just as it has been said in chAdhOgya upanishath 8-15 “ *na cha punarAvarthathE* ” (those who reach SrlvaikuNtam do not return), it appears as if mOksham has been attained. It appeared that he would not separate again from her. It appeared that he had come right in front of her.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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66. pAsuram 64 – irukkAr mozhiyAl

avathArikai (Introduction)

In the earlier pAsuram AzhwAr had said that sarvESvaran had glanced at him with his divine eyes and showered his mercy on him. He analysed this saying “Why did he glance at me with his divine eyes instead of at his favourable ones?” He concludes saying “I had recited his divine names superficially and not even wholeheartedly. It could be because of this”

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*irukkAr mozhiyAl neRi izhukkAmai ulagaLandha thiruththALiNai nilaththEvar vaNanguvar yAmum avA
orukkA vinaiyodum emmodum nondhu kaniyinmaiyl karukkAy kadippavar pOl thirunAmachchol
kaRRanamE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

irukku – being mentioned in *rig vEdham* (one of the four parts of sacred texts)

Ar – completely (explaining the true nature of supreme entity)

mozhiyAl – with purusha sUktham

neRi – the supreme path of worshipping supreme entity

izhukkAmai – without mistake

nilaththEvar – SrlvaishNavas, who are referred to as the dhEvathAs (celestial entities) of earth

ulagu – world

aLandha – one which measured

thiruththALiNai – divine feet

vaNanguvar – will worship [and attain]

yAmum – we too

avA – desire

orukkA – not allowing to reach

vinaiyodum – with sins

emmodum – and with us

(looking at these two true natures)

nondhu – grieving

kani inmaiyl – due to absence of fruit

karukkAy – unripened fruit

kadippavar pOl – those who eat

thirunAmachchol – divine names without following the meanings

kaRRanamE – learnt

Simple Translation

brAhmaNas who are referred to as celestial entities on earth, keep worshipping the two divine feet [of sarvESvaran] which measured all the worlds, through purusha sUktham seen in rig vEdham, which explains the true nature of the supreme entity, without transgressing from the path of righteousness. We grieve at our sins and our nature which are a hurdle to realise our desire of worshipping in a similar way. Consequently, we learnt only to recite the divine names of sarvESvaran, just as those who eat only unripened fruit since ripened fruit is not available.

vyAkyAnam

irukkAr mozhiyAl – Due to the distinguished knowledge of those who had carried out *prapaththi* (SaraNagathi, or act of surrendering) to SarvESvaran, through the lines mentioned in rig vEdham, the lands where crops grow to a meagre extent as well as arid lands became fully grown lands. The vyAkyAthA says that there is no need to feel bewildered that in vEdhams, terms such as Sambhu et al denote rudhra, brahmA et al as eminent entities. This is because the distinguished divine word of nArAyaNa as mentioned in places describing sarvESvaran's *svarUpam*, *rUpam*, *guNam*, *vibhUthi* (true nature, divine form, auspicious qualities and wealth respectively) is superior to everything else. In other words, he says that in nArAyaNa anuvAkam, only sarvESvaran is spoken of. In yajur AraNyakam, the verse *sarvE vEdhA yathraikambhavathi* refers to the fact that only nArAyaNa is being recited in everything [including the defining names of all entities]. Since all the terms which refer to eminent entities in this nArAyaNa anuvAkam speak only about nArAyaNa, it should be considered that all the terms refer only to him.

neRi izhukkAmAi – not deviating from *bhagavath ArAdhanam* (worshipping of sarvESvaran), which is the path of righteousness,

ulagaLandha thiruththAliNai – his nature is such that he would say “Whether these entities (both sentient and insentient) do or do not know, these are all my property; I will not let go of them”. When all the entities were not even aware of, did he not redeem them all, by measuring everyone and everything?

nilaththEvar vaNanguvar – though the brAhmaNAs are living in this *samsAram* (materialistic world), just as they have been referred to in thiruviruththam 79 *viNNuLArilum sriyar* (they are more eminent than nithyasUris), they are considered as dhEvathAs [celestial entities] on earth.

yAmum – I, who am not having knowledge on SAsthrams just like they have

avA orukkAvinaiyodum emmodum – my sins prevent me from engaging with matters related to sarvESvaran with the same desire which I have towards worldly matters. I am grieving about those sins and about me, who is having those sins. Grieving because of the fact that these are there and I am there, carrying on with these sins.

kani inmaiyl karukkAy kadippavar pOI – even though I do not have the qualification which they have in worshipping, without deviating from the path of righteousness, I recited only the divine names, just as one who does not have access to fruits, eats only the unripened ones.

thirunAmachchol kaRRaname – even when I recited those divine names, I did so without knowing their meanings. I had not even known their greatness. However, sarvESvaran showered his mercy upon me, without any reason.

Alternative explanation:

avA . . . – there is a sin which enables the desire which is there for worldly matters to be diverted towards matters related to sarvESvaran. It is referred to as *bhakthi* [devotion]. Could *bhakthi* be termed as sin? Since it is the cause for suffering when one does not attain bhagavAn, it can be termed as a sin.

kani inmaiyl karukkAy kadippavar pOl – just as those who eat the unripened fruit when ripened ones are not available, AzhwAr had to make do with reciting divine names. He wanted to see sarvESvaran with his eyes and embrace him with his hands. In such a situation, what could he do with only reciting of divine names? There is another interpretation for the word *kani inmai* . Just as people would eat an unripened fruit before it becomes ripened, before nithyasUris could enjoy him [sarvESvaran], AzhwAr destroyed him by only speaking about him.

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67. pAsuram 65 – kaRRuppiNai

avathArikai (Introduction)

The *nAyakan* , caught in the glance of *nAyaki* , narrates how her eyes harmed him.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*kaRRuppiNai malarkkaNNin kulam venRu OrOkarumam uRRuppayinRu sevyodusAvi ulagamellAm
muRRum vizhungi umizhndha pirAnAr thiruvadikklzh uRRumuRAdhum miLirndha kaNNAy emmai
uNginRavE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

kanRu – being youthful

piNai – doe's [female deer's]

malarndha – blossomed

kaNNin – eyes'

kulam – gathering

venRu – being victorious

OrO karumam – one task

uRRu – determining

payinRu – attempting (to do that)

sevyodu – with ears

usAvi – discussing (that task)

ulagamellAm – all the worlds

muRRum – completely

vizhungi – swallowing (during the time of deluge)

umizhndhu – spitting out (during the time of creation)

pirAnAr – benefactor, sarvESvaran's

thiruvadikklzh – under his divine feet

uRRum – fitting (with me)

uRAdhum – not fitting

miLirndha – looking radiantly

kaNNAy – having the name 'eyes'

emmai – us

uNginRa – (two entities) are harming me

Simple Translation

The eyes of the *nAyaki*, emerging victorious over the eyes of a rangale of deer [a herd of deer], determining to carry out a job and attempting to carry it out, engaged in a discussion with her ears. Despite being present under the divine feet of sarvESvaran who benefitted the worlds by swallowing them (during the time of deluge) and by spitting them out (during the time of creation), the two entities of the *nAyaki*, called as eyes, are engaging and disengaging with me, harming me in the bargain.

vyAkyAnam

kaRRuppiNaimalar – deer which is young; the eyes of such a young deer.

malarkkaN – eyes which are like flowers, viz. well opened eyes.

kulam venRu – being victorious over the eyes of all young deer.

OrO karumam . . . – thinking of a specific task only, and discussing with ears on that specific task. Instead of engaging with several tasks at the same time, without attachment with any of those, thinking intently about one task alone; just as it has been mentioned in Srl bhagavath glthA 10-9 “*bOdhayantha: parasparam*” (discussing with each other), glancing at only the *nAyakan*. When he looks at her, she will change her glance and appear to look elsewhere, just as it has been mentioned in thirukkuRaL 1094 “*yAnOkkungAlainilan nOkkum nOkkAkAlthAn nOkki mella nagum*” (when I look at her, she will avoid my look and look at the ground below; when I am not looking at her, she will look at me and smile gently).

ulagamellAm . . . – despite being under the divine feet of the protector of all the worlds. The eyes will cause harm in spite of being under his boundary.

uRRum uRAdhum miLirndha – the eyes will look at him, questioningly. If he looks at her with ecstasy, they [the eyes] will change their glance to some other direction and shine lustrously.

kaNNay emmai uNginRavE – A harmful object, allegedly called as eyes, will harm me.

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): This is the situation of SrivaishNavas who are looking at AzhwaR’s situation. The verse *kaRRuppiNaimalarkkaNNin kulam venRu* refers to innocence regarding what is to be done. *OrO karumam uRRup payinRu* refers to *prapaththi* (SaraNAgathi, the act of surrendering to sarvESvaran). Is this not related to knowledge? How is there a connection with the previously stated innocence? Even though *prapaththi* is manifestation of knowledge, there is a lack of focus in it, due to innocence. The act of *prapaththi* arises out of one’s true nature as a jlvAthmA and is not to be considered as an effort taken by the jlvAthmA to attain the means.

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68. pAsuram 66 – uNNAdhu uRangAdhu

avathArikai (Introduction)

This pAsuram also reveals the words spoken by the *nAyakan* who is engaged with the beauty of the *nAyaki*'s eyes.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

uNNAdhu uRangAdhu uNarvuRum eththanai yOgiyarkkum eNNAy miLirum iyalvinavAm eri nlr vaLi vAn maNNAgiya emperumAn thanadhu vaigundhamannAL kaNNAY aruvinaiyEn uyirAyina kAvigaLE

Word-by-Word Meanings

eri – for fire

nlr – for water

vaLi – for air

vAn – for sky

maN – for earth

Agiya – as indwelling soul

emperumAn thanadhu – for emperumAn who is my benefactor, his wealth

vaigundham annAL – she, who is like SrlvaikuNtam (having enjoyability)

kaNNAY – being called as eyes

aru – cruel

vinaiyEn – I, having sins

uyirAyina – life-giving airs

kAvigaL – red water lily

uNNAdhu – foregoing food

uRangAdhu – foregoing sleep

uNarvu – knowledge (about true nature of AthmA)

uRum – those who have attained

eththanai yOgiyarkkum – for even the distinguished people who carry out meditation

eNNAy – to think about

miLirum – being radiant

iyalvinavAm – they have that nature

Simple Translation

She is like SrlvaikuNtam, which is the abode of sarvESvaran who remains as the indwelling soul of the five elements, fire, water, air, sky and earth. Her two eyes are like red water lily and are the life sustaining airs for me. Her eyes, which are radiant, are such that even great yOgis, who keep constantly meditating on sarvESvaran, foregoing their food and sleep, would keep thinking of.

vyAkyAnam

uNNadhu . . . – unable to sustain themselves through the pleasures available in this world, with the intellect that this world and its materials are to be renounced, being firm in their minds that only the AthmA which is the goal to be attained is apt, considering that even that entity AthmA is not independent but a conduit for obtaining knowledge about sarvESvaran – even for such yOgis

eNNay miLirum iyalvinavAm – if such people, as described above, were to become the target of these eyes, even they will discard the supreme entity who they can attain as their nature, and consider these eyes as eminent.

eri . . . – the causal factors of the five elements are representative of the effect factors too [whatever is enjoyed through these five entities]. sarvESvaran has all these as his wealth.

emperumAn – sarvESvaran's vibhUthis (spiritual and materialistic realms) are the benefits for one. Apart from his auspicious qualities, his vibhUthis are also apt for him.

thanadhu vaigundham annAL – unlike the materialistic realm which is created and destroyed repeatedly, she is like his nithyavibhUthi (SrlvaikuNtam) which is never destroyed and which is his natural abode as well as confidential to him.

kaNNay . . . – when such a lady came near me, her eyes, which are the most important limb in her form, which are like the entity AthmA which does not change or does not get destroyed, and which, unlike the AthmA, remain independent and cause harm, indeed harmed me.

aruvinaiyEn – I have carried out such sinful activities that the entity which should protect me, is harming me.

uyirAyina kAvigaLE – when they are with her, they remain as her eyes; when she comes near me, they are like my life.

uyirAyina kAvigaLE – it appeared as if life took a form to harm me.

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): Thus, for the SrlvaishNavas who are enjoying the *SrlvaishNavaSrl* (wealth of service to sarvESvaran) of AzhwAr, this gives their position of *dhEvum maRRaRiyEn* (we do not know of any other deity). They cherish him because of connection with sarvESvaran. This states how his *SrlvaishNavaSrl* is so complete that they do not cherish sarvESvaran but cherish him. Those who are engaging with *charamAvathi* (ultimate position) will not engage with *prathamAvathi* (primary position) [in other words, AchAryan takes precedence over sarvESvaran, which is the underlying principle of SrlvaishNavam]

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69. pAsuram 67 – kAviyum neelamum

avathArikai (Introduction)

In this pAsuram too, the *nAyakan* keeps talking about the beauty of her eyes.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*kAviyum neelamum vElum kayalum palapalavenRu Aviyin thanmai aLavalla pArippu asuraichcheRRa
mAviyam puL valla mAdhavan gOvindhan vEngadam sEr thUviyam pEdai annAL kaNgaLAya thuNai
malarE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

asurai – demons

seRRa – one who annihilated

mA – having greatness

viyam – having amazing activities

puL – garuda

valla – capable of conducting (as his vehicle)

mAdhavan – Sriya:pathi (consort of Sri mahAlakshmi)

gOvindhan – sarvESvaran, who tends to cows, his

vEngadam – in his divine abode of thiruvEngadam

sEr – living permanently

am – beautiful

thUvi – having wings

pEdai annAL – *nAyaki* who is like a female swan

kaNgaLAya – called as eyes

thuNai – together

malar – like flowers (these)

pArippu – spread

kAviyum – red lily

neelamum – blue lily

vElum – spear

kayalum – fish

palapala – and various other entities

venRu – emerging victorious

Aviyyin – AthmA's

thanmai – svabhAvam (true nature)

aLavalla – cannot be contained (it will go beyond)

Simple Translation

This *nAyaki* is like a female swan which is permanently residing in thiruvEngadam. This is the abode of sarvESvaran, who conducts garuda who annihilates demons. He has great eminence and has amazing activities, who has Srl mahAlakshmi constantly on his chest and who tends to cows. Such *nAyaki*'s eyes are like flowers which match each other well. Their expansive nature wins over many entities such as red lily, blue lily, spear, fish etc and are beyond the nature of AthmA.

vyAkyAnam

kAviyum . . . – If one were to look for an entity which matches her eyes, one has to refer to Srl rAmAyaNam bAla kANdam 1-18 “ *vishNunA sadhruSA: vIryE sOmavath priya dharSana: kAla agni sadhruSA: krOdha kshamayA prithvl samA:* ” (matching Srl mahAvishNu in valour, chandhiran (chandhra – moon) in attracting others, agni in anger, bhUmi (earth) in patience); as mentioned in this SIOkam, in each attribute, one has to compare with several entities and even then, one will have a doubt whether these would be an exact match for that attribute. In this SIOkam, in the verse *vishNunA sadhruSO vIryE* he compared parathvam (supreme) only to the quality of valour. Here, it is not so. By its [eye's] reddish colour it was superior to red lily, by its dark colour it was superior to blue lily, by its sharpness it was superior to a spear and by its innocence it was superior to fish; thus it was superior to several entities.

Aviyyin thanmai aLavalla pArippu – is destroying entities such as flowers etc, which will in any case get destroyed in course of time, a sign of victory? The eyes are capable of destroying even AthmA which is indestructible.

Aviyyin thanmai aLavalla – not stopping merely with the entity of AthmA, going towards the entity which is the sustaining force for it – in other words, her limbs are capable of bewildering even sarvESvaran.

asurai . . . – one who is capable of conducting garuda who destroys the demons along with their clan, who is great and is equivalent to emperumAn himself, having amazing activities.

mAdhavan – more than the greatness of being the conductor of garuda, sarvESvaran has the greatness of being the consort of Srl mahAlakshmi.

gOvindhan – due to that union with Srl mahAlakshmi, he is simple to attain; that simplicity made him come down to thirumalai and be easily approachable to his followers, making that easy approachability as a sign of supremacy. The *nAyaki* is like *thUviyampEdai* – the female swan which has beautiful wings, which will live only in that thiruvEngadam, belonging to gOvindhan and not in any other place. Alternatively, *thUviyampEdai* could refer to Srl mahAlakshmi, and in this case, *nAyaki* is similar to Srl mahAlakshmi. What is the necessity to speak about *garudavAhanan* , *lakshminAthan et al* ? He wanted to talk about sarvESvaran's easy approachability, spoke about supremacy which is the basis for the quality of easy approachability and finally he came into the boundary of simplicity.

kaNgalaAya thuNai malarE – being referred to as eyes, they became two flowers which matched each other.

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): AzhwAr is enjoying the pAsuram of SrivaishNavAs who say that as per AzhwAr there is no limit to those who enjoy the simplicity of one who stands in thirumalai [sarvESvaran].

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70. pAsuram 68 – malarndhE ozhindhila

avathArikai (Introduction)

The *nAyakan*, who had united and later separated from the *nAyaki*, told her before leaving “I will come when the *konRai* flowers blossom (*konRai* is a tree belonging to the legume family, with elongated clusters of yellow flowers)” The *konRai* flowers started blossoming with the arrival of that season. Since the *nAyakan* had not returned, the *nAyaki* felt distressed. Her friend sees the flowers, knows that the season has arrived, but still tells her “They are only in the process of blossoming but have not blossomed yet. He will certainly return at the correct time; do not worry”

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

malarndhE ozhindhila mAlaiyum mAlaiippon vAsigaiyum pulandhOy thazhaippandhal thaNduRa nARRip poru kadal sUzh nilandhAviya emperumAn thanadhu vaigundham annAy kalandhAr varavedhirkoNdu van konRaigaL kArththanavE

Word-by-Word Meanings

poru – agitating

kadal – ocean

sUzh – surrounded by

nilam – bhUmi (earth)

thAviya – one who measured

emperumAn thanadhu – sarvESvaran’s

vaigundham annAy – one who is (enjoyable) like SrIvaikuNtam!

van – being cruel

konRaigaL – konRai trees

kalandhAr – sarvESvaran who united (with you)

varavu – arrival

edhir koNdu – expecting

kArththana – are forming buds

mAlaiyum – as garlands (string)

mAlai – made as garland

pon vAsigaiyum – golden strings

pulam – on the earth

thOy – falling

thazhai – well grown

pandhal – as a bower

thaNdu – in the branches

uRa – fitting

nARRi – making it to hang

malarndhEyozhindhila – have not blossomed fully

Simple Translation

Oh one who gives joy like SrlvaikuNtam which belongs to sarvESvaran, who had measured this earth surrounded by agitating oceans! The cruel *konRai* trees are waiting with buds, for the arrival of sarvESvaran who had united with you. They are not seen with blossomed flowers on their branches which come down like strings of garlands or garlands with golden strings, to the ground from the bower on which they have spread.

vyAkyAnam

malarndhE ozhindhila – the friend tells *nAyaki* “This is not the season when he said he would return” The *nAyaki* tells her “How do you say so even after seeing that the flowers have blossomed?” The friend says “You could only see them trying to blossom; they have not blossomed fully”

mAlai . . . – only if they come down in strings as garlands or as golden strings through those garlands, could one say that they have blossomed. They should come down to the earth in such a way that those who see them would have their sensory organs stolen by them.

poru kadal – [friend’s words] aren’t you matching his indestructible *nithyavibhUthi* (spiritual realm)? Will he allow you to get destroyed? He has one *vibhUthi* (leela *vibhUthi*) which keeps getting formed and destroyed repeatedly and one *vibhUthi* (*nithya vibhUthi*) which is indestructible. Measuring this earth which is surrounded by ocean, he is the lord who brought all the worlds under him.

thanadhu vaigundham annAy – is it possible for you not to have *svarUpa gyAnam* (knowledge about your true nature)? Aren’t you matching his *nithyavibhUthi*? Only if he gives up that *nithyavibhUthi*, would he give you up too. Will he allow you to get distressed?

kalandhAr – even if he does not know your true nature, will he not know his true nature? Would he, who had united with you and knows your importance, let go of you? Know well that his identity is that he is *kalandhAr* (one who united with you).

varavedhir koNdu – even plants which do not know any distinction between correct and incorrect, were ready to blossom as mentioned in Srl rAmAyaNam yudhdha kANDam SIOkam “ *akAlapalinO vrukshA* ” (thought it was not the season, trees blossomed flowers). Thus, when these flowers are waiting for the arrival of *nAyakan* to blossom, why are you upset?

van konRaigal – the *konRai* trees were anxiously waiting, deciding to blossom only when he comes and not otherwise

kArththana – they formed buds. When the embryo is formed, it would change colour. This indicates that. It could also be taken to refer to rainy season.

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): this pAsuram states how those who were nearby comforted AzhwAr, saying that due to his knowledge of sarvESvaran's auspicious qualities and due to the fact that sarvESvaran had entered his mind, sarvESvaran will not remain without coming during the time which is apt for enjoyment.

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71. pAsuram 69 – kArERRiruL

avathArikai (Introduction)

Next, dusk came and started tormenting her. Since the time after dusk is the happy time of night, and since the *nAyakan* had not come there to be with her, the *nAyaki* feels distressed. Her friend tells her “This is not dusk. Two bulls are raring to fight with each other”, making her feel bewildered about time and trying to console her.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*kArERRiruL segilERRin sudarukku uLaindhu velvAn pOrERRu edhirndhadhu punthalai mAlai
bhuvaniyellAm nIrERRaLandha nediya pirAn aruLAvidumE vARERRiLa mulaiyAy varundhEl un
vaLaiththiRamE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

iruL – darkness

kAr – black

ERu – bull

segil – reddish

ERRin – bull (refers to sUriyan (sUrya))

sudarukku – effulgence

uLaindhu – losing out

(hiding all along, now)

velvAn – to win (against that bull)

pOr – battle

ERRu – accepting that

pul – negligible

thalai – duration

mAlai – in the evening time (dusk)

edhirndhadhu – fought

bhuvaniyellAm – throughout the earth

nIr ERRu – accepting water (given as sign of giving alms, from mahAbali)

aLandha – one who seized

nediya – one who had unlimited friendliness

pirAn – sarvESvaran, the benefactor

aruLAvidumE – will he not shower his mercy?

vAr – with bodice

ERRu – being held

iLa mulaiyAy – Oh one who has youthful bosoms!

un vaLaiththiRam – regarding your bangles

varundhEl – do not grieve

Simple Translation

The bull of darkness had lost out to the bull of reddishly splendrous sUriyan. However, in order to win against that bull, it came during dusk, which lasts only briefly. Will sarvESvaran, who had accepted water, as a sign of receiving alms from mahAbali, and measured all the worlds, not show his mercy on you at this time of dusk? Oh one has held her bosoms in a bodice! You need not grieve regarding your bangles.

vyAkyAnam

kArERRiruL – darkness looks like a black bull.

segilERRin sudarukku uLaindhu – surrendered to the rays of reddish bull, called as sUriyan, after losing to it. That dark bull told itself “Should we lose like this such that we would perish? We should also win once” and waged a fight with the reddish bull, donning the garland (or evening) [In thamizh language, both garland and evening are referred to by the same word, *mAlai*].

pun thalai mAlai – *sandhya* (dusk) time which lasts only briefly; dusk which has minute buds of embers of darkness. Is it possible to ascribe buds to evening? Just as it has been mentioned in the saying *nakanibhasunjathiyAnthamOvallaya* : where darkness is compared to a creeper, it is acceptable to say that darkness has buds.

bhuvani . . . – shouldn’t one, who knows sarvESvaran’s qualities, remain patiently? Is he not one who kept his divine foot, which are like the flowers for nithyasUris, on everyone’s head, without any reason, treating indhra as the cause for doing that way? Will he, who is the benefactor for all, leave you behind? Would one, who comes and helps entities who are engulfed by *thamas* (ignorance) and complain to him [reference is to indhra et al], remain idly when *thamas* (darkness) spreads in the world (during dusk)? Would one, who comes seeking alms to reclaim land which others claim as their own [mahAbali] leave you, who are his wealth, and that too when he does not have to seek alms? Would one, who does not let go of anything on this earth which is full of forests and highlands, let you to suffer? Would one, who hastened when the earth was in trouble, remain patiently when a lady is in trouble?

vArERRu iLa mulaiyAy – would he, who keeps his divine feet on forests and highlands, not keep them on your bosoms?

aruLAvidumE – would one, who transforms himself to help those who have the quality of *sathvam* (goodness) occasionally, not help you who is full of *Sudhdha sathvam* (pure goodness)?

bhuvani . . . – he is the great benefactor who feels that he has not done anything even after keeping his divine feet on the heads of everyone, when he measured the earth consequent to accepting water as a sign of taking alms.

aruLAvidumE – even if his affection for you is lost, would even his mercy, which is a corollary of his true nature, not be showered on you?

vaArERRu iLamulaiyAy – oh one who has bosoms which have to be held by a bodice! Would he allow you to bear your bosoms which are to be borne either by the bodice or by him?

iLa mulaiyAy – though you have not reached adulthood, your bosoms are such that they have to be sustained by bodice. Just as children cry out for food during times of hunger, your bosoms are heaving, crying out for worldly pleasures.

varundhEl un vaLaiththiRame – you do not have to grieve for the bangles slipping out of your hands. If you wish, you could grieve for entities on his hands slipping out. Just as it has been said in thiruppallANDu 2 “ *appAnchasanniyamum pallANDu* ” (long live that conch, pAnchajanyam), praise his conch [our bangles are representative of the conch since they are made of conch].

In the previous pAsuram, how AzhwAr sustained himself through the knowledge of sarvESvaran’s auspicious qualities and through sarvESvaran entering his mind, was mentioned. In this pAsuram he says that even that is not required; mere knowledge that he is the protector and we are the entities to be protected is sufficient. *varundhEl un vaLaiththiRame* – this is similar to the saying in bhagavath glthA 18-66 SLOkam “ *mA Sucha :*” (do not grieve). Through the words *aham thvA* , the true nature of both (sarvESvaran and AzhwAr) has been explained and only after that has *mA Sucha :* been said.

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72. pAsuram 70 – vaLai vAy

avathArikai (Introduction)

Due to the craving arising out of the desire of obtaining the garland of thuLasi which had been worn by SrlvaikuNanAthan [sarvESvaran], this pAsuram narrates the difficulty in spending time.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*vaLaivAyth thiruchchakkaraththu engaL vAnavanAr mudimEl thaLaivAy narungaNNith
thaNNandhuzhAykku vaNNam payalai viLaivAn miga vandhu nAL thingaL ANdu Uzhi niRka emmai
uLaivAn pugundhu idhuvOr kangul Ayiram UzhigaLE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

vaLai – being bent

vAy – having mouth

thiruchchakkaraththu – having the divine disc

engaL – being our swAmy

vAnavanAr – sarvESvaran, who is the controller of paramapadham, his

mudimEl – donned atop his divine crown

thaLaivAy – having the opportunity

naRu – having fragrance

thaN – being cool

am – being beautiful

kaNNI – strung as a garland

thuzhAykku – for the divine thuLasi

(desired by me, but feeling sad since it is not available)

vaNNam – c olour

payalai viLaivAn – to make it become pale (losing colour)

idhu – this

Or – one

kangul – night

nAL – as a day

thingaL – as a month

ANdu – as a year

Uzhi niRka – as a kalpam (life time of brahmA), apart from transforming

emmai – us

uLaivAN – to trouble

migavandhu – increasing repeatedly

pugundhu – entering

Ayiram – many

UzhigaL – increased as kalpams

Simple Translation

I desired the cool, beautiful thuLasi garland which is fragrant and has the nice opportunity of decorating the divine crown of our lord sarvESvaran, who has the divine discus which has curved mouth and who is the controller of paramapadham. As a result of this, in order for the complexion in my form to lose its colour and become pale, this one night appears to extend beyond one day, one month, one year and many kalpams, troubling me.

vyAkyAnam

vaLaivAy thiruchchakaraththu – divine disc which has a bent mouth. Alternatively, one who has *vaLai* – Srl pAnchajanyam (divine conch) and *vAy* – divine disc which has mouth. Reference is made to Srl rAmAyaNa SIOkam yudhdha kANdam “*thamasa: paramOdhaAthA Sanka chakra gadhAdhara :’*” (one who is beyond the darkness of ignorance, one who is supreme and who adorns the divine weapons of conch, disc, mace etc).

engaL vAnavanAr mudimEl – having the opportunity of donning the divine crown of SrlvaikuNtanAthan who is having divine weapons, divine garlands and who is the lord of *thripAdhvibhUthi* (nithyavibhUthi, the spiritual realm) which is three times larger than *leelA vibhUthi* (materialistic realm); the garland has been strung by nithyasUris such as AdhiSEshan, garudan et al.

naRungaNNith thaNNandhuzhAykku – the divine garland of divine thuLasi which is fresh.

vaNNam . . . – desiring that divine garland, and becoming pale since it has not been obtained; losing colour.

miga vandhu . . . – the night which came, first became a day; that day then became a month; that month became a year; that year became a kalpam. Thus a single night extended to several kalpams, in order to torment me.

miga vandhu – each part came, getting worse than the previous. Thus, several nights came this way. How one night turned out to be!

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): this pAsuram explains the benefit that AzhwAr desired similar to the benefit which slthAppirAtti attained in Srl rAmAyaNam as mentioned in ayOdhyA kANdam 16-21 “*pathi sammAnithA slthA*” (slthAppirAtti who was given a happy message by her husband) and how it became extremely difficult to spend time on not attaining that benefit.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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73. pAsuram 71 – UzhigaLAy

avathArikai (Introduction)

The *nAyakan* who had clandestinely united with the *nAyaki* and separated from her, sends a few persons to sell fruits to the place where the *nAyaki* resides. These fruits resemble the complexion of his divine form and would help her to lessen her distress in separation. Looking at those fruits, the *nAyaki* sustains herself. Her mother notices this and chides her. The *nAyaki* tells her friends about this excessive act of her mother's.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

UzhigaLAy ulagEzhum uNdAn enRilam pazham kaNdu Azhi kaLAM pazhavaNNam enRERku ahdhE koNdu annai nAzhivaLO enRum gyAlam uNdAn vaNNam solliRu enRum thOzhigaLO uraiyIr emmai ammanai sUzhginRavE

Word-by-Word Meanings

UzhigaLAy – being the controller of all the worlds ruled by time

Ezhu ulagam – (during deluge) all the seven worlds

uNdAn – ate (to keep them in his stomach and protect them)

enRilam – we did not say that

pazham kaNdu – looking at the fruit

kaLAppazha vaNNam – the colour of berry fruit

Azhi – like the colour of ocean

enRERku – to me who said so

ahdhE koNdu – presuming another meaning for that word

annai – (my) mother

ivaL – this girl

nAzh – is clever

enRum – saying so

gyAlam – earth

uNdAn – one who swallowed

vaNNam – complexion

solliRRu – said

thOzhigaLO – Oh my friends!

emmai – regarding me

ammanai – mother

sUzhginRa – saying it repeatedly

(remedy for this)

uraiyIr – please tell

Simple Translation

Oh friends! I had not revealed the name of my *nAyakan* explicitly by saying “He is the lord of all the worlds ruled by time and he protected the seven worlds in his stomach during deluge”. Instead, looking at the colour of berry fruits, I had said “The colour of ocean is the colour of this fruit”. My mother, who listened to my words, said “This girl is very clever! She is referring to the complexion of the one who swallowed all the worlds” Please tell me a remedy since my mother is accusing me repeatedly and hurting me.

vyAkyAnam

UzhigaLAy Ezhulagum uNDAn enRilam – Had I said “During deluge, he swallowed and protected the seven worlds”, I could be accused of talking about him (*sarvESvaran*). However, I had not said “He is the controller of all entities such as time etc; he is the great benefactor who swallowed all these entities during deluge”. Those who say that *sarvESvaran* does not have auspicious qualities will give a different meaning to the words *sathyam*, *gyAnam* etc which are mentioned in *thaiththirIya upanishath Anandhavallee “sathyam gyAnam anantham brahma”* (the supreme entity is permanent, omniscient and unlimited). In the same way, the *nAyaki* too feels happy to praise the greatness of his auspicious qualities by saying indirectly about his complexion etc. She has a right to say this. Her mother too has a right to deny what the *nAyaki* had meant. The right for the *nAyaki* comes from the basis that she cannot remain quiet about someone who has carried out a beneficial act for her; one with intellect cannot keep quiet. Her mother, on the other hand, felt that the *nAyaki*’s thoughts would torment her later. She thought that deep involvement with the qualities of a person would lead to worries later on.

pazham kaNDu – when one looks at an entity in this world, it is natural to identify it by its name. Whether it is *ghatam* (pot) or *patam* (cloth), it is called by its name. Is identifying a material by its name, an offence?

Azhi kaLAM pazhavaNNam enRERku – I merely said that the colour of the berry fruit is similar to the colour of the ocean. However, my mother presumed “She is talking about the one who has the complexion of ocean [*sarvESvaran*]”

ahdhE koNDu – Instead of accepting what I had said, she thought that there was an inner meaning to it.

annai – was she a mother right from the time of her birth? It appears that she had not grown up to the stage of a young girl (before becoming a mother). If there is a fault, it could be chided. But when there is no fault, is it proper to see as to who is controlling and who is being controlled?

nAzhivaLO enRum – we are seeing the fruits and speaking about them. Does she not understand what I am saying? Why is she taking a different meaning for it? Is she having a skill in talking meaninglessly? *nAzh* refers to skill.

What is the greatness of the *nAyaki* ?

gyAlam uNdAn vaNNam solliRRu ennum – sarvESvaran had kept all the worlds during the time of deluge, inside his stomach to protect them. Reminiscing that quality, my daughter could not bear separation from that sarvESvaran.

thOzhigaLO uraiyIr – Oh friends! Don't you stand with me in my happy moments and sad moments? You are not like my mother.

emmai ammanai sUzhginRavE – just like a snake in the house will torment even when it is not biting, whenever someone comes into the house or leaves the house, my mother is tormenting me.

sUzhginRa – my mother is exaggerating things three times. While I am seeing something and speaking about the same thing, my mother torments me saying that there is some other meaning to what I am saying. Only you have to offer me a remedy for this.

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): this pAsuram says that it is not possible to sustain oneself without looking at entities which are equivalent to sarvESvaran and that it is not possible to redeem someone who is having overflowing affection towards sarvESvaran.

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74. pAsuram 72 – sUzhginRa kangul

avathArikai (Introduction)

When the *nAyaki* had to sustain herself by looking at objects which were similar to the *nAyakan*, during the time of separation, the night time entered and started tormenting her. When she was thinking “Who will protect me from the torment of separation?” chandhiran (chandhra – moon) appeared. piLLai amudhanAr used to narrate a story here. One ascetic brAhmaNa was walking through a forest when a cow started following him. He was wondering as to who will protect him from the cow when a tiger happened to come there; it killed the cow and ate it up. It then came in front of the brAhmaNa, twitching its tail. The brAhmaNa thought “I could have at the least saved my life from the cow. Now it appears that there is no way that I could survive this”. The *nAyaki*’s situation is similar to this.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

sUzhginRa kangul surungAviruLin karundhiNimbaip pOzhginRa thingaL am piLLaiyum pOzhga thuzhAy malarkkE thAzhginRa nenjaththoru thamiyAttiyEn mAmaikkinRu vAzhginRavAru idhuvO vandhu thOnRiRRu vAliyadhE

Word-by-Word Meanings

sUzhginRa – pervading everywhere

kangul – caused by the night

surungA – not contracted (huge)

karu – being black

iruL – darkness’

thiNimbai – strength

pOzhginRa – splitting

am – being beautiful

piLLai – favourable like a son

thingaLum – chandhiran too

pOzhga – let him split

(only for that)

vAliyadhu – strong

vandhu thOnRiRRu – it rose up (in the sky)

thuzhAy malarkkE – only for the divine garland of thuLasi (worn by sarvESvaran)

thAzhginRa – languishing

nenjaththu – having heart

oru thamiyAttien – I, who am lonely, without anyone to assist; my

mAmakkku – natural complexion

inRu – during this time

vAzhginRa ARu – the way I live

idhuvO – is it like this?

Simple Translation

Let chandhiraṇ, who rose up to split the black coloured darkness which occurred in the night and which pervaded everywhere, split me too. The beautiful and strong chandhiraṇ, who appeared like a son, seems to have risen up only for splitting me. I am alone, with no support, longing for the divine thuLasi garland worn by sarvESvaraṇ, with a languishing heart. Is this the way to live for my complexion?

vyAkyAnam

sUzhginRa – just as pralayam (deluge) pervades everywhere, this [darkness] pervaded everywhere, without leaving a place where one can take rest away from it.

kangul surungA iruLin – the darkness of the night, without any contraction. There are limits when it is expected to come with full denseness and when it is expected to come without being dense. This did not follow that principle. It was fully dense.

karum thiNimbai – having a black colour. Through the word *thiNimbai*, strength is indicated. It is as if the petals outside the flower of darkness have been removed and the strong diamond-like darkness inside is manifested.

pOzhginRa . . . – chandhiraṇ who comes splitting and tearing apart such darkness. Since I do not have any right over anything outside of myself, let that chandhiraṇ harm me too.

pOzhginRa – darkness and chandhiraṇ are natural enemies. Thus, in the presence of chandhiraṇ, darkness, aside from being torn apart, is being destroyed physically. The strength of darkness and the youthful state of chandhiraṇ are indicated.

thingal am piLLai – chandhiraṇ who is like a beautiful child. Initially he appears as a favourable entity, but later turns out to harm us. He is favourable since he is driving out darkness, but is a harmful entity because he reminds the *nAyaki* of her loneliness. Sri rAmAyaNam kishkindhA kANdam 1-71 “*padhmaKOsa palASani dhrushtvA dhrishtir hi manyathE I slthAyA nEthra kOSAbhyAm sadhruSAm ithi lakshmaNa II*” (Oh lakshmaNa! Since these petals of lotus flower are like the eyes of slthA, when I look at them, I am reminded of her eyes and it hurts me) In other words, when one is in distress, differences are not noticed. Would it be proper for the tongue, which is supposed to eat only tasteful food, to eat poison? In other words, without realising the danger which is going to come from chandhiraṇ, is it proper to call him as being beautiful? Sri rAmAyaNam AraNya kANdam 43-24 says “*paSyA lakshmaNa ...*” (for the sake of this slthA, I will catch that deer; protecting her is our duty), in other words *dharSi saumithri* – look, lakshmaNa – they saw the situation at that point of time and did not think of what would happen later.

thuzhAy malarkkE . . . – desiring to obtain the divine thuLasi garland which decorated his divine shoulder, and having a mind deeply engrossed with that.

thuzhAy malarkkE thAzhginRa – not thinking of the situation when it does not occur that way

oru thamiyAttiiEn – for her loneliness, even the loneliness of sithAppirAtti cannot equal. The *nAyaki* was distressed by both the dark night and chandhiran. The term *oru* (one) signifies that there is no simile for her condition.

mAmaikkinRu vAzhginRavARidhuvO – was it for this that we felt happy that chandhiran has come to remove the distress caused by the dark night?

vandhu thOnRiRRu vAliyadhE – she laments “Just as chandhiran came to get rid of the darkness of the night, isn’t there a sUriyan (sun) who would get rid of the chandhiran?” She says that chandhiran himself would stay firmly and keep harming.

The verses should be arranged this way to convey the sequential meaning: *thingaL am piLLaiyum pOzhga* – let that also come and harm; *vandhu thOnRiRRu vAliyadhE* – over and above that darkness, this chandhiran too appeared to harm; *mAmaikkinRu vAzhginRavARidhuvO* – is this the way for my complexion to survive?

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): Just as it has been said in periyā thiruvandhAdhi 24 “*iruLanna mAmEni*” (divine form which resembles darkness), the dark night reminded AzhwAr of sarvESvaran’s divine form and tormented him. On top of that, chandhiran reminded him of sarvESvaran’s divine face and divine conch and tormented him even further.

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75. pAsuram 73 – vAl veNNilavu

avathArikai (Introduction)

The moon rose to be a huge entity, harming the *nAyaki*, who swooned, unconsciously. Her mother, seeing this, said “Look at the disgrace which has befallen righteousness”

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

vAl veNNilavu ulagArach churakkum veN thingaLenRum pAl viNsuravi suramudhirmAlai paridhivattam pOlum sudar adalAzhippirAn pozhilEzhu aLikkum sAlbin thagaimaikolAm thamiyAtti thaLarndhadhuvE

Word-by-Word Meanings

veN thingaL enRum – being referred to as the whitish moon

viN – moving in the sky

suravi – cow

vAl veN – being very whitish

nilavu – moon

pAl – milk

ulagu – world, considered as the (receptor) vessel

Ara – to be full

surakkum – secreting

sura – secretion

mudhir – matured

mAlai – night time

thamiyAtti – this girl, without any support

thaLarndhadhu – has crumbled

paraidhivattam pOlum – looking like the sun’s halo

sudar – having radiance

adal – battle-ready

Azhi – one who has the divine disc

pirAn – sarvESvaran, who is the benefactor

Ezh pozhil – the seven worlds

aLikkum – protection

sAlbin – the eminence of protection

thagaimai kolAm – is it the true nature?

Simple Translation

This matured evening (night) is filling up the milk of whitish moon in the container of world. It also has the secretion of the cow which is roaming in the sky as moon. During this time, this girl, who is without anyone to help her, is lying in a crumbled state. Is this due to the nature of sarvESvaran who is having the divine disc which has the radiance of the halo of the sun, and who has the greatness of protecting all the worlds?

vyAkyAnam

vAl veNNilavu . . . – the *nAyaki*’s mother is having doubts on the capability of sarvESvaran in protecting people, after looking at her daughter’s oppressive state. Whitish moon, which looks like a cow, is in the sky, secreting its white light which looks like milk, into the world, which looks like a container for holding that milk.

viN suravi – the moon is in the sky, ensuring that the deluge of the *nAyaki*’s oppression does not come anywhere near it.

paridhi vattam . . . – there is an enemy for the moon in the sky. sarvESvaran who showers benefits on all, has the divine disc which has the radiance of sun’s halo and which is always battle-ready.

pozhiL EzhaLikkum sAlbin thagaimai kolAm – is this the way of protecting, by one who is the protector of all the worlds? He is at the eminence of protecting all the worlds. Is this his nature? Those who considered him as the protection are in a good position. Even when deluge comes, those who have deep faith in him will escape. However, is this the way to protect, having his divine hands and divine disc? We offer our salutations to his earlier state of protection [this is said in derision].

thamiyAtti thaLarndhadhuve – Will he, the protector be like this if someone within his sphere of protection remains like this [like the *nAyaki*]? The mother says that despite her [mother] being together [with the *nAyaki*], the *nAyaki* considers herself to be alone, without any support. This is because she considers only the sarvESvaran as the protector and the rest as those who worship other dhEvathAs (deities). In the last stages of one’s life, when the messengers of yama (the deity for righteousness) surround the person, they will not come for help. They will merely say “Whatever has been destined to happen, has to happen” and cause distress only.

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): This pAsuram states the doubt that those, who saw AzhwAr suffering from the distress due to separation, had in the protective ability of sarvESvaran.

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76. pAsuram 74 – thaLarndhum muRindhum

avathArikai (Introduction)

Southerly breeze was blowing then. The *nAyaki* feels saddened seeing this saying “The southerly breeze has set in; but the *nAyakan* has not come” Her friend tells her “Do you think that this is merely southerly breeze? When the fragrance of the palace starts spreading, it would indicate the arrival of the prince. In the same way, along with this breeze you could smell the fragrance of divine *thuLasi*. This is a hint that the *nAyakan* is coming. You need not feel sad”

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*thaLarndhum muRindhum varu thiraippAyil thirunedungaN vaLarndhum aRivuRRum vaiyam
vizhungiyum mAlvaraiyaik kiLarndhum aRidharak kiNdeduththAn mudi sUdu thuzhAy aLainduN siRu
pasum thenRal andhO vandhu ulAGinRadhE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

thaLarndhum – crumbling down

muRindhum – breaking down

varu – coming

thirai – having waves

pAyil – in the mat of milky ocean [thiruppARkadal]

thiru – due to beauty

nedum – without limit

kaN – divine eyes

vaLarndhum – closing

aRivu – thinking of protecting the worlds

uRRum – engaged in

vaiyam – worlds

vizhungiyum – (during deluge) eating them

mAl – huge

varaiyai – gOvardhanam

kiNdu – (from the earth) uprooting

kiLarndhu – raising

maRidhara – upside down

eduththAn – one who lifted, his

mudi – in the divine crown

sUdu – donned

thuzhAy – in divine thuLasi

aLaindhu – pervading

uN – having stayed with it

pasum – without contact with any other entity

siRu thenRal – gentle breeze

vandhu – reaching

ulAginRadhu – is blowing

The word *andhO* is an indication of the happiness felt on seeing the gentle breeze

Simple Translation

sarvESvaran is lying on the divine mat of thiruppARKadal in which the huge waves are rising, crumbling and breaking down repeatedly. sarvESvaran has closed his beautiful, divine eyes and meditating on protecting the worlds. He keeps all the worlds in his divine stomach during the time of deluge and lifts up the gOvardhana mountain from earth, holding it upside down to protect all the herd and herdsfolk. A gentle breeze has pervaded the divine thuLasi which is decorating his long divine crown and, without contacting any other entity, is blowing here, making me feel happy.

vyAkyAnam

thalarndhum . . . – thiruppARKadal (milky ocean) has huge waves which rise up, crumbling down on their own weight as well as breaking down due the effect of wind. sarvESvaran is reclining on that mat, with his beautiful eyes which indicate that he is the sarvESvaran, closed, thinking of ways to protect the worlds.

aRivuRRum – when all entities get troubled by deluge, he awakens thinking “When I am lying here only to protect them, would I allow them to suffer?”

vaiyam vizhungiyum – keeping the worlds in his divine stomach, during the time of deluge and protecting them.

mAl varai . . . – it is not only when the entire world is suffering that he comes and rescues. Even when a small place suffers [such as gOkulam] he runs in to help the people. Without any effort, he uprooted the huge mountain of gOvardhanam and held it upside down so that all the herd and the herd-folk could stand under it. Such sarvESvaran’s . . .

mudi sUdu thuzhAy – her thoughts are on the divine thuLasi on his divine feet, just as it has been mentioned in thiruvAimozhi 4-2-1 “*thALiNai mElaNi thaNNandhuzhAy*” (the divine, cool thuLasi applied on top of his divine feet); he considers that as *gruhNathi SirasAsvayam* – he considers that which has been offered to his divine feet, as having been offered to his divine crown. Hence the friend says this way. The breeze pervades the divine thuLasi which has been laid out on his divine crown, takes

the fragrance from there and without entering any other entity, comes to the place where the *nAyaki* is present and blows there. The friend asks the *nAyaki* “Do you have the time for feeling sad?” The pAsuram says “ *mudi sUdu thuzhAy* ”. The reason for all the explanation thus far has been to indicate that the breeze approaches him [sarvESvaran], pervades the place fully and brings the fragrance to her.

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): By this, the pAsuram explains how those who were near AzhwAr comforted him [when he was suffering from separation from sarvESvaran] by telling him about the qualities of sarvESvaran lying in thiruppARKadal, protecting the worlds by keeping them in his divine stomach and carrying out *gOvardhanOddhAraNam* (lifting the gOvardhana mountain) to protect the people. AzhwAr sustains himself by meditating on such qualities.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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77. pAsuram 75 – ulAginRa keNdai

avathArikai (Introduction)

This pAsuram describes the *nAyakan* celebrating the *nAyaki* when they are united. Alternatively, it could be taken as a natural doubt raised by the *nAyakan* [after looking at her eyes].

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*ulAginRa keNdai oLiyambu emmAviyai Uduruva kulAginRa venjilai vANmugaththIr kuni sangidaRip
pulAginRa vElai puNari am paLLiyammAn adiyAr nilAginRa vaigundhamO vaiyamO num nilaiyidamE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

ulAginRa – roaming

keNdai – innocent, like fish

oLi – having a radiance

ambu – eyes which are like arrows

em Aviyai – my *prANan* (life)

Uduruva – crumbling it by piercing

kulAginRa – bent

vem – cruel

silai – having eye brows which are like bow

vAL – having a radiance

mugaththIr – oh those who have faces!

num – for you

nilai – dwelling

idam – place

kuni – being bent (to the right side)

sangu – conches

idaRi – pushing (to the shore)

pulAginRa – being a matter for sensory perceptions

vElai – having waves

puNari – ocean

am – beautiful

paLLi – having as mattress

ammAn – lord's

adiyAr – nithyasUris, his devotees

nilAginRa – place of dwelling

vaikundhamO – is it SrlvaikuNtam?

vaiyamO – or, is it leelAvibhUthi (materialistic realm)?

Simple Translation

Oh you people who have radiant face having splendorous eyes which are like arrows piercing our lives and which look like fish which keep roaming, and eye-brows which are like cruel and bent bows! Is your place of dwelling SrlvaikuNtam which is inhabited by the followers of sarvESvaran who has as his mattress the divine milky ocean (thiruppARKadal) where conches curved to the right side are pushed to the shore by the waves or is it this earth?

vyAkyAnam

ulAginRa keNdai – the innocence of the eyes looks like roaming fish.

oLiyambu – when the *nAyakan* looks at her, she would not look in his direction; when he is not looking at her, she would look at him. Without his being aware of it, the arrow will come and pierce him.

oLiyambu – he cannot escape from her eyes

emmAviyai Uduruva – this will not pierce anyone else. It will pierce us only [says the *nAyakan*]. Even that, it will not do superficially on the skin, but will pierce the *prANan* [vital air; life itself]; even that, it is not superficially but deep down.

kulAginRa venjilai vAL mugaththIr – [eyebrows are] constantly bent so that when an arrow has to be shot, one need not bend the bow, string it and then take aim; by merely looking at a person, the arrow will be shot immediately. Also, instead of having the bow in the hand, having the bow on the face itself. Oh, such people! Another interpretation: the term *vAL* could be considered as radiance; in this case the meaning will be – Oh one who has a face with a bent bow and radiance! Her bow [eyebrows] is tormenting him.

kunisangu . . . – pushing ashore conches which are curved to the right.

pulAginRa – making a noise, the ocean which has agitating waves and is a mattress for sarvESvaran.

pulAginRa – it appears to be the time of dawn since the conches keep emitting radiance constantly. Such sarvESvaran who has this ocean as his bed, his

ammAn . . . – instead of remaining constantly at paramapadham [SrlvaikuNtam] where sarvESvaran holds the court so that both he and the nithyasUris could spend their time together, he enters thiruppARKadal which roars because of his presence and stays there similar to those who set up a house in a place of their liking, with the purpose of protecting the words and reclines. This makes nithyasUris to be amazed at his simplicity. [The *nAyakan* asks the *nAyaki*] Is your residence SrlvaikuNtam which is the dwelling place of such nithyasUris or is it the leelAvibhUthi (materialistic realm) which he visits occasionally and which keeps getting created and destroyed similar to the arrangement of pandhal etc made during festival times? Just as it is said in thiruvAimozhi 3-9-9 “*vAnavar nAdu*” SrlvaikuNtam is the

place where the nithyasUris would draw the rules and regulations [since nithyasUris are *parathanthrars* (totally dependent on him) he allows them to run that realm as per their desire]. However, leelAvibhUthi (materialistic realm) has chEthanAs (sentient entites) who are *svathantharars* (independent) having ego and possessive qualities. Hence he does not let them rule it as they wish; instead, he rules it by himself. piLLai thirunaRaiyUr araiyar would say “*adiyAr nilAginRa vaigundhamO anRikkE avanadhAna vaiyamO?*” (is it SrlvaikuNtam ruled by nithyasUris or this leelAvibhUthi ruled by sarvESvaran?)

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): those who saw AzhwAr said “There is none like AzhwAr in both the vibhUthis”. Those who are in nithyavibhUthi are constantly in engagement with bhagavath vishayam (matters relating to sarvESvaran). Those who are here (leelAvibhUthi) are constantly engaging with worldly matters. AzhwAr is distinct from both of them. He is without permanent engagement with bhagavath vishayam [since he is still here]. He is not sustaining himself with food, water etc [like the chEthanAs who are here]. Thus this explains how he is outside the nature of both vibhUthis.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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78. pAsuram 76 – idam pOy virindhu

avathArikai (Introduction)

During the time of moon rising, the *nAyaki* feels very distressed. She tells her mind “It is the nature of chandhiran (moon) to carry out simple tasks such as to make the lotus to close its petals and to make lily to blossom. Do not grieve regarding this’.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*idam pOy virindhu ivvulagam aLandhAn ezhilAr thaNdhuzhAy vadam pOdhil naiyum madanenjamE
nangaL veLvaLaikkE vidam pOl viridhal idhu viyappE viyan thAmaraiyin thadam pOdhu odunga
mellAmbal alarvikkum veN thingaLE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

idam – at various places

pOy – going

virindhu – pervading

ivvulagu – this world

aLandhAn – one who measured

ezhil – by [his] beauty

Ar – being full

thaN – cool

thuzhAy – divine thuLasi

vadam – in the garland

pOdhil – in its beauty

(desiring it and since not attaining it)

naiyum – crumbling

madam – having stubbornness

nenjamE – Oh mind!

viyan – amazing

thAmaraiyin – lotus’

thadam – broad

pOdhu- – flower

odunga – to contract

(one who does)

mel – small

Ambal – lily flower

alarvikkum – one who makes it to blossom

veN – white

thingaL – chandhiran (moon)

nangaL – our

veL – pale

vaLaikkE – on the bangles

vidam pOI – like poison

viridhal – spreading its rays

idhu – this [activity]

viyappE – is it of any surprise?

Simple Translation

Oh mind which is craving for the beautiful divine thuLasi garland of sarvESvaran who measured the world at all places with his divine foot! Is it any surprise that the whitish moon, which makes lotus to close its petals and lily to blossom, is spreading like poison on top of my pale bangles?

vyAkyAnam

idam pOy virindhu – just as flood will fill up all the low lying areas, [sarvESvaran’s] divine foot permeated wherever there was space. Beautiful, cool divine thuLasi is there on the divine form of the one who measured all the worlds; the divine garland is there as the sustenance for that divine thuLasi. Oh mind, which is stubbornly desirous of that garland since it is beautiful and cool on account of being in constant contact with is divine form! You are languishing because the divine thuLasi is not attained and you are not listening to me when I say that it is not easy to obtain that!

nangaL . . . – is it any surprise that the white rays of the chandhiran are spreading on my bangles made of conch, like poison?

veL vaLaikkE – it is natural for harming something when an entity is capable of harming it. Since chandhiran is whitish and my bangles too are, seeing a congruence in the colour, it could be harming.

viyan thAmarai . . . – when someone does not know the distinction between a great and a lowly entity, what will he not do? When chandhiran is capable of making the great and wondrous lotus flower to contract and the lowly lily flower to blossom, is it a surprise that it is spreading like poison on our bangles?

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): AzhwAr is narrating about how in a situation when he could not get the beautiful divine thuLasi garland which sarvESvaran wore when he mercifully measured the worlds, even favourable objects [such as chandhiran] turn out to be harmful.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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79. pAsuram 77 – thingaLam piLLai

avathArikai (Introduction)

This narrates the words of the *nAyaki* who is feeling saddened by the onset of dusk.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*thingaLam piLLai pulambath than sengOl arasupatta sengaLam paRRi ninRu eLgu pun mAlai thenpAl
ilangai vengalam seydhA nam viNNOr pirAnAr thuzhAy thuNaiyA nangaLai mAmai koLvAn vandhu
thOnRi naliginRadhE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

thingaL – chandhiran (moon)

am – beautiful

piLLai – son

pulamba – weeping (due to the sounds of birds)

sengOl – one who was ruling with his sceptre

than arasu – his king sUriyan (sun)

patta – fell down (sun set)

sem – reddish

kaLam – battle field

(reddish sky)

paRRi – attaining

ninRu – remaining

eLgum – engaging with

punmAlai – short duration of dusk

thenpAl – in the southern direction

ilangai – lankA

vengalam seydhA – made it into a cremation ground

viNNOr – by celestial entities such as brahmA et al

pirAnAr – lord, who is apt to be worshipped

nam – worn by our chakravarthy thirumagan (son of emperor dhaSaratha)

thuzhAy – desire which was created in the divine thuLasi

thuNaiyA – as helping hand

nangaLai – us

mAmAi koLvAn – to destroy the natural complexion

vandhu – reaching

thOnRi – rising

naliginRadhu – is tormenting

Simple Translation

It was the time of dusk when the King sUriyan, who has been ruling righteously with his sceptre, was about to meet his end in the reddish battlefield [of western horizon] and son of dusk, chandhiran, was about to rise, crying. It [the chandhiran] is trying to take our desire for the divine thuLasi garland, worn by Srl rAma, who created a battlefield in the southern place of lankA, as its support and is trying to torment us by destroying our natural complexion.

vyAkyAnam

thingaLam piLLai – the beautiful son, chandhiran. Just as it has been mentioned in Srl rAmAyaNam AraNya kANdam 66-3 “*mahathA thapasa*” (by superlative control), he is a son sired after lot of difficulties.

pulamba – could not wail with a loud tone since there were other entities such as ocean, birds etc which were making lot of noise at that time.

than sengOI . . . – the short duration of dusk held on to the reddish sky where its king, sUriyan, who was ruling righteously with his sceptre, had fallen down. The redness could be compared to the earth which had become reddish due to the flood of blood shed in a battle. Just as maNdOdhari called out in the battlefield where rAvaNa had fallen and just as thArA had called out, along with her son angadhan, in the battlefield where her husband vAli had fallen, this evening time too is remaining in that battle field, where she had lost sUriyan, and is engaging with that place; just as AzhwAr had sung in thiruvAimozhi 2.1 decad *vAyum thiraiyugaLum* when it appeared to him that every entity which he saw at that time was commiserating with him. The *nAyaki* too feels despondent, after losing sUriyan who has been mentioned as *pagaR kaNdEn* in iraNdam thiruvandhAdhi 81 (I saw Srlman nArAyaNan who is like the sun which never sets).

thenpAl . . . – in the southern side where great people [reference to kubEran and other dhEvathAs] had lost, in lankA, where wise people will not venture, making it to look reddish with blood.

vengalAm – making it look like a cremation ground and places allied to it. It is similar to thirumozhi 10-9-1 “*ilangai oLLeri maNdiuNna*” (making the effulgent agni (lord of fire) to pervade lankA and eat it up fully)

nam viNNOr pirAnAr – just as it has been said in Srl rAmAyaNam yudhdha kANdam 117-13 “*bhavAn nArAyanO dhEva* :” (brahma tells Srl rAma “You are the lord Srlman nArAyaNan” sarvESvaran carried out acts of benefaction to everyone such that brahma et al all stood and praised him.

thuzhAy thuNaiyA – taking my desire to obtain the divine thuLasi garland lying on his divine shoulder, as the means.

nangalai . . . – the dusk, instead of calling us to comfort it during its sorrowful moment [of losing sUriyan], is calling us to torment us.

nangalai mAmai koLvAn – for those who covet others' complexion, is complexion a necessity at all? Instead of calling us to support it during its difficult time, it is craving for tormenting us, who are already in distressed condition.

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): In the previous pAsuram, AzhwAr's distress in not getting the garland which sarvESvaran wore at the time he measured the worlds, and which he desired, was narrated. In this pAsuram, AzhwAr's distress in not getting the garland which sarvESvaran wore after annihilating rAvaNa, which AzhwAr desired, has been narrated.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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80. pAsuram 78 – naliyum naraganai

avathArikai (Introduction)

The *nAyaki* who was engaged with krishNAvathAram (incarnation as krishNa) desires to obtain a material connected with it. This pAsuram narrates that.

Let us go through the pAsruam anda its meanings:

*naliyum naraganai vIttiRRum vANan thiN thOL thuNindha valiyum perumaiyum yAn sollum nIrrthalla
maivaraipOl poliyum uruvil pirAnAr punai pUm thuzhAy malarkkE meliyum mada nenjinAr thandhu
pOyina vEdhanaiyE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

naliyum – troubling

naraganai – the demon narakAsuran

vIttiRRum – destroying

vANan – the demon bANAsuran's

thiN – strong

thOL – shoulders

thuNiththa – severed

valiyum – strength

perumaiyum – eminence (which followed it)

yAn sollum – to be informed by me

nIrrthalla – do not have that nature

maivaraipOl – like a black mountain

poliyum – shining (beauty)

uruvil – having divine form

pirAnAr – krishNan, the lord

punai – donning

pU – being beautiful

thuzhAy malarkkE – for the divine thuLasi flower

meliyum – withering

madam – being stubborn

nenjinAr – mind

thandhu pOna – given

vEdhanai – (this) agony

Simple Translation

The strength and greatness of sarvESvaran’s acts in the annihilation of narakAsuran and severing the thousand shoulders of bANAsuran are not of that simple a nature to be narrated by me. The agony of my heart, pining with stubbornness for the divine thuLasi garland which is worn by krishNa who looks beautiful like a black mountain, is like this.

vyAkyAnam

naliyum naraganai – the demon narakAsuran imprisoned those who were apt to be part of sarvESvaran’s retinue.

naliyum – their trouble [of being imprisoned] was like his [sarvESvaran’s]

vlttiRRum – felling him – killing him.

vANan . . . – bANAsuran, the demon, who imprisoned ushai (ushA, his daughter) and anirudhdhan (grandson of krishNa) instead of allowing them to be together.

thiN thOL – the demon was thinking that he had very powerful shoulders after taking refuge of some other deity [and not sarvESvaran]. The vyAkyAthA explains a few verses from thaiththirlyA upanishath Anandhavalli 2 to distinguish this from one who takes refuge under sarvESvaran. “ *Anandham brahmaNO vidhvAn* ” – one who knows about the joy of brahmam (sarvESvaran); *na bibhEthi kuthaSchana* – will not fear anything; *EshashyEvAnandhayAthi* – due to that courage, he will not respect entities which his intellect respects. Due to the false courage that the demon bANan had about his taking refuge under some other deity, he did not show reverence to those entities which his intelligence accepted as reverential. The strength and greatness [of sarvESvaran] who severed the shoulders of such bANAsuran. Alternatively, the greatness of such strength.

yAn sollum nlrththalla – is it something which would be narrated by me at this time?

nlrththalla – it [the narration] is not of that simple a nature. Could I narrate today about his quality of annihilating his enemy, his manliness and his greatness? If his true nature were spoken about, then it will be impossible to blame him for the sorrow that I am facing due to his absence.

Then, was it due to someone else?

maivarai . . . – AzhwAr says that it is the gift given by the heart by not analysing whether something is attainable or unattainable and desiring it.

maivarai – the divine form is like a black mountain.

poliyum uru – since there is nothing equivalent to the divine form’s beauty, it cannot be explained through an example. If among the entities which exist, one were to consider the best to attempt to match the beauty of his divine form, that would be found wanting, viz. everything else is inferior.

pirAnAr – just as jithanthE SIOkam 5 says “ *bhakthAnAm* ” (for the sake of followers), his divine form exists for the sake of followers.

punai . . . – only for the divine thuLasi garland which he has donned.

meliyum mada nenjinAr – if one desires something which is possible to get, yet if it is not obtained, there will be sorrow. But what will happen if one desires to get something which is impossible to get? This is what the stubborn heart did for me, leading to this agony.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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81. pAsuram 79 – vEdhanai veNpuri

avathArikai (Introduction)

AzhwaR is mercifully speaking about those who are able to enjoy firmly all the matters related to bhagavAn, unlike himself who becomes faint on thinking about him.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*vEdhanai veNpurinUlanai viNNOr parava ninRa nAdhanai gyAlam vizhungum anAdhanai
gyAlandhaththum pAdhanaip pARKadal pAmbaNai mEl paLLi koNdaruLum sldhanaiyE thozhuvAr
viNNuLARilum sriyarE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

vEdhanai – one who is described by vEdhas (sacred texts)

veN – whitish

puri – having strands

nUlanai – having divine sacred thread

viNNOr – nithyasUris (permanent dwellers of SrlvaikuNtam)

parava ninRa – being worshipped by

nAdhanai – being the lord

gyAlam – leelAvibhUthi (materialistic realm) including earth

vizhungum – one who swallows

anAdhanai – one who does not have a lord for him

gyAlam – earth

thaththum – one who brought under

pAdhanai – having divine feet

pARKadal – in thiruppARKadal (divine milky ocean)

pAmbu aNai mEl – on top of the divine bed of divine AdhiSEshan

paLLi koNdu aruLum – one who is reclining mercifully

sldhanaiyE – sarvESvaran who has coolness as his natural quality

thozhuvAr – those who worship

viNNuLARilum – more than nithyasUris

sriyarE – are eminent

Simple Translation

sarvESvaran is described by the vEdhas, he wears the divine sacred thread with white strands and is worshipped by nithyasUris. He swallows all the worlds, doesn't have a lord for himself and measures all the worlds and keeps them under his divine feet. He reclines on the divine mattress of AdhiSEshan in the divine thiruppARKadal and has coolness as his true nature. Those who worship him are more eminent than the nithyasUris.

vyAkyAnam

vEdhanai – AzhwAr thinks of vEdhas which keep thinking, just like himself, only about sarvESvaran and which do not have a beginning or end.

veN puri nUlanai – just as it has been seen in the previous pAsuram *maivarai pOl poliyum uru*, he has a dark form; vEdhas too describe such divine form. He has a whitish divine thread which contrasts with that dark form.

viNNOOr parava ninRa nAdhanai – even nithyasUris, in a disorderly way, keep calling out to such form

gyAlam vizhungum anAdhanai – he does not look at his eminence in being praised by those who have no shortcomings in them [nithyasUris]; he thinks constantly of samsAris (dwellers in materialistic realm) and protects them by keeping the world in which they live, in his divine stomach, during deluge. He has no one who can tell him “You are not supposed to do this” [he has none above him who can order him].

gyAlam . . . – instead of protecting once and letting go, like a worm making movements such that it forms an alphabet by accident, he has the divine feet which encircled the world fully, protecting them.

gyAlam . . . – even after carrying out all the activities for samsAris, including measuring their worlds and protecting them, he thinks “We have not done anything for them”

pARKadal . . . – he keeps reclining on thiruppARKadal (the divine milky ocean) thinking about the protection of the worlds; despite doing everything, he thinks “We have not done anything for them”; he retrieves the worlds which indhra [the lord of celestial entities] had lost out to demons, and reclines.

sldhanai – if one were to think about his reclining on thiruppARKadal, all the heat [anguish] gets removed; he has such a cool nature. Just as it has been mentioned in narAyaNa sUktham *thApArthO jalaSAyinam* – he reclines on water in order to remove the heat of samsAris.

sldhanaiyE thozhuvAr – those who worship him without expecting some other benefit [instead of himself]; those who worship him without becoming faint hearted on hearing his divine name.

viNNUlAriLum slriyarE – unlike those who are permanently enjoying sarvESvaran from *that* place [nithyavibhUthi], those who are in samsAram, which is the exact opposite of nithyavibhUthi, and having the activity of worshipping him as a constant behaviour, are more eminent than nithyasUris.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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82. pAsuram 80 – sIrarasANdu

avathArikai (Introduction)

The sun had set and darkness engulfed fully. This pAsuram reflects the words of the *nAyaki* in distress due to that.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

slrarasANdu than sengOl silanAL seleeikkazhindha pArarasoththu maRaindhadhu nAyIRu pAraLandha pErarasE em visumbarasE emmai nlththu vanjiththa OrarasE aruLAY iruLAY vandhu uRuginRadhE

Word-by-Word Meanings

slr – very well

arasu – kingdom

ANdu – governing

than – his

sengOl – rule

silanAL – some time

seleei – conducting

kazhindha – after spending

pAr – on the earth

arasE – with the kings

oththu – being equal [to them]

nAyIRu – sUriyan (sun)

maRaindhadhu – set

iruLAY vandhu – darkness, with its true form, came

uRuginRadhu – is contacting

pAr – earth

aLandha – one who seized

pEr – having a great quality

arasE – oh lord!

em – being in close proximity to us

visumbu – for paramapadham (SrlvaikuNtam)

arasE – oh one who is the lord!

emmai – us

nIththu – leaving

vanjiththu – through deceit

Or – being unique

arasE – oh one who became the king!

aruLAy – show your mercy

Simple Translation

The sUriyan (sun) set like kings who rule very well for some time and then leave. Darkness which followed that, engulfed me fully. Oh my lord who measured this earth! Oh the lord of paramapadham which is close to us! Oh the lord who deceitfully left me! You should show your mercy on me.

vyAkyAnam

slrarasu ANdu – ruling the kingdom well. When the pANdava king dharman left the country for *vanavAsam* (to dwell in the forest), the people of the country followed him with all their ritualistic paraphernalia, saying “if dharmaputhran does not rule the country we too would not stay here”; ruling the kingdom in such a noble way.

than sengOl silanAL seleei – not ruling for an insignificant period but for a long time, in an eminent way.

kazhindha pAr arasu oththu – ruling like respectable kings such as mANDhAthA (one of the kings in the ikshvAku dynasty, a lineage to which Srl rAma belonged)

maRaindhadhu nAyIRu – when sUriyan is around, it would appear as if *nAyakan* is around, comforting her. However, with sUriyan setting and night approaching, the sensory organs are focussing only on her separation from the *nAyakan* and are frightening her. In the daytime, each sensory organ would be involved in matters related to it and distress due to separation would not be intensely felt.

maRaindhadhu – sUriyan is common to all people; however, to the *nAyaki*, he was more significant since she was looking at his disappearance just like she would keep looking at her *nAyakan* when he was leaving her.

pAraLandha pErarasE – if sUriyan, who has been caught in the web of darkness, has to be redeemed, it would require the presence of the same entity who had redeemed earth from the clutches of mahAbali.

aLandha – just as he had measured the entire expanse of earth with his divine feet, couldn't he measure this darkness too? Just as it has been mentioned in thiruviruththam 33 “*iruLAr vinai keda*” (to annihilate the sins of darkness) wouldn't he be ruling to get rid of darkness?

pErarasE – he is not one who carries out lowly and simple acts; all his activities are great ones.

em visumbarasE – after acquiring knowledge about matters relating to sarvESvaran, paramapadham (SrlvaikuNtam) appears to be much closer to AzhwAr than samsAram. Just as it has been mentioned in thiruvAimozhi 6-8-1 “*ponnulagu ALIrO*” (AzhwAr tells the birds that he would give them SrlvaikuNtam itself to rule), AzhwAr had gifted SrlvaikuNtam as the first gift to those who were to unite him with sarvESvaran.

emmai nlththu vanjiththa OrarasE – thirukkurugaippirAn piLLAn would explain this by saying “As if he had crowned himself separately for the two vibhUthis, it appears that he had taken over this vibhUthi only to separate me and to destroy me”. bhattar would explain this by saying “When he separated from me, he had said ‘I will not leave you’; once he separated me from him, he seemed to say ‘Who can equal me in this nature?’ It appeared as if he had coronated himself separately for this behaviour saying ‘There is none to equal me in dismissing those who will not separate’ ”

aruLAy – when nothing exists, there will be none asking for mercy to be showered. Those who are in paramapadham will not desire anything since they are deeply engaged with the qualities of sarvESvaran; those who are in samsAram will sustain themselves only through food, water etc. Could he not shower his mercy on someone who, staying here, is in the status of those who are in paramapadham? Those in paramapadham would be fully devoted to enjoying the auspicious qualities of sarvESvaran while those in samsAram would be fully devoted to *SabdhAdhi vishayam* (matters relating to sensory perceptions such as sound, touch etc). sarvESvaran has to shower his mercy on samsAris who have only knowledge about his auspicious qualities but not the experience with them.

What is the need to shower his mercy here, now?

iruLAy vandhu – instead of a tiger disguised as a cow, now the real tiger itself has come in the form of darkness. In other words, instead of fearing deluge, darkness has come to cause harm. For regular samsAris, deluge would cause harm; for those in separation, darkness itself does that much of harm.

uRuginRadhE – darkness has come to envelop her fully. Before that, she wants to unite with sarvESvaran who is referred to in periya thiruvandhAdhi 26 as “*iruLanna mAmEni*” – the huge form of sarvESvaran which is dark.

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): AzhwAr mercifully says that since the time of stay in samsAram creates ignorance, he wants sarvESvaran to redeem him soon from it.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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83. pAsuram 81 – uRuginRa kanmangaL

avathArikai (Introduction)

Darkness had set in everywhere. The *nAyaki* has become unconscious, thinking about him. Even after seeing her position, her relatives do not seem worried about it; they say “We will do the appropriate remedy at the appropriate time”. An old, knowledgeable woman, seeing this, says “Her position is sinking; her eminence is so great; when such is the case, why are they so lackadaisical? Are they not her parents?”

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

uRuginRa kanmangaL mElana OrppilarAy ivaLaip peRuginRa thAyar meynondhu peRArgol thuzhAy kuzhalvAyth thuRuginRalar thollai vEngadamAttavum sUzhginRalar iRuginRadhAl ivaLAGam mellAvi eri koLLavE

Word-by-Word Meanings

mel – being soft

Avi – (her) vital air

eri – the fire of separation

koLLa – is swallowing her

ivaL – this *nAyaki*’s

Agam – form

iRuginRadhu – is perishing

mElana – what is going to happen

uRuginRa – approaching closely

kanmangaL – deeds to be carried out

OrppilarAy – without enquiring about them

thuzhAy – divine *thuLasi*

kuzhalvAy – on her locks

thuRuginRinar – they are not applying

thollai – being ancient

vEngadam – in the pond of *thiruvEngadam*

Attavum – giving her a bath

sUzhginRilar – they are not attempting

ivaLai – this distinguished *nAyaki* *peRuginRa* – those who begot

thAyar – mothers

mey nondhu – with the body in pain

peRAr kol – did they not give birth to?

Simple Translation

The fire of separation is slowly destroying the *nAyaki*'s soft life. Her mothers do not seem to know the distinguished activities which will remove her distress. They are not applying the divine *thuLasi*, worn by *sarvESvaran*. They are not giving her a bath in the pond at the ancient *thiruvEngadam*. It appears that her mothers did not give birth to her, after suffering severe pain in their bodies [implying that she is not born to them but probably adopted].

vyAkyAnam

uRuginRa – The old lady is wondering whether there is no activity to be performed by them [relatives of *nAyaki*] considering the relationship between them and the *nAyaki*.

uruginRa kanmangaL mElana OrppilarAy – the *nAyaki* is not well. They have to take some actions for that. Though the time has come now for taking those actions, they seem to be undecided about the actions.

ivaLaippeRuginRa thAyar – should her mothers not be worried about her situation? Do they have to think whether their actions would be beneficial or not? Is it not enough that she is the daughter that they had sired?

mey nondhu peRAr kol – didn't her mothers give birth to her after suffering pangs of pain during labour? Or, did they adopt her from someone and bring her up?

What is the reason for the old lady to say like this?

thuzhAy kuzhalvAyth thuRuginRalar – The time for carrying out the action which had been mentioned in *thiruviruththam pAsuram 53 maNNAyinum koNdu vIsuminE* has passed. Now, it is not sufficient to blow divine *thuLasi* or any of its connected entities such as stem or root or soil. Now they have to decorate her locks with *thuLasi* such that it is fully covering her locks.

thollai . . . – they do not seem carry out any of the remedial measures which the people of their clan had done in the past.

vEngadam Attavum – the place which is full of stones and forests, appears to be a pond for the *nAyaki*. Just as it has been said in *mahAbhAratham mOksha dharmam 4-50 Esha brahma pravishtOsmi* – they are not immersing her in the pond of *parabrahmam* (*sarvESvaran*) to give her a bath.

sUzhginRalar – they may not do that. They are not taking the initial steps for that; they are not enquiring about what is to be done. Would enquiring about it be sufficient to improve her situation? Since it is a matter related to *sarvESvaran*, the minute they take the first steps, it would start yielding the benefits.

Should the disease as well as the remedy be fully analysed before doing anything?

iRuginRadhAl ivaL Agam – would her nature tolerate such a lengthy process? Her form is crumbling.

mellAvi eri koLLavE – is it proper to look at the process when her soft AthmA is getting burnt by the fire of separation?

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): this pAsuram narrates the way AzhwAr is immersed in matters relating to bhagavAn such that it becomes difficult both for those who try to sustain him and for sarvESvaran [the protector].

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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84. pAsuram 82 – erikoL sennAyiRu

avathArikai (Introduction)

jlyar [nanjlyar] would mercifully say that this pAsuram is not to his liking. This is because, just as it is mentioned in periya thirumozhi 7-1-9 “ *thAyAyaLikkinaRa thaNdAmaraikkaNNA* ” (Oh one who has divine eyes similar to cool, reddish lotus flower and who showers mercy like a mother!), sarvESvaran’s eyes which are soft are described in this pAsuram as being fiery. We could experience what AzhwAr is saying only if we too are suffering in distress, just like AzhwAr.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

erikoL sennAyiRu iraNdudanE udhayam malaivAy viriginRa vaNNaththu emperumAn kaNgal mINdavaRRuL erikoL sendhIvIzhasuraraippOla empOliyarkkum virivasolleer idhuvO vaiyamuRRum viLariyadhE

Word-by-Word Meanings

emperumAn – sarvESvaran, who is my lord

kaNgal – divine eyes

erikoL – having fire

udhayam malaivAy – in the mountains where it rises from

udanE – simultaneously

viriginRa – spreading

sem – having reddish rays

iraNdu nAyiRu – twin sUriyans’

vaNNanththa – having the true nature

erikoL – having flame

sem – reddish

thI – like fire

avaRRuL – in the splendour of the sUriyan

mINdu – again

vIzh – falling

asuraraippOla – like demons (known as *mandhEhar*)

empOliyarkkum – like us who are affectionate (in matters related to bhagavAn)

viriva – appeared before us

vaiyam muRRum – throughout the world

viLariyadhu – calling out

idhuvO – was it for this?

solleer – please tell

Simple Translation

The divine eyes of sarvESvaran appear like two sUriyans, spitting fire, which have risen at the same time over the mountains. Just like demons die in the splendour of sUriyan's flames, sarvESvaran's divine eyes are harmful for us who are devoted to him. Please tell us whether it is for this that the world is calling out to that sarvESvaran.

vyAkyAnam

eri . . . – The divine eyes of sarvESvaran are similar to two reddish sUriyans which are spitting fire and spreading it when they rise over the mountains.

mINdu . . . – when the sUriyan rises, demons, known as *mandhEhars* , will hold on to his chariot, preventing him from going further. The divine water offered by brAhmaNAs when they offer *argyam* will provide a splendour to sUriyan. The demons will fall into and get destroyed in that fire. Similar to those demons who fall into that roaming sUriyan's fire and get destroyed . . .

empOliyarkkum viriva – for those like me who desire him and become sorrowful, they cause harm just like they do for the demons.

solleer idhuvO vaiyam muRRum viLariyadhE – is this the result for the world calling out to him? Please tell. Is it to fall into that fire that the world is calling out to him? Isn't she the one who had thought in thiruvAimozhi 2.1 decad *vAyum thiraiyugaLum* when she felt that the entire world was suffering from the same sorrows that she was suffering from?

Alternatively

mINdavaRRuL erikoL sendhivlzhazuraraippOI empOliyarkkum – just like those demons who fall into that flame of sUriyan's splendour and perish, these eyes are harmful for people like me.

viriva solleer – tell me a refuge. In this context, the term *viriva* refers to being expansive and thus implies a refuge.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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85. pAsuram 83 – viLarikkural anRil

avathArikai (Introduction)

In the previous pAsuram, sarvESvaran's divine eyes tormented the *nAyaki*. This pAsuram narrates her sadness at seeing two nightingale birds sitting on a palm tree in the frontyard of her house. The two birds had locked their beaks when the female bird leaves. The male calls out after her. Seeing this, the *nAyaki* goes into a state of stupor. Her mother, hearing the bird's high pitched calls, says "The sound of the bird is like this. Her [the daughter's] distress due to separation is like this. Her softness is like this. Will I see her happy with her desire fulfilled?" When parASara bhattar was narrating this, his disciple nanjlyar asked him "Could you please narrate an incident similar to this from Srl rAmAyaNam?" bhattar responded saying "When lakshmaNa left slthAppirAttialone in the forest [when she was pregnant] she let out a cry. Sage vAlmiki who heard her cry of distress had a mental makeup similar to the *nAyaki*'s mother"

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

viLarikkural anRil menpEdai mEginRa munRil peNNai muLarik kurambai idhu idhuvAga mugil vaNNan pEr kiLarikkiLarip pidhaRRum mellAviyum naivumellAm thaLariRkoLO aRiyEn uyyalAvadhu iththaiyalukke

Word-by-Word Meanings

mel – having a soft nature

pedai – with female bird

mEginRa – being united together

viLari – in a high pitch

kural – voice

anRil – nightingale bird's

munRil – in the frontyard

peNNai – on top of the palm tree

muLari – made of lotus flower

kurambai – nest

idhu idhuvAga – tormenting permanently

mugil – like cloud

vaNNan – sarvESvaran who has a form like that

pEr – divine name

kiLarik kiLari – taking it repeatedly

pidhaRRum – babbling

mel – soft

Aviyum – vital air

naivum – (body) crumbling

ellAm – since all these happened

iththaiyalukku – for this girl

uyyalAvadhu – to be alive

thaLaril koLO – is it possible

ariyEn – I am not sure

Simple Translation

There is a palm tree in the frontyard of *nAyaki*'s house where a male nightingale bird, with a high pitch, is living with its female nightingale which has a soft nature, inside a nest made with lotus flowers. Her mother says that she is not sure if the *nAyaki* will survive since she keeps babbling the divine names of sarvESvaran, since she has a soft nature and since her form is crumbling [due to separation from sarvESvaran].

vyAkyAnam

viLarikkural anRil – the term *viLari* refers to a high pitched voice. The male nightingale bird calls with such a high pitched voice.

men pEdai – the softness of the female nightingale bird is such that when being united, touching it would appear to be similar to touching a flower. If there is separation in such a soft natured entity, the distress would be impossible to tolerate.

mEginRa – being permanently united, without any separation. It would remind one of *anapAyini* (Sri mahAlakshmi who will not separate from emperumAn even for a moment).

munRil peNNai – the term *munRil* would refer both to frontyard and entrance. Some people asked vangipuraththu nambi when this pAsuram was being recited “Will anyone have a palm tree in the frontyard of the house?” nambi responded saying “You are asking about that! Isn’t that the reason as to why her matters are like this, where even the tender leaves are snapping?” Just as it has been said in periya thirumozhi pAsuram 11-2-1 “*munRil thani ninRa peNNai mEl kidandhIrginRa anRilin kUttai pirikka kiRpavar yArkolo ?*” (who has the cleverness to remove the nest of the nightingales, which are always together, from the palm tree seen at the entrance?) wouldn’t her relatives be busy in bringing the *nAyakan* back? The *nAyaki* is not the type who goes around separating and uniting entities.

muLarik kurambai – the male nightingale will build the nest with lotus leaves and flowers, to be apt for the soft nature of the female bird. Alternatively, *muLari* would refer to thorns and the nest would be built with thorns to protect the birds from outside attack.

idhu idhuvAga – after building nest like this and not tormenting.

mugil vaNNan pEr kiLarik kiLarip pidhaRRum – repeatedly babbling the divine name of sarvESvaran.

mellAviyum – even though she was reciting the divine names, did it make her feel peaceful? That did not happen because of the tiredness caused in her heart.

naivum – her physical form too was crumbling

thaLariRkoLO (iththaiyalukku uyyalAvadhu) – survival for this girl

thaLariRkoLO – without even this blabbering, the only way to survive is to perish. I do not know whether she can survive without perishing.

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): those who saw AzhwAr found that his form was getting tormented a lot. They said “Would we see him sustain himself until he reaches his end goal of attaining sarvESvaran? It appears that there is hope only after he leaves this physical form”

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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86. pAsuram 84 – thaiyanallArgaL

avathArikai (Introduction)

This pAsuram says how the *nAyaki*, in a state of bewilderment, runs here and there, calling out to sarvESvaran, since she is not able to see him. This is similar to the way Srl rAma wandered in the forest, looking for slthAppirAtti, as mentioned in Srl rAmAyaNam AraNya kANdam 60-36, 37 “ *kvachith udhbhramathE vEgAth kvachith vibhramathE balAth || kvachith maththa iva AbhAthi kAnthA anvEshaNa thathpara : |*” (somewhere by forcefulness of illusion and somewhere else by the powerfulness of allusion and elsewhere, due to the love for his impassioned ladylove, he was running like a madman).

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

thaiyanallArgaL kuzhAngaL kuzhiya kuzhivuLLum aiyanallArgaL kuzhiya vizhavinum angangellAm kaiya ponnAzhi veNsangodum kANbAn avAvuvan nAn maiyavaNna maNiyE muththamE enRan mANikkamE

Word-by-Word Meanings

thaiyal naLLArgaL – gems of women

kuzhAngaL – association

kuzhiya – huge

kuzhuvinuLLum – in gatherings

aiyanallArgaL – wise men

vizhavinum – in celebrations

angangellAm – at all those places

maiya – like black pigment

vaNNA – one who has a form (such that the eyes of the beholder would feel cool)

maNiyE – one who is easily approachable

muththamE – one who is cool like a pearl

en than – as a lord for me

mANikkamE – one who is eminent like a carbuncle

kaiya – in the divine hands

pon – radiant

Azhi – with divine disc

veN – whitish

sangodum – with Srl pAnchajanyam (divine conch)

nAn – I

kANbAn – to worship (you)

avAvuvan – desired

Simple Translation

Oh one who has a divine form like a black pigment which is comforting for the beholder! Oh one who is easily approachable! Oh one who has a cool nature similar to pearl's! Oh one who is like a carbuncle and who is my lord! Among the huge gatherings of women who are like gems and among the festive gatherings of wise men, I desire to see your divine hands holding the radiant divine disc and the divine white conch.

vyAkyAnam

thiyanallAr . . . – there are women who are like gems; there are huge gatherings of such women. When AzhwAr sees such gatherings, he would presume that krishNa is amidst them, ready to begin the dance called as *kuravai* (a dance in which two people will hold their hands tightly together and spin around, holding their feet at the centre).

aiya nallAr . . . – just as the wise saying goes “*aRavOrarundhavaththOraiyar*” (eminent are those who follow righteous path and who carry out deep penance). *aiyanallAr* are even better than such people. *avargal kuzhiya vizhavinum* – places where yagyams (ritualistic events) are held, where they will be present in large numbers. In such places as well as in places where people similar to dhaNdakAraNya rishis are gathered. Places such as the one mentioned in Srl rAmAyaNam ayOdhyA kANdam 57-13 “*samAjEshu mahathsucha*” (great assembly of wise men).

angangellAm – in places similar to these

kaiya . . . – AzhwAr desires to see sarvESvaran without distinction between his incarnations where he had hidden his divine disc and conch (such as krishNAvathAram) and those where he had displayed them. He had hidden his divine weapons only from demonic entities. What is the hurdle for me to see him with such divine weapons? Didn't arjuna tell him in bhagavath gItai 11-46 “*thEnaiva rUpENa chathurbhujEna*” (I desire to see your form with four shoulders, as before)?

avAvuvan nAn – Does desire have eyes? I desire only “To see”. I do not wish to think “He is difficult to see” If he is difficult to be seen, did he create the desire in you to see him and punish you?

maiya vaNNA . . . – he says that it is the eminence in the entity that created the desire in him. When someone loses an eminent entity, will that person wait to get it back?

maiya vaNNA . . . – the entity is capable of making the beholder's eyes to be cool, as if black pigment has been applied.

maNiyE – even when the entity is like this, it has to be experienced fully.

muththamE – if the entity were embraced, all the thirst would evaporate.

enRan mANikkamE – absolutely inestimable.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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87. pAsuram 85 – mANikkangoNdu

avathArikai (Introduction)

This pAsuram reveals the words of the *nAyaki* who is saddened by the appearance of night. This could also be treated as the words of the *nAyaki*'s mother who is lamenting the *nAyaki*'s position.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its words:

*mANikkangoNdu kurangu eRivoththu iruLOdu mutti ANipponnanna sudar padumAlai ulagaLandha
mANikkamE en maradhagameE maRRoppAraiYillA ANipponnE adiyEn adi Avi adaikkalamE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

kurangu – monkey

mANikkam – gem [carbuncle]

koNdu – taking it

eRivu oththu – equivalent to throwing

iruLOdu – with darkness

(coming)

mutti – getting close

ANipon anna – like a distinguished gold

sudar – radiant sUriyan ([sun]

padum – suffering

mAlai – dusk (appeared)

ulagu – worlds

aLandha – one who seized

mANikkamE – Oh one who is virtuous!

en – being my lord

maradhagameE – one who is invigorating like an emerald gem!

maRRu – over and above

oppArai – those who are equal

illA – ohe who does not have

ANipponnE – Oh one who is like distinguished gold!

adiyEn – this servitor, my

adi – being your servitor

Avi – vital air

adaikkalam – is to be protected (by you)

Simple Translation

Oh one who measured all the worlds! Oh one who is virtuous and is like an invigorating emerald gem to me! Oh one who is like distinguished gold, without anyone being your equal! Just like a monkey threw a carbuncle gem, the dusk time has thrown out sUriyan who is like eminent gold. This *AthmA* (soul) of mine, your servitor, has to be protected by you.

vyAkyAnam

mANikkam koNdu kurangu eRivoththu – Just like a monkey would throw a gemstone of carbuncle. A monkey, without knowing the great value of a gemstone, throws it out such that it reaches a place where it will be of no use to anyone. Alternatively, being an animal, it throws the gemstone where it cannot be used even by the monkey itself and the gem remains losing its shine.

iruLOdu . . . – coming with darkness. The evening time appeared, destroying sUriyan who is like an incomparable, eminent, reddish gold. Just like the carbuncle gem was destroyed by the monkey, sUriyan was destroyed by darkness.

Instead of merely speaking about evening, she now speaks about sarvESvaran's great activities.

ulagaLandha mANikkame – he is one who pushed aside entities such as mahAbali when indhra et al, who think that they are the protectors, withdrew, being unable to fight with such mahAbali. He is an entity who is virtuous, who measured the worlds which are full of forests and mountains.

mANikkame – he transformed himself though he is priceless and inestimable [for the sake of indhra et al].

en maradhagamE – he is invigorating when embraced.

maRRoppAraiyilla ANipponnE – he is eminent without any simile to compare him with – like distinguished gold.

adiyEn – AzhwAr calls himself as *adiyEn* [servitor] manifesting his enjoyability [by sarvESvaran].

adiyAvi – If these are the *nAyaki*'s words, this would refer to the *Athmavasthu* (her soul) which is subservient to sarvESvaran. It is so much subservient to sarvESvaran that even offering it to him would tantamount to being an act in excess [it belongs to sarvESvaran; hence there is no need even to offer it to him]. It is to be offered as soon as one is bewildered; once offered, it would be so severed from him/her that it would make him/her shrink from thinking "I offered an entity of mine to him". It will be similar to sthOthra rathnam 53 " *athavA kinnu samarppayAmi thE* " (What can I offer you?) and thiruvAimozhi 7-9-10 " *uRReNNil adhuvum aRRu AngavanRannadhu* " (if I wanted to call it as mine, even that *Athmavasthu* happened to be his). The vyAkyAthA (periyavAchchAn piLLai, commentator for this prabandham) narrates an incident when kUraththAzhwAn was sent by bhagavdh rAmAnujar to thirukkOttiyUr nambi (rAmAnujar's AchAryan) to find out whether it is *gyAthruthvam* (being with knowledge about matters relating to sarvESvaran) or *SEshathvam* (being a servitor of sarvESvaran) which is *AthmasvarUpam* (the true nature of AthmA). nambi mercifully informed kUraththAzhwAn "Oh my child! Where he should have said *ennuLLAn* [within me] as in thiruvAimozhi 8-8-2 ' *adiyEnuLLAn*

udaluLLAn ' (he is within me), he had said *adiyEnnuLLAn* to signify that it is servitude which is the true identity for AthmA”

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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88. pAsuram 86 – adaikkalaththOngu

avathArikai (Introduction)

In the previous pAsuram, he had narrated the way darkness had tormented him. He says in this pAsuram that however much darkness surrounds and torments, sarvESvaran's true nature is such that one cannot blame him about anything.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*adaikkalaththOngu kamalaththalarayan senniyennum mudaikkalaththUN munnaranukku nlkkiyai
Azhisangam padaikkalamEndhiyai veNNeykkanRu Aychchi van thAmbugaLAI padaikkalandhAnai
emmAnai ensollip pulambuvanE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

adaikkalaththu – as an entity to be protected

Ongu – grown well

kamalaththu – (having been born in the divine navel) lotus'

alar – born in a flower

ayan – brahma's

senni ennum – known as head

udai – having an unpleasant smell

kalaththu – in the vessel

UN – food

mun – in earlier time

aranukku – for rudhra

nlkkiyai – one who removed

Azhisangam – divine disc and divine conch

padai – divine weapons

kalan – as ornaments

Endhiyai – one who donned

anRu – during the time of krishNAvathAram (incarnation as krishNa)

veNNey – for butter

Aychchi – yaSodhAp pirAtti

van – strong

thAmbugaLAI – ropes

pudaikka – to hit

alandhAnai – one who had trouble

emmAnai – one who is my lord

en solli – by speaking about what deficiencies

pulambuvan – could I call?

Simple Translation

brahmA was born in the lotus flower which originates from the divine navel of sarvESvaran who is the refuge for all. rudhra took his food from the skull (head) of brahmA [which was plucked by rudhra] which had an unpleasant smell. sarvESvaran removed that curse on rudhra; he holds the divine weapons of disc and conch; when he incarnated as krishNa, he stole butter and was hit by strong ropes by yaSOdhA [his mother]. With what deficiencies in him could I call him, who is my lord?

vyAkyAnam

adaikkalaththOngu – growing under sarvESvaran, to whom he has surrendered, brahmA is like *nikshEpam* (treasure)

kamalaththalarayan – *nikshEpam* refers to a treasure which is hidden. However, that term refers here to his being looked at by sarvESvaran such that there is no deficiency in him. Apart from that, brahmA has the fortune of having been born directly to sarvESvaran.

senni . . . – while brahmA is considered as the *IOkaguru* (AchAryan for the world), he is the father of rudhra, who plucked one of his heads and stood as one who has committed a serious crime. brahmA stood in sadness, having his head severed. He [sarvESvaran] removed both their sorrows.

ayan senni ennum mudaikkalam – that skull [severed head of brahmA] became a vessel with a foul smell. Since it was having an unpleasant smell [due to its contact with brahmA's flesh] wherever rudhra went, he was followed by birds of prey such as eagle etc.

mudaikkalaththu UN mun aranukku nikkiyai – [due to the curse of brahmA], rudhra had to eat his food by begging for alms, from that skull. rudhra, who is the deity for annihilation, had to suffer like this. sarvESvaran removed this curse for rudhra, in an earlier time. He thought "Someone who was created by me should not suffer for a long time like this" and removed that difficulty. Through this, it has been brought out that for those who are born in samsAram, being attracted by karma and the resultant physical form, difficulties etc are common to all and that these are applicable for these two too (brahmA and rudhra). One stood with his head severed; one stood having committed that heinous act; sarvESvaran stood as one who removed both their sorrows.

Azhi sangam padaikkalam Endhiyai – he constantly holds his divine weapons such as disc and conch since he cannot search for them to protect samsAris [such as brahmA and rudhra] when they are wandering in difficulties. He has the nature of wearing these divine weapons as divine ornaments in order to carry out the activity of protection.

veNNey . . . – though he is capable of removing the difficulties of brahmA, rudhra et al and has the necessary implements for that, when he gets into any difficulty from his followers, he cannot extricate himself from such difficulty. While he is the controller of brahmA, rudhra et al and remains as the

supreme entity, he cannot sustain himself without a few materials which have a contact with his followers. While he is *avApthasamasthakAman* [he does not have any unfulfilled desire], he feels that there is some deficiency and if he cannot get it directly, he goes to the extent of stealing it. Even while stealing it, he makes sure that he leaves evidence behind to be caught; when caught, he does not take any action to extricate himself from such situations.

anRu – a day comes when he gets tied down and looks as a very simple person! Such a day too occurs! I had missed that day when he had himself tied down and looked so simple and I am praying for attaining him today!

Aychchi – he could not seek a remedy for the difficulty posed by a herdsman!

van thAmbugaLAI – whatever ropes she [yaSOdhA] could lay her hands on, turned out to be short to tie him. Hence she took more ropes and hit him with those. The anger towards a person would be present to the same extent as affection towards that person. It is pertinent here to recall periyā thiruvandhAdhi 38 pAsuram “*idaichchi kumaiththiRangaL . . .*” (the difficulties that he had undergone at the hands of yaSOdhA)

pudaikkalandhAnai – even when he was in such difficulties he did not take any remedial action.

alandhAnai – the term *ala* refers to blossoming. As she [yaSOdhA] hit him with the ropes, his face became more and more blossomed. periyā thirumozhi 5-9-7 says “*kaNNiyAr kuRungayiRRAl katta vettenRirundhAn*” (as he was tied with short ropes which were tied together, he stood as if agreeing to that act)

emmAnai – as he was being tied and hit, he shed copious amount of tears from his eyes and his dark divine form became pale; with such an act, he made me to be subservient only to him. Just as it has been mentioned in thiruvAimozhi 5-10-3 “*paiyavE nilaiyum*” (the way he stood trembling in fear), it was this which made me lose my steadfastness.

en sollip pulambuvenE – I desired for him now and am wailing since I could not attain him. I was not there when he carried out his activities in krishNAvathAram and I cannot point out to any deficiency in him. I am unable to attain him now because of the result of my past deeds. He has no shortcoming in him for me to blame him.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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89. pAsuram 87 – pulambum kanai kural

avathArikai (Introduction)

The *nAyaki*'s mother tells sarvESvaran "During this time when she is separated from you, harmful entities are tormenting her. You have made her to call out to you which is being seen by the people of the world!"

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

pulambum kanai kural pOzhvAya anRilum pUngazhipAyndhu alambum kana kural sUzh thirai Azhiyum Angu avai nin valam puLLadhu nalam pAdum idhu kuRRamAga vaiyam silambumbadi seyvadhE thirumAL iththiruvinaiyE

Word-by-Word Meanings

thirumAL – Oh the consort of Srl mahAlakshmi!

nin – as your vehicle

valam – having strength

puLLadhu – periya thiruvadi's (garudan's)

nalam – auspicious qualities

pAdum idhu – this singing

kuRRamAga – as a wrongful act (using this as a reason)

iththiruvinaiyE – this lakshmi

kanai kural – with an illegible sound

pulambum – crying

pOzh – splitting (affecting girls in separation)

vAy – having mouth

anRil – nightingale bird

pU – being beautiful

kazhi – in the salt pan

pAyndhu – flowing copiously

alambum – splashing

kanam – heavy

kural – having sound

sUzh – expansive

thirai – having waves

Azhiyum – ocean too

Angu avai – with such harmful entities

(tormenting this girl)

vaiyam – the world

silambumbadi – to cry out

seyvadhE – you are making!

Simple Translation

Oh the lord of Sri mahAlakshmi! The nightingale bird is crying out with a loud voice, splitting the hearts. The ocean, with its waves, is splashing around, to flow copiously into the salt pans. This lakshmi (my daughter) is singing on the strong garuda, your vehicle, about his auspicious qualities. Looking at this, the world is abusing her. You are making all these to happen!

vyAkyAnam

pulambum kanai kural – the nightingale bird is speaking about various matters, with a heavy voice, splitting the hearts of those who have separated from you.

pUngazhi . . . – expansive ocean which is flowing copiously into the salt pans, splashing its waves, making uproarious sound

Angavai – for those who are in separation, there are many harmful entities which torment, such as the bell tied to the neck of bull, rising moon, gentle breeze etc. Alternatively, it is the entities which have already been mentioned here – the call of nightingale and the sound from ocean. All these are tormenting her.

What is her fault for these entities to harm her?

nin valam puL . . . – she sang about garuda, who has a great strength, matching yours, about his qualities to carry you on his shoulders. Sri vishNu purANam 5-30-1 says “*garudOvAruNam chathram thadhaiva maNiparvatham | sapAryancha hrishIkESam leelayaiva vahan yayau |*” – after the death of narakAsuran, krishNa left the town of prAgyOthish carrying several things. At that time garuda carried krishNa and maNiparvatham, varuNa’s eminent umbrella on his back as if it was a sport for him. The *nAyaki* sang about such garuda. Just as it has been mentioned in sthOthra rathnam 41 “*thvadhagri sammardhakiNanga SObhina*”, having carried out kainkaryam to sarvESvaran and carrying out the scars of footprint on his shoulders, she too wanted to wear the scars of their union. Hence she sang a few words about garuda. Making this out as a fault . . .

vaiyam silambumbadi seyvadhE – without any distinction between elders and youngsters, just because they lived in the same place as the *nAyaki*, they pointed fingers at her and blamed her. How could they do this?

thirumAL – are you doing all these because she is not your consort?

iththiruvinaiyE – is she in any way inferior to those who desired you? Is she capable of remaining as patient as slthAppirAtti who was crowded around by the demonic women sent by rAvaNa? Will you

allow the people of the town when they blame her condition of being tormented by ocean etc? Will it not be your fault if your consort is distressed?

svApadhESam (distinguished meaning): Those who are near AzhwAr are asking sarvESvaran “Will it not be a deficiency for you if you delay coming to him when he is so distressed, being unable to overcome separation from you?”

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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90. pAsuram 88 – thirumAl uruvokkum

avathArikai (Introduction)

Even though the people of the town blamed her, the *nAyaki* (AzhwaR) mercifully says in this pAsuram “There is no shortcoming in us, even though the whole town has been blaming us” What has been said in this pAsuram is this – sarvESvaran’s divine form is without any equivalent entity, at all times. If a simile for that is seen, instead of consoling oneself saying “We are able to see a simile for an entity which is non-pareil”, it will create a craving in us to see the original entity itself. For such a person like us, is there any fault? Alternatively, when looking at his activity of creating all the entities and remaining as the sustaining force for them, instead of stopping with that, it would create a desire to see his distinguished divine form. For such a person like us, is there any deficiency?

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

thirumAl uruvokkum mEru ammEruvil senjudarOn thirumAl thirukkaith thiruchchakkaram okkum anna kaNdum thirumAl uruvOdu avan chinnamE pidhaRRA niRpadhOr thirumAl thalaikkoNda nangatku engE varum thlvinaiyE

Word-by-Word Meanings

mEru – the mountain *mEru*

thirumAl – the consort of Srl mahAlakshmi

uruvu – with his divine form

okkum – will be equivalent

ammEruvil – on the peak of that *mEru* mountain

sem – reddish

sudarOn – sUriyan (sun) with his rays

thirumAl – the consort of Srl mahAlakshmi, his

thirukkai – on his divine hand

thiruchchakkaram – with divine sudharSana chakram (divine disc)

anna kaNdum – despite seeing entities which are equivalent to sarvESvaran’s divine form and divine weapon

uruvOdu – with the divine form

avan – his

chinnamE – only divine weapons

(desiring to see)

pidhaRRA niRpadhu – calling out

Or – distinguished

thiru – eminent

mAl – bewilderment

thalaikkoNa – developed (firmly)

nangatku – for us

thlvinai – cruel sins

engE varum – how will it happen?

Simple Translation

The mEru mountain is a match for the divine form of sarvESvaran, who is the consort of Srl mahAlakshmi. sUriyan, with his reddish rays, on top of the mEru mountain, is a match for the divine sudharSana chakram held in the divine hand of sarvESvaran. Thus, even though we are able to see the entities which equal the divine form and the divine disc of sarvESvaran, we desire to see the divine form of sarvESvaran and his divine disc. When we call out to him, which is like an eminent bewilderment for us, how will cruel sins reach us?

vyAkyAnam

thirumAl uruvokkum mEru – the mountain mEru, through its huge size and radiance, matches the divine form of Srlya:pathi (consort of Srl mahAlakshmi).

ammEru . . . – sUriyan, who is traversing that mountain mEru

thirumAl thirukkaith thiruchchakkaram okkum – just as it has been said in thiruppallANdu 2 “*vadivAr sOdhi valaththuRaiyum sudarAzhiyum*” (divine disc having a radiance which pervades sarvESvaran’s entire form, residing on his divine right hand, burning enemies), sUriyan will look like that divine disc.

anna kaNdum – thus seeing entities which resemble sarvESvaran

thirumAl . . . – crying out incoherently to see the divine form which is like the mEru mountain and his distinguished weapons which are described as in thiruvAimozhi 6-4-9 “*valakkaiyAzhi idakkaichchangam*” (divine disc on the divine right hand and divine conch on the divine left hand)

Alternatively,

thirumAl thiruvokkum mEru . . . – mEru resembles the divine form of sarvESvaran; sUriyan, who is traversing it, resembles the divine disc on his divine hand; these two represent all the entities which sarvESvaran had created and for which he is the sustaining force.

anna kaNdum – even though they [mEru and sUriyan] remain as his physical form as per the relationship described in *AdhArA – AdhEya* (sustaining – being sustained), *niyanthru – niyAmya* (controller-controlled) and *SEshi – SEsha* (owner-owned) modes...

thirumAl . . . – instead of being satisfied with seeing entities for which he is the sustaining force, calling out with a desire to see his distinguished divine form and distinguished divine identities.

thirumAl – just as it has been mentioned in bruhadhAraNyaka upanishath 4-4-5 “*nidhithyAsithavya:*”- meditating on him without any break, AzhwAr attained the state which is true nature for him.

thalaikkoNda – *thalaikkoLLudhal* refers to being firm in a matter and not dropping it since some people spoke against it. Not considering the way some people had blamed her [in the previous pAsuram], remaining firm in matters related to sarvESvaran, just like diamond cannot be destroyed by fire.

nangatku – for us, who are involved in matters related to sarvESvaran. Just as the saying goes “ *avaSyam anubhOkthavyam krutham karma SubhASubham* ” (everyone has to necessarily experience the results of their deeds, whether good or bad), are our deeds capable of creating any fault in us?

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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91. pAsuram 89 – thIvinaikkaru nanjai

avathArikai (Introduction)

AzhwAr says “We have reached the stage of being distinct from samsAris; when will we mingle with the people who have attained him and are experiencing him?”

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*thIvinaikkaru nanjai nalvinakku innamudhaththinaip pUvinai mEviya dhEvi maNALanaip punmai
eLgAdhu Avinai mEykkum vallAyanai anRu ulagu IradiyAl thAvina ERRai emmAnai egyAnRu
thalaippeyvane*

Word-by-Word Meanings

thI – cruel

vinaikku – (followers’) sins

aru – being rare

nanjai – being like poison [as an antidote]

nalvinaikku – for good deeds

in – sweet

amudhaththinai – being like nectar

pUvinai – lotus flower

mEviya – dwelling aptly

dhEvi – for periyA pirAtti (SrI mahAlakshmi)

maNALanai – as her consort

pumnai – lowly act

eLgAdhu – without despising

Avinai – cows

mEykkum – one who tends to

val – being eminent

Ayanai – as krishNa, the cowherd

anRu – during the time of mahAbali

ulagu – worlds

IradiyAl – with two steps

thAvina – one who seized

ERRai – being eminent

emmAnai – sarvESvaran, who is my lord

egyAnRu – when

thalaippeyvan – will I approach?

Simple Translation

sarvESvaran is the rare poison for the cruel sins of his followers; he is the sweet nectar for their good deeds; he is the consort of Srl mahAlakshmi who dwells on a lotus flower; without considering as a despicable act, he tended to cows, having been born in the clan of cowherds and measured all the worlds with just two steps; when will I reach such sarvESvaran?

vyAkyAnam

thlvinaikkyaru nanjai – he [sarvESvaran] is the intolerable poison for the bad deeds which are a hurdle in attaining him.

nalvinaikku – for bhakthi (devotion) which is carried out without expecting any benefit from him

innamudhaththinai – he gives unlimited joy and he is the ultimate goal.

Next he explains as to why he removes our sins and creates an engagement in us, with him.

pUvinai mEviya . . . – due to his union with periya pirAtti; there is nothing which is more eminent than his being the consort of periya pirAtti.

punmai . . . – despite having that eminence, since he is together with periya pirAtti, he is easily approachable for his followers.

punmai eLgAdhu Avainai mEykkum – without thinking whether it will be apt for his eminence as the consort of periya pirAtti, he tended to cows without considering it as a despicable act.

vallAyanai – if even a drop of water (rain) falls on the cowherds, he would not tolerate it and hold a mountain as an umbrella for them.

anRulagu . . . – just as he protected one village, he protected this earth.

ERRai – he stood proudly after getting the worlds under his divine feet. He considered the benefit thus obtained as his and not as that of the people of the worlds.

emmAnai – just as sarvESvaran felt proud and eminent after his victories, AzhwAr too felt eminent after losing out to him for such activities of sarvESvaran's.

egyAnRu thalaippeyvanE – when sarvESvaran's activities are like these, AzhwAr knows that he is bound to attain him but is not sure as to when. Just as it has been said in Srl rAmAyaNam ayOdhyA kANdam 24-37 “*apldhAnIm sa kAlassyAdh*” ((kausalyA dhEvi tells Srl rAma) may that time be just now), though kausalyA knows that Srl rAma would come at the end of fourteen years, she could not wait for those fourteen years to end and wished that that day had come then itself. AzhwAr too is in the same state.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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92. pAsuram 90 – thalaippeydhu yAn

avathArikai (Introduction)

In the previous pAsuram AzhwAr was lamenting “*egyAnRu thalaippeyvane*” (when will I attain you?) sarvESvaran asked him “Why cannot you remain with the belief that connection with sarvESvaran will yield the result of uniting with him?” AzhwAr says “I could remain like that If I do not have any desire in you, like the samsAris” He says that it is impossible for him to spend time without thinking of sarvESvaran. What is he saying in this pAsuram? If I think about the facts that I have obtained a physical form which is capable of attaining you and that it is uncertain, due to the unbearability of not being with you, the time to attain you seems to extend forever. Alternatively, since I have obtained a nature by which I cannot sustain myself through any entity other than you, and since this nature came about because of my presence in samsAram, time is not sufficient to think about the fact that this is not uniform.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*thalaippeydhu yAn un thiruvadhich chUdhum thagaimaiyinAl nilaippeydha Akkaikku nORRa
immAyamum mAyam sevvE nilaippeydhiAdha nilaimaiyum kANdORasurar kuzhAm thalaippeydha nEmi
endhAy thollai Uzhi surungaladhE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

asurar – demons’

kuzhAm – for their clan

tholai – destruction

peydha – one who made

nEmi – one who has the divine disc

endhAy – Oh my swAmy (lord)!

yAn – I

thalaippeydhu – attaining

un thiruvadi – your divine feet

sUdum – donning on my head

thagaimaiyinAl – due to the nature

nilaippu eydha – having firmness

Akkaikku – to get the form

nORRa – carrying out good deeds (for many thousands of births)

i – this

mAyamum – amazement

mAyam – amazing form

sevvE – very well (uniform)

nilaippeydhu ilAdha – not having firmness

nilaimaiyum – position *kAN dhORu* – whenever I think of

thollai – being ancient

Uzhi – kalpam (brahmA's lifetime)

surungaladhu – is not shrinking

Simple Translation

Oh my swAmy who has the divine disc and who destroys the clan of demons! I have obtained a form by carrying out some good deeds in the past many thousands of births due to which I could attain you and don your divine feet on my head. When I think of these amazing activities as well as the condition of not reaching you soon enough, I realise that the time to reach you and experience you is extending without any shrinkage.

vyAkyAnam

thalaippeydhu – attaining you

yAn – I who am remaining without any means

un thiruvadi . . . – the amazement that I have obtained a form due to good deeds carried out in many thousands of births earlier; as a result I could sustain that form by attaining your divine feet

mAyam sevvE nilaippeydhiAdha nilaimaiyum – due to the amazing nature of this *prakruthi* (samsAram), that nature cannot be taken as being firm.

Alternatively,

thalaippeydhu . . . – I approached you and attained the nature of sustaining myself only with nothing else other than your divine feet and the amazement attained due to that.

Akkaikku nORRa immAyamum – Just as Sri vishNu dharmam says “*janmAnthara sahasrEshu*” (after taking thousands of births), wouldn't this nature come in only with carrying out good deeds over several thousands of births? Wouldn't this nature result only after obtaining such a form? Thus, getting such a form is also a part of bhakthi (devotion)

In this thought process, while it appears that carrying out good deeds in the past births is the reason for the present situation, the distinguished nature of donning your divine feet on my head (*thiruvadichchUdum thagaimaiyinAl nilaippeydha*) can be a nature primarily only because of the distinction of having *sathva guNam* (only purely good quality) [the form which the human beings acquire is made of three qualities, viz. *sathva*, *rajas* and *thamas* (purely good, passion and ignorance respectively)].

mAyam sevvE . . . – since this form is under the control of three qualities [as seen above], the nature spoken of earlier will not come to the surface when the body is under the control of *rajas* or *thamas*

component, but will be true only if *sathva* component is predominant. Thus, the form is not uniform always and is a cause of amazement.

kAN dhORu – whenever this [feature of three qualities] is thought of. In other words, it could be said that he keeps thinking of this continuously.

asurar . . . – Oh my swAmy who destroyed the clan of demons and who has the divine disc! Am I consoling myself that you are without ability, that you cannot be attained or that I am suffering due to my deeds?

thollai . . . – this time which is ancient is not shrinking [viz., it is not reducing in terms of its length]; it is extending further. Alternatively, if I keep thinking about this amazing nature, time does not seem to shrink; time is not passing.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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93. pAsuram 91 – surunguRi veNNey

avathArikai (Introduction)

In the previous pAsuram, AzhwAr had felt miserable about time not shortening [to attain sarvESvaran]. A few samsAris, on seeing this, told him “We are engaged with matters relating to samsAram and are not complaining that time is not lengthening or shortening. We are enjoying the matters relating to samsAram even if time lengthens or shortens. Why don’t you change your involvement from matters relating to bhagavAn and engage with worldly matters?” AzhwAr says “Yes, I could do it provided I get a heart which is capable of doing that; my heart knows nothing other than bhagavAn. Even this heart I can engage with, provided he had not stolen it”

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

surunguRiveNNey thoduvuNda kaLvanai vaiyam muRRum orunguRavuNda peruvayiRRALanai mAvali mAttu irunguRaLAGi isaiya Or mUvadi vENDichchenRa perungiRiyAnai allAI adiyEn nenjam pENaladhE

Word-by-Word Meanings

surungu – contracted (with the aid of deceptive ropes)

uRi – hoop like structure, hung from ceiling to keep pots etc

veNNey – butter [kept in a pot inside that hoop like structure]

thodu uNda – one who stole and ate

kaLvanai – one who incarnated as krishNa having the quality of stealing

vaiyam muRRum – entire world

orungu – in a small corner

uRa – fitting well

uNda – swallowed

peru – huge

vayiRRALanai – having stomach

mAvalimAttu – to mAvali

iru – huge (small)

kuRaLAGi – as vAmana [dwarf]

(went)

isaiya – making (him to) accept

Or – unique

mUvadi – three steps

vENdi – seeking

senRa – one who went with a beautiful gait

perum kiRiyAnai allAI – other than the one who is a great means

(another)

adiyEn – a servitor only for him

nenjam – mind

peNaladhu – will not like

Simple Translation

My heart will not like anyone other than sarvESvaran who ate butter from the hoop by stealing, who kept all the worlds inside corner of his stomach, who went to mahAbali, seeking alms as a dwarf and made him agree to giving him three steps of land and who is a great means [for attaining himself].

vyAkyAnam

surunguRi veNNey – it was a hoop made with deceptive ropes [so that its location would not be known easily].

veNNey thoduvuNda – he stole the butter and ate it, without disturbing the marks which had been made by the owners of butter.

kaLvanai – he stole the concept of stealing itself; thus some people [who had lost their butter] said “This could not have been stolen by people; did Gods steal our butter? Did we not keep butter inside that?”

vaiyam . . . – while his stomach got filled up with butter, when he swallowed all the worlds [during deluge], it did not fill up even half his stomach. The implication here is that he would be able to sustain himself with a material touched by his followers while his mind was not much enthused about protecting the worlds.

mAvali mAttu – he approached and attained a demonic entity; AzhwAr says that sarvESvaran should have attained him who desired only sarvESvaran and none else.

irunguRaLagi – being a huge dwarf [The word *iru* which means huge is used as a *viparIthalakshaNam* here – meaning exactly the opposite]. His short stature was such that among the dwarfs of the world, the shortest dwarf would appear like thrivikraman in his presence.

isaiya – he did all the work to make mahAbali to agree to his request; making mahAbali’s acceptance to be under his control. Though there were others (sukrAchAryar) who did not want mahAbali to accede to his request, sarvESvaran made mahAbali to accept.

Or mUvadi vENDichchenRa – instead of asking for two steps and measuring with both the steps, he asked for three steps and measured with two steps so that he could imprison mahAbali with the third step.

vENDichcchenRa perungiRiyAnai allAI – he went in such a way that his quality of *sarva nirapEksham* – ‘not desiring anything’ was not manifested. He went such that mahAbali thought “Unless I give him what he wants, he cannot sustain himself”. He hid his quality of *ISvarathvam* – controlling everyone. He

went asking for alms to make it appear that one who does not have any desire unfulfilled, came with a desire. He took such a form that it created mercy in mahAbali.

perungiRiyAn – a hugely clever person.

adiyEn – AzhwAr is not like mahAbali, about to give something. He is not like indhra [head of celestial entities] too, waiting to obtain one. He is one who has lost out to that activity of sarvESvaran's and made himself as a servitor to sarvESvaran.

nenjam pENaladhE – he will not desire even the supremacy of the supreme entity, just like hanuman did in Srl rAmAyaNam uththara kANDam 40-15 “ *bhAvO nAnyathra gachchathi* ” (my thoughts will not go to anyone other than you)

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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94. pAsuram 92 – pENalamilla arakkar

avathArikai (Introduction)

AzhwAr had said in the previous pAsuram “ *perungiRiyAnai allAI adiyEn nenjam pENaladhE* ”. Here he says that dhEvas (celestial entities) who are limited [by their abilities] but are higher than samsAris, are not involved even to this extent with sarvESvaran. Their deficiency is that while we attempt to attain sarvESvaran by destroying our sense of possessiveness, they try to gain advantages for themselves even if they have to make him transform himself.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

*pENalamilla arakkar munnIra perum padhi vAy nINagar nILeri vaiththu aruLAY enRu ninnai viNNOr
kAnilam thOyndhu thozhuvar nin mUrththi pal kURRil onRum kANalumAngol enRE vaigal mAlaiyum
kAlaiyumE*

Word-by-Word Meanings

munnlra – surrounded by ocean

perum – expansive

padhi – vibhUthi (materialistic realm)

pEN – protecting

nam illa – not having the benefit

arakaar – inhabited by demons

nIL – having the greatness of not being able to be destroyed by anyone

nagar – in lankA

nIL – not being burnt by any other entity

eri – fire

vaiththu – making use of

aruLAY – protect (us)

enRu – beseeching

ninnai – you

viNNOr – celestial entities

nilam – on earth

kAl thOyndhu – keeping their legs firmly

vaigal – every day

kAlaiyum mAlaiyum – during dawn and dusk

thozhuvar – will worship

nin mUrthy – in the beauty of your divine form

pal kURRil – among the many forms

onRu – at the least one form

kANulAmAngol enRE – is to see (that they worship)? (No)

Simple Translation

The celestial entities worship you everyday, both during dawn and dusk, planting their feet firmly on earth, asking you to save them by setting fire to lankA which is inhabited by demons. lankA is a small part of the expansive earth, surrounded by ocean. The demons, who do not have the quality of protection, inhabit it. Are they doing this considering that they would like to see one form among your many divine, beautiful forms? (No, they are doing this to serve their own interests).

vyAkyAnam

pENalam . . . (munnlra perum padhiyaip pENalamillA arakkar) – your realm, composed of many different parts, which is surrounded by ocean.

nINagar . . . – they will request you to destroy a small part of your realm. Since they know that harming anyone or anything is against the grain of your divine mind, in order to show pity on them, they will use apt words. They will say “Your vibhUthi will not survive if they survive”. They will tell sarvESvaran “They are harming rishis (sages) who are meditating on your divine auspicious qualities, dwelling in one place and celestial entities”.

pENalamillA – sarvESvaran considers that protecting others is his benefit. The demons will not think that others should live, as they do.

pENalam . . . – demons who do not have the benefit of protecting sarvESvaran’s realm.

munnlra perum padhi vAy nINagar – since that place [lankA] is like a refuge for those who fear for their safety, it became the refuge for the entire cruel clan of demons. Since it is well surrounded by ocean on all sides, it is impossible for some to enter it. It is a huge island with the ocean serving as a moat.

nINagar – the place has been reinforced by the benefits of boons granted by celestial entities.

nILeri vaiththaruLAy – the celestial entities will beseech sarvESvaran to use his arrows which are capable of destroying the power granted through their boons. Just as it has been mentioned in thiruvAimozhi 4-2-8 “*ilangai nagar ambu eri uyththavar*” (fire which was shot off the arrows from Srl rAma), they prayed to sarvESvaran to burn the entire place.

ninnai – you are one who is deeply engrossed in protecting all the worlds. They will shed tears of distress through their eyes to change your mind when you are against destroying a place in your realm.

viNNOr – these celestial entities do not dwell in the place where nithyasUris [who dwell in paramapadham] constantly experience sarvESvaran; they do not dwell on earth where sarvESvaran comes down, manifesting his simplicity amidst his greatness. They dwell somewhere in between, in svaragam, like an attic.

kAl nilam thOyndhu – aren't they the people who will come here, degrading themselves, since this is the place where they do not like to place their feet.

thozhuvAr – unlike rAvaNa who said as in Srl rAmAyaNam yudhdha kANdam 36-11 “ *na namEyam . .* ” (Even if I am broken into two pieces, I will not bend before anyone), the celestial entities will stand before you, worshipping you.

nin . . . – are they worshipping you to get the benefit desired by those who worship you? It is certainly not to experience the divine form that they are worshipping you. Are they worshipping you to see the procession of your beautiful form [as during a festival in temples] which is one part among the many parts of your divine form?

anRiRE – they are not like the great people mentioned in sthOthra rathnam 56 “ *sakruth thvadhAkAra vilOkanASayA thriNikruthAn uththama bhukthi mukthibi:* ” (the followers who consider their great qualities as inferior to a blade of grass if they could see your divine form once).

vaigal mAlaiyum kAlaiyumE – the worshipping carried out by celestial entities is not for the purpose of seeing your divine form which your followers will worship for; yet they will keep worshipping you incessantly, for a much longer time [in order to destroy the demons and enable them to live peacefully].

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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95. pAsuram 93 – kAlai veyyORku mun

avathArikai (Introduction)

Celestial entities, due to their pride of calling themselves as *ISvaran* (one who controls everything) have forgotten sarvESvaran. Are the others worshipping him? Without making any distinction between one and the other, for everyone, it is only the worldly matters which are of interest.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

kAlai veyyORkumun Ottuk koduththa kangul kuRumbar mAlai veyyOn pada vaiyagam paravuvavar anna kaNdum kAlai nangyanaththuRaipadhindhAdik kaNpOdhu seydhumAlai nannAvil koLLAr ninaiyar avan maippadiyE

Word-by-Word Meanings

kAlai – during dawn

veyyORku – for sUriyan (sun)

(being fearful)

mun – earlier itself

Ottukkoduththa – one who ran away

kangul – called as night

kuRumbar – mischievous person

mAlai – during dusk

veyyOn – sUriyan

pada – as he sets

vaiyagam – on earth

paravuvavar – will spread

anna – at that type of change in time

kaNdum – even after seeing

kAlai – during sunrise

nal – (related to bhagavan) being distinguished

gyAnam – knowledge

thuRai – on the banks

padindhu – fitting well

Adi – taking a bath

kaN – (sensory organs such as) eye

*pOdh*u *seydhu* – blossoming well (such that they do not engage with worldly matters)

mAlai – sarvESvaran who is bewildered (with his followers)

nal – eminent (in being devoted to praising sarvESvaran)

nAvil – tongue

koLLAr – those who do not accept

avan – that sarvESvaran's

mai – being black like pigment

padi – divine form

ninaiyAr – will not keep in their hearts

Simple Translation

The mischievous person, called as night, runs before sUriyan rises in the morning. But he returns in the dusk time, once sun sets. Despite seeing time flying away like this, every day, there are people who do not think of sarvESvaran alone, in the morning, which is when knowledge about sarvESvaran is full, who do not take a bath on the bank of that knowledge and who do not keep away from engaging with worldly matters through their eyes and other sensory organs. Such people, who do not recite the divine names of sarvESvaran from their tongue, cannot keep the divine form of that sarvESvaran, which is dark like a black pigment, in their hearts.

vyAkyAnam

kAlai . . . – when sUriyan rises in the morning with his powerful rays, he drives away darkness; during night, darkness overpowers sUriyan. Despite seeing this activity, just as it has been mentioned in Srl rAmAyaNam ayOdhyA kANdam 105-24 “ *nandhanthi udhitha AdhithyE nandhanthi asthamithE ravau* ” (people are delighted when the sun rises and are happy when the sun sets), they feel happy when it dawns so that they could go in search of worldly matters to feed their sensory organs; they are again happy when sun sets since the time has come to experience worldly matters without others knowing about them.

kAlai . . . – it is the time of dawn. The mischievous people such as night will run away from sUriyan who rises at that time, since his rays fall on them. When it is dusk, they will destroy the mighty and powerful sUriyan and take away his expansive kingdom. They will make earth to be ecstatic since the time to sleep arrives.

anna kaNdum – Despite seeing this happen every day, since *bhagavath vishayam* (matters relating to sarvESvaran) does not yield itself to sensory organs, they become ignorant of it and perish. Even though *bhagavath vishayam* is not visible to the eyes etc, it is strange that they are not able to perceive it with their minds too.

kAlai – it is that time of the day when *sathva* (good) matters rise to the surface.

nan gyAnam – if it is knowledge, it cannot be related to anything other than *bhagavath vishayam* . The vyAkyAthA cites the following references to stress this:

mudhal thiruvandhAdhi 67 “ *oNdAmaraiyAL kELvan oruvanaiyEnOkkum uNarvu* ” – one’s mind will look at the consort of Srl mahAlakshmi alone.

Srl vishNu purANam 6-5-87 “ *thath gyAnam agyAnamathOnyadhu:kam* ” – only that which leads to knowing about sarvESvaran is referred to as knowledge. All the rest are ignorance only.

Srl vishNu purANam 1-9-41 “ *vidhyAnyASilpanaipuNam* ” – faculties other than knowledge do not bestow mOksham (liberation from samsAram) on AthmA.

There is no distinction between knowing other [worldly] matters and sewing rag clothes.

thuRai padindhAdi – entering this water called as *gyAnam* (knowledge) and taking a bath

kaN pOdhu seydhhu – *pOdhu seydhhal* refers to closing like buds as well as blossoming. When worldly matters are seen, the eyes will close like buds. They will blossom when the matters are related to sarvESvaran are seen.

mAlai – All that is required to be done is to keep constantly meditating on sarvESvaran; once this is done, sarvESvaran will come on his own and fall on us head over heels; he is to that extent infatuated with us.

nal nAvil – *nal nA* refers to avoiding all the unwanted worldly matters and talking about matters relating to sarvESvaran. AzhwAr says that despite being provided with a tongue which is apt to speak about sarvESvaran, the samsAris are going for outside [worldly] matters. Srl vishNu dharmam – 1 says *sA jihvA* – tongue is there only to speak about him.

ninaiyAr avan meypadiyE – no one thinks about the divine form [of sarvESvaran’s] which cannot be given up even if he does only harmful activities towards us instead of being infatuated with us and carrying out benevolent activities. sUrppaNakA says in Srl rAmAyaNam, after looking at the divine form of Srl rAma [and lakshmaNa] *tharuNau* – youthful entities; despite being severed of her nose and ears by Srl rAma, this is how she described to rAvaNa of their physical beauty. Other than being filled with happiness on seeing their divine forms, for what did she have to describe them this way, despite being harmed by them?

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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96. pAsuram 94 – maippadi mEniyum

avathArikai (Introduction)

sarvESvaran asked AzhwAr “You say that since celestial entities have a pride that they are eminent and since samsAris are ignorant, they lose out on *bhagavath vishayam* (matters relating to sarvEsvaran). Do you have any deficiency?” AzhwAr responds “You have created a deficiency in me. You had showered faultless knowledge as well as devotion. You showered that knowledge with devotion. Due to the devotional trance, in my state of bewilderment, I did not praise you”. In thiruvAimozhi decad 1-5 *vaLavEzh*, AzhwAr had said that due to his being without any qualification, he would not say anything. This is similar to that.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings.

maippadi mEniyum sendhAmarai kaNNum vaidhikarE meyppadiyAl un thiruvadi sUdum thagaimiyinAr eppadi UrAmilaikkak kuruttAmilaikkum ennum appadi yAnum sonnEn adiyEn maRRu yAdhu enbanE

Word-by-Word Meanings

vaidhikarE – those devotees who know your true nature as mentioned in vEdhas (sacred texts)

mai – black pigment

padi – having its nature

mEniyum – divine form

sem – reddish

thAmarai – like lotus flower

kaNNum – having eyes

un – your

thiruvadi – divine feet

sUdum – to be donned on their heads

thagaimiyinAr – have the nature

Ur – approaching the town

A – cows

eppadi – how

milaikka – moo (sound made by cows; also called as ‘low’)

(hearing that)

kuruttu A – blind cow

milaikkum – will also moo (like the former)

ennum appadi – just like the idiom used in the world

yAnum – I too

sonnEn – said (about you)

adiyEn – I, in a devotional trance

maRRu – beyond that

yAdhenban – what will I say?

Simple Translation

You have a divine form which is dark in complexion like black pigment and reddish, divine eyes which are like lotus flower. Only those people who know your true nature as mentioned in *vEdhas*, are qualified to don your divine feet truly on their heads. When cows return home after grazing during the day, the cows will moo [in anticipation of seeing their calves]. Hearing this, a blind cow too will moo. In the same way, I too said a few words about you. What else can I, who am in devotional trance, say beyond this?

vyAkyAnam

maippadimEniyum – divine form which is like black pigment. The divine form which is soothing on the eyes of the beholder. *vyAkyAthA* narrates an incident which occurred during the time of *bhattar* (son of *kUraththAzhwAn*). *bhattar* was explaining this *pAsuram*. *piLLai vizhuppararaiyar* and *AppAn thiruvazhundhUraraiyar* were in the audience. *bhattar* said for this verse “The divine form which causes infatuation in the hearts of those who think about *sarvESvaran*” *nanjIyar*, *bhattar*’s disciple quoted *periya thirumozhi* 10-10-9 “*innAr enRu aRiyEn*” (I do not who this entity is, who is holding the divine disc and divine conch). *bhattar* asked as to who made that remark. The *araiyars* said that it was *nanjIyar* who made the remark. *bhattar* praised him, saying “We did not think of that. You were born in a place which is hundreds of miles away from here and you are explaining this to us so well!”

sendhAmaraikkaNNum – the divine eyes which bring out the inner, hidden, auspicious qualities.

vaidhikar . . . – here, the term *vaidhikar* refers to one who is firmly immersed in the first part of *vEdhas* [the first part of *vEdhas* deals with deeds to be carried out and the second or end part of *vEdhas* deals with the supreme entity]; they will involve with the cluster of deeds to be carried out for various purposes and will not meditate on *sarvESvaran*’s *svarUpam* (true nature), *rUpam* (divine form), *aiSvaryam* (wealth) etc. Alternatively, just as *bruhadhAraNyaka upanishath* 4-4-5 says “*nidhithyAsithavya* :”(constantly meditating on the auspicious qualities of *sarvESvaran*, without a break) – those who are with unchanged devotion towards *sarvESvaran*. Unlike those who are involved with carrying out deeds and are clear in their minds, these people will be in a state of bewilderment since they keep thinking constantly of *sarvESvaran*’s auspicious qualities. Only such people have the ability of holding on to your divine feet, truly.

sarvESvaran asks of *AzhwAr* “That may be so. If only such people are apt to attain our divine feet, how did you speak about us?” As a response to that, *AzhwAr* says

eppadi . . . – when cows return home in the evening, after grazing, they will make a loud noise, called as mooing. Not knowing as to why they are mooing, even a blind cow will make a similar noise.

appadi yAnum sonnEn – without thinking “Who am I to speak about *sarvESvaran* when only knowledgeable people can speak about him” I too spoke a few words about you, like those blind cows.

adiyEn maRRu yAdhu enbanE – am I, in a state of devotional trance towards you, capable of speaking clearly about you and completing it? Alternatively, am I, leaving you after speaking in an inapt way about you, capable of speaking anything matching your auspicious qualities and completing it?

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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97. pAsuram 95 – yAdhAnum Or Akkaiyil

avathArikai (Introduction)

Instead of leaving sarvESvaran showing his inadequacy in either his devotional trance or inaptness in meditating on him, he bowed down to the divine feet of sarvESvaran since he created engagement in AzhwAr to be fully devoted to matters relating to him and distaste in worldly matters. vyAkyAthA narrates an event regarding nanjIyar with reference to this pAsuram. When parASara bhattar was in thirukkOttiyUr, one SrlvaishNava, rAmAnujadhAsar, approached him and asked him to mercifully explain thiruviruththam to him. bhattar told him “Due to my separation from perumAL (periya perumAL, Srl ranganAthan, at Srlrangam) I am in a state of distress and I am not in a frame of mind to say anything”. Turning to nanjIyar, bhattar told him “You please explain to him”. nanjIyar also started explaining thiruviruththam to him. Another person, vaLavan pallavatharaiyan, joined them in this. He was a follower of thirukkOttiyUr nambi (one of the AchAryars of Srl rAmAnujar). When this pAsuram was about to be explained, vaLavan pallavatharaiyar was in tears. Looking at this, nanjIyar asked him “I have not started explaining this pAsuram. Why are you in this state already?” pallavatharaiyar replied “When thirukkOttiyUr nambi was instructing me about thiruviruththam, he had mercifully told me to recite this pAsuram in front of sarvESvaran everyday. I was reminiscing that”. Hearing this, nanjIyar asked him “Could you recollect a few words which thirukkOttiyUr nambi had mercifully told you about this pAsuram?” pallavatharaiyar said “I do not remember that. All that I remember is reciting this pAsuram” nanjIyar felt very happy that thirukkOttiyUr nambi liked this pAsuram so much and spoke in praise of that for a few hours.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

yAdhAnum Or Akkaiyil pukku angAppuNdum Appavizhndhum mUdhAviyil thadumARum uyir munnamE adhanAl yAdhAnum paRRi nIngum viradhaththai nal vIdu seyyum mAthAvinaip pithuvai thirumAlai vaNanguvanE

Word-by-Word Meanings

uyir – jIvAthmA (soul)

munnamE – from time immemorial

yAdhAnum Or – in something or other

Akkaiyil – physical form

pukku – entering

angu – in that form

Appu uNdum – getting tied down to it (due to *prArabdha karma* (past deed which has started yielding result))

Appu avizhndhum – getting liberated from it (due to destruction of *prArabdha karma*)

mUdhu – being ancient

Aviyil – in the subtle form

(staying in *svargam* and *naragam* (heaven and hell))

thadumARum – will keep fluctuating

adhanAI – due to that repeated act

yAdhAnum – some matter (related to *prAkrutham* , the causative matter)

paRRi – holding on to

nIngum – moving away (from matter related to sarvESvaran)

viradhaththai – (my) vow

nal vIdu seyyum – one who liberated me

mAthAvinai – being affectionate like mother

pithuvai – being well-intentioned like father

thirumAlai – the consort of Sri mahAlakshmi

vaNanguvan – I will attain

Simple Translation

jlvAthmA (soul) has been, from time immemorial, entering some physical form, getting tied down to it, and at one point of time, getting liberated from it. It would then enter a subtle form and keep going to *svargam* and *naragam* . With that bondage (to that form) as the reason, it has been holding on to some matter or the other related to worldly pursuits and leaving matters related to sarvESvaran. However, sarvESvaran made me give up my firm vow (to keep vacillating among these sates, mentioned here); he has been like a mother to me, being affectionate, and he has been like a father to me, being well-intentioned about me. I will attain such sarvESvaran.

vyAkyAnam

yAdhAnum Or Akkaiyil pukku – entering some *SarIram* (physical form), and praising it as *mamAyam dhEha* : (this is an amazing form), even if it is a lowly form. Having taken such a form, due to firm bondage with it, an inability to leave that form and getting involved with it fully. Since it is referred to as *Akkai* , as per the root of the word *dhEham* which is *dhiha upachayE* , dhEham attains *upachayam* or growth. Thus, it keeps growing.

pukku – for *chEthana* (sentient entity), attachment to an insentient entity is not his own nature but comes out of *karma* (previous deeds). Thus, AthmA, a *chEthana* entity, enters a physical form which is *achEtha* entity.

angAppuNduM – due to his [*chEthana* 's] association with previous deeds and being habituated to it, he will get bonded to the physical forms. Despite knowing through the words of an AchAryan (teacher) or through SAsthras (religious texts) and through direct experience, that these [the physical forms) are lowly, wondering as to what he will do if he were to give up his forms, he will be unable to give them up.

Appavizhndhum – not knowing that his bondage with the physical form is due to his karma, he will be unable to get rid of it; once karma gets destroyed, the physical form will get annihilated.

mUdhAviyil – through this, he is reminiscing early times. The term *Avi* refers to *prANan* – vital air. Since *prANan* is distinct from *achith*, the subtle form is now referred to as *Avi*. This is considered as an activity of *prakruthi* (primordial matter) and also as a part of *prakruthi*. This will keep following until liberation. It will help the *chEthana* in his movements and non-movements.

thadumARum – as described in *panchAgni vidhyai* (the journey of *AthmA* through five stages in its repeated cycle of births), the *jlVAtmA* will enter clouds [after *svargam/naragam*], enter earth through rains, enter foodfrains, enter a *chEthana*'s form through intake of food and enter the womb of a lady during their union. In all these states, he keeps stumbling without being able to stay firmly in any place. During his journey, there will be places which are known as well as unknown to him.

uyir – the *AthmA*, which is full of knowledge and full of joy, and is permanent, suffers like this.

From when has this stumbling and existing been like this?

munnamE – this has been there from time immemorial.

adhanAI – since the association (with *achEthana*) has been there for a very long time, he thinks that the *achEthana* entity is his guide.

yAdhAnum paRRi – thinking that only matters other than those related to *sarvESvaran* should be attained; accepting all such matters without analysing their virtues and faults.

nIngum – only matters relating to *bhagavAN* are to be given up.

viradhaththai – even if some people instruct “Whatever you are holding on to are faulty. Only matters related to *bhagavAn* are apt to be held on to” and even if what they say are correct, I have taken a vow that I will give them up [matters relating to *bhagavAn*]. Just as *sarvESvaran* has taken a vow, as mentioned in *Sri rAmAyaNam yudhdha kANdam* 18-33 “*Ethath vratham mama*” (even if the person who comes to me is my enemy, I will not give him up; this is my vow), the *jlVAtmA* has taken a vow that he will give up *sarvESvaran*; just as *rAvaNa* had said in *Sri rAmAyaNam yudhdha kANdam* 36-11 “*na namEyam*” (even if I am split into two, I will not bow to someone; my body will only fall backward).

nal vidu seyyum – removing the present situation and making me pray, as in *thiruviruththam* 1 *inninRa nIrmai inyAm uRAmai* – holding his divine feet and asking him to relieve me from this *samsAram*. Before developing an involvement with him, severing my interest in matters related to worldly pursuits.

mAthAvinaip pithuvai – the mother and father, who are not really our mother and father, are responsible for this physical form and for our being involved with *samsAram*. However, *sarvESvaran* is the one who relieves us from this. What is the need to mention both?

thirumAlai – since he is the consort of *Sri mahAlakshmi*, as said in *mahAbhAratham pithA mAtha cha mAdhava* : – both father and mother are *mAdhavan*, the consort of *Sri mahAlakshmi*, he is mentioning both.

vaNanguvanE – it is not possible for us to carry out a beneficial act to *sarvESvaran* matching his beneficial act towards us in creating a distaste in us for worldly matters and affection towards him. The only action that we can do is to submit the entity which was his, always (*AthmA*).

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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98. pAsuram 96 – vaNangum thuRaigal

avathArikai (Introduction)

In the previous pAsuram, AzhwAr had submitted the AthmA which belongs to sarvESvaran back to him since he could not match the benefit that sarvESvaran had carried out for him. The benefit that sarvESvaran had done for AzhwAr was that he had stopped the interest in worldly pursuits and created interest in matters related to him, when AzhwAr was unable to seclude himself without speaking about it or could not remain without speaking either (about these two – refraining from worldly pursuits and engaging with matters relating to bhagavAn). In this pAsuram, he says that all the ingredients to attain sarvESvaran are not available here. Since you [refers to sarvESvaran] have given up, does it mean that I too [refers to AzhwAr], who am capable of carrying out your tasks, should give them up? When all the chEthanAs [sentient entities] were lying like achEthanA entities during the time of deluge, you had granted the qualities which are exclusive to chEthanAs and the knowledge to choose between what is to be acquired and what is to be discarded. The reason for granting them this was for them to decide as to what is the end goal for them and how to attain that. However, since that knowledge is common with engaging with worldly pursuits and being firmly rooted in them, due to their association with karmas (deeds, both good and bad) since time immemorial, with that knowledge these chEthanAs have been engaging with worldly pursuits. Thus, since you made them engage with worldly pursuits, your situation has become similar to a mother who was unable to prevent her child from falling into the well and was accused of having pushed that child into the well.

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

vaNangum thuRai palapalavAkki madhivigaRpAl piNangum samayangaL palapalavAkki avai avaidhORu ANangum palapalavAkki nin mUrththi parappi vaiththAy iNangu ninnOrai illAy ninkaN vEtikai ezhuvippanE

Word-by-Word Meanings

vaNangum – to attain (other deities)

pala pala – many

thuRaigal – various deities who instruct

Akki – created

madhi vigaRpAl – due to difference in intellect

piNangum – disagreeing

palapala – of many types

samayam – philosophies

avaiyavaidhORu – among all those philosophies

ninmUrththi – as your forms

aNangum – deities

Akki – created as being apt to be attained

parappi vaiththAy – you created expansively

iNangu – (with those deities) appearing to be a match

ninnOrai – those who are an equal to you

illAy – Oh, one who doesn't have!

ninkaN – towards you

vEtkai – desire

ezhuvippanE – I will create

Simple Translation

You have created many different paths for people to attain their goals; you created many different philosophies due to differences in the levels of intellect and deities, who are all part of your form, for those philosophies. Even though those deities are a part of you, you have none who is equal to you. I will create desire in the minds of samsAris, towards you.

vyAkyAnam

sarvESvaran asked AzhwAr “You are saying that I had pushed these chEthanAs in samsAram. What can I do for it?” AzhwAr responds . .

vaNangum thuRai . . . – samsAris have the qualities of *rajas* (passion) and *thamas* (ignorance) in them. When they get an involvement based on these qualities, they would be told to attain the deity which is predominant for those qualities, by instructors who were created by you. The word *thuRai* refers to sacred water and through that, it refers to celestial entities.

madhi . . . – due to bewilderment in their knowledge as well as differences with one another, when one person enunciates his philosophy, another person takes it as something which opposes his philosophy. You created many such philosophies to cater to such feelings of mistrust and misunderstanding.

avai avai . . . – you created many deities who are spoken of highly in those philosophies.

nin mUrthy parappi vaiththAy – just as you had mentioned in bhagavath glthA 7-21 “*yOyO yAmyAm thanumbhakthya*” (for whatever reasons someone worships whichever deities ...), you created many deities who realise their powers from you. Just as the saying goes “*paisal kaisunOy mukkaisu*” (even the small sufferings of a child are serious diseases), you had created lack of knowledge in these chEthanAs, you created those who tell such chEthanAs that attaining only lowly deities are apt for them and you also created pAsurams (hymns) in those SAsthras (sacred texts) extolling those deities and you created the deities too.

iNangu ninnOrai illAy – if you create a maze of such philosophies and deities for those philosophies, there is none through whom these could be avoided. There is none who could stand equalling you, none who is like you. On hearing this, sarvESvaran asked AzhwAr “That may be. What are you going to do now?”

nin kaN vEtkai ezhuvippanE – I will stop these activities of yours which you are carrying out due to your unlimited independence; I will stop them [samsAris] from experiencing the results of their activities which they are indulging in due to the faults in their knowledge; I will make them run towards you with

desire, just like me. This has arisen out of AzhwAr getting faultless knowledge even while he was in samsAram.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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99. pAsuram 97 – ezhuvadhūm mINdE

avathArikai (Introduction)

sarvESvaran tells AzhwAr “You had said in thiruviruththam 91 *perungiRiyAnai allAI adiyEn nenjam pENaladhE* and in the previous pAsuram *nin kaN vEtkai ezhuviṭṭanE*, appearing very worried. If you keep meditating on these aspects, you will keep feeling distressed, unavoidably. If you look at other samsAris you would find that they are totally devoted to worldly pursuits, enjoying themselves, spending their time eating and sleeping. Could you not follow their practice, forgetting about me and engaging with worldly pursuits?” AzhwAr says “They are indulging in all these, since they do not know you”

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

ezhuvadhūm mINdE paduvadhūm pattu enai Uzhigal pOy kazhivadhūm kaNdu kaNdu eLgalallAI imaiyOrgal kuzhAm thozhuvadhūm sUzhvadhūm sey thollai mAlaik kaNNArak kaNdu kazhivadhOr kaDhal uRRArkkum uNdo kaNgal thunjudhalE

Word-by-Word Meanings

ezhuvadhūm – the way of creating

mINdE – the same way

(immediately)

paduvadhūm – the way of perishing

pattu – being born

enai Uzhigal – for a very long time

pOy – passing all these

kazhivadhūm – (later) perishing

kaNdu kaNdu – seeing repeatedly

eLgalallAI – other than despising

imaiyOrgal – nithyasUris’

kuzhAm – their gathering

thozhuvadhūm – worshipping

sUzhvadhūm – going in circumambulation

sey – carrying out

thollai – ancient

mAlai – sarvESvaran

kaN Ara – such that eyes get satisfied

kaNdu – worship

kazhivadhu – such that time passes

Or – being unique

kAdhal – due to desire

uRRArkum – those who are fitting aptly

kaNgaL – their eyes

thunjudhal – closing (sleeping)

uNdO – could it happen?

Simple Translation

Other than giving up the repeated cycles of taking birth and perishing after sometime, for those who desire to see to their eyes' content, sarvESvaran who is surrounded and worshipped by nithyasUris, will hurdles such as closing the eyes (sleeping) occur?

vyAkyAnam

ezhuvadhun . . . – there are two interpretations. First interpretation: either being born and perishing immediately or being born, living for sometime and perishing. Just as it has been mentioned in chAndhOgya upanishath 5-108 “*jAyasva mriyasva*” (being born and dying) some people die within moments of being born while some are born at the time of creation and die at the time of deluge. To AzhwAr, both appear identical.

kaNdu kaNdu eLgal alIAl – if one were to analyse these, they will only appear to be fit to be ridiculed. Would anyone give up his/her involvement with you? [asks AzhwAr of sarvESvaran]. *eLgai* is despising/ridiculing. If one looks at the fault in this repeated cycle of taking birth and perishing, one would feel detachment towards them.

Second interpretation: **ezhuvadhun** . . . – repeated rising and setting [of the sUriyan, sun]. Even if one were to see these for many days

eLgalalIAl – instead of being involved with you, is your matter such that we could move away from you? Here, *eLgai* refers to being involved. The implication here is that having developed desire for you and having waited for such a long time, instead of waiting patiently for the remaining time too, to attain you, could we say “We have been waiting for a long time; there is no sign of attaining sarvESvaran; hence we will move away”? If there are faults in your matters, it may be apt to give you up. When you are distinctly superior to everything and since there is a natural relationship between us, can we leave? Reference is made to thiruvAimozhi 2-5-4 “*eppozhudhum nAL thingaL* . . .” (sarvESvaran is new to his followers, every second, month, year, epoch etc)

imaiyOr . . . – sarvESvaran is one who has been constantly worshipped and followed by the gathering of nithyasUris who cannot keep their mind on anyone other than you, just as it has been mentioned in mahAbhAratham mOksha parvam 16-4 “*nithyAnjaliputA hrushtA* :” (feeling happy, with joined palms) and in Srl bhagavath glthA 11-40 “*nama : purasthAdh athaprushtathas thE*” (offering salutations from the front and from the rear) and considering this to be the sole purpose of their existence.

kaNNArak kaNdu – just as it has been mentioned in Srl rAmAyaNam sundhara kANdam 40-3 “ *gAthrai: SOkAbhikarSithai:* ” (slthAppirAtti tells hanuman ‘with my limbs emaciated by grief, I wish to touch that Srl rAma, the tiger among men’) the desire will be satiated only if sarvESvaran is seen. In other words, only that desire will get fulfilled on seeing him. What comes subsequently is the strong affection towards him which follows the jlvAthmA’s nature of being subservient to him.

uRRArkum – for those who have that affection firmly.

uNdO . . . – we have heard that the fully independent perumAL (Srl rAma) had slept; however, have we ever heard that iLayaperumAL (lakshmaNa) who followed him to the forest, had ever slept? Have we ever heard before that those who are involved with sarvESvaran had closed their eyes [slept]?

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100. pAsuram 98 – thunjA munivarum

avathArikai (Introduction)

Some people told AzhwAr “You are constantly involved with sarvESvaran and are speaking about it, you are trying to correct others through your experiences and make them to turn their heads towards sarvESvaran; you are feeling distressed due to all these. Instead of doing this, since krishNAvathAram is very dear to you, why do you not spend your time meditating on the narration of krishNa stealing butter?” They do not know the extent of his involvement in such matters. In thiruvAimozhi 1-3-1 “*eththiRam*” did he not remain unconscious for months together, reminiscing about sarvESvaran’s act of stealing butter and getting beaten up by yaSOdhAppirAtti, after being tied down to a mortar? AzhwAr says that one cannot even think about such an act [of sarvESvaran’s]

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

thunjA munivaraum allAdhavarum thudara ninRa enjApppiRavi idar kadivAn imaiyOr thamakkum than sArvilAdha thanipperu mUrththy than mAyam sevvE nenjAl ninaipparidhAl veNNey UN ennum Inachcholle

Word-by-Word Meanings

enjA – without contraction

piRavi – happened in samsAram

idar – sorrow

kadivAn – to remove

thunjA – not having contraction

(having great knowledge)

munivarum – eminent sages such as sanaka et al

allAdhavarum – others such as brahmA et al

thudara – to follow

ninRa – one who remained mercifully

than – for himself

sArvu ilAdha – one who does not have (another entity) as protection

thani – being unique

peru – without any limitation

mUrththy than – sarvESvaran, who has such a nature, his

veNNey – butter

UN – ate (by stealing)

ennum sol – word such as this

mAyam – only amazement

imaiyOr thamakkum – even for nithyasUris who do not have any contraction in their knowledge

sevvE – very well

nenjAl – through mind

ninaippu aridhu – will be impossible to think of

Simple Translation

sarvESvaran is one who is worshipped and followed by eminent sages such as sanaka et al who do not have any contraction in their knowledge as well as by other samsAris such as brahma et al, in order to remove the sorrows which happen due to samsAram; he does not have anyone to protect him; he is unique and does not have any limitation. The amazing activity which is indicated by the words “He stole butter and ate” is impossible even for nithyasUris to think of.

vyAkyAnam

enjAppiRavi idar kadivAn thunjA munivararum allAdhavarum thudara ninRa – *thunjA munivar* is one who is similar to the one mentioned in Srl bhagavath glthA 2-69 “*nisA sarvabhUthAnAm*” (when it is night time for all living beings, the enlightened will be awake). In the earlier pAsurams, AzhwAr had said “My mind will not go after anyone other than sarvESvaran” “Sleep will not befall those who are involved with matters relating to sarvESvaran” “I will make all the samsAris to be involved with him like I am”. Some people, who heard him, told him “Why are you getting distressed like this, thinking of others? Isn’t krishNAvathAram very dear to you? Don’t you keep reminiscing his act of stealing butter? Why don’t you continue to think about that?” AzhwAr responds saying “If I think of other activities of sarvESvaran, I might probably exist. However, I cannot think of the depth of this particular activity; I cannot sustain myself too; thus instead of thinking of this activity and getting caught, it would be better not to think of it”

thunjA munivarum – just as samsAris are immersed in worldly pursuits such as *Sabdham* etc (the five senses such as sound etc), eminent sages such as sanaka et al are immersed in matters related to AthmA and ISvaran, and they are without the qualities of *rajas* (passion) and *thamas* (ignorance). Just as it has been said in Srl bhagavath glthA 2-69 yA *nisA* – when all the other living beings sleep during night, they will be awake. Though sarvESvaran had created them in samsAram, due to their eminent deeds over many births, they have developed detachment towards samsAram and are mumukshus (those desirous of *mOksham*, liberation). They are such eminent entities that looking at their nature, samsAram would decide “They are not the people for us; we will seek out those who are apt for us”

allAdhavarum – unlike such eminent entities as sanaka et al, due to variations in their virtues and vices, these people will be under the control of their karma (past deeds), being celestial entities such as brahma et al. They will have a mixture of karmabhAvanai and brahmabhAvanai (activities based on their karma and involvement with sarvESvaran respectively). When their sathva quality comes to the fore, they will attain the mode of brahmabhAvanai and on those few occasions they will think “samsAram is to be given up; only sarvESvaran should be attained”. They will take efforts to attain sarvESvaran during those occasions. During all the other times, they will be like samsAris only.

enjAppiRavi – in order to avoid the sorrows caused by the unending births which keep coming without any contraction

thunJA munivarum allAdhAdhavarum enjAppiRavi idar kadivAn thudara ninRa – since this sorrow cannot be cured by samsAri, since he has no strength on his own and since it has been coming from time immemorial, he has to attain an omnipotent entity at an opportune time.

than sArvilAdha – while brahmA et al attain sarvESvaran in order to get rid of their sorrows, sarvESvaran does not have an entity who he has to attain.

imaiyOr thamakkum sevvE nenjAl ninapparidhAl – those in samsAram, despite knowing that they are engaged with lowly activities, do not have the capability to give them up; but, nithyasUris are those who constantly experience and enjoy sarvESvaran. However, there is an amazing activity which even the nithyasUris cannot think of. What is that activity? sarvESvaran, who is the refuge for brahmA et al, who has no unfulfilled desire in him, treats those materials which have a connection with his followers [gOpikAs, the cowherd girls in Srl gOkulam] as his sustenance. If he cannot get such a material directly, he will obtain it even by stealing and will eat it. During the act of stealing, he will ensure that he is caught redhanded; he will allow himself to be tied down to a mortar and get beaten up for that; his divine form will get drained of its complexion and become pale and he will remain in a state of fear. Is it possible for anyone to even think of this activity? It will be a source of amazement even to sarvESvaran himself.

The vyAkyAthA narrates an incident from the life of piLLai uRangAvillidhAsar (a disciple of bhagavadh rAmAnujar). A person stole the milk kept for the king and drank it up. He was caught by the guards, tied to a tree and was being beaten up. dhAsar was going that way when he saw this incident. On enquiring, he was told as to what had happened. When he heard this, he was reminded of krishNa stealing milk, getting caught, tied to a mortar and beaten up for it. He became emotional on thinking of these incidents. He told the guards “Let him go; I will take responsibility for his action”

sevvE nenjAl – a few people, such as SiSupAlan et al could narrate a few words about sarvESvaran on the basis of their enmity with him. However, it is not possible to narrate his auspicious qualities.

The pAsuram should be rearranged to read like this to get sequential meaning:

thunJA munivarum allAdhavarm enjAppiRavi idar kadivAn thudara ninRa than sArvilAdha thanipperu mUrththiudaiya veNNey UN ennum InachchollAna mayAmaAnadhu imaiyOr thamakkum sevvE nenjAl ninaipparidhAl

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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101. pAsuram 99 – Inach cholAyinumAga

avathArikai (Introduction)

Seeing this AzhwAr deeply involved with bhagavath vishayam (matters relating to sarvESvaran) and falling unconscious, SrlvaishNavas told him “Due to your involvement with bhagavath vishayam, we are unable to determine when you will fall unconscious and when you will be in normal state. We are unable to have complete faith in you because of that”. The vyAkyAthA narrates a few incidents about those who are deeply engaged with sarvESvaran, falling unconscious. He starts with the incident from Srl rAmAyaNam when bharatha had swooned, remaining unconscious, and kausalyA dhEvi is trying to wake him up, as it has been mentioned in Srl rAmAyaNam ayOdhyA kANdam 87-9 “*adhya rAja kulasya ..*” (the life of this royal ikshvAku clan is dependent on you). Just as people will get perturbed when the stone used by an alchemist (one who converts iron into gold) falls on the ground, the queen mothers were worried on seeing bharathan falling down unconscious [on hearing about the departure of Srl rAma for the forest]. They tell him “We thought that we would be alive, treating you as the leader of this kingdom. The chakravarthy (dhaSaratha, the emperor) has passed away, Srl rAma has left for the forest. We are alive because of you. We are holding on to our lives in the hope that Srl rAma and the other two will return after seeing the sorrow on your face. If you are not there, will they even look in this direction?” Just as it has been mentioned in Srl rAmAyaNam ayOdhyA kANdam 87-9 “*puthra vyAdhi na thE kaSchith SarIram paribAdhathE*” they ask him “Oh child! I hope that no ailment is afflicting your body” Srl rAmAyaNam ayOdhyA kANdam 59-4 says “*api vrukshA:*” (even trees were withering due to the sorrow of Srl rAma leaving them) – thus, when everyone in ayOdhyA was in distress, bharathan fell down unconscious suddenly as a result of which his mothers had to ask him “Oh son! What is your disease?” Since they have only *sathva guNa* (the quality of goodness) it is difficult to know as to when they will swoon and when they will be aware. AzhwAr is one who will remain unconscious for six months, just reminiscing krishNa’s quality of *saulabhyam* (easy to approach).

The next incident involves kUratthAzhwAn (disciple of bhagavath rAmAnujar). Whenever kUratthAzhwAn starts his discourse on thiruvAimozhi, piLLai uRangAvilli dhAsar would become very emotional; shedding tears copiously, he would speak about sarvESvaran’s auspicious qualities. Seeing this, kUratthAzhwAn would tell him “Unlike us who are well versed in SAsthrams, having learnt Srl bhAshyam etc, your crumbling nature on thinking about the auspicious qualities of bhagavAn is incredible. Your birth is indeed a great one!” The same kUratthAzhwAn was once narrating periyA thirumozhi pAsuram 3-7-1 “*kaLvankol yAnaRiyEn*”, keeping a little girl on his lap. In this pAsuram the mother of parakAla nAyaki (thirumangai AzhwAr in feminine mood) would be wailing about sarvESvaran having taken away her daughter. Just then, the husband of that little girl came there to take her home. Seeing this and reminiscing the pAsuram, kUratthAzhwAn fell unconscious. Such kUratthAzhwAn was telling piLLai uRangAvilli dhAsar that he had a strong heart while dhAsar was having a soft heart due to which he was crumbling on merely thinking of the auspicious qualities of sarvESvaran.

When nanjIyar was still an adhvaithi, thirumalaidhAsar, a SrlvaishNava, told him about the greatness of parASara bhattar and made him to attain the divine feet of parASara bhattar. One day, the two of them were sitting inside Srlrangam temple, learning thiruvAimozhi. kUratthAzhwAn happened to pass that way. Seeing him, nanjIyar started to rise. kUratthAzhwAn signalled to him to sit and asked him “While samsAris will spend their time eating, is this what you people are doing?” nanjIyar responded saying “We have learnt thiruvAimozhi at the divine feet of parASara bhattar”

emperumAnAr (bhagavadh rAmAnujar) would spend the day time in writing / teaching Srl bhAshyam. At night, before going to bed, he would ask his disciples to learn *santhai* of thiruvAimozhi (a mode of learning where the AchAryan (teacher) would recite a verse once and the sishyan (disciple) would repeat it twice/thrice). When he starts reciting a verse first time, he will be very much involved in it and will be elated. When he repeats it, he would crumble and shed tears continuously, requiring several towels to wipe them. When prasAdham (food offered to periya perumAL) would be taken to periya perumAL's sannidhi, he would leave instruction with those who are offering the prasAdham to show him the prasAdham items before as well as after offering to perumAL. Not realising why he had told them this way, they would show him the prasAdham items, both before and after offering to periya perumAL. After six months had passed this way, he told periya perumAL "Oh SrlranganAthA! Would you not show me the mark of having eaten this prasAdham? "

kidAmbiyAchchAn (one of rAmAnujar's disciples and the one who used to cook food for him) was learning thiruvAimozhi from kUratththAzhwAn. One day he came late to rAmAnujar; following is their conversation:

"Why are you late?"

"I had gone to learn thiruvAimozhi from kUratththAzhwAn"

"What did he teach today?"

"He taught thiruvAimozhi 5.10 decad *piRandhavArum* "

"Could you say a few words from that?"

"There is no word to recount"

"What did you listen to? What did he say?"

"He started to teach. He recited the pAsuram. Then reminiscing the devotional trance of AzhwAr, he started weeping for a long time. Then he told us, 'What an involvement this AzhwAr has! Could I, having no involvement with bhagavath vishayam, explain about AzhwAr's involvement?' With that he stopped"

"What a supreme entity is AzhwAn!"

The vyAkyAthA now returns to avathArikai – the SrlvaishNavas, who were with AzhwAr told him "You are now in your conscious state, without swooning. You should tell us your philosophy". "In that case, listen to this", said AzhwAr, mercifully explaining his philosophy. Just as *mithrabhAvEna* is Srl rAma's philosophy, this pAsuram is AzhwAr's philosophy [*mithrabhAvEna* refers to Srl rAma telling sugrIva and others that he would accept anyone who comes to him with a friendly appearance, even if that person has a defect].

Let us go through the pAsruam and its meanings:

InachchollAyinumAga eRithirai vaiyam muRRum EnaththuruvAy idandha pirAn irum kaRpagam sEr vAnaththavarkkum allAdhavarkkum maRRellAyavarkkum gyAnappirAnai allAI illai nAn kaNda nalladhuvE

Word-by-Word Meanings

Inachchol – (my) word is without any benefit

Ayinum – even if it is

Aga – let it be

(I would still say)

eRi – throwing up

thirai – having waves

(during deluge)

vaiyam muRRum – all the worlds

Enaththu uruvAy – with the form of a wild boar

idandha – one who pierced and removed (from nether world)

pirAn – as benefactor

gyAnam – having complete knowledge

pirAnai allAI – other than Srlman nArAyaNa, the lord

irum – having the greatness (of fulfilling wishes made under it)

kaRpagam – the [celestial] wish-fulfilling tree, *kaRpagam sEr* – desirous of reaching it

vAnaththavarkkum – for celestial entities

allAdavarkkum – nithyasUris, who are distinct from the celestial entities

maRRu ellAyavarkkum – other entities such as *manushya* (human) et al

illai – there is no other means to uplift

nAn – I

kaNda – ascertained

nalladhu – benefit (is only this)

Simple Translation

Even if my words are without any benefit, let them be so. I would still say this. There is no means other than Srlman nArayaNa, who in the form of a wild boar, pierced and protected all the worlds which have oceans with rising and agitating waves. This is true for celestial entities who are desirous of reaching the celestial tree *kaRpagam* ; this is true for nithyasUris, who are different from the celestial entities; this is true for other creations such as humans, animals etc. This is my ascertained view.

vyAkyAnam

InachchollAyinumAga – When some people are willing to listen with interest, I will not refrain from saying it. When sarvESvaran initially saw the sorrow on the face of arjuna, he gave him all the secretive meanings and later grieved over it saying that he had brought out into the courtyard explicitly, what had been kept hidden in a corner. AzhwAr shares his misgivings at the forefront itself. *Inachchol* is a word which is not doing any good; in other words, which is not beneficial. It is against the true nature of a

chEthana (sentient entity). It is saying something which he could not do himself. Since he has entrusted all his activities with the omnipotent sarvESvaran, this is not an impossible activity to engage with. This position is congruent with his nature of being under the control of sarvESvaran. If one were to hold on to a supreme entity, then there is no possibility for deficiency in knowledge or in strength.

AyinumAga – even if what he says does not have a benefit, instead of calling it as a good word in a humble way, since he says *AyinumAga* [let it be so], he feels that just as there were a few people who were there to listen to what sarvESvaran said mercifully [*Sri bhagavath glthA*], there will be a few people to listen to what he has to say. Whether they accept or reject what he has to say, he is not going to step back from saying it. Even if what he says may not be correct and he is desirous of speaking about sarvESvaran even if he feels that he is in a lowly state, he is not going to step back from speaking it.

Some people who listened to AzhwAr saying this, ask him “There is a saying in the world that the money invested in flowers will not yield results. In a similar way, why do you say that what you have to say does not have benefit?” AzhwAr responds . . .

eRi thirai vaiyam muRRum EnaththuruvAy idandha pirAn – it is apt for all the *chEthanas* to hold on to sarvESvaran alone. But why is this so? During the time of danger [deluge] when they are unable to look after themselves, should they not hold on to someone for their protection? This is called as *hEthu garbha prathigayi*. This is a vow taken by sarvESvaran that during times of danger, he would protect them since he is the causative factor for them. How is he the cause?

eRi thirai vaiyam – when *pralayam* [deluge] comes to submerge the earth surrounded by ocean, he transforms himself [even as a wild boar] for the sake of others. For protecting others, he transforms himself.

idandha – this implies that he is omnipotent.

pirAn – apart from omnipotency, it is he who has the control to protect them; he is the lord. He has the knowledge for protecting them; he has the strength and control to match that knowledge. The *chEthana*, with his ignorance and lack of strength, has to hold on to sarvESvaran only. Only the one who owns will take the efforts to attain the owned [wealth]. The owned cannot take any effort. Thus, only he is necessary for all. Why should those, who do not think of asking for him but asking for wealth, hold on to him?

irum kaRpagam . . . – for those who carry out good acts here, reach *svargam* (heaven), stand under the *kaRpagam* tree and seek benefits, only he is required to grant all those. When the *chEthana* carries out good activities, as a result of which he reaches *svargam*, why is sarvESvaran required? When the *chEthana* carries out good deeds, their benefits are not given immediately. Those benefits should not get destroyed when the *chEthana* leaves this place. An *ISvaran* is needed to estimate the deeds carried out by the *chEthana* as well as the *chEthana* himself and provide him the benefits. There are some people who say that due to the effect of *kriyASakthi* and due to *apUrvam* (these are concepts floated by some philosophies but which are not accepted by *vEdhams*). Instead of trying to create new concepts, it would be better to accept sarvESvaran as the provider of these benefits.

maRReLLAyavarkkum – apart from those who experience benefits which keep reducing over time, sarvESvaran is required for *nithyasUris* too who experience permanent benefits which do not reduce over time. Even though they are *nithyasUris*, their existence is essential to enjoy sarvESvaran.

ellAyavarkkum – without knowing as to when this physical form will fall (viz when will death occur), manushyas (human beings) keep saying that “I am fat” “I am slim” etc. Even for their pleasures and to bestow those pleasures, sarvESvaran is required. Since those with knowledge and without knowledge are under his control equally, the knowledge which chEthana has is considered as *asath* (non-existent) only. Some people claim that only through knowledge *mOksham* (liberation) can be attained. When such is the case, shouldn’t chEthana need knowledge to attain *mOksham* ? It is neither that knowledge is essential nor knowledge is not essential. The only knowledge to be sought from sarvESvaran is that which will enable the chEthana not to avoid sarvESvaran when he comes to help. The knowledge needed for providing the benefit is already with sarvESvaran.

gyAnappirAnai – the only knowledge that chEthana has is the unfavourable knowledge that he could protect himself. The knowledge for doing what is to be done to protect others is available with sarvESvaran.

allAI illai – even those who wrote false SAsthrams saying that sarvESvaran does not exist, in their last days, realised that their SAsthrams were swept aside, saying that *sahaSruthi* pushes out their philosophy. *sahaSruthi* is described by thaitthirya upanishath Anandhavalli “ *sOSnuthE sarvAn kAmAn saha brahmaNA* ” – after attaining *mOksham* , the mukthAthmA (the chEthana who got liberated) enjoys with brahmam. The atheists too wonder towards the end of their lives whether they had taken the wrong path. Thus, other than sarvESvaran, neither the chEthana himself nor other means would be the means to attain sarvESvaran.

Once thirukkOttiyUr nambi had come to Srlrangam to witness a temple festival. He wanted to instruct rAmAnujar the supreme philosophy that apart from sarvESvaran, there is no other means and he wanted to instruct that confidentially. Thus, he took rAmAnujar to a secluded spot inside the temple. However, he saw a person, who was engaged in cleaning the temple, sleeping soundly there. He instructed rAmAnujar the philosophy on another occasion when there was none nearby to hear it. As soon as he heard this supreme philosophy, rAmAnuja hurried, in hot weather, to kUratthAzhwAn’s thirumALigai (divine residence), where kUratthAzhwAn was having his lunch. He told kUratthAzhwAn “nambi had told me not to reveal this to anyone else; however I cannot refrain from instructing you this” and shared the philosophy of *sahakAri nairapEkshyam* (sarvESvaran not expecting any assistance in granting liberation to a chEthana). Now, only the nature of chEthana who experiences the benefit and the means which he had adopted, remain as assists. AzhwAr now removes this too ...

nAn kaNda – since knowledge is composed of both virtues and vices, when virtues surface, the knowledge gets manifested clearly and when vices surface, it gets bewildered. However, this knowledge that I received as bhagavath prasAdham (blessed by sarvESvaran) is not meant to bewilder the others through any deceitful acts. I did not reveal it in order to tell others. I revealed it as an outlet for my enjoyment.

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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102. pAsuram 100 – nallAr navil

avathArikai (Introduction)

AzhwAr was asked “You have the knowledge to obtain the mercy of sarvESvaran and the position to clearly state that sarvESvaran is the means to attain him, as a result of which you have been able to get rid of samsAram which is a hurdle in attaining sarvESvaran. However, what can samsAris, who do not have your knowledge and who are not fortunate to attain sarvESvaran, do?” AzhwAr responds saying “They may not have knowledge to the extent that I have; it is enough if they recite these pAsurams; they will also attain the same benefit which I attained”

Let us go through the pAsuram and its meanings:

nallAr navil kurugUr nagarAn thirumAl thiruppEr vallAr adikkaNNisUdiya mARan viNNapm seydhA sollAr thodaiyal innURum vallAr azhundhAr piRappAm pollA aruvinaI mAyavan sERRaLLaI poynnilaththE

Word-by-Word Meanings

nallAr – distinguished people\

navil – speaking (permanently repeating what AzhwAr said)

kurugUr – known as thirukkurugUr

nagarAn – lord of thirukkurugUr

thirumAl – Sriya:pathi (consort of Sri mahAlakshmi), his

thiruppEr – divine names

vallAr – SrlvaishNavas who are qualified to recite, their

adi – divine feet

kaNNi – garland

sUdiya – one who donned on his head

mARan – nammAzhwAr

viNNappam seydhA – mercifully sung

sol – through divine words

Ar – complete

thodaiyal – garland

innURum – these hundred pAsurams

vallAr – those who can recite

piRappAm – known as birth

pollA – cruel (capable of destroying AthmA)

aru – difficult (to cross over)

vinai – being the cause for good and bad deeds

mAyam – being deceitful (by creating taste)

van – being strong

aLLal sERu – pressing like a quagmire

poy – being temporary

nilaththil – in this prakruthi (primordial matter)

azhundhAr – will not be caught

Simple Translation

AzhwAr is the lord of thirukkurugUr where distinguished people keep reciting his divine words. He dons on his head the divine feet of SrlvaishNavas who keep reciting the divine names of Srlman nArAyaNan, the divine consort of Srl mahAlakshmi. Those who learn well the hundred pAsurams which are like a garland composed of fully complete words and which are divinely composed by such nammAzhwAr, will not get caught in this samsAram which perpetuates birth in it, which destroys the true nature of AthmA and which presses like a quagmire.

vyAkyAnam

nallAr navil – all the people in the world keep chanting “AzhwAr, AzhwAr” just like the people in ayOdhyA kept reciting “rAma rAma” as mentioned in Srl rAmAyaNam yudhdha kANdam 128-103 “rAmO rAmO rAma:” (while Srl rAma ruled the kingdom, the people kept reciting rAma, rAma, rAma). Srl rAmAyaNam bAla kANdam 1-16 says “ *sarvadhA abhigatha: sadhbi:* ” (always accessible to purely good people) – just as ocean is attained by rivers, Srl rAma is attained by sages. When Srl rAma sits in a place to take rest after completing his chores, sages, who keep thinking of others’ good, would reach him. Their purpose is not to remove any shortcoming in Srl rAma – do rivers reach ocean in order to fill it up, which has been filled up already? No, they need to sustain themselves – in the same way, these sages attain Srl rAma in order to get rid of their shortcomings.

thirumAl . . . – while the people surround him, chanting his name, AzhwAr keeps praising the followers of sarvESvaran just as he had said in thiruvAimozhi 3-7-1 “ *payilum thiruvudaiyAr yavarElum avar kaNdlr emmai ALum paramar* ” (those who carry out kankaryam permanently are my lords)

AzhwAr has as his identity the garland, also known as divine feet of SrlvaishNavas, who have the qualification to recite the divine names of Srlva:pathi (consort of Srl mahAlakshmi).

viNNappam seydhA – in the first pAsuram of this prabandham AzhwAr had said “ *adiyEn seyyum viNNappamE* ” (this is my appeal) and completed the prabandham with *viNNappam* (the prabandham composed by him).

sollAr thodaiyal – this [prabandham] need not be cherished just because it has been composed by a well-wisher. This should be cherished for the sweetness observed in it, just as it has been said of Srl rAmAyaNam in bAla kANdam 4-8 “ *pAtyE gEyE cha mathuram* ” (it is melodious to read and sing).

innURum – unlike mahAbhAratham which is very expansive or praNavam which is very brief, this prabandham has only hundred pAsurams, indicating knowledge.

vallAr azhundhAr – first he speaks about the benefit; in what will they not get trapped?

piRappAm pollA – the cruel cycle of births. The *Athmavasthu* (sentient being) is full of knowledge and full of joy. He is sarvESvaran's servitor. Such Athma comes to samsAram to be in association with achith vasthu (insentient entities) which is incongruent with it.

aruvinai – karma (effect of past deeds, both good and bad) which follows the AthmA, grows continuously and locks up the AthmA in samsAram.

mAya – creating taste and scent in samsAram

van sERu – if one falls into this quagmire, the stain made cannot be removed easily.

aLLal – if one sets foot on it, it will pull down the person further

poynnilam – this samsAram does not have a floor. If one stands atop it, the legs will keep exploring below further, searching for firm footing. Those who recite this prabandham will not get caught in such samsAram.

This brings us to the end of this prabandham.

periya pirAtti samEdha periya perumAL thiruvadigaLE SaraNam

nammAzhwAr thiruvadigaLE SaraNam

emperumAnAr thiruvadigaLE SaraNam

periyavAchchAn piLLai thiruvadigaLE SaraNam

jIyar thiruvadigaLE saraNam

adiyEn krishNa rAmAnuja dhAsan

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